You Make Me See Stars

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/25232167.

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Explicit

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F/F

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Alternate Universe - Coffee Shops & Cafés, Magical Realism, Alternate Universe - Magical Realism, Magic, Alternate Universe - Modern with Magic, Slow Burn, Lesbian Disaster Adora (She-Ra), Rating has changed, Rated E for ~Spicy Times~

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Part 1 of Starry Eyed

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You Make Me See Stars

by lologoblens

Summary

Adora has grown up, she really has, she doesn't chase down the stars that lit up her childhood anymore, she's making her own way in the world, and building a family from scratch. But when the stars start to come out again she must answer the question;what does it really mean to grown up? And do we ever really stop?
A story about learning to accept love at face value, finding compassion for your littlest self and connecting with your own childlike sense of wonder. A story about falling in love with your friends, with your partner and with yourself.

Magical Realism AU

The Stars

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Prologue

It had been so long since Adora had seen stars. Well besides the stars in the sky, though even that was less and less frequent now that she lived in the city. Light pollution and smog could do that she supposed. The real stars though, the ones that seemed to fill the atmosphere of all of her most magic moments, they had faded with time, or age maybe. Adora's age that is, it seemed the further into disillusionment she fell, the faster the magic of her youth just died. And one day she realized she forgot what it looked like when something glowed with goodness and magic.

Adora had seen stars just twice in her adulthood, and both times she brushed it off as just remembering what it was like combined with the instinct of good things to come. And come they did. The first time was shaking Glimmer's hand. She was the daughter of Adora's new boss, an intern for the summer, and was tasked with showing Adora the ropes. They had grasped hands and Adora had barely maintained her gasp when stars began to trickle out from the space between their palms and reached out like vines, twisting up and around each girls' arm. The stars fell to the ground as they released and lay forgotten on the lobby floor. If Adora was honest with herself, even after the fact the floor of the lobby seemed to reflect the lights a little more warmly than they ought to have done. Adora wasn't honest with herself very often.

The second time had been just a few weeks later, and much harder to deny. Glimmer had invited Adora for drinks with her and her best friend and roommate. Bow was so much of what Glimmer talked about, she felt like she half knew him already. She also wondered if best friend and roommate' totally covered the bases of what their relationship truly was, but Adora had never really been one to pry.

When she walked into the bar and spotted Glimmers pink hair at a table in the corner, she intentionally missed the stars bouncing lightly

on the table. Then Bow turned around, his expression so open it gave Adora momentary pause. She pushed herself forward after a moment and Bow stood to greet her. He didn't leave it at just an effervescent, "I am so glad to finally meet you! Wow!" though. Instead electing to also pull Adora into an embrace so warm it made her want to cry. She couldn't recall encountering anyone else with a hug that hit like Bows, before or since. With his arms around her, firm but not tight, Adora closed her eyes to block out the absolute meteor shower of stars that burst forth from between them. Big and unapologetic, blasting with energy, they filled the room and bounced against the windows.

It had been about a year and a half since their introduction and despite the occasional glint out of the corner of her eye Adora would swear up, down and sideways that she hadn't seen a single star since. Not that anyone asked, not that anyone really knew anymore. Adora didn't talk about the light from her childhood, that was kid stuff and she grew up a long time ago. Adora could get the light she needed just like everyone else, no stars to guide her path. She just wished she didn't feel so lonely without them.

Chapter End Notes

> I have a vague idea of where this story is headed and some lessons Catra and Adora have to learn, but honestly I'm mostly here to play with magic! Hope some folks out there enjoy it!

A Celebratory Mood

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Just finished my last final! Like, *ever*! Last! Ever! Final! Do you want to meet at our place or the bar?" Adora laughed pulling the phone with her exuberant and also very, very loud friend on the other end, a few inches further from her ear. She can practically see the victory dance.

"Wow, Glimmer so happy for you! Lot of energy there though, maybe just like tone it down a notch for me or... like a few notches. Your call."

"Uh-oh someone sounds grumpy!"

"I'm not grumpy! I'm just in the breakroom."

"Ohh, right work. Sorry, *but*," her vice turned sing song, "it's summer vacation! You can't be too miserable!"

"Glimmer I don't get- "

"Yes, I know, you're an *adult* and you don't get one of those but, lucky you! You get to live vicariously through me."

"Lucky me." Adora responded, dead pan. "And hey- don't say *adult* like that."

"Like what?" The faux innocence was hardly charming, or maybe it would have been had Adora not been stuck between fluorescent lighting and cheap linoleum floors. At least the rest of the office had been remodeled but Adora couldn't really take a personal call at her desk and besides, then her supervisor was right around the corner

and that was hardly more relaxing. But then again, Glimmer never really could pull off the angelic vibe.

"Like you're a long-lost member of the royal line. It's not so unreasonable that I'm an adult with a job, we all have to grow up eventually, right? I don't really understand the job to be honest." Okay maybe she was a little grumpy, sassy at the very least.

"Ugh, adults are boring Adora- "

"Hey!"

"And *you're not* boring. I just wish...ugh never mind, I'm sorry."

"No, no fair Glim! What were you gonna say?"

A long-suffering sigh fills the line and just when Adora thinks she's going to need to prompt her friend again, "I just wish you'd let yourself be young for once. You take yourself so seriously all the time, like I know you're a Capricorn," Adora still doesn't really understand what that means or has to do with anything, but she rolls with it. "and I know you need to work because we all must succumb to capitalism, but- well I don't know"…

"Bull." Adora doesn't totally recognize her own voice, she sounds tense and her voice is loaded with emotions she doesn't understand. "You do know."

"I think you're trying so hard to prove you're an adult that you forget that you're a *young* adult. It's okay to let loose, you don't always have to make the responsible decision and you can make a mistake once in a while without punishing yourself. Go out on a weeknight, have the extra drink if you want it because you know Bow's always gonna DD anyway, buy the boots you look at every single time I drag your cute butt to the mall, even if it means you have to tweak that budget of yours a little bit for a while. You're so smart and driven Adora; you're not gonna fuck your life up over something stupid, you can just relax."

She appreciates the sentiment, really. She's just not sure she can afford the luxuries Glimmer is describing. Adora clears her throat and, "Oh." *Shit*, she can't cry in the break room at work.

There's a long pause and Glimmer blessedly breaks the silence. "I'm sorry Adora, I didn't mean to... you know I always support you and- and you know best what you need. I just- worry, it's what I'm good at, right?" A soft forced laugh, "But that's not why I called you! This is a time for celebration! And drinks, lots of drinks because I am going to be very stressed until my grades come back."

Adora allows the flow of conversation to change, shoving her emotions back into the compartments in which they belong. She laughs, "Does that mean I see steamed buns in my future?" It's the only thing Glimmer know how to cook; she'd argue she can also make a pretty good pasta but she's the only one who thinks her noodles count as al dente. They're definitely just undercooked, crunchy noodles. Adora suspects the issue is one borne from a lack of patience rather than skill.

Glimmer laughs too and the finally tension breaks, "I'd argue on principle but honestly I asked Bow to get me stuf f from the store yesterday."

"Okay, then I definitely want to come to your place before we go out. I forgot to pack a lunch so I'm running on apples from the work kitchen and like, two sips of coffee I was able to get down before calling it quits." It's true and she rubs her belly just thinking of the carbs now in store for her.

"Adora! You better hope I don't tell Bow!"

"Ugh, don't tell dad, I'll eat before I drink. It's fine!" She can practically see Glimmer's disbelieving expression; with the same arched brow her mother busts out when one of her staff members fails to impress. "Anyway Glim, I love you so much and I'm so proud of you. I gotta go back now though, just text me what time you want

me to come over and we can talk bars and grad party and everything then."

"You can just head straight from work, sorry *directly* from work." Adora acknowledges the bit with a snort. "I'm heading there now and Bow's just going in for a couple hours to cover the end of Merm's shift. She said she has food poisoning but like, when is she gonna learn that if I'm on her close friends list then Bow is gonna see her private stories too? Anyway, she and her boyfriend are off again, so she went out and she's def hung over today. And Bow the bleeding heart is going in so she can take off early, truly none of us deserve that boy."

"Honestly though." Adora can't help but agree, having been on the receiving end of Bow's generosity more times that she could believe she deserved. "Anyway, I like, really gotta go now Glim."

"Okay, see you in a few hours! Love you!"

"Uh, yeah, see you soon." Adora hung up the phone and even though she knew Glimmer understood and wasn't expecting it, her heart sank at her inability to return her friend's sentiment. She cared about her friends so much, would do anything for them, but the couple of times she told them the words felt cumbersome and awkward in her mouth. When she had finally opened up about her discomfort Bow had put a steady, understanding hand on Adora's shoulder (*no stars*, just a friend's comforting hand, no big deal) and told her that they said it because they felt it and wanted her to know, not so that she would reciprocate.

"Besides," Bow had said "your love language is definitely acts of service, and you're always showing us you care about us. We don't need words of affirmation to feel secure in that." Glimmer had nodded along and that's how Adora ended up borrowing Bow's book about the five love languages that there apparently are. It made sense, she supposed, but she still felt bad. It shouldn't be so hard to just...say how she felt, right?

Adora spends the last five minutes of her break, face down on the table and just counting her breaths. In, two, three, four . Out, two, three, four, five, six. In, two, three, four…

The rest of Adora's shift passes in a blur and soon she's in her truck, stopping by the market for champagne and flowers for Glim and then making her way to The Castle, as Bow and Glimmer had dubbed the apartment which they shared with one of Glimmer's classmates. Luckily, they didn't live far from her office, because Adora's stomach was sure to start eating itself any minute now. She parked half a block down the street and made her way to the building with her grocery bag and backpack.

She reaches the door and tries the handle; it turns easily , and she sighs shaking her head at Glimmer. Apparently Bow wasn't home yet. Letting herself in and locking the door behind her, Adora hears clattering from the kitchen and muffled pop music and heads in that direction. When she opens the kitchen door, she unleashes the full power of whatever pop princes Glimmer is getting down to. Knowing Glimmer will never be able to hear her she sets down her stuff and pokes her once in the shoulder.

She gasps, jumps about a foot in the air and whips around to face Adora, hand over her heart. "Jeez Adora, you scared me!"

"Well maybe if you locked the front door ever you wouldn't have to worry about axe murders letting themselves in." Glimmer dismisses her with an eye roll and dials the music down to a more reasonable volume, then turns back to the plates she's loading up. "Hey , hold on a sec Glim." Glimmer turn back around, and she digs out the flowers and champagne she brought along. "Congrats again, I really am so proud of you. Oh, also I grabbed extra bottle of that sauce you like, I didn't know- "

Suddenly Adora is wrapped up in a hug. "Aw, Adora! You big ol' softie! Thank you!" Glimmer pulls away and takes the flowers,

bustling around to look for a vase. "Carnations really are the most underrated flower, how can something that looks so much like a firework be tacky?" Adora knows the question is rhetorical so she just shrugs.

"Where's Bow anyway, shouldn't he be back by now?"

Glimmer rolls her eyes. "He texted me like, five minutes ago. I guess his relief was late but he's on the way now. In fact, I don't see any reason to wait to open that bottle of Champagne…"

Adora laughs and hands the bottle over. "You go for it, I've gotta eat something first or I won't be in any state to go much of anywhere tonight."

"Oh, that's right! Here," she shoves a plate with four perfectly formed buns into Adora's hands, "eat up so I don't have to drink alone."

She leaves Adora's side to dig around for glasses and emerges with three mismatched wine glasses. Adora is sure none of them are intended for champagne, but she doesn't really know enough to care. She wastes no time stuffing her face and as Glimmer pops the bottle and she starts on her third bun, listening to Glimmer talk about all the couple of bars she wants to hit tonight. Soon enough they hear commotion from the front door.

"Honey, I'm home!" Bow calls out.

"In the kitchen! Adora's here too."

Bow bustles his way into the kitchen and wraps Glimmer and then Adora in tight hugs. "Hey, you two already getting this party started?" He glances at Adora and takes note of her stuffed cheeks, laughing at the image. "Well I can see Adora's already getting turnt up."

She rolls her eyes and Glimmer supplies, "We have champagne! I know you're driving but we probably won't leave for a little while, you want a glass?"

“Just a small one, thanks Glim.” She nods, pours the glasses and passes them around.

“To Glimmer and her big, powerful brain! May it need never consume another text book again.” Bow raises his glass to initiate a toast and is met with the clinking of glasses and, “Hear, hear!” from his friends.

They each drink to seal it and Glimmer sighs. “I can't believe it's really done, doesn't feel real yet.”

“I'm sure it'll set in by graduation.” Bow assures her.

“What are your post grad plans Glimmer?” Adora asks, she knows Glimmer's been thinking about a few different things, but she hadn't decided last they checked in and everyone wanted to give her space to get through finals.

“You mean like grad party or like the boring stuff?” Adora just blinks back at her. “Right, look who I'm asking.” She sighs and Adora swears she hears her mutter, “Hopeless.” Before carrying on. “Well I have some cash saved up to float me for a little while, but I don't want to eat up all my savings. I'm gonna take a month off and then when my mom and I get back from visiting Auntie Casta I'll start looking for work which will give me enough time to be a *little* choosy hopefully. You two are still planning to come up to the beach for the long weekend, right?”

Bow and Adora nod and Glimmer groans in relief. “Thanks goddess, I really don't know what I would do without you two. Especially alone with my mom and Casta for two weeks.” She shivers dramatically. “Anyway, before that, we party! Tonight, and then I'm thinking grad pool party! Merms said she's be down to host at her parents' place. She's house sitting for them like, all summer, I guess.”

“That sounds great Glimmer!” Glimmer beams back at Bow.

“I know, right!” Adora chuckles, appreciating the enthusiasm. “Alright, Adora did you bring your own clothes to change into or do I need to

take you to my closet?"

"No, no! I learned after last time, I've got jeans and a Glimmer approved top in my pack." Glimmer nods in satisfaction.

"Alright, you two change! I'll make Adora and me drinks, you better finish that bubbly before you come back by the way, and then I'll do a quick costume change of my own." She gives Adora a pointed look and she nods seriously.

"Of course, general, excellent battle plan." Before Glimmer can respond Adora grabs her pack and heads for the bathroom. Honestly as much as Adora doesn't love the primping she loves going out dancing, certainly more than she ever though she would. She's definitely not great, her limbs always a little too long to feel graceful, never having grown fully out of her post growth-spurt gangly, awkwardness. A couple drinks and that didn't matter so much though. In fact, on the dance floor with her best friends beside her Adora felt almost free.

Occasionally, if she had just enough liquor in her , she could let herself believe all the glitter on the dance floor was stardust. She'd never admit it sober but sometimes she even swore it was more than that. As if when her inhibitions were lowered the stars knew they could sneak back in, just for the night. After her 21st birthday she'd gone through a brief period of getting tipsy with dinner more often than not, just hoping for a glimpse, but it didn't seem to work that way. After showing up to work hungover a couple days in a row she stopped letting herself drink alone. What was she doing chasing childhood fantasies anyway? Besides, that was before she met Bow and Glimmer, she wasn't so lonely as that anymore. A night on the dance floor with them was enough, more than enough.

A knock on the door startled her out of her reminiscing. "Hey Adora! Glimmer went upstairs to do her face, she said she'll be ready in twenty."

"Cool, so taking of f in like forty-five then?"

Bow laughed, "Yeah, if we're lucky. I'm gonna go eat something, I'll meet you in the kitchen!"

About an hour later they were climbing into Bow's car.

"I like the glitter Glim." Adora called from her spot in the back.

"Hm, what glitter?" Glimmer responded absently, flipping through Spotify on her phone in search of music that would 'get the party started here and now'.

"Oh, uh, never mind"…

Chapter End Notes

Meet cute up next! Thinking this story will come in at 10-12 chapters but [shrug emoj]

Daily Special

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora was hungover, she couldn't remember ever being so hungover before. She rolled over to peak at her alarm clock with a groan. Ugh, ten? Okay , so she was *really* hungover. She needed coffee, badly. She took note of her dry mouth, water too then. But mostly coffee. Knowing there was none in the kitchen she looked forlornly at her closet. Was coffee really worth leaving the sanctuary of her bed? She closed her eye and, getting no reprieve from her splitting headache decided, yes, it most certainly was worth it.

It took her over an hour to drag her butt out of bed, clean up in the bathroom, get herself into something resembling outside clothes and manage a full glass of water. Soon enough she had all of her essentials in hand, sunglasses over her eyes and was out the door. She slid her wallet and phone in her pockets and clipped her keys to her belt loop, leaving just her water bottle to be carried in her hands.

Typically, Adora wasn't much for coffee so she didn't have a usual spot, but she lived just a few blocks down from a main drag with plenty of shops. She figured if she just walked along there long enough, she would be bound to run into somewhere to get her fix. It only took two blocks to find what she needed. She was in front of a building that looked like it had probably been a residence at some point. Painted a pale lilac with sage trim and doors, the place gave off a distinctly homey vibe, only aided by the flowering planters, large wooden porch swing, and iron patio set on the building's front porch.

Figuring this spot would be as good as any other she let herself in the door and registered a bell tinkling overhead as she walked through. There was a short line, about three groups deep, ahead of her. Probably for the best, as it would give her some time to attempt

to gather her wits and figure out what, specifically, she was there for. She peeked down at her phone, just the missed call from Mara she had seen while flipping through her phone on the toilet that morning. She figured Bow and Glimmer wouldnt be up for another hour or so, then she could check in about swinging by to get her car. Maybe if she offered to supply coffee should could get one of them to come pick her up. Until then she could kill time reading on her phone, or maybe even call Mara back if the coffee dulled her headache enough.

Satisfied with her course of action she hopped in line and peered up at the menu. Adora stared at the it for her entire time in the line, too overwhelmed by the coffee decision to even think about looking at the pasty case. Slowly she shuffled her way through the line and closer to the moment of truth. Her turn to order, she could feel the barista's eyes on her, surely waiting for her to tear her eyes from the menu and acknowledged them. A few beats too long, Adora could feel her blush creeping further up her neck with each one, and she finally glanced down to the person in front of her. She was greeted with a patient, if not patronizing, smile below a shock of green hair and pale-yellow-green eyes.

"What can I get for you darling?" Was it Adora's anxiety kicking up or was their tone almost sinister?

"Oh, um well, I dont drink a lot of coffee. What's um good here?" She cringed at her own insecure stuttering and even more so at the arched brow that met her question. Her head really hurt too bad for this.

"Hm, well I personally like a con panna, light on the espresso heavy on the whip cream." A snort from behind the barista taking her order pulled Adora's attention from them to the one working the machine and making drinks. Nonsensically the sight of them made Adora's blush deepen and burn more fiercely. She was relatively certain a trip to the coffee shop shouldnt be so mortifying, but there was little she could do about that now. She'd just continue to blame the hangover. "But since *Kiten* here is on bar today," Adora just barely

caught the scowl that over took the mirth on their coworker's face at the nickname before her attention redirected itself. "I'd recommend the special."

Adora glanced down to the little chalkboard on a miniature easel they had indicated. It read Daily Special' in loopy , flowery script at the top. Below that in much harsher, angled handwriting, Barista' s Choice'. "Oh, uh what?"..

A smirk, "Catra back there decides, and trust me honey , she *never* gets it wrong. Now there's a girl who knows what to do with her… coffee."

If Adora made it out of this shop without setting of f the fire alarms from the heat off her face and steam billowing from her ears it would be a small miracle. She just barely managed to stammer out, "Oh, wow, that's...sure that' s great!That' s sounds uhm, ha uh," an awkward cough, "fabulous!...hank you!"

"Great! Just let us know if you have any allergies for kitchen to avoid. What's your name hun?"

"No, no allergies and it' s uh, Adora"?She winced at the question in her voice.

"Hm, how...delightful." They gave her a measuring look but ominous commentary on her name aside, they carried on like their customer wasn't melting into an absolute puddle of a hot mess right before their eyes, marking up a cup with her name and order. Maybe she was being more chill about this than she thought?Unlikely , in fact it was far more likely they just had good customer service skills. She should leave a heavy tip for all the extra work she had made for them honestly, like a *really* good tip. "That'll be $5.47, cash or card"? Adora handed them a crumpled ten before muttering something about not needing change and lumbered away as quickly as possible to stand as far away from the pick-up area as she felt was reasonable.

A few minutes or so into doing nothing in particular on her phone Adora felt a pair of eyes on her and looked up directly to the gaze of Catra? She was pretty sure it was Catra. Alright, so she definitely knew it was Catra and would probably never forget it to her dying day, even if old age and dementia took her own. Too dramatic? Definitely too dramatic. As if the locked eyes and torturous internal monologue weren't enough to stop Adora's heart, Catra crooked her finger in a universal come-hither motion. Or come here rather, skip the sensual undertones please, she admonished herself. Adora finally broke her gaze away long enough to see a paper cup with her name scribbled across the side in Catra's hand. With some context for her current predicament, Adora felt herself moving forward.

When she was within a couple feet of Catra the other woman sized her up languidly and, as Adora came to a stop in front of her, she finally spoke. "Adora?" She nodded, silenced by the sound of her name in Catra's low rasp. "That your real name?" Another nod and Catra's expression became amused and mischievous. A dangerous look if Adora ever saw one. "Hm, and if I hold myself back from commenting on how absolutely *adorable* that is will you tell me how many would-be suitors have tried to pick you up with that line?"

"I" T oo loud, way too loud. She cleared her throat and looked down at her shoes. "Uh, sorry . But no, I mean none really ." She hesitated, "But like, countless grandmas. Y ou wouldn't believe the scenes that have been made when I go to the pharmacy ." She grinned shyly, chancing a glance back at Catra to gauge the success of her joke.

Catra blanched for half a second and then tipped her head back and *laughed*. The sound was big, rich and full, taking up every spare inch in the cafe, the air around her seemed to shimmer? Adora brushed the thought away. "Alright Adorable, quit distracting me and lemme make you this drink." Adora chose to ignore the fact that Catra had called *her* over and put her hands up in a universal sign of submission, taking a step or two back from the counter. When had she gotten right up next to it anyway?

The next couple minutes passed with just the whirring of the grinder and soft music filling the space. With no one in line behind Adora, and no one coming in the door since, the other barista had wandered into the back. Soon enough Catra was sliding the cup across the small counter and catching Adora's eyes again. "Order up."

Adora walked closer and looked down at the drink and then back to Catra. "What um, what's in it?" She didn't mean to sound so breathless but…

Catra laughed, "Try it first, if you like it, I'll tell you."

Adora hummed, "They," she indicated with a nod toward the door Catra's coworker had disappeared through, "seemed to think that was a given."

Another laugh, even the short chuckle warmed Adora from the inside. "Well there's always a first time, exception proves the rule, right?"

Adora didn't answer and just looked down at the drink again. In and of itself the drink was completely inoffensive, just a cup of coffee with one of those intricate hearts drawn into the foam. She was pretty sure Bow had called it a tulip once. What was giving Adora pause, what really took her breath away, were the stars making the latte art glitter under the lights, spilling down the sides of the cup and onto the counter.

Tentatively she picked up the cup, Catra's watching gaze making her so, so nervous. Did she watch everyone who ordered the special like this? Adora closed her eyes and took a sip of what was easily the best drink anyone had ever made her. Smooth espresso, still strong and bitter, creamy and rich, and just a light taste of toffee and hazelnut, not too sweet.

It was delicious, but what made it so good was the stirring of nostalgia in Adora's heart. It called her back to her grandmother's kitchen, Granny Razz bumbling about her kitchen making coffee and

muttering a list of ingredients they'd need for making pie later , asking Adora if she'd seen her glasses, and Adora giggling as she told her they were right on her face. f the kitchen wasnt filled with stars it was because in that place Adora felt like she was inside the heart of the sun, inside a star where she would always be safe. And she was, until Granny got too old and was deemed too far gone to properly take care of Adora anymore. And then wellit was the 'and then' memories that made it so hard to remember what it was like being inside the sun.

"So?"

Adora blinked her eyes open, remembering where she was. "Perfect."

Catra's answering grin opened floodgates she couldnt possibly have known existed. All around her the air was suddenly charged with starlight;some streaking across the air around her , others twinkling by her face, at the corners of her eyes which were all crinkled up by her smile, and all of it together was lending a soft glow that warmed Catra's complexion and made her eyes even more stunning. Suddenly aware of her staring Adora tore her eyes from the starlit blue and hazel of the magician before her and looked back at her drink.

"W ell, glad to keep my streak going. t' s just an oat milk latte with a pump of our house made toffee syrup and medium roast espresso. You know, if you want one and Im not here or whatever ."Catra shrugs, looking intentionally nonchalant.

"And if you are?"The words tumble out before Adora can even figure out what to make of them. Catra grins and makes eye contact again, it makes Adora's stomach squirm pleasantly and she finds herself glad she didnt give herself the opportunity to overthink it for once.

"Order the special again, after all some days you just.need something a little different, you know?"

Adora nods even though she's not sure she does know. "Thanks, for the coffee." And the magic.

"Sure thing, have a good day, Adorable."

"Yeah, yeah, you too." And even though she had planned to stick around the café and kill time for a bit, she walks out the door in search of fresher air instead. Her cup trails stars in the direction of the cafe down to the very last drop. As the last one floats away Adora wonders; is *this* the last time she'll see the stars? Or did she just become a caffeine addict?

Chapter End Notes

Fun Fact: this is the very first chapter I wrote for this story! Drop a comment if you've got thoughts. :)

The Good Outweighs The Bad

Halfway up the stairs in front of her apartment, Adora's phone goes off. Luckily the coffee has all but cleared her headache so the sound isn't nearly as grating as it would have been an hour ago. Now she just needs food. She pulls her phone out and swipes to answer when she sees an incoming video call from Glimmer. Her head appears to be in Bow's lap, though all she can see is his dark, toned stomach beneath his crop top shrouded by Glimmer's rat's nest of hair. Glimmer looks like hell, mascara and dark circles beneath her eyes and resting pout face on.

"Hey bish, you alive over there?" She seems to notice Adora's surroundings a second later, as her eyes widen almost imperceptibly. "Geez Adora, have you already left the house? How? You were more drunk than I was when we dropped you off last night!"

"I'm surprised you even remember that, I had to carry you in-" Bow's voice, filled with mirth, filters in from off screen.

"Hush Bow! Seriously Adora, are you even hungover? Are you a robot? You don't even have your sunglasses on!" She sounds downright indignant. Sure enough, Adora reaches up to find that she never put her sunglasses back on after leaving the café, instead leaving them to do her absolutely no good on top of her head. She blushes at the realization.

Letting herself into her little studio and plopping on her bed she defends, "I needed coffee! You know, for the hangover."

"Oh," Glimmer hums sympathetically, still pouting. "Did you get me any?"

Adora laughs, "I honestly didn't think you'd be up just yet Glim, I was gonna stick around the shop for a while but I can get you now though, if you want."

"No, no," Glimmer sits up then, bringing Bow's face and the back of their couch into view. "We were actually calling to see if you wanted to go to the diner. I need pancakes, plus your car is still here and Bow figured you'd want a ride. So, we can pick you up and bring you back here after food, if that works?"

"Sounds perfect, thanks guys. Bow, do you have to work later?"

"Nah, I asked for the day off when Glimmer got her final's schedule. Figured, we'd be hanging." He smiles and offers a thumbs up. It's cheesy, which Adora likes.

"Awesome, well I'm ready whenever, want to just text me when you head out?"

"That's great, see you soon Adora!"

"Bye for now!"

Adora ends the call and flops back on her bed. What she wouldn't give to just close her eyes, she probably has time for a quick power nap with the state Glimmer was in. But no, she should vacuum and clean the bathroom, no rest for the wicked and all. With a sigh she gets up, glancing back at the bed Glimmer's words from the day before nag at the back of her mind. Isn't this the kind of thing she was talking about, should Adora just relax for twenty minutes? She shakes the thoughts away. How is she supposed to relax with a grimy shower?

She's wrapping the vacuum cord up half an hour later when she feels her phone buzz in her pocket. Pulling it out she sees a text from Glimmer in the Best Friend Squad chat. *Here! Forgot to text before we left, gimme! Take your time though!* She shakes her head but drops her task to be resumed when she gets home. In no time at all she's locking her door and clipping her keys on her belt.

Taking the stairs two at a time Adora scans the lot for her friends, and spots Bow's car idling in a spot right in front. She slides in the

back and the threesome exchange greetings.

“How was your morning?” Bow asks, peaking at her in the rearview mirror.

Adora’s barely felt her cheeks start to warm when Glimmer, not missing a thing, whips around in her seat. “Oh my gosh, Adora! Why are you blushing?” Bow look at her , she looks like a strawberry.”

“Present that, thank you very much!” The protest falls on deaf ears and Bow is chancing another glance at her in the mirror.

“You do look pretty pink all of the sudden, wanna tell us what that’s all about buddy?”

“Nothing! I just woke up, hungover as all get out, went out for cof fee,” she knows she gets redder as she says it, Catra’s face and the stars floating into her mind in spite of herself. “and you two called me right as I got home. Also, I cleaned the bathroom.”

Glimmer rolls her eyes. “Of course you still did your chores!”

“Well why wouldn’t I?”

Glimmers only response to this is another eye roll. “Whatever , that is clearly not all there is to the story.” She turns in her seat to face Adora again to offer her warning. “Don’t think this is over , I just don’t have the energy to fight you on it until *af ter* pancakes.”

Bow offers her a sympathetic glance in the rearview mirror while Glimmer turns back around to busy herself playing DJ. Adora slumps in her seat, electing to pout and look out the window until they arrive at their regular greasy spoon.

It’ s like a space forgotten by time, the hostess has an excessively teased beehive and Adora really can’t tell if her beauty mark is real or not. Either way, Adora likes the vibe. She directs them to a booth and the slide in along the vinyl seats, opting to immediately peruse

their menus in lieu of small talk. But Adora's peace only lasts so long, as soon as they've put their orders in Glimmer is on her like white on rice.

"So, what happened at cof fee this morning Adora?"

"Glimmer!" She whines, "I thought we were saving the interrogation until *af ter* you had pancakes."

"The order 's in, same difference." She dismisses. "Y ou're a fool if you thought I was gonna sit here and ignore the elephant in the room instead of getting you to spill the tea while we're stuck waiting."

"Bow , a little help here!" She looks at him pleadingly , begging for an ally in this conversation.

"W ell." Adora doesn't like that hesitation one bit, he' s definitely about to betray her. "Honestly I'm pretty curious too, you were blushing *pretty* hard."

"Et tu Brute?"

Ever the peace keeper Bow scrambles to continue, "I f your comfortable! Maybe just start by telling us where you went?"

Adora drops her chin into her hand, elbow on the table and pouts, trying to remember. "Plumeria, I think?"

"I think I've seen that place! It' s over on Eternia Ave, right? Over by your place?" She nods. "W as it any good?"

"Okay , see! Now why are you blushing? Seriously , what, was the coffee truly orgasmic or something?"

"*Glimmer*!" Her outrage only incites snickering from across the table. "No, it was fine. I mean, better than fine, it was really good! Like, kind of insanely good... You know it sort of made me think of my Grandma Ra?"

Suddenly both expressions from across the table are much gentler. Bow ventures softly, "Do you wanna tell us more about that? You don't talk about her very often." Was that true? Adora loves her Granny, it hurt her heart a little to think that her best friends in the world barely knew anything about her. It just made her sad to talk about. After years of information getting lost in the system and crummy foster parents getting in the way she'd finally managed to track down the home Granny was in with Mara's help. But by that time well Raz's memory wasn't so good these days. Adora still called and sent cards but more often than not her Grandmother couldn't remember who she was. Sometimes she called Adora Mara'. She wasn't sure if Raz was remembering her big sister, or if it was just a coincidence.

"Uh, I mean sure. I guess. I don't know if was something about the smell, or the taste, or what, but well, did you know Granny Raz loved making pie?" Her friends shook their heads in tandem. "Yeah, practically every weekend. I used to have pie for breakfast almost every Monday morning for years." She laughs softly at the memory, recalling her school picture from the third grade, her teeth still stained blue from the berry pie she'd eaten that morning. "In the summer we'd forage for berries along the roadsides, and we'd steal apples and stone fruit from our neighbor's gardens when they were in season. Honestly looking back, I think they knew but must have thought we were too cute to stop us or something." She chuckles remembering sneaking across lawns, plucking fruit from the trees, the rebounding branches raining stars that would fall on them, showing up in the pie later and lingering in their hair until the next morning.

Bow reaches over and grabs her hand on top of the table. The tenderness of the gesture causes a few of the tears that have started to gather in her eyes to spill over. "That sounds really magical, Adora." She reaches up to brush away the tears that have escaped, but when she pulls her hand back and looks down it's not water, she sees streaked across her hand, but stars.

She lets out a watery chuckle, embarrassed at her display of emotion and trying to regain her composure. "Yeah, it really was."

There's silence at the table but soon they are rescued from figuring out how to resuscitate the conversation by the delivery of their food. Adora digs gratefully into her omelet but a glance up reveals that Glimmer is mostly pushing her food around her plate. After a few minutes of this she huffs quietly and looks up at Adora.

"Adora," her voice is much smaller than usual. "I'm really sorry. I didn't realize- I shouldn't have pushed so hard. I know your history is... complicated and I..." She drifts of with another soft sound.

"Hey it's okay Glimmer." She offers her a reassuring smile and then feels her expression shift as she debates how honest to be. "Honestly, that sort of just... came up. It wasn't why there was something else." Glimmers eyebrows raise but Adora can tell she's still too humbled to jump at the bait with the enthusiasm she normally would. "There was sort of..." she rushes out the next bit and forcefully stabs an excessively large bite of omelet in her mouth immediately after. "There was sort of a girl."

The reaction from across the table is nothing short of explosive.

"What?"

"Adora!"

"I can't believe you didn't text us *immediately*!" Glimmer cries.

"Who is she? Did you get her number?"

Adora scoffs outright at that. "No of course I didn't *get her number*. Who do you think I am?"

"It's not *such* an absurd idea for you to show your interest in someone." Bow defends gently.

"No, I know. It's just..."

t’ s just”…

m not,”she shrugs, “brave like that.”

“Pf ft!”

Adora turns to scowl at Glimmer. “What”?

“Like hell you arent brave!Adora, youre the bravest person Iknow . Youve been emancipated since you were barely seventeen, put yourself through two years of school and got your degree with little to no help, moved to a new city, all on your own *and*”she grins at her own joke before it’ s even told, “youre friends with the two of us. Youre plenty brave, youre just gay and let yourself get intimidated by pretty girls.”

Adora blinks, unsure of where to even start with all of that. She looks to Bow hoping hell have an idea but he’ s just nodding, pride and stars in his eyes. Seeing Adora obviously floundering with no hope of recovering, Glimmer eventually throws her a bone. Sort of. “Okay well, you didnt get her number , but maybe youll see her again if you go back!What’ s her name?What’ s she like”?

“Uh, Catra”?Adora mumbles, not concerned about her friends hearing her as theyre very nearly leaning into her personal bubble as they hang onto her every word. “She um, she was on bar”?

“Ooo, mystery girl made the magic drink!Cute!”Bow looks so excited for Adora youd think she just announced an engagement or a lottery win or something.

“Anything else”?Glimmer prompts with a look that says she knows there is and Adora had better spill it.

“dont know what to say , she was justcool. Her hair was pulled back, but it looked like it would be really wild when she lets it down, um Ithink maybe she’ s latinx?The drink special was like, barista’ s

choice and she made me this really good toffee latte thing. Like it tasted really good and prompted the memories ofwell, you know ."

Bow nods sagely, "Y eah id probably fall in love with someone who' s coffee brought back my happiest memories too tbh. That's a hard initial emotional connection to beat."

"Im not in love with her!" *Shit* loud, too loud. "Sorry , Ijust, Ibarely even met her. Plus, she was a work and, Idont know . Isnt it like, bad form to hit on innocent service workers anyway?"

"Hm," Bow looks thoughtful. "That is a fine line to walk. Id say just like, make it obvious youre interested and test the waters a bit. Y ou know, flirt a little, make good eye contact and see how she responds. Go from there"

"Oh! Casually drop into conversations places that youve been meaning to go!" Glimmer adds.

"What, like, hey you barely know me and probably arent interested-
"

"Probably is." Glimmer cant help but cut in, Adora ignores her .

"-but Im thinking of swinging by the grocery store later .? What' s the point of that?"

"Oh my gosh Adora, please tell me youre being dense on purpose. Obviously, Im not saying you should tell your crush about your *errands*." She says the word 'errands' disdainfully . "What Imean is drop date ideas. Like, 'did you hear about that new restaurant? Im just dying to go! you know , and then like flutter your eyelashes a little, give a sort of significant look. Bing bam boom, youve got a date."

"Okay I *know* you dont think Im that smooth."

"Alrightfair , maybe skip the eyelashes and do more of a bashful Adora thing."

"Bashful Adorawhat?What does that mean?"Glimmer starts to cackle lightly at Adora's indignation, so she whirls on Bow. "What does that mean?

"W ell, uh Ithink what Glimmers getting at is you have a sort of"He looks to Glimmer for help but she's still no use. "Like an endearing sort of charm."

"That' s about clear as mud to me Bow."

"W ell, you're kind of shy and, like Glim said, bashful. Y ou're just… sweet. And people like that!"

"So, what you two are saying is Icant pull of f flirty and sexy and am doomed to be a blushing, bumbling mess every time Itry to flirt. Fabulous."Adora slumps back into her seat.

Bow's insistent, "No!"is cut of f by Glimmer.

"Y eah pretty much."Adora glares at her but it gets no reaction. "Come on Adora, you're not much of a sex kitten and that' s *f ine*, so what?Like Bow said, you're super endearing. Literally everyone you meet loves you, have a little more confidence in yourself!"

"Idont know . Imeanjust, say Ido go in and she happens to be there, and Imanage to actually talk to this girl without making a fool of myself. Idont really want to leave the same impression you'd get from-from like a fluffy bunny or something!"

"A w bunnies!"Bow has heart eyes at the mere mention of cuteness. "Sorry , Imean;bunnies are cute, why wouldnt you want her to think you're cute?"

Adora groan and smacks her head back against the seat. Not looking down from the celling she says, "Can we be done with this

for now please? I'm feeling a little overwhelmed."

"Of course! Thanks for telling us! And if you do want to talk more about this, we're always here."

"For sure, and super interested in any potential cof fee girl updates." There's a scuffle and Bow must have nudged Glimmer or something because she follows up with, "if you want! No pressure."

"Why don't I go see if I can get the check and we can take of f, yeah?"

"Thanks Bow ." Adora says, finally looking down to of fer him a small smile.

Twenty minutes later the three of them are standing in front of Adora's car, having been 'saying goodbye' for the last five minutes.

"Alright, I love you both so much, but I need a carbs nap like, now ish." Glimmer says blinking heavily , the arm carrying her leftover food beginning to droop.

"Y eah, we should get inside. Adora, want to come over for dinner when you get off on Wednesday? I'm of f all day so I thought I'd make us something a little more involved, you know classy people food."

"Oh, fancy feast! H eck yeah, wild dogs couldn't keep me away . Half five or so work for you?"

"See you then!"

"Bye Adora." Glimmer waves sleepily and Bow follows her inside.

Adora drives home in relative silence. When she pulls into her parking spot and kills the engine she realizes since she finished all her chores before brunch now is as good a time as any to call Mara back. She climbs out of the car, pulling the contact up on her phone and turns to walk around the block instead of heading inside.

The line rings three times and then clicks, “Hey Sqirt, how ya doing?”

“Hey Mara! I’m pretty good, just got home from brunch with Bow and Glimmer.”

“Aw, how are those two doing?”

“They’re good! Bow’s up to the same old shenanigans and Glimmer is finally done with classes, so she’s thrilled.”

“Wow, so that means she’s done with her bachelors now, yeah?”

“Sure does.” Adora comes to the end of the black and hangs a right, heading in the direction of the little neighborhood park nearby.

“Is she hopping right into the job hunt then?”

“No, she and her mom have a trip planned at the beginning of July, so she’s gonna take a little break and get on it when they get back.”

“Hmm, that’s good.” There’s muffed background noise and Mara says, “Sorry Dora gimme just one second.” She can hear muffled conversation, sounds like something about Darla and the vet. “Alright, I’m back!”

“Was that who I heard?”

“It was indeed.”

“Give her my love.”

“Will do and I’m sure she sends hers back to you. She just took off; Darla is due for her checkup.”

“Aw, Darla, how is that doggo doing?”

“Good, good, just getting older, you know how it is. She has the energy of a puppy, but now she drools more.” Mara and Adora both

laugh at the image of the old mutt slobbering and jumping around.

"Sounds about right. And um, Razi, have you seen her recently?"

Mara sighs and the tenor of it makes Adora's heart clench. "Yeah Squirt, Hope and I went to see her on Thursday."

"Ohw um," Adora clears the emotion from her throat. "How is she doing?"

"You know Raz, still goofy and sweet as can be but..." She pauses and Adora can practically see the furrowing in her brow and the way she tugs on her long braid when she's anxious or fussy. "Her physical health is still normal for her age so she's good there but her mind... she hasn't remembered us at all the last few times we've gone to see her. She's in good spirits and it doesn't seem to bother her but she's pretty lost most of the time."

Adora drops to a bench near the entrance of the park and cradles her head in her free hand in an attempt to hide her teary eyes for anyone who might pass by. It's a Saturday afternoon so the park is decently busy, even though the clouds have started to roll in threateningly. "Do you think... should I come home?"

"Aw kiddo, that's really up to you. I will say while I certainly can't tell the future, I don't get the sense she's going anywhere yet. Of course, Hope and I would love to see you and you're always welcome to come." Her voice is soft and comforting. It reminds her of the security blanket she had lost in the move between her second and third foster home, warm and familiar.

"Okay." She lets out a breath in a long whoosh of air. "Will you tell me if the time comes? When it does. I know- I know she probably won't remember but, I want to be there. I wish I could be more but I..."

"It was time to go Adora, it isn't selfish to take care of yourself."

"I know . Mostly. We just we had so much time stolen from us already, it feels weird to sacrifice what's left."

"It's not the same Adora." Adora lets out a shuddering breath. "Hey, are you okay? I know this stuff is hard, but you just seem a little more raw than usual."

"I'm fine, I was just talking to Bow and Glimmer about Razz and her pies earlier, I guess having her at her best on my mind makes the reality of her current situation…"

"A little harder to swallow?" Mara supplies.

Adora nods, then realizing what she's doing manages, "Yeah, definitely hard to swallow."

"I'm so sorry scrapper. You know I wish I could have." Adora knows the almost endless ways she could finish that sentence. She appreciates the sentiment, but at the end of the day, eighteen or not, Mara was still just a kid too when Adora's world came crashing down.

"I know, I know you do. You've also helped me out more than I could ever repay you for. Me and Razz."

"And *you* know I didn't do anything for repayment, just cause I love ya kid. The both of you kooks for that matter." This part of the conversation is familiar territory and Adora feels a small smile start to bloom on her face.

"Yeah, yeah. Thank goddess for the big brother/big sister program."

"For we'd both have been lost without it." Mara laughs. "Alright, alright I won't drag your Saturday down any further," she offers as if Adora isn't the one who brought up the more somber topics. "but I did call you for a reason."

"You mean besides just to hassle me?" Adora can practically hear Mara's eyes roll.

"W atch it there, Squirt, or I'll really start to hassle you. Start bugging you about your love life."

"Bold of you to assume there's anything to bug me about." She thanks every deity from every civilization she can think of that Mara can't see her blushing.

"Y eah, yeah. Anyway, can we focus on me now?"

"I'm not stopping you, please take the floor."

"W ell, remember I told you Hope and I were gonna check out that fertility clinic?" Adora can feel her pulse pick up and supplies an 'mm-hmm.' "W ell she took a test this morning... W e're gonna be moms! Can you believe it?"

Adora screams and pays no mind to the curious stares around her. "Oh my gosh Mara! Congratulations! I can't believe it. Oh, you're gonna be such a *great* mom! Like, the *best ever* mom!" Adora whole heartedly believes it too, after all there was a time where she was desperate for Mara to be *her* mom. At ten she didn't really understand why nineteen-year-old Mara might not be ready to take on a dependent. An adult is an adult when you're that age after all. "Y ou just found out this morning so I'm guessing you haven't talked to a doctor yet?"

"No, not yet. But our doc managed to fit us in T uesday afternoon, so we don't have to wait too long."

"W ow! Oh my gosh, well call or text me after okay? I want every baby update!"

"Sure, sure! And hey, get ready to be a goddess parent, yeah?"

"A w, Mara! Are you sure? I'm already gonna be the kid's aunt, you really don't have- "

"We're *sure* squirt! This kid is gonna be so lucky to have a guiding light like you to turn to."

"Well shit Mar, now you're just making me blush." This was fully accurate. Mara just laughed until it petered out into a sigh. "Hey Mara?"

"Yeah kid?"

"I really am so, so happy for you. And Hope, and this lucky as hell kid."

"Thanks, Adora. Listen, I should let you go. Have a good rest of your day and, one way or another, I'll let you know how things go at the doc tomorrow."

"Sounds good! Tell Hope congratulations from me also."

"Will do, bye Squirt!"

"Bye."

Adora hangs up the phone and attempts to settle into this new reality. A baby, Mara a *mom*, and sweet Raz! It's a lot, but the good so heavily outweighs the bad. She looks down at her phone, about to check the time and stops short. From the earpiece and the mic are thousands upon thousands of stars, pouring out of the phone and piling up around Adora's feet. She must have been so distracted by her call she hasn't noticed them until now, forming an ever growing mountain by her feet.

Another Capricorn

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Sunday is calm and restorative for Adora, she goes to the gym, runs a few errands, manages to actually meal prep at least a little bit, and is in bed by nine. The start of her week is relatively nondescript;she works, does a little art with her free time and really just chills. When she leaves work on Tuesday however there is an inexplicable sense of foreboding settling in her gut. She gets home fine, but does see not one, but two people run red lights on the way. She makes herself dinner and scrolls through pet finder with a show on in the background, daydreaming. Still though, she cant shake that weird feeling.

It hits her like a truck when she crawls in bed a few hours later- anxiety. She's not anxious about anything in particular really. Of course, as she tosses and turns for over an hour her mind finds things to worry over needlessly;did she remember to forward those emails before leaving work for the day? Will Glimmer and Bow get tired of her incessant insecurity, realize she's actually super boring and drop her? What if something happens to Raz and she cant get there in time to say-

With an audible huff Adora sits up and marches to the bathroom. She throws back a Benadryl with water from the sink, glares back at her own reflection, and flicks off the light with a sharp and defiant nod before marching back to bed. She turns her side table light back on. A glance at the clock tells her it's already midnight, she's going to be exhausted tomorrow, but she rolls her eyes and starts flipping through her book anyway. Fifteen minutes or so later, as she feels the antihistamine start to drag her under, she thinks to herself, *'maybe getting coffee in the morning wouldn't be a terrible idea'…*

She wakes up to her alarm in the morning, groggy and disoriented as she usually is when she has to resort to taking something to help her sleep. She remembers her thought from the night before, *yeah, cof f ee is actually a great idea* She avoids thinking about any potential of running into Catra altogether. Nope, definitely not a motivating factor, at all. She distracts herself with hurrying through her morning routine to save time for the extra stop, her meal prepping coming in handy for that. Half an hour later, presentable and with her pack ready to go, she grabs an apple on her way out the door for some semblance of breakfast and holds it between her teeth as she locks the door.

She hops in her car to make the short trek to the café, avoiding an unnecessary walk back to fetch her it later. Finding princess parking directly in front of the café, she hops out and hustles to the door. She definitely *doesn't* scan the service area the second she walks in. And her heart definitely does not sink when she sees two unfamiliar people working.

The line moves fairly quickly but she still has time to peek at her phone, five unread messages from Mara and one from Bow in the Best Friend Squad' group chat. She opens the one from Bow first.

Still on for tonight? Thinking I'll make some raviolis! It's followed by a long string of emojs; mostly hearts, the dancing tango lady, and that one with the nails being painted. She texts back quickly to confirm and, moving another step toward the till, opens the messages from Mara.

Doc said all looks good!
Due date is Jan 19!! A series of hearts in rainbow order follow that.
"Told Hope if she could hold the bun in there a couple extra days, we could avoid another Capricorn in the fam haha." Three of the little purple devil faces follow.
Hope did not find that as funny as she should have. :/'
P sure the doc did tho, lol'

Adora rolls her eyes and texts back, "I literally do not know what that means. Happy to hear Mom and baby are both healthy tho!"

A response comes through immediately, "Whatever. It means between you and Hope AND Darla my poor Cancer ass is outnumbered. And I for one am SICK of it!" There's a heart at the end as if to soften the blow.

"Thought you said Cancers and Capricorns are like, buddy signs or whatever?"

"Thought you said you didn't understand what any of it meant?" And its sister signs, should b easier to remember since ur my lil SISTER!" Realizing the person in front of her has started to pay Adora just sends an emoj with its tongue stuck out in response.

The person manning the till is small and wiry, with a shaggy mop of blond hair. They're wearing an apron with a couple of enamel pins and a small shiny button with 'he/him' written on it. He's much more low-key than the person on till last time and since Adora knows what to order, thanks to Catra, her transaction goes much more smoothly. She waits a few minutes and takes her coffee with a, "Thanks!" She looks down at it, the art is slightly less intricate and, unsurprisingly, there are no stars.

On her drive to work she starts to wonder about them. It's been so long since she's seen them, longer even if she doesn't count meeting Bow and Glimmer. She usually doesn't, convinces herself it was something else going on, but now—well now she isn't so sure. What does it mean? She thinks about the last time she saw them before meeting Glimmer. They were faded and infrequent by then, and when they did show up those days it was usually only a few at a time. She was getting ready to leave her foster father's house for the last time, on her way to her emancipation hearing. Gods he was an asshole. He always had been, but he'd become a true terror after his wife left him in the dead of the night six months prior. She remembers their last exchange.

"I don't know why you're bothering. They'll never let a *child* like you be emancipated. You might as well leave all of your *garbage*; you'll be back by days end." He had laughed cruelly at her.

She paused with her hand on the door knob, staring straight ahead she had told him, "I'm *not* a child." Then, turning to look at him dead in the eye she said, "I haven't been for a very long time." And with that she had left. She promised herself she wouldn't look back, but she did it anyway. Her heart sank down to her knees. It wasn't the last glimpse of the house she had lived in for the past three years that did it, but the trail of her own foot prints leading from the door made up of stars that grew dimmer and dimmer with each step. She squeezed her eyes and blinked a couple times until they were gone all together. A deep breath in and out and she had turned around and walked toward Mara's waiting car.

She arrives at the office and takes a moment before she gets out, steeling herself for the day with a few deep breaths. She settles in quickly once she gets upstairs and gets down to it. Luckily, she mostly just has a lot of busywork today, so the time passes quickly and soon enough she's hopping right back in her car, pointing it in the direction of The Castle.

Adora finds parking easily and hops up to the door. She tries the handle, but it's locked. Bow's home then, she knocks, and he comes almost immediately to the door. "Adora! Come on in. I was just about to boil the pasta and everything else is ready, so perfect timing."

"Awesome, I'm so ready for food." She follows him back into the kitchen where they find Glimmer, fussing with a corkscrew and a bottle of wine.

"Hey Adora! How was work, need wine?"

"Adora laughs, "Honestly not that bad but, yes, always thanks." Glimmer nods and finally pulls the cork out with a *pop*. "I heard from Mara this morning."

"Oh, Hope's appointment was yesterday, wasn't it?" Glimmer asks, setting one of three now full glasses next to Bow at the stove where he's boiling the pasta.

"Uh-huh, yeah sounds like everything is on track so far. Thanks Glim." She takes a sip of the wine she's been handed.

"That's great!" Bow says, looking up from his pop for a moment. "Do they have a due date then?"

"Ah, yeah, Glimmer you should appreciate this one. The date is January nineteenth, apparently Mara told Hope at the appointment she should try and avoid labor a couple extra days, so they don't have a Capricorn. Apparently between Hope, Darla and I she feels 'outnumbered.'"

Glimmer busts out in laughter. "Oh my gosh Mara is fucking hilarious; I can't believe both Hope *and* their dog are Caps."

"Hope must have loved that." Bow interjects with lifted brows.

"She did not, sounds like Mara has the doctor charmed though."

"Sounds about right. Okay, so grab you wine and a plate because we are ready to take this shindig to the table." Bow claps his hands together and picks up his own dinner, leading the way to the dining room.

"Oh my gosh Bow, this looks *phenomenal*!" Glimmer gushes as they take their seats.

"Seriously Bow, I think you've out done yourself!"

"Aw, thanks friends! I was just ya know noodling around in the kitchen." The girls laugh and they fall into a companionable silence as everyone digs in to pasta and salad.

"So uh, I went back to Plumeria this morning." Adora offers hesitantly, taking a large gulp of red wine after.

"Oh my gosh, Adora! Coffee girl update?" Glimmer exclaims, Adora feels the table jolt as Bow kicks Glimmer lightly under the table. "Ow! If you want that is"…

Adora shrugs and frowns down at her plate. "Nah, I didn't recognize either of the people working this time."

"Oh, well." Glimmer pouts but then brightens almost immediately. "Maybe we should all go scope it out! What do you say, maybe this weekend? Bow, you don't work until pretty late on Saturday, right?"

"Yeah!" Adora can tell from his expression that Bow is fully on board with this idea.

"I don't know guys isn't this kind of creepy?" Her friends stare at her blankly. "I just mean, I don't even know this person and now I'm gonna, what? Start stalking her at work?"

Glimmer rolls her eyes, "It's a coffee shop Adora, it's not like you're waiting in the bushes and following her home." Adora supposes she has a point. "We won't go if you feel weird but… *please*? I've literally *never* heard you actually express interest in someone! I just wanna see what the fuss is all about."

"For what it's worth, I'm pretty curious too." Bow offers.

"Okay, you still look really conflicted. Hey!" Adora jumps at the exclamation. "How about I read your cards after dinner? Maybe see if they can offer you a little clarity. *Then* you can decide about Saturday."

Adora hesitates, she's let Glimmer read tarot for her before but still isn't totally sure she buys into it. But Glimmer insists that, whether Adora believes in the magic and mysticism of the cards or not, they're still a powerful tool for self-reflection. "Okay, sure, after dinner."

"Great, it's decided then! I can clean up and get dessert going after dinner while you two do your reading."

"Bow , no! You did all the cooking; we should at least help with the cleaning." Adora protests.

"Adora, I love you, but," he points his fork threateningly in her direction, "stay the *hell* out of my kitchen."

She puts her hands up in in surrender, and Glimmer shifts the conversation to vent about family drama. "Oh my gosh you guys! You would not *believe* what Aunt Casta said to my mom when she called her to talk details for our trip"…

After dinner Adora finds herself sitting cross-legged on the living room floor. There are a few crystals Glimmer has collected from various shelves scattered on the floor next to her and her deck is resting between where Adora is sat and the cushion Glimmer will, eventually, claim for herself. Currently she is wandering around the room, a burning bundle of mint, lavender and sage harvested from the apartment's balcony garden in hand, occasionally blowing on it and humming lightly.

"I think we're ready!" She says and as she plops down on her cushion, she drops the smoking bundle into a large abalone shell to her right. She picks up her deck and hands it to Adora. "Shuf fle please!" Adora begins to do so and as she does glimmer says, "Great and while you're shuf fling think of your query . f you don't have a specific one just meditate on your relationship with love and romantic love in general. And just hand the cars back when you feel ready."

Adora most definitely isn't going to be able to come up with anything specific, so she starts to think about the concept of love. It's always been murky territory for her. She feels love, *of course* she does! She loves Raz, Mara and Hope, and her friends. She loved the little cat she had in elementary school who had to be surrendered when they moved out of the house. Adora loves and has loved but she

supposes she's never felt totally secure in the receiving of love, *maybe* ever? Or at least, not since she was little.

Romantic love however, well Adora is pretty sure she's never felt *that*. Sure, she went on a couple of dates in high school, mostly dances when someone asked her, but they were with guys and she wasn't really into it. Then, after being emancipated and needing to work to help out with bills after Mara took her in, on top of school, she really just didn't have the time. And well, since coming out all she's done with girls, with the exception of a couple set ups her friends have arranged, is get really flustered at the gym any time she gets caught looking a little too long.

She doesn't miss the way the cards have been steadily glowing brighter as she shuffles and, feeling ready to be done with that line of thinking anyway, Adora passes the cards to Glimmer. She cuts the deck once, twice, and then closes her eyes and starts feeling her way through the deck pulling out one, two and then three cards. She lays them flat on the ground between them, blinks her eyes open and sets the rest of the deck to the side. As she's flipping the cards over one by one Bow emerges from the kitchen.

"Alright! I just threw the pie into the oven! Should be ready before too long." He looks at Adora and scratches the side of his neck awkwardly. "After the diner the other day I thought maybe… well I hope you like the pie."

Adora quickly puts an end to his uncomfortable fidgeting. "Bow," she can hear how choked up she is in her voice and is sure he can too, "that sounds amazing, thanks."

At that he lets his shoulders drop and plops down to the ground to sit beside his friends and the cards spread between them. "Good… that's good. So, what have we got going on here?" He looks down at Adora's cards and whistles. "Wow, powerful spread. Looks like someone is feeling some *feelings*"

Adora looks between Bow, Glimmer, the cards; The Tower, The Hermit, and The Star she notes, and back to Bow again. "What?" She looks at Glimmer, "What's that mean?"

"Well I think what Bow is referring to is that we've got all major cards here." Glimmer explains.

"What makes them Major?" Adora asks, feeling like Glimmer kind of expects her to know. She's walked Adora through the basics before but that was like, months and months ago.

Patient as ever Glimmer tells her, "They're all from the Major Arcana, the Minor is the one with the suits, remember? Kind of like a deck of cards; more symbolism and stuff of course but you get the idea. The Majors are just like, I wouldn't say more *powerful* but they're really significant, like trump cards. When I read I do so within the context of any majors in the spread. Also, just from a statistical point of view it's significant. There's twenty-two of them and seventy-eight cards in the deck so it's less than like, a thirty percent chance that you'll pull one."

"Gotcha, and if you only pull minor cards?"

Glimmer shrugs, "It's chill, the cards still have plenty to say. But enough chit chat! Let's read these bad boys."

"Glim, you mind if I throw on some music?" Bow asks.

"Go for it! Just keep the vibe chill please?"

"You got it."

Glimmer and Adora look down at the cards together, Glimmer brushes her hand across them and in its wake; a sea of stars. Just sort of bouncing lightly to the beat of Bow's music, crowded most tightly around the cards and just sort of spreading out from there. Adora blinks, feeling caught off guard, almost unsteady. It seems to her almost as if every time she's seen them in the last few days

there's a little bit more of them, and like they glow just a little more warmly. Almost testing the waters, asking her if shell let them stay , if she's ready to come home again, how vulnerable she is capable of being. She doesnt have an answer for them, doesnt know what possibilities she's ready to open herself up to.

"So," Glimmer starts, "figured we'd keep it simple with just a pass/present/future spread. We're reading from your perspective so, past...present...future." She indicates the cards in turn from left to right. "So, starting with a bit of a doozy here in the past; The T ower." The card has a drawing of a house on a cliff, with a bolt of lightning and a what looks like a sun setting over water beneath the cliff side. "So, this speaks to a dramatic, usually sudden and unwelcome, event. Sometimes this is read as ominous, but Ilike to see it as hopeful, because after the events of The Tower you are left on firmer ground. Kind of like a fire burning away the old and what' s left nourishing the soil to grow new life. Does that resonate with you?"

Adora clears her throat, feeling awkward. "Uh, yep, yeah."

Bow, giving her a calculating look from the side, asks her, "Do you want to expand on that?"

Adora feels her entire body clench at the question and it' s almost as if the stars do too, wavering like they might blink out at any moment. She takes a deep breath and on the exhale the stars seem to relax and resume their bouncing. "Uh, Imean Ican. Y ou guys know a little bit about, uh, what happened with Raz." Both of them nod, encouraging her to go on. "W ell Imean that was definitely sudden and unwelcome, it definitely felt like my life was burning down. She just...she was getting old and she had a conference with my teacher , just like a regular check in thing, and Idont really know what was said but then one thing leads to another and the next thing Iknow some social worker is telling me Raz needs to go somewhere where people can take care of her and that means." She can feel tears pricking in her eyes. "that means she wont be able to take care of *me* anymore."

"I'm so sorry that happened Adora." Bow says, shifting a little bit closer and settling a hand on her knee. Glimmer nods along.

Adora shrugs, "I mean it is what it is I guess, it was hard but I found out, I mean I know you know this, but she's got dementia. I guess all the forgetfulness and stuff that was going on, everything that was slipping through the cracks, I just thought was Raz. She was always pretty forgetful and so silly." Adora chuckles and it's watery. "Honestly, I'm pretty sure that woman smoked more leaf than I ever could have imagined at the time, especially when she was young. Anyway, after that it was a matter of bouncing between foster homes every few years. My social worker was mostly clueless and totally lost track of Raz but thankfully she always made sure that I got to see Mara. I think it helped that Mara was legally an adult by then and hassled her regularly."

"Honestly, goddess bless Mara." Glimmer praises.

"I really don't know what I would ever have done without her. She's the one who helped me find Raz a few years later and took me in after I left the foster system so, I was really lucky all things considered but it was just hard, and I always felt so… *unstable*."

"That's so messed up Adora. You never take away a Capricorns sense of stability! What is earth without structure, I ask you!"

"Like a mudslide?" Bow provides helpfully.

"A mudslide, yes! Thank you, Bow." Adora shrugs again but laughs at their antics.

"Alright, alright enough tragic backstory now, what's going on here with the present?"

Glimmer sits upright again and Bow shift backs to his previous position. "Right, so The Hermit! Doesn't sound *at all* like anyone I know, what about you Bow?" She snickers.

"Hey! I am not a hermit! I'm here with you two right now, aren't I?"

"Yeah, yeah, but *romantically* you are, seriously have you been on a date in this calendar year?"

"Yes! You set me up with that one girl-what's her name, like a couple weeks after my birthday."

"You mean that girl from my econ class? Yeah, I don't remember her name either honestly. And you barely went out! Remember, you cut out after drinks and skipped the movie because supposedly neither of you were feeling it?"

"Still a date." Adora defends.

"I mean, *technically*. Whatever Adora, so The Hermit, maybe you can identify with it, maybe you can't. But the cards never lie. Also, I should note this is the one reversed card in your pull."

Adora looks at it curiously, it's a moonlit, pink and blue river with a figure standing off in the distance, on a bridge. "That's significant?"

"Eh, depends on who you ask. I think to a degree it is, the way I interpret it is; it usually means you have a choice to make or like, a say in the matter. So, The Hermit speaks to turning communication inward, taking space from your relationships to work on your relationship with yourself."

"Oh." Her friends look at her searchingly for a moment.

"Yeah, so, with this card in the reversed position you're likely being called to do some self-reflection. Kind of, take some time to get to know yourself again and evaluate what's important to you. The choice is, do you take the time you need to be honest with yourself so you can come out stronger and more clear-minded for it? Or, do you allow yourself to spiral further and further into a cycle of denying whatever thoughts are plaguing you?"

Adora immediately thinks about the stars, she zones out, watching one skip its way across the bridge drawn on the card, and down the river. Someone clears their throat lightly, whether to get her attention or just instinctually she couldn't say. Either way she isn't really ready to talk about the stars, about what they could mean. "Gotcha and um...The Star?" *Well so much for not talking about stars*, Adora thinks, but it's too late now.

Glimmer pauses and stares at Adora for a moment. Whatever she sees seems to prompt her onward and she looks down at the card. This one is much more abstract than the last two, but Adora can make out orange lilies on a backdrop of pinprick stars in a dark blue sky. "Right, so considering the query of The Hermit and The Star's position in the future it's likely to be a warning or a sign of hope, depending on your choices in the present. The Star is a generally going to be the latter. Meaning if you make choices that, while maybe hard, are in your own best interest," she makes eye contact with Adora and the look is all significance, no subtlety. "The Star is what you have to look forward to. The Star speaks to hope, of course, but also faith in a brighter future paying off. Sort of trusting in the universe, the stars, whatever higher power you're into, to guide you home or like, wherever it is you need to go."

It's quiet for just a moment and then Bow's phone is chiming. "Oop, sorry! That's our pie, be right back." He scurries out and Glimmer makes eye contact with her once more.

"So Adora, what's it gonna be?"

Chapter End Notes

> Super excited for the next chap! We finally get to meet Perfuma and Scorpia who have my FAVE connections to magic- especially Scorpia! Should have that one polished up tomorrow! Also descriptions of Glimmer's cards are based on my own deck; Prisma Visions Tarot!

Venus in Cancer

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

After the tarot reading turned therapy session Adora promised Bow and Glimmer that she would take them to Plumeria and they're going, likeright now . And that's fine, great even. Even when she came and didn't see Catra, the place was great!The cof fee wasn't the same, but it was still really good. So, she's excited to be taking her two best friends to what is rapidly becoming her favorite spot in town.

She's just nervous about how excited *they* are.

Adora stops a couple yards from the café door, it's not the first time on the walk over that she's stopped short but Bow and Glimmer stumble into her just the same. She turns to face them. "Okay just like, don't be weird okay . I've only met this person once and last time I came she wasn't even here so just be chill."

"Adora, we're just excited that you have a potential romantic interest and are curious- "

"Which is totally natural since you've hardly taken an interest in anyone since we met you. Like this girl's got to be something really special!"Glimmer impatiently steam rolls Bow' s attempt to placate Adora. She then takes to craning her neck over Adora's shoulder, as if she even knows who she's looking for.

"Ahem, as I was saying, we're definitely curious but we aren't going to lose our heads, right Glimmer? *Glimmer*?"Bow has his patented "dad look' on but Glimmer barely pays him any mind.

"Right yeah, sure, heads firmly attached to necks, all good."She finally stops making a show of looking over toward the café window

to level a look at Adora. "Now , can we *please* go in? I'm also in desperate need of caffeine and sugar, the object of your affection isn't the only thing you're standing in the way of here."

Adora hesitates but ultimately lets her shoulders drop with a nod and turns around. "Wow this girl has really got you twisted up huh?" Bow comments with a hint of a smirk.

"Shut up Bow ." His expression doesn't drop and instead he takes a couple extra-long strides to make it to the door and hold it open for his companions. Adora walks in behind Glimmer and looks around, it's exactly as she remembers it, though the lighting is maybe a little bit warmer than her memories.

There's a lot of dark wood elements, countertops line the whole café, with chairs that face out the windows. An occasional bookshelf is dispersed throughout to break up the line of the counter, and in the large open area is a long, olive green, velvet couch and two chairs with that same dark wood and green velvet. The rest of the dining area is filled with a few tables that sit two, or four people, with green glass lamps sitting at the edges.

The most striking element however is the plants which fill every available surface;with just a few books here and there, every shelf on the bookshelves is brimming with them, every corner has at least one large plant (and several have plant stands with more medium plants as well), the milk station is crowded with carafes, sugar and even more plants and they are dotted along all the counters in the space-both in front of and behind the service counter. There are even several hanging plants placed around. Most of the plants are thriving but here and there is a plant that looks like it's surviving at best, making them stick out like a sore thumb amidst the lush green.

"Wow!" Glimmer drags the word out long and low . "It's like a jungle or-or a forest. I *love* it!"

A soft giggle from the counter draws the attention of the three friends over to a woman, leaning on the surface. She looks soft and sweet,

a long blond braid has flowers incorporated neatly in and falls past her waist, freckles dot along her cheek bones and she's wearing a flowy, pastel pink maxi dress. "Thanks, welcome in!"

"Oh, hi, um, Ilove all your plants!" Adora loves watching Glimmer get flustered and this is no exception, in fact she revels in it extra after all the teasing she endured on the way here.

"Thanks! They're my babies." Another woman, with short platinum hair and an undercut comes in from the back carrying trays of pastries. Adora feels her heart sink, it's early afternoon, and if these two are working Catra probably isn't. Who knows, maybe she got a new job. Or moved, or only works weekday afternoons while Adora is at work now. Who knows? "A w and here's my other baby!"

The newcomer flushes and grabs the back of her neck bashfully. "A w shucks, thanks Fuma! Hi friends! I'm Scorpia!" She says introduces herself with a small wave. "Do y'all know Perfuma?"

They shake their heads collectively and Perfuma jumps in to explain, "Not yet babe! These folks just walked in." She turns back to look at them. "So, I'm sure you gathered but, my names Perfuma. I'm part owner of Plumeria, just don't ask me a thing about the cof fee! My partner takes care of that side of things and the plants are all me."

"Y our space is amaz ing! Ho w long have you been open?" Bow makes his way closer to the counter and now the four are crowded around, keeping the circle opened to still include Scorpia who is working to fill the case in front of them.

"W e opened up shop almost two years ago! W ell probably do something for the anniversary in August." She smiles proudly at this.

"Nice, two years! I can't believe we've never made it in before. So Scorpia, does that mean you're the brains behind the cof fee side of things?" Bow turns to look at her and the ladies around him follow suit.

"Ha!" Scorpia laughs as if the idea is absurd. "No, no I'm just the romantic partner. And the cupcake maker!" She indicates the now full pastry case which Adora looks at for the first time. Man, everything in there looks phenomenal. How did she not notice before? Well maybe she knows. "Catra is the real brains behind the operation, yes business woman extraordinaire." Adora begs her cheeks not to blush at the mention of that name, not that they listen. Either way her interest is certainly peaked. Catra is part owner here? That's really intimidating, uh-interesting that is. Also, hot, definitely hot. Shit Adora's *cheeks* are hot, she has got to calm down. "Oh! You folks probably came in for drinks huh? I can just go grab her from the back. I told her I'd keep an eye on the front if she wanted to sneak in a ten, and was supposed to grab her if anyone came in. Be right back!"

Scorpia disappears behind the door to the back and Adora ignores the burning holes her friends are boring into her neck with their eyes. Sensing that she won't be reacting any more than she can help and unwilling to stand in silence, Bow turns back to Perfuma. "So, do you make the food here too? Anything you'd recommend?"

"Scorpia makes everything elsewhere actually! She has a small commissary kitchen she uses to run a catering business. And really you can't go wrong, it's all vegan and she uses fresh flowers from our garden at home. It's all inspired by the language of flowers, so you can go by what sounds good or by intention. Personally, I just love the Daily Gratitude Muffins!" She smiles at them and nods to a tray on the top shelf of the case.

There's a little tag in front, Daily Gratitude: With Begonia for Gratitude and Sweet Woodruff for Humility this guy is sure to start your day off on the right foot. And if the flowers don't help, the fiber is sure to do the trick! "All sales support our community coffee and meals program" Adora laughs at the fiber bit and slides her gaze to look at the next tray, she's just reading about the Get That Banana Bread (This banana bonanza is sure to help you harness your inner Capricorn with Cornflower for wealth, prosperity, fortune and

friendship! Seriously what does that even mean?" when movement in front of her causes her to look up and right into the blue and hazel eyes she's been thinking about all week.

Catra smiles, "Welcome back Adorable, if you're looking for a snack the carrot cake is bomb."

"Funny , if Adora's looking for a snack I'd recommend you." Glimmer murmurs under her breath. Adora blanches and slams her elbow into Glimmers arm, *hard*. She prays silently that Catra didn't hear that, or at least doesn't notice her absolute mortification in response. If her cat that caught the canary expression is anything to go by though, she definitely did.

"So how about it?" She raises an eyebrow and it feels to Adora like a dare. "What'll you have?"

Seriously, Adora can't possibly blush any harder , right? She honest to goddess gulps but is at least able to maintain eye contact. "Uh, cake sounds great."

She looks down to see what she's ordered. "To Be Young Again: Let this Carrot Cake take you home again with Primrose for Youth, Gladiolus for Remembrance, and Queen Anne's Lace for Sanctuary. Topped with lemon and Lilac cream cheese icing for the joy of Youth and a Daisy garnish for Innocence and Hope.'

Catra smirks and nods. "That for here or to go?"

"Here please."

Grabbing a plate to load with her order she asks, "What about you hooligans?" She looks up at Bow and Glimmer , still with the smirk.

"I'll try the Daily Gratitude please!" Bow turns his attention to the drink menu and Adora sees him eyeing the little specials board. Barista's Choice' again, Adora feels more pleased than feels reasonable about that development.

“Adora did you see the banana bread?” Glimmer laughs. “Do you think it would just like, heighten your Capricorn-ness or would it just cancel out? Oooh, you could like, chill for a day! Like, oh my goddess, remember when you ate that brownie- “

“Alright Glimmer! Yes, I saw it.” Glimmer at least looks like she’s realized the territory she just started to breech in front of Adora’s… crush or whatever and looks abashed.

“A Cap, huh?” Catra’s attention is back on her.

“I still don’t get what that means, but yeah.” Adora grumbles, unsure if she should be pleased or mortified that Catra now knows that information.

“Hmm.” Catra considers her for a moment and then turns back to Glimmer. “You know Adorable here’s moon and rising?”

“I do, she doesn’t.” Glimmer laughs again.

“I figured as much.”

“Cap sun, Taurus moon, Leo Rising.” She pauses and gives Adora a look she’s not sure she likes. “Cancer Venus” Yeah, she definitely doesn’t like that look.

Well, Catra is smiling at least so that’s gotta be a good sign.
“Interesting.” is all she says.

“Why is that always what astrology people say when they hear someone’s chart? What’s so interesting?”

And then, in a move surely meant to stop Adora’s heart once and for all, Catra looks her dead in the eye and just says, “You.”

“You know, I could really go for a weed brownie right about now .” Perfuma muses as if she’s totally missed the direction the conversation moved in since that tid-bit slipped, oblivious to the mounting tension in the air. Scorpia finally emerges from the back,

saving everyone else from coming up with a response. "Oooh, babe will you swing us by the dispensary on the way home?"

"Sure thing!" Scorpia beams and crosses the counter . "Have a good rest of your shift Wildcat! Still on for game night this coming Friday?"

"Sure Scorp, now get out of here, both of you." With a final wave at the group the duo takes off and Catra clears her throat looking a briefly awkward in the wake of their departure. "So, drinks?"

"Oh, I think we all were hoping to get the barista's choice, or I guess that's your choice." Glimmer looks at her friends to confirm and when they both nod, she looks back to Catra. "And can I get and Own Your Power muffin too please? And you can ring them up all together!"

Bows, "Thanks Glim!" Almost drowns out Adora's, "Glim, no you don't have to do that!"

"You're welcome Bow . Back off Adora, don't harsh on my love language!"

Catra laughs and punches the order into her till, a quick swipe of Glimmer's card and she's passing the pastries across the counter. "I'll have those drink right out for ya." She crosses to the espresso machine and after Glimmer signs her receipt the trio makes their way to the couch to set their things down before they go to wait for their drinks.

"What was your muf fin all about Glim?" Bow asks peeking over curiously.

"Oh, it sounds so good! It's like, dill and dandelion and is supposed to help you overcome evil and make your dreams come true or something like that. This muffin is going to get me a 4.0 when my grades come back." She smiles smugly , as if she's come up with a fool proof plan.

"That' sa powerful muf fin."Bow laughs. As they start their way toward the pick-up counter, he turns his attention to Adora and says under his breath, "Soc couldnt help but notice the heavy-handed flirting going on just now ."

"What!"T oo loud, way too loud. Yep, Catra definitely looked over. She turns back to the drinks after a moment and Adora releases her exhale. In a harsh whisper she adds, "wasnt- Im not even- Bow!"

"Not you Adora, *her*."Glimmer butts in as they reach the counter , cutting off Adora's chance to deny everything and/or run away. The latter sounding much more appealing at the moment. She probably shouldnt though, right? Right, that would be like, super fucking weird.

Catra looks up at their arrival and smiles, sliding three drinks across the counter one by one, naming them as she goes. "Alright Crop Top, here's a shot in the dark with arguably way too much vanilla. Glim, was it?"

"Glimmer , actually."

Catra lifts a brow, "Right, so for Sparkles,"she ignores the huf f she gets in response, "Grapefruit shakerato, medium roast, light on the sugar. And for Adorable,"She looks right at Adora for this one, "Spicy Chai, extra cinnamon."

Bow and Glimmer mutter their thanks and pick up their drinks but Adora is stuck, and Catra shows no signs of releasing her just yet. She grabs her cup but Catra doesnt immediately let go. The air is charged and glowing, Adora's not really sure what that means, but something tells her not to back down. Maybe it's just her stubborn competitive streak surfacing. Either way, she holds eye contact and holds the cup. Finally, Catra chuckles quietly and releases, sliding her hand back toward herself. Adora doesnt know what' s most enchanting;her eyes, that chuckle, or the stars suddenly tumbling lightly from all three drinks.

"Thanks." The word is soft but genuine, though Adora isn't really sure what she's expressing gratitude for. The drink of course but it... feels like more than that. Feels like Catra *deserves* more than that.

"Sure thing, enjoy ." And with that she turns around and Adora is dismissed.

Bow whistles lowly. "Seriously!" Glimmer whisper yells. "The unresolved sexual tension there, I mean goddess above Adora. And don't- " She cuts Adora off with a warning finger in her face before she can even get her mouth fully open. "...even try to argue! Seriously Adora, did you even hear how many times she managed to call you *adorable*? What was that?"

Bow nods sagely and takes a sip of his drink as he sits; they've finally arrived back at their seats on the couch. Suddenly his eyes widen, "Holy crow y'all, I know we have to analyze Adora's love life at length here- "

"No, we really don't."

"...but this is seriously , so good! It weirdly reminds me of our senior ski trip, do you remember that Glimmy? Oh, that was so fun! That's where we- " Bow cuts off abruptly clearing his throat and pausing to take another drink. His eyes widen again and both he and Glimmer are blushing, leaving Adora to glance back and forth between them, wondering what she's missed. "How has she never heard about this trip before? Ahem- where we had so much fun!"

"Sorry , what am I? What trip is this?" Adora knows she must sound as lost as she feels.

Bow looks away and stuffs a large bite of muffin in his mouth. Glimmer glares at him but he either doesn't notice or doesn't care. "Just the ski trip our high school takes seniors on every year . Super fun, Bow fell on his butt trying to ski like, so many times." Glimmer laughs but it's forced, and Bow's only response is a weak smile that, frankly, looks more like a grimace.

"Okay so why are you two being so weird about this?" Again, Adora glances between her two friends, waiting to see who will answer. This time Glimmer hastily picks up her drink, shoving the straw in her moth. Her eyes widen at first too, but she seems to relax into herself at least a little bit after that.

Bow sighs, as if resigned to his fate. "Uh, it's where," his voice breaks a bit and he winces, sighing again, "Glim and I uh, kissed the first time on our senior ski trip. I'd come out as a lesbian junior year, but I came like, all the way out to my dads over holiday break shortly after. I was still kind of figuring myself out and the timing it was just a lot; I was feeling kind of confused still and it didn't seem like, the move, I guess. We talked about it at the time, but uh, don't anymore, very often." He glances over at Glimmer and she reaches across Adora to give Bow's hand a squeeze.

"It's in the past and we have all the time in the world to figure our shit out." Glimmer holds Bow's gaze until he nods at her and then she lets it and her hand drop.

"Right, got it. Uh, sorry . Sorry to pry." Adora smiles halfheartedly at them both.

"You're not prying Adora." Bow pauses to cough into the crook of his elbow. For once Adora lets herself notice the stars that escape. "You're allowed to ask us questions about ourselves, we want to share with you. We just clearly have some work left to do in that area."

"Right, okay . Thanks Bow so uh?"

"Yes?"

"You really think she was flirting?" Adora fights the small smile threatening to break loose. Her attempt to cut the tension in the air works. She's glad, for once, to take over the hot seat if it means giving her best friends a respite.

"Adora, gimme a break!" Glimmer cuts in, "you don't make that much eye contact if you aren't interested, like *very* interested."

"Okay , maybe but how do you even know she's, y'know?"

Bow and Glimmer share a glance, and both come up empty. "Y eah, no. You're gonna need to help us out here."

"What if she' s not like," Adora glances at the service area and see Catra blessedly helping another customer. Nevertheless, she lowers her voice to a whisper. "Like, queer or whatever?"

Her friends both blanch and then Bow is smiling hesitantly and Glimmer lets out a full-on laugh. Booming and loud, too loud. Catra is mere feet away and they're just sitting there, *talking about her* . "I would refer you to my prior statement about the eye contact. Seriously Adora you can be so oblivious; do you even have gaydar?"

"I mean I didn't even know I was gay until like, a year ago so… maybe not." Adora grumbles and slides down into the couch, as if she could disappear between the cushions like a set of keys and loose change.

Glimmer makes a face like she's considering that and tilts her head side to side for a moment. "Y ou got me there I guess."

"Glimmer!" Bow admonishes before returning his attention to his friend who is about to melt off the couch. "Adora it' s okay to feel unsure and insecure about whether or not your crush likes you. And it's good that you want to respect her boundaries and not make assumptions about her identity." She sits up a little bit further at that. "W e just don't want you to ignore when someone is sending you really clear signal, and risk closing yourself off from things that you may want. Things that could be really good for you if you open yourself to the possibility." She sinks back down again and pouts.

"Girls are scary ." Both of her friends laugh at this.

"That they are my friend, that they are." Bow pats her knee soothingly. "So, are you gonna try these treats or not? Your drink is gonna get cold."

She leans forward and tries the drink first. It's spicy and so good, it makes her feel warm and cozy; like she could curl up on the couch for a little cat nap and, for once, have no trouble getting to sleep. It feels good after all the tension this little excursion has brought. She indulges in a few more sips before pulling her slice of cake closer. She eyes it hungrily while Glimmer and Bow move the conversation on to a debate over what to watch that evening when they get back to The Castle.

Adora takes a bite and, *oh*! Suddenly she is eight years old again with Granny Razz, picking berries on the side of the road. She crouches in the dirt watching a lady bug crawl through a sea of stars and relishes when a car zooms by and kicks up a brief but satisfying breeze which carries a few stars further down the street. She closes her eyes as if to hold tight to the memory, as if she can really *feel* herself there, in that moment. It's like that first sip of coffee again but this time she can feel the *earth* of the stars tickle her skin. As if from the distance of her childhood, she hears her fork clatter back to its plate.

When she opens her eyes there are stars, so many stars. Not just lingering around the drinks anymore, but *everywhere*. They're coating her fork, are scattered like crumbs across the plate and table, she looks up to her friends and sees them rolling down from the crowns of both of their heads, they tumble down from the ceiling and run up the walls and over floorboards. Bow reaches a hand over to place it on her shoulder bracingly. She watches the progression as stars practically drip from his arm and hand.

"Adora? Adora you're tearing up, are you okay?"

"Seriously, how good is that cake? I might need to try that." Glimmer snarks but Adora hears the genuine concern laced within.

The tears are spilling over now, just a couple as she fights to keep them in check. A laugh and sob escape from her throat simultaneously, almost sounding like a hiccup, and she is smiling at her friends through her tears. "Just, I lo-love you guys so much and th..ere' s just I c..an see so many stars."

Chapter End Notes

Thanks so much to everyone who's reading this story! And double thanks to all of you who have taken the time to review! I had a blast working out the details of Scorpia's connection to magic! I'm obsessed with flowers and food magic!

Tell Me About The Big Bang

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Adora, we love you too!"

"So much! Uh, you mind explaining the bit about stars though? Is that like a metaphor?" Glimmer asks hesitantly, looking around the couch briefly.

Adora is suddenly terrified, and terribly ashamed. "Oh, uh, not really." Neither friend presses her to continue, they just wait quietly. She glances slowly over at the bar and, blessedly, her outburst doesn't seem to have garnered any extra attention. Catra appears to be cleaning and chatting with another barista who has apparently started working since they sat down. She suddenly feels really lucky the couch is on the other side of the café. She turns her attention back to her friends. "Um, it's kind of weird."

"We *love* weird." Bow tells her and Glimmer vigorously nods in agreement.

"Well uh, so when I was younger, like in elementary school and stuff I used to see or well, maybe imagine? all these *stars* everywhere. They seemed to like, kind of crowd around things or people or situations that made me happy or felt really special."

"What do they look like?" Glimmer interjects, Adora pauses as if to gauge whether the question is genuine or not. She senses nothing but innocent curiosity in her friends' tone and expression, and the stars tumbling down from the crown of her head seem to sparkle just a little bit more. She watches them for another moment before answering.

"Um, its sort of weird to explain and it' s not always the same. Imean theyre always glowy and warm but sometimes theyre more like little pinpricks of light and sometimes theyre likestar shaped, Iguess? Usually it's a mix. And for the most part theyre like yellow/goldish but occasionally there's some silvery, almost opalescence mixed in. Super sparkly, in general."

"And they just like stick to things or?"

"Well, no usually theyre moving, kind of likein time to the energy that attracts them or whatever. Or at least that's my suspicion, sometimes if there's music they sort of move in time to that. So, like now theyre, um like, trickling up and down the walls. Theyre also crowding around certain things and bouncing a little bit in place. Theyre really just *drip*ping off the two of you, mostly sliding down um," she scratches at her upper arms bashfully , "your heads, sort of."

Rather than looking at her with disbelief or disdain like she feared, the last part of her confession actually serves to please and almost bolster both of her friends. t' s Bow who asks, "So how often do you see them now?

"Uh, almost never ."

" *Never?* "

"Nu-uh." She shakes her head and scratches a phantom itch on the bridge of her nose. "I mean likebefore today? Maybe five times or so since Iturned seventeen."

" *Five* times, in the last *eight* years?" Glimmer gasps, as if horrified at the disappearance of something she didnt know existed until ten minutes ago.

Adora nods, "Roughly , sometimes Ithink Isee them but then Iblink andtheyre gone."

There's a moment of silence and then Bow asks, "Well what happened to make them all but disappear?"

"I mean, I just got older and that's kids' stuff, everyone told me that was kids' stuff. Even Mara kind of shut me down when I was still seeing them into my teens. So, I just stopped talking about them and slowly they just faded away." She pauses, remembering the moment those fading footprints disappeared. Thinking about the first time she saw them again, trailing up Glimmers arm. "And I guess I… just wonder, if they are back and I'm not just losing my mind, what does that mean? What else have I been categorizing as kids' stuff and shut down, what have I been blocking out and- I mean Glimmer you like, just called me out on this last weekend."

"Uhm, what?" Glimmer blinks and Bow gives her an inquiring look, bordering on stern.

"You know, you called me at work, and said-you said I'm always trying so hard to prove that I'm an adult. And it's *true* because I *had* to, like I literally had to prove to a judge that I was an adult and then was solely responsible for my own wellbeing. I mean I had Mara to help but for the most part." She shrugs. "And it worked, and I've been really proud of where it's gotten me but…"

"But?" Bow prompts.

"But what if I was wrong?" When did Adora become the kind of person to cry in public anyway? This was so not her vibe. "What if I sacrificed things I didn't need to, I mean my *childhood* -" she breaks off, too choked up to continue without respite.

Sweet Bow reaches over and pulls her into a hug, a really good Bow hug. She feels loved all the way down to her toes. Soon she feels Glimmer place a soothing hand on her back as well. Pulling back without releasing her Bow looks her in the eye as he says, "Adora you're so strong and you've been through a lot. It's okay that you

developed coping mechanisms to get through the rough patches and lost sight of some of the magic inside of you. It's also really healthy to reevaluate those coping mechanisms, find what isn't healthy or no longer serves you and adjust. Find your magic again, or your stars as it were."

"So you guys just believe me? You don't think I'm..." She trails off, *nuts? Or gullible? Or mockery? Totally unstable?* She finishes in her head.

The both of them frown at her and it's Glimmer who answers. "Of course not, Adora we love you, which means we trust you, which means we believe in you and your truth."

"Totally!"

"Gods, how am I supposed to just unpack all of that? You two make it sounds so easy." She can feel the grimace that takes over her face.

"No," Bow shakes his head sadly, "it's really not, unfortunately. But what's that quote? 'Work hard at work worth doing.'"

Adora chuckles wetly. "Right, right, thanks Bow." She turns to her other side, "You too Glim, really. I haven't talked about his stuff in so long. And as naive as I started to feel believing in these silly stars I really missed them when they were gone, you know? I really appreciate you, both of you so much." She grabs a hand from each of them and squeezes. "You make me feel safe and *seen* and-and I honestly love you both *so much*."

"Aw Adora! You big softie." Glimmer looks over her head and they must exchange some sort of look because Adora feels Bow nod and then suddenly she's being crushed between them in a big group hug.

"We *love* you!" The two of them practically shout, which thoroughly embarrasses Adora.

"Alright, alright! I think that's enough of Adora Emotional Vulnerability Hour if that's okay with the two of you." They nod against her and release. "Didn't you two say you had something to talk to me about of the way over here?"

"Right!" Says Bow.

"Yeah, real convenient you *love us* so much," Glimmer waggles her eyebrows at Adora. "Cause we were actually thinking—well, your place is still month to month, right?" Adora nods, confused by this turn in the conversation. She leans forward to grab her plate so she can keep eating and leans all the way against the back of the couch so she can look at both of her friends.

"*Well*," Bow says, "Our third roommate is moving out so…" He looks at Adora beseechingly, but her lungs are failing her, and she can't respond. "Well we were thinking maybe you'd want to move in with us at the beginning of August."

Adora swallows her bite thickly, and then her mouth just sort of… hangs open. She's sure she looks absolutely ridiculous, but her brain is too many paces behind to care. Glimmer jumps in enthusiastically. "We already talked to the landlord too! She said we've been excellent tenants so far, so as long as your references come back positive, which of course they will, she's happy to edit the lease."

"Adora?"

"Yeah, sorry yeah. I'm just—catching up, sorry. So, to be clear, you two," she looks between them, "want *me* to come live in The Castle with you in August, this August?"

"Only if you want! If you like having your own space, we totally respect that." Bow assures her.

"Totally, but I would just point out that you'd actually be saving on rent for more space, plus our company, *plus* like, an actual kitchen instead of whatever you call what your current place has."

"I think it's a kitchenette." Offers Bow.

"Glim, you don't have to *sell* me on this. I mean, yeah! This is so exciting. Literally nothing would make me happier." It's true and as the news settles in around her she starts grinning, watching as all the stars around her shine a little more brightly. There's squealing on either side of her and she barely has time to set her plate down again before she's being crushed into another group hug.

After that day Plumeria is quickly becoming a favorite haunt for the best friend squad, and they end up there in some combination or other several times over the next week. They assure Adora that, while they do enjoy seeing Adora blush at every turn when Catra is behind the counter and taking every opportunity to tease her, they just really like the place. "Seriously, what is even in those baked goods? Nothing is supposed to be *that* good!" Bow claims. In fact, Adora knows that Glimmer has even started to go on her own when both Adora and Bow have to work.

It's Friday night now and Adora is at The Castle for movie night. Or as Glimmer calls it, "an excuse to take down three to four bottles of wine." Honestly, at the rate they're going soon enough Bow is going to throw on a cartoon for background noise. Then they'll gab the night away and end up skipping the movie altogether. Glimmer is laying on the couch, strewn across the entire thing with her legs flopped on Bow's lap. Next to them Adora has folded herself up on the chair, watching the small stars that float lazily around the room and wondering if they've always been there. They've caught up on the events of the day and are now listening to Glimmer go over travel plans.

"So, I'll drive up tomorrow morning, and then Adora, were you able to get that half day on Friday so Bow can grab you and drive you up then?"

"Sure was, my boss actually said I can take off by eleven if I get all my reports in Thursday before I take off. Shouldn't be an issue."

"Great! Want to just text me when you're taking off and I can meet you at your place?" Bow checks in, looking away from the TV where he's started to scroll through options, no longer asking for their input.

"Works for me, thanks Bow."

"Of course, wanna swing by Plumeria after I get you? I think coffee would be good on the way out of town."

"Oh, s-sure!" Maybe one day she'll be able to control her wild blushing. Not today, clearly. As it is, she feels her face bloom with the mere mention of the café.

"What, without me?" Glimmer pouts dramatically.

"Glimmer," Bow laughs at her, "didn't you *just* go on your own earlier today?"

She rolls her eyes as if he's intentionally missing a very obvious point. "Whatever, bring me one of those sage scones please? With that super good rose jam. Oh, and I guess if you don't mind maybe one for mom and Casta too."

"Yeah Glim, we can do that."

"Oh, speaking of!" She sits up and tugs her legs under her, turning to waggle her eyebrows at Adora. "*Catra* was coming in as I was leaving today."

In her effort to sound casual and disinterested Adora's voice pitches a couple octaves too high, "Oh?"

"Dude, she's a *triple Scorpio*."

Adora opens her mouth to remind Glimmer that this means nothing to her, when she's cut off by a dramatic gasp from Bow who has

dropped the remote altogether to stare wide eyed at Glimmer. "*Oh!*"

Glimmer smiles smugly, "Yeah, for real! Sun, moon and rising! So already a stellium, plus her *Mrs* is Scorpio too." She turns back to Adora. "And I already know you're going to tell me so save it. I'll remind to that google is a thing. Plus, your girl- "

"She's not *my* girl!" Glimmer ignores the interruption and Bow rolls his eyes, turning half of his attention back to the television.

"told me herself which means, at least to some degree, she identifies with some big Scorpio energy." She shrugs, "Free insight, and if it were me, I'd absolutely be looking the compatibility of our signs, even if just for shits, ya know?"

"I guess." Adora shifts uncomfortably in her seat. Either disregarding her discomfort or capitalizing on it Glimmer continues.

"She asked about you, you know." Adora turns beet red and Glimmer arches an eyebrow at her.

"She-she did? What did she ask?"

"Well… *technically* she asked about you and Bow, *but* when I said you two weren't joining me, she said, and I quote, hm, that's too bad'. I mean, come on!"

Adora looks at her friends dubiously. "Oh."

"*Adora* she was clearly asking about you and just trying to be chill. She didn't even use Bow's *name* for crying out loud!" Glimmer sits up even more and starts leaning over the arm of the couch toward Adora.

"Yeah but has she ever?" Adora challenges.

"No, and I'm still not sure if I find that charming or rude." Bow cuts in. "Did she use Adora's name or Adorable?" Both of Adora's friends snicker; the simultaneously flattering and *really* embarrassing

nickname having become one of their favorite topics of conversation in the last week.

"Well okay she didn't use Adora's real name either- but Adorable is way closer to your actual name!" She cries, determined to make something of this. "She's a *triple Scorpio*, she's probably trying to retain her air of mystery."

"That's fair." Says Bow, finally switching on a cartoon and settling in further to the couch. Adora can't help but disagree with this assessment but Glimmer grins triumphantly.

"Whatever you two say, I guess." Glimmer sticks her tongue out and then flops dramatically back into a horizontal position.

"She also mentioned that she'll be working on Sunday." Glimmer adds with a wink in her direction. Then, washing her hands of the matter, turns her attention to the show and begins barraging Bow with questions about what's going on. He doesn't seem to mind and the stars floating around the room seem to drift in the direction of the couch, growing more and more dense in the air around the two friends.

Adora grabs lunch the following day with Mermista, they have a nice time catching up. Apparently, she and Sea Hawk have mended fences again so, while her humor is still dry as all get out, she seems to be in pretty high spirits. The rest of the weekend all she has on the agenda is a healthy dose of self-care time. She spends Saturday morning and evening taking care of chores and errands, setting herself up well for the rest of the week. By the time she's plopped in front of the TV eating dinner there's not a single productive thing left to be done.

Sunday dawns and she makes herself breakfast and putters around the house for a bit. She feels restless, fussy. Last night she thought having all of her responsibilities sorted was a blessing, but without a

to do list she's at a loss of how to spend her day. She pulls out a sketchbook, it's been seeing more action in the last few weeks than it has in months. However, she must have lost her creative spark or something because she just sits at her table, tapping pencil on paper for fifteen minutes. Feeling frustrated she groans and drop her head to the table. It's too hard, way too hard.

She should probably just get out of the house. She's been avoiding thinking about Glimmers words from Friday since they left her mouth. *She also mentioned that she'll be working on Sunday.* Now, however, they seem to have broken free from the compartment she shoved them into and it's all she can think about. Honestly, Catra or no Catra, a trip to Plumeria doesnt sound half bad. She could bring her pad, maybe a change of scenery would get the spark going again? Better bring a book along too, just in case.

Not giving herself the chance to talk herself out of the idea, she loads up a tote and is walking out the door. She takes the walk to the café slowly but it's close so she's still there in barely more than ten minutes. She has her door on the handle and pauses for a moment, steeling herself with a couple of deep breaths. Not wanting to be noticed looking like she's having a dilemma, even though maybe she is, she pulls open the door and is inside.

Before the door has even closed behind her she hears, "*Hey* Adorable!" Adora looks up and sees Catra on bar, gesturing her over with the motion of her head. Her heart begins to pump in overtime, but nevertheless she walks over to her, past the short line, and bellies up to the counter.

"Uh, hey, hi Catra." Catra smirks at her and Adora's stomach flops.

"What, no posse today?"

"Oh, just me, sorry." She starts to make some sort of gesture with her hands but lets them fall lamely to her sides.

"I don't see any reason to apologize for that. I'm glad to see you." Adora blushes by way of response. "Listen my shift ends in a few minutes here, you got plans?"

"Oh, uh, I was just gonna sit." She shrugs.

"Great!" Catra's eyes twinkle. "If you're up for some company I was gonna stick around anyway, got a little bit of paperwork to do."

Adora startles, Catra wants to what? Sit with her? Hang out? "Oh, yeah, great, that's sure. I mean, yes I'd like that, thanks."

Adora is sure she isn't imagining Catra's barely withheld laughter at her antics. She's less convinced she isn't imagining the few stars floating around the other woman, almost like a headpiece. But she's working on trusting herself in that area too. "Awesome, don't bother ordering. Just pick a spot and I'll bring your drink over after Lonnie clocks on and taps me out. You hungry?"

"Oh, no-you don't have to, I can just hop in line!" Adora protests.

"Like I said," she says with a wave, "don't bother." And then as if sensing Adora's discomfort she adds, "Adora, I literally own the place, it's no trouble. Go, sit and I'll be right over."

Adora nods, "Well, thanks!" She supplies. Then backs up a couple steps before turning to track down a spot. She plops down at a two top; she's facing the nearby window but hasn't strayed too far from the bar. Unsure of what to do with herself while she waits for Catra she pulls out her pad and colored pencils. She picks out a light blue at random but just starts drumming it lightly on the cover, listening to the music trickling in from unseen speakers and the sounds of Catra making a couple coffees and calling out her orders. A few minutes pass and then she hears a new voice from over near where Catra is.

"Whew, sorry I'm late girl! I was talking to my Ma on the way over and I swear that woman *never stops talking*."

t’ s like two minutes past Lonnie, dont stress. Y ou ready to hop on?”

“Almost, jst gotta wash up.”Adora can jst faintly hear the water running over the music in the lobby.

“Great, Im jst gonna make a couple drinks and Ill get out of your hair.”

“Hm,”the other girl-Lonnie- sounds sort of...suspicious. “A couple, huh?

“What?”Adora isnt sure if the other girl says something she cant hear or if she jst doesnt respond but a few seconds later Catra adds. “Im jst having a drink with a fr..end.”Adora’ s pulse skips a beat at that.

“A friend?”Catra doesnt seem to say anything but must point or something because her coworker speaks again. “Ohh, is this the crush-tomer Ikeep hearing about?W ell, the back of her head is cute at least.”Adora blushes and thanks all that is good and holy she’ s facing away from them right now. She suddenly starts to wonder if she should be eavesdropping on this particular conversation, but it’s not like she’s *trying*. Plus, she’s not sure what she could do to drown them out without making a scene.

“Jeez Lonnie! Keep your voice down.”She drops her voice to a harsh whisper that Adora cant really hear , but she thinks she catches the words, “right there.”

“Sorry , sorry! Y oure right, looks like your done anyway , why dont you go get your girl.”

Catra huffs, “Whatever Lonnie.”Lonnie jst laughs and Adora shifts awkwardly in her seat, willing her blush to die down before Catra comes over.

She sets down a glass of what looks like iced tea in front of her and a steaming mug on the other side of the table. Both are, as Adora

has come to expect from Catra's drinks, shrouded in stars. Adora is grateful hers doesn't seem to have any coffee, she's pretty sure that it would only make her jittery. "Am I allowed to ask what this is?" She gestures to the glass in front of her.

Catra smirks, "After you try it, I'll be right back, need to grab a couple things from the office."

She walks off and Adora takes a sip, it's honestly amazing. Super floral, almost a little peppery and she's pretty sure she can taste lavender and honey distinctly. Whatever it is in there, one sip and already she feels significantly more relaxed. She hums contentedly and peeks down at her art supplies again, giving a start when she notices stars running down the binding of her pad and a few of the pencils;green, blue, yellow and brown she notes. She's not sure how long she spends staring before she hears footsteps approaching her and Catra is swinging herself into the open seat. She drops a binder and a stack of papers on the table.

"So," she begins, resting her elbows on the table and making a flat surface with her hands on which to rest her chin. "what do you think?"

"It's perfect, your coworker was right that first day I came in, huh? You really don't ever get it wrong." Adora offers a shy smile with her compliment.

Unbelievably Catra seems to blush lightly, a proud smile overtaking her expression. She lifts her head from her hands just enough to wave one dismissively. "Eh, it's no big deal. And for what it's worth, don't listen to a thing DT ever tells you. They're a trouble maker and a flirt."

"They didn't seem so bad." Adora defends out of instinct.

Catra just arches an eyebrow at her. "DT *literally* stands for Double Trouble."

Adora laughs, "Okay well I'm sure they didn't give *themself* that nickname!"

"Adorable," Catra deadpans "they had it legally changed."

Adora facepalms. "Alright well, shows what I know." She levels Catra with a suspicious look. "Unless you're pulling my leg. Not that it's not err...a lovely name! If it is their name...maybe I'll just ask them."
She won't.

Catra just throws her head back and *laughs*. "Damn, there you go again."

"What?" She demands.

Catra looks her directly in the eye to respond. "Living up to your name." Adora could swear she blacks out. She's blushing so hard she starts to wonder if it will actually ever fade this time. Catra laughs at the mess she's made of Adora but doesn't let her stew in it too long before changing the subject. "So, what are you working on over here?"

"Oh, um, just like, doodling I guess."

"Can I see?"

Adora fights the urge to grab her pad and hug it to her chest, or he'll just light a match and burn the whole thing. If only she *had* a match. "Uh"...

"You don't have to." Catra's smile is kind, albeit a bit mischievous. "Just curious."

"Well um, I mean you can-" Adora is about to tack on a disclaimer, something about Catra not setting her expectations too high, when Catra cuts her off.

"Great!" She practically lunges across the table to snatch the pad and immediately opens it. As she looks her gaze turns softer and her

movement slows, taking her time looking at the images. She looks up at Adora. "Adora, these are really something. I had no idea you could." She turns the pad around to show her what page she's on. It's an image of Razz that Adora had started after her little episode in the café last week done in watercolor and ink, hand drawn stars and glitter spilling all around her visage. "Who's this?"

Adora bites at her lower lip. "Oh, uh, it's my grandma."

"Hmm, she in the city?"

"No, uh, she still lives back home."

"Ah, and where's home?"

Adora blanches, the answer should be obvious she supposes. That is, she knows what Catra is asking. For some reason however, the question gives her pause. "Well, she's in Etheria. My big sister's there too so they check in on her."

"You have siblings?"

"Well, I mean I have Mara and her wife. Mara's uh, well my sister for all intents and purposes." When all Catra does is continue to watch her, she explains. "I was part of the Big Brother/Big Sister program when I was little. Mara's just," She shrugs, "looked out for me ever since."

Catra smiles kindly. "That's nice."

Adora nods, Catra has no idea how on the nose she is. She continues, desperate to move the spotlight away from herself. "Yeah, what about you? Siblings?"

Catra scoffs, "Not that I know about, foster kid." She explains. "I mean there were a few kids who would come and go. Mostly though it was just me and Weaver." Something about the way she says that name tells Adora not to ask.

"Oh! Um, same foster kid I mean."

"No shit?" Both her eyebrows raise in surprise and at Adora's nod her expression turns inquisitive. "So, your grandma wasn't…"

Adora grimaces at the territory they've crossed into. Not somewhere she thought she'd end up with her… *crush* during their first real conversation. "Well, uh, she was. But then, well I was ten and she… Raz has dementia so they, well it didn't work out long term."

Catra considers her for a moment more and begins to nod slowly. "Gotcha. Alright Adorable, I know you could distract me all day but if I don't get this paperwork done before I go Perfuma all be pissed. Well, she doesn't really do pissed but she'll be disappointed and that is frankly much worse."

Adora blushes fiercely again, much to her dismay and Catra's obvious pleasure, and nods. She reaches over to accept the pad Catra is offering back to her and soon enough they're both absorbed in their own tasks. Unable to fight her sudden inspiration, Adora attempts to hide her work with the crook of her right arm. She doesn't think she would ever recover if Catra realized she was her latest muse.

About half an hour later Catra stretches in her chair and asks, "I'm getting snacky, you want anything?"

"Oh, um sure, that would be great, thanks." Adora answers blinking slowly and looking up from her pad, quickly flipping the page over to a different work in progress to hide the drawing.

"Awesome, you want something sweet or savory?" Adora blanches and before she has time to recover Catra chuckles and says, "Tell you what, why don't I get one of each and we can just share?"

"That's perfect, thanks Catra. I appreciate it." Adora says with a genuine smile, relieved at not having to make a choice.

Catra considers her for a moment before responding. "Sure thing, Adorable. Be right back." She returns a few minutes later setting down two plates, a quiche with a couple forks on the side, and a blondie cut neatly in half. Both are coated in an even layer of stars. "Here we are!"

"Yum! Thank you so much Catra." Catra resumes her seat and shrugs nonchalantly. "What um, what do they do? I mean! I know Scorpia puts a lot of intention in and- yeah."

Catra just watches Adora fluster herself and when she's sure she's run out of steam explains. "The quiche is like, fennel, sunflower, sage and snapdragons, it's for self-confidence or whatever. And the Blondies are marigold and calendula for creativity and," She makes eye contact as she finishes, "passion."

Adora gulps, "Oh, good- that's good." Her voice is embarrassingly strained, and she gives herself a small shake. "Hey, wasn't um, I thought I noticed the blondies, aren't they the Wildcat Blondies." Catra doesn't respond but Adora thinks she detects a light blush on her cheeks. Sensing the opportunity to get the upper hand *for once* she presses. "It's funny, I thought that's what Scorpia- "

"Yes!" Catra cuts in, her face now decidedly flushed, with no explanation. Adora just raises a single brow and Catra huffs in resignation. "Yes, Scorpia named those ones after me." She pauses. "Don't call me that though."

"Aw, that's sweet! You guys are close then?" Adora askes, her voice coated in false innocence.

"I guess." Catra grumbles back, slouching in her chair. And then, almost too quiet to hear, "I'm lucky to have a friend like Scorpia."

Adora, deciding she's had enough fun, nods. "That's how I feel about Glimmer and Bow."

Catra's expression becomes briefly confused and she sits up in her chair again. "Bow? You mean Crop Top?" Adora throws back her head and laughs.

"We didn't think you *actually* didn't know his name!"

Catra becomes flustered again. "No one ever said it! I don't think… whatever, Crop Top suits him."

"What were you gonna call him come winter?"

Catra gives her an appraising look. "So, you think y'all are gonna keep coming in that long?"

Now it's Adora's turn to become flustered. "I mean I- well- you didn't say- it's not even- we should probably try this, before it gets cold, yeah?" Catra just laughs and nods, picking up a fork and digging in. "So is the blondie your favorite then?" Catra looks up, confusion evident in her expression. "I mean it's named after you, I just figured…"

"Oh, right. I mean it's super good, don't get me wrong, but nah."

"Hm, do you have one though, a favorite I mean?"

"Well I remember that carrot cake you had." Adora, thinking back to her reaction to the aforementioned dessert, nods. "Yeah, I love that shit. I had it for breakfast every day for like a week the first time Scorp made it."

Adora laughs. "Oh yeah?"

"That shit is magic." She points her fork at Adora in challenge.

Adora hums thoughtfully, remembering the stars that coated the café last weekend. "You're not wrong." She admits. "What about that *particular* magic resonates with you?"

Catra looks at her for a minute before responding, as if to gauge her sincerity. "Hm, well, my childhood wasn't all like rainbows and Pegasus and shit." She chuckles darkly . "When I met Perfuma and Scorpia well I was still kind of messed up about it. And well, it was mostly bad, but it wasn't all bad, y'know? But the bad made it hard to connect with the good." Adora nods in a way she hops is encouraging, she can certainly empathize with that. "I think I think that getting caught up in that cycle made it easy to forget that it was my *childhood* that was fucked, not like, me *as a child*. When I eat that cake I d unno I guess it helps me connect to my littlest self or like, inner child, whatever you want to call it, and to see the good in her."

There is a silence that stretches long between them. Both meditating on what Catra has shared, the aforementioned looking a little surprised at how vulnerable she's been with her answer. Her energy is much more timid then Adora has ever seen it. Adora, for her part, is mostly enraptured by the sudden explosion of stars shooting out from Catra's body.

"What does that mean, to you?" Adora finally asks, breaking the silence. "Connecting to your little self again, I mean?"

Catra hums thoughtfully, seeming to consider the question. "I think it's less about connecting to me at my most youthful and more about the root of myself. Who I am outside of my trauma and other outside factors." She leans her head into her hand, elbow resting on the table top. "I see goodness there now , which used to be really hard to see, y'know?"

Adora nods, "I do, I really do." The two women smile softly at each other, reveling in their newfound connection. Though strikingly new, it doesn't feel tenuous like Adora wonders if it should. At that realization she notices it, an entire milky way stretching across the space between them.

Chapter End Notes

Chapter title is lifted from "Sing The Body Electric; Especially When My Power Is Out" by Andrea Gibson. W ould highly recommend it (and their entire body of work tbh) if you aren't familiar!

The Wisdom to See...

Adora takes off after a couple hours with Catra. They chat about different things;friends, work, et cetera. Catra tells her about the inspiration for the name of the shop ("Oh that? I guess Perfuma *loved* playing princess as a kid and that's was what she always named her kingdom. She said she loves the idea of inviting people to engage with their own childlike sense of wonder'. If figured it' s a pretty enough name and I wasn't about to go with some shitty cof fee pun so.") and Adora gives a brief description of her crummy day j ob. They don't cover anything super specific or deep compared to the territory covered in the first part of the conversation, but Adora loves it j ust as much. By the end she' s even feeling confident enough to start teasing back. Catra isn't *nearly* as easy to fluster, but Adora thinks that only makes it more satisfying when it happens.

Something from earlier is still nagging at the back of Adora's mind though. Two blocks toward her apartment Adora pulls out her phone. t only rings once before the phone clicks. "Hey Adora!" Glimmer 's voice is overly bright and cheerful, and her next words are slightly muffled. "Mom, Casta, I think Adora needs to talk, I'm j ust gonna pop out to the porch really q ick." Adora hears the sound of a door slamming slightly and then she's back. "Oh my *goddess*, your timing is good! They've been talking politics for like, over an hour . Even when they're on the same side they find a way to argue! Anyway , what's up?"

"Hey Glimmer what do you think a c.. rush-tomer 's?" Her q estion is rushed, she doesn't mean for it to be but.. Adora has exactly no chill. Is it what she thinks/hopes it is? *Probably not, right?*

"Oh, I've heard a few friends talk about theirs. t' s j ust a goofy way of saying a customer you have a crush on lol, why?"

"Umm"…

"Oh my gosh Adora, why? Did you go to Plumeria today?"

"Sort of?"

"Tell me *everything*." She seems to have a What Would Bow Do' moment because she adds, "if you want."

"I just wanted to get out of the house!" She's not sure why she feels defensive all of the sudden. Instinct, she supposes.

"Uh-huh, and?"

Adora groans, but she's the one who called Glimmer. Clearly, she wants to talk about this. I mean, that galaxy between them! What was that? She's never seen stars like that before. "And Catra was working and she um, she sort of asked to sit with me?"

"*Holy crap Adora!*"

Adora lets herself grin in earnest now. "I know, I know! And so, she made us drinks and, well her coworker came in and she's the one- well I'm pretty sure it was me- anyway she's the one who I heard call me that, she said something about she keeps hearing about her. Or me, maybe, maybe it wasn't me."

"Okay, but it was definitely about you though, right?"

Adora hems and haws for a moment before finally admitting, "Well, yeah."

"Adora!" She pulls the phone away from her face at Glimmer's shouting but presses it back to her ear when Glimmer's voice turns to singsong instead. "She totally *likes* you, she wants to *date* you, she wants to *build* with you, she wants to get a *kitten* with you- "

Adora cuts her off, realizing this could go on forever if she lets it. "How do you know she's not a dog person?"

"I just know." Adora can practically see her rolling her eyes. She wonders if Glimmer can practically see her doing it back.

"Whatever Glimmer . Um, but do youyou really think so?" She bites her lip, suddenly nervous. This…*thing* whatever is happening with Catra it is, well, a *thing* now. This afternoon cemented that. She just doesn't want to get her hopes up and be let down.

"*Oh Adora!* Come on, she *literally* calls you Adorable every chance she gets. It's clearly not just a weird in joke you two have or whatever you've tried to tell us before. She likes you and has clearly given you multiple green lights to ask her out. You should go for it."

"Well, I don't know about that. I mean shouldn't we feel like we should hang out as friends first. Get to know each other."

"Adora, your chemistry is off the charts!"

"I know! Or , well I know from my side it is but well chemistry isn't all it takes to make a relationship work, right? And Catra seems really cool, I don't want to fuck a friendship because I was too hasty , or whatever."

Glimmer doesn't say anything for a minute, as if considering what Adora is saying. "Alright, well that's actually pretty mature, I guess. If you're really doing it out of a sense of caution and consideration. If , however you're doing it from a place of fear , well buck up soldier . Either way, make *some* kind of move, even if it's platonic, okay? You both clearly like each other."

"Yeah, okay Glim, I'll keep that in mind."

"Good. Now , I can stay and talk if you want but if that was it, I might let you go. I should probably go make sure everyone is alive inside."

"Yeah, yeah that was it. Tell Angella and Casta hi' from me!"

"Will do, bye Adora, love you!"

"Love you too Glim, see you soon!"

"Ugh, not soon enough." Then she hangs up with a click. A few stars spark from Adora's fingertips as she locks her phone and slides it into her pocket.

Adora keeps her word to Glimmer, she thinks about the conversation all night. She thinks about Catra; making herself an early dinner , working on the puzzle she started, getting ready for bed and as she falls asleep. She doesn't gain any fabulous new insight, she just… thinks.

The start of Adora's week is fairly mundane. She has dinner out with Bow on Tuesday, which is pretty low key. She does update him on her Sunday afternoon, his reaction is eerily similar to Glimmers; equally enthusiastic, just a little less teasing and a lot more understanding and empathy, conveyed in Bow's gentle voice.

Wednesday morning Adora wakes up with a headache. She takes a couple aspirin but decides the monster in her head is going to require coffee as well. She hurries through her routine, so she has enough time to swing by Plumeria on her way to the office. She scores a spot right in front, it makes her wonder if finding princess parking is her super power. Then she remembers the tight, back of the lot spot she ended up in last time she went to the grocery store and decides probably not. Can't be a super power if it only applies at one place, right?

When she gets in the door, she tries her best for subtle, however she doesn't try to lie to herself: she absolutely checks for Catra behind the counter. She doesn't seem to be in but Adora is surprised to see Perfuma behind the register. Despite the time of day there's only one person ahead of her, she steps up behind them and waits patiently.

Perfuma is passing a plant to the person at the counter and Adora overhears their exchange. "Alright Frank, I think she's ready to go home."

"Shucks Perfuma you didn't have to give her back! I'm not even sure I can keep her looking so healthy!"

"Nonsense, just remember;westward window and water it every few days or when the soil is dry. Didn't you say your kitchen faces west?"

"It does, I'm surprised you remember though."

"Well, I think that sounds like a lovely home for her! Take care Frank, of the plant and yourself!"

"You do the same!" The other customer walks off with the plant in hand, it really is gorgeous;dark green leaves with little stripes of pink that trail down the side of the pot. Adora also notes the pot is brimming with stars, so full they spill over the side along the trail of leaves and litter the counter and floor beneath them.

Perfuma looks up and notices Adora. "Adora! Welcome back, I'm so glad to see you."

Adora steps forward. "Hey Perfuma, good to see you too! I thought you usually stayed away from the coffee side of things."

"Oh, I do, usually. I came in to check on the plants and a few other odds and ends. One of our baristas wasn't feeling so great though so I just hopped on to cover until Catra can get in." Adora's heart skips a beat at the name. Perfuma giggles lightly, "Well until Catra wakes up and sees the messages. Anyway, what can we get going for you?"

"Just an oat milk latte please."

"Coming right up! Thanks so much for coming in, I hope we see your lovely face in here again soon."

Adora blushes lightly, "Uh, yeah, sure thing. Thanks, Perfuma, have a good one!"

She goes to wait for her drink and, in the absence of a line, watches Perfuma take a pitcher and begin tending to the plants. Adora is sure she's just watering them, but to her it looks like a river of stars that

spills forth, making all the plants glitter and shine. As she picks up her coffee and wanders out the door with a final wave to Perfuma she thinks to herself; *all in all,not a bad start to a W ednesday.*

The rest of the day, and in fact the rest of the week, passes by in a bit of a blur. Before she knows it Adora is packing up her bag Friday morning and slipping out of the office before anyone can hope to sidetrack her. Once in the car she shoots off a message to Bow, *Leaving now! Still meeting at me?*

Not a minute passes and she receives back a long string of emojs including, but not limited to;hearts of every color , a unicorn, a sunflower, and a few beach balls. She takes that to mean 'yes' and, most likely, 'on my way' and guides her car home. When she pulls in the lot Bow's car is already there. She walks over and taps on the window, which bow then rolls down.

"Hey Adora! You set or did you need a little time? I'm in no rush!"

"I'm basically ready , I just need to grab my overnight bag and change out of my office clothes."

"Great, cool if I just wait here for you?"

"Sounds good." With that she scurries upstairs. She drops her work bag and trades out her slacks and blouse for a comfortable pair of shorts and a muscle tank. She gives her hair a quick check, her ponytail looks fine still but she redoes the pouf in front, smoothing it out a bit. A last look around the studio and she's good to go. It also strikes her how ready she is to pack up and get out of this place. She reminds herself to put in her notice in the next few weeks.

She hops down the stairs with her bag in tow, tosses it in the backseat and flops into the front.

"All set?"

"Let's hit the road!" the exchange excited smiles, both realizing simultaneously that their vacation has officially begun.

"Still down to stop by the café?" Bow checks, Adora nods. She's kind of forgotten but can't deny she's excited at the prospect of seeing Catra. If she's even working. They make the short drive over and before Bow can drive past Adora points out the open spot right in front of Plumeria. "*Wow* I can't believe we scored *princess parking* on Eternia Ave!" he exclaims as they climb out of the car.

Adora shrugs, "Honestly I've scored the same spot every time I've driven over. It's been heaven sent in the mornings before work." Bow gapes at her. "What?"

"I just...that's amazing luck. When's the last time you bought a lottery ticket?"

Adora laughs, "It's really not such a big deal Bow."

He grabs the door for her and as she walks in, she spots Catra and Scorpia behind the counter. "I beg to differ." As they walk up to the counter Bow is still talking about it. "*Every time*? On *Eternia Ave*? That never happens!"

Adora shrugs. "I really don't know what to tell you Bow, it's just a lucky coincidence. Besides I walk half the time."

Catra, wandering over from the pastry case where she's been chatting with Scorpia looks between the two of them for a moment. "What never happens?"

Bow, eager to share his weird indignation with someone jumps at the chance to explain. "Adora here *claims* that every time she's come here, she's managed to get princess parking. My car is literally in the spot right in front of the door! And she says that *always* happens. That *never* happens though, right?"

Catra arches an eyebrow at him and turns to size up Adora. "Yeah, that tracks."

"What's that supposed to mean?" Adora demands, immediately riled up.

"Nothing at all, Princess."

Adora scoffs, "Hardly." But Bow is laughing loudly over her. Then Scorpia wanders over, the pastry case apparently full now.

"Hi friends! What are we talking about over here?" She nudges Catra and gives her some kind of…*look*. Adora doesn't really get it. Choosing to ignore it, she rolls her eyes.

"Apparently I've just been coronated."

Bow's laughter busts out louder and Catra's snicker joins him. "Princess Princess Parking!" he howls.

"Uh, am I missing something?" Scorpia asks, looking lost.

"Nah," Catra offers. "I was just commenting on how lucky we are to be graced with royalty this morning." She's clearly talking to Scorpia, but her eyes don't leave Adora's. Adora can feel a light blush creeping up her neck but she holds her gaze steady. "Anyhow, what can I get your highness?"

"Can I get *you* not to call me Princess?" Adora asks, deadpan.

"*Absolutely* not, especially if you're gonna get so worked up about it. Goddess Adora, you almost make it too easy."

Adora blushes harder and starts to stutter, much to the amusement of her audience of three. After a moment Bow saves her. "Hey Scorpia, what kind of jam do you have on those scones today?"

Scorpia brightens at being addressed. "Oh boy, it's a great one, maybe my favorite!"

"Scorp, you *always* say that." Catra rolls her eyes, her fondness for her friend clear in her expression.

Scorpia just laughs jovially. "And it's always true! Today we have yellow rose jam, so with the sage scone, Wisdom to See Friendship and Caring! Wow, what a special thing to be on the lookout for, huh? Luckily I don't have to look too hard with this one around." She gestures her head over to Catra, who blushes lightly beneath a faint smattering of freckles. Adora doesn't remember noticing those before. Maybe they came out with the sun? She's so busy staring she almost misses the side eye Catra shoots her way.

"Hey Scorp, I know it was a small batch, but you got any of the lavender rose jam left?" Scorpia looks initially incredulous, blinking a few times at Catra. Then there's an obvious uptake in her excitement. "Oh wow, wow wow wow wow wow! Catra you are *a genius*. Yes, absolutely there are. I have I think one left in the back." She looks over at Adora excitedly.

"Uhm." Adora has no clue what's happening here.

Catra turns to her with a smirk, the challenge clear on her face. "What do you think Princess, you up for it?"

Adora rolls her eyes again. "For a scone? Yeah, I think I can take it."

"Great! And what about you Crop Top?"

"Okay, see I know you know my name now."

"You *told* him?" She accuses Adora. She just shrugs and smirks back at her.

"You never said not to."

"Whatever." She turns back to Bow. "Crop Top suits you better, now what can I get ya?"

Bow laughs, apparently, he's decided the nickname is charming and not, in fact, rude. "Can I get three of the scones and a couple slices of banana bread please?"

"Coming right up." She moves over to bag up the pastries and Scorpia comes bustling out from the back.

"Alright, one lavender rose jam scone, for the lady." She passes a parchment bag, which is glowing lightly as if filled to the brim with stars, to Adora.

"Thanks, so much Scorpia! Hey, what's the intention behind the lavender roses anyhow?" She asks, wondering what exactly she's signed up for.

Scorpia's face goes blank and, Adora could swear, a little bit paler. She looks to Catra who briefly freezes in her movements putting the wrapped pastries into a handled bag all together. "Uh, um, well… sorry, what?"

Before anyone can respond Catra is back, dropping the bag between them on the counter. She looks Adora dead in the eye. "What's the matter Princess?" She fake pouts lightly, her eyes a curious mix of teasing and discomfort. "Not feeling brave today?"

Adora huffs and throws her food in the bag with the rest, luckily the parchment is white instead of unbleached like the rest, so she'll easily know the difference. "Whatever."

Catra, seemingly satisfied nods once. "I'm choosing your drinks." It isn't a question. "Just the two of you?"

"Y up!" Answers Bow, who then pulls out his wallet.

"Don't bother." She waves him away.

"Oh," he replies looking uncertain. "Are you sure? It's really- " The face she responds with shuts Bow up quickly and he throws his

hands up in surrender. "Well thanks, that's really kind of you." He turns to Adora with a look that screams, *See? She definitely likes you!*

Adora's return expression is a clear and defiant, *Shut up Bow* and then morphs into, *She is literally watching us right now*.' Bow throws up his hands again and follows as Adora migrates to the espresso machine where Catra (and Scorpia who seems content to just float after her now that her work is done) has moved to.

"So," She looks up from her work. "What brings you in on the middle of a weekday anyway, Adorable?"

"Oh, we're actually heading out of town."

"Ooh! Vacation, so fun!" Scorpia looks so excited you'd think she was the one heading to the beach.

"Where are y'all off to?" Catra seems to be trying a little too hard to play her interest off as small talk.

"Just to a beach a few hours out of the city for a long weekend. Glimmer's aunt has a house out there and she and her mom are up for a couple weeks. We're going half for the time away, half to act as buffer for a couple days." Adora chuckles.

"Hm, seems like a good trade off." Catra comments.

"Honestly yeah, Casta drives Glimmer and her mom nuts, but she's always super sweet while we're around." Bow supplies. "She always makes us the *nicest* sweaters for Christmas."

"Bow, you are the only one who likes those sweaters." Bow gasps dramatically in indignation. Adora laughs at him. "What? You have to know that. And you only like them because she makes yours into a crop top!"

"Well sure, but you literally can't find that *anywhere*!"

Catra gives him an appraising glance. "But you've looked, haven't you?"

"Well duh, I'm tired of my midriff being practically *suffocated* all winter!" All three women snicker at him.

"Alright, well let's get you two on the road so you can stay in Auntie's good graces then. For Bow an iced triple raspberry white mocha."

"I almost feel uncomfortable hearing you say my name now." His tone makes it clear Bow is teasing.

"Literally cannot win with you. And for the princess, an iced London fog."

"Thanks so much Catra!" Adora grins at her.

"Sure thing Princess, drive safe." Waves are exchanged all around and Bow and Adora head for the door with their goodies. Adora hears the two whispering behind them as they leave, it almost sounds heated. Then As they're just steps from the door Catra calls out. "Hey Princess! Come here a sec, will you?"

Adora turns with a start and walks back to the door. "What's up?"

Catra looks almost shy? *Couldn't* be. Scorpia has walked away, busying herself with shuffling around stuff on the counter behind Catra, still obviously listening to them. Catra then slides her hand across the counter next to the register. "Listen, since you're gonna be gone- well I've gotten used to seeing you around here on the weekends. Guess I won't have anyone to give a hard time, unless…" She lifts her hand off the paper and pulls it back toward herself, stuffing both into the pockets of her apron. Left behind where her hand used to be is a scrap of paper with a phone number. Adora is sure she must have used ink, but it looks to her as if Catra's name and the number below are written in tiny stars. "Well, if you're not too busy building sandcastles for you and your subjects- hit me up."

Adora stares at the paper, she reaches out halfway and her hand freezes in midair, then after a few beats too long her hand darts forward to snatch the paper up. She looks up at Catra, beaming. "I *definitely* will."

Catra's whole body seems to relax. "I'll hold you to that, Princess."

Bow waits until they're in the car to explode. "*Oh, my goddess!*"

"Bow!"

"*Oh, my goddess!*"

"Bow, *I know*!"

"*Oh, my goddess!* She gave you her *number*!" Adora nods, unable to contain her joy the movement is almost frantic. "We are talking about this, maybe the entire way there. Oh, my goddess, I'm so *thrilled*. Gosh, okay, you! Put that number in your phone right now so you don't lose it." As if that's possible. "I'm texting Glimmer in the group chat." There's a charged silence that lasts a minute or two. Then Bow speaks, as if his voice can barely contain his excitement without cracking. "*Adora*…"

"Uh, what?" She regards him nervously, wondering what could possibly have made him more excited.

"So uh, I looked up lavender roses." Adora sits up in her seat and leans closer, as if to try and sneak a peek at his phone.

"*Ad?*"

He looks at her wide eyed, "Well with sage for wisdom and the lavender roses, Adora, it's; Wisdom to See Love at First Sight." Adora's jaw drops and Bow glances quickly down at his phone screen. "Also, Glimmer wants to know how many stars you're seeing on that paper. So do I, frankly."

Adora looks down at it again, unsure of how to answer. There are even more than when Catra initially passed it to her, and theyŕe positively innumerable now.

The Spark that Ignites Us

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

They've been driving for an hour now;they spent the first forty-five minutes dissecting every word and every bit of body language from the encounter at the café. WellBow had mostly dissected while Adora blushed furiously and begrudgingly agreed with every one of Bow's insights. Adora had spent the last fifteen minutes staring at a blank message on her phone. Bow insisted playing it cool and waiting a couple days was silly and overrated. "Catra was being brave when she gave you that number, now it's your turn. Besides Adora, let's be honest, you have exactly zero chill. No reason to pretend."Adora had scowled at him. She didnt deign to actually respond beyond some low grumbling under her breath while she dug out the phone.

And now the cursor was justblinking. Hey Catra, thanks for the- she deleted every word. Hi again!We're on the road!Thought id- again she scrapped the draft.

"Bow , what am Ieven supposed to say?"The sudden growl makes Bow jump, but he smiles good naturedly once he' s recovered.

"W ell, what do you want to say?"

"honestly have no idea. Ijust wantIdont know , Idont have anything to say really."

Bow deliberates for a moment. "What about a meme?"

Adora sits with the idea for a second. "Oh!"Inspiration strikes and she googles it and sends it to Catra before she can think better of it. Then she hastily stuffs her phone under her legs and covers her eyes with her hands, emitting a low groan.

"What did you send her?" Bow demands.

She drags her hands down her face until they are pulling down her cheeks, making a pathetic looking silly face. "The stitch one?"

"Aw, where he's like, H-Hi?" He takes one hand off the wheel to mimic the awkward, alien wave and she nods. "That's *perfect* Adora! Really! Let me know what you get back, don't sit on any deets."

"Yes sir!"

"Thank you, now do you mind switching up the tunes? I think I'm a little tapped out on this playlist." Adora grabs his phone and selects something new, they spend the next chunk of their drive singing along and engaging in lighthearted banter. It's really fun. Before she knows it Adora has forgotten the text entirely, simply enjoying singing with her friend and watching the stars that fill up the car, dancing along with them.

When they're about an hour out Bow pulls off to a rest area so they can both go to the bathroom. He takes Adora up on her offer to drive the rest of the way. The beginning of the second leg of their journey is quiet. Finally, Adora decides to just bite the bullet and ask something she's been wondering about. Bow *did* say it was okay if she asked, that he and Glimmer would want to share.

"Hey Bow?" Bow hums, letting her know he's listening. "Can I ask you something? I-I mean it might be too personal, you don't have to answer if-if it is."

"I can't really think of anything I'm not open to sharing with you to be honest, but I'll let you know if you approach a boundary. Go for it Adora." He's angled a little more in his seat to face her, she glances over quickly but keeps her eyes glued to the road to hide her nerves. She's never been one to pry but she is really curious.

"Well I've just noticed that since that day at the café well you and Glimmer have been like, extra cozy, I guess."

The corners of Bow's moth turn down just slightly, so a hint of a frown crosses his expression. "Uh-huh."

"Well, I just wondered; have you two like, talked? I just mean, I guess your friendship has always seemed really unique. When I first met y'all I kind of wondered if things were strictly platonic." She looks at Bow to gauge his reaction, but his expression hasn't changed so she rushes on to explain herself further. "I mean I know now that it is, and I know you've been friends for a long time and are just really close but I just wondered." She finishes lamely.

Bow sighs heavily and sags, sideways, against the back of his seat. "Honestly Adora I don't know that I would say our friendship is strictly platonic." At Adora's answering glance he explains, "We're just friends, like we're not in a relationship! But I don't know we've been friends since we were little kids and then at the end of junior high it just started to feel different."

He pauses there for a moment so Adora prompts, "Different how?"

"I mean, we hit puberty and I knew what being gay was, but it was still confusing to feel that way about a girl. Not to mention my best friend. And well it wasn't till a couple years later that I started learning about the gender spectrum and what being trans means and can look like, you know?" Adora nods, she's cis but she can empathize generally with the confusion of sorting out your identity in a heteronormative environment. "I guess what I'm trying to say is, yes at that age I started to feel attraction to Glimmer. And I found out later that it was the same for her, though her timeline was a little bit off from mine. But what really felt different is that for the first time our friendship wasn't a purely safe space, I was so confused about my feelings and where the lines were."

"That sounds really hard, Bow." She turns briefly from the road to offer him a smile. He offers one back, though admittedly it is a little strained with emotion.

t was, sometimes it still is to be honest. Thanks for bringing this up by the way, it's I never really know how , but it helps to say some things out loud."

"Of course, Bow! I'm always here if you want to talk." She assures him emphatically.

"Thanks, Adora. Anyway , to answer your initial question, no we haven't talked about it. I mean, not lately . We talked after that kiss in high school. We were sharing a room, so it was kind of hard to avoid it. Both of us cried a lot, we were so confused and scared of losing each other. That conversation ended up being the first time I admitted out loud that I don't feel like a girl. W e decided that even if there was something between us, the timing wasn't right."

"So, have you talked about it since then?"

"W e have; it came up our sophomore year of college, the quarter before I decided to take indefinite leave. W e went to this party and Glimmer got absolutely *trashed* and I found her kissing some girl. I'm not proud of it, but I got really jealous and totally blew up at her in front of a bunch of people. We talked the next morning and I don't know. At first, I kind of thought maybe that conversation was going to lead to you know... *something more* but, well clearly not. Glimmer felt weird and let' s just say the two of us have been nicer to each other than we were in that conversation. We didn't talk for over a week after that happened. t was actually just a couple months before we met you."

Adora gapes at this revelation. "I had no idea; I can't imagine the two of you not talking."

"Y eah, it made things *really* awkward around the apartment for a little bit there." Bow laughs, it' s a little awkward, but genuine. "Anyway , obviously we made up and Glimmer said." Bow takes a deep breath and lets it out in a gust. "She said that she felt like if and when we ever date it's going to be end game. She said that she wasn't

sure she was done experimenting and she wasnt ready to settle down like that yet. She also"…

Bow trails off, seemingly lost in thought. Adora lets his mind wander for a couple minutes before clearing her throat lightly. "Sorry , uh, I was gonna say;she also told me that the way a romantic relationship between us has always felt so *inevitable/ kind of scares her sometimes. Like it almost takes away a facet of her free will."*

Adora: "And how did you react to that?" Adora can't imagine that was easy to her.

Bow laughs,"Oh yeah, not super well at first. I was pretty defensive. It felt like she was accusing me of trying to force her into something. But we talked it out and I do get it now. We're so close and our feelings run so deep that alone can feel intimidating. And I can hardly blame her for wanting the opportunity to see what the possibilities are outside of what we could be. I mean, Sagittarius, right? The best way to drive her away would be to try and pin her down against her will."

Adora looks at him dubiously, "You know I don't get the zodiac reference,right?"

Bow just laughs,clearly feeling more lighthearted having that off his chest."Yeah,but enough exposure and I'm sure you'll pick a couple things up.Besides,you do know Glimmer."

Adora laughs loudly. "Hey, that is true.So,what about you then?"

Bow looks bewildered at the question."What about me?"

"Well I just wonder if Glimmer dates casually sometimes. Is that something you want to do too,explore your options as it were?"

Bow looks thoughtful for a moment."Well, I've never been much for dating for the sake of it.I know that's something you can understand."Adora nods,they've talked before about how they both

identify somewhere on the asexual spectrum, how casual is dating largely unappealing to both of them. So, I feel like I'm just walking this fine line between waiting for her and not dating because I don't want to do so casually. Ultimately if something came along, say I met someone and felt a connection, I'd like to think that the possibility of her wouldn't stop me from seeing what it could be."

"That's fair, seems healthy."

"I like to think so." Bo chuckles.

"Have you dated much then? I know you've been on one or two first dates since we met but not a lot, right?"

"Not a lot, no. I did date someone for a few months freshman year of college. There was also someone right around the time you and I met. It never really panned out to anything, but we went out a bunch of times before mutually agreeing that the spark just wasn't going to ignite."

"Makes sense. Do you do you feel like you compare your relationship with the one you have had with her? Sorry, I don't know if that's totally fair."

"No, no it is. The honest answer is yes and no. It's hard to know how attraction can feel and not compare to that. But I also recognize it's hardly fair to expect anyone to live up to a twenty-year friendship's worth of emotional intimacy right of the bat. Plus, even if my attraction to other people isn't the same as it is with her historically it has, at least, been a way less complicated." He shrugs.

"Sorry Bo, that sounds tough."

"Sometimes it feels that way. But at the end of the day I wouldn't trade what her and I have for the clarity of something easy."

Aurora nods and, sensing the end of the conversation drawing in close, she redirects. "Hey, do you mind digging out those snacks? I haven't eaten in probably too long."

"You got it! Quartermaster reporting for duty!" Bodhi pulls the bag from where it's been placed in the backseat, digging out his and Aurora's food. "You ready for this Wisdom?"

Aurora groans, "Uh, don't remind me or my stomach won't settle enough to actually eat the stupid thing." Bodhi grins wryly and passes her half of her scone, digging into his bread. She eyes her snack from her periphery, it's dotted with stars and honestly looks so, so good. Resigned to whatever fate she's signed on for she takes a big bite. She gets half way through and when there's no immediate reaction she relaxes.

"So... how is it?" Bodhi asks leadingly.

"Honestly it tastes fucking delicious." She responds, a few crumbs and stars spraying from her full mouth. Bodhi defaults momentarily at the lack of dramatic reaction, but then perks up.

"Sooo... pretty darn interesting that Extra decided you just had to have that pastry, eh? Scorpia seemed to think it was a really good idea too."

At the thought of Extra stars flood Aurora's vision. She can still see clearly but it's so distracting she pulls into the next driveway they pass, looks like a gas station. It's lucky they'd pulled off the freeway shortly before and were on side streets now. Bodhi looks immediately concerned.

"Aurora? You okay there buddy?"

"Sorry, yeah! I just I got distracted from the road for a second. Some, uh, stars or something. Figured this was safer."

"Hey... do you need me to drive?" Bodhi's tone is consoling.

Alora thinks for a second, blinking a little extra hard. As she does the stars seem to disperse until just a few linger at the corners of her vision. "Uh, I'm okay."

"If you're sure." Bow's reply is hesitant.

"Really Bow, I wouldn't drive if I weren't completely sure."

"That seems to satisfy him. "So is it okay if I bring up um. you know Mo again or was that?"..

Alora thinks, about that. Or rather, she thinks about Cora and, while the thoughts are pretty consuming, it doesn't throw off her ability to drive again so she just nods "I'm really fine Bow."

"Okay, so that is pretty wild huh? And then she gave you her number! Don't tell me you aren't at least a little bit excited."

"I mean, more than a little it's I don't know. I feel like if I tell you or her that it felt unexpected I'm going to get scolded maybe? Something. I just flirting with a customer and sitting down after the end of her shift is different than offering me her attention on her own time, ya know?"

"I'm so sorry if you've felt like we put that pressure on you Alora!" Bow looks horrified at the thought. "We're just excited for you. But I can talk to Cora again about reeling it in."

Alora waves him off, "It's fine, I know your intentions are good."

"Good good, just let us know if it becomes too much! We want to support you, not overwhelm you."

"Thanks Bow."

"Sure, sure. So love at first sight?" Alora blushes deeply. "I'm just saying Cora mentioned it was a small batch. I wonder if Scoria gave one to Cora too, you know to help her sort out her own feelings?"

Alora honestly hadn't thought of that. It does sound possible.
"Maybe."

"Well, is it?"

Alora sighs, "I don't know. But, isn't that kind of hokey?"

"Maybe, but hokey doesn't have to be bad or false."

"I don't feel like I could fall in love with someone at first sight, not really. I feel like, isn't that just falling in love with the idea of them?"

Bria tips his head from side to side for a moment, weighing the possible responses. "Eh, maybe? I think it's more about intuition, but I definitely see where you're coming from."

"Well, I don't think I love extra." But it's a little bit but doesn't seem to have a mind to argue. She hesitates before finishing the thought. "But I think I could." The brightening of the stars at the edges of her vision indicate to her that the sentiment is absolutely true.

It's only twenty minutes later that they're pulling up to the beach house and Gen is immediately running out the door. Alora wonders idly if she's been texting Bria for updates on their arrival. She almost definitely has now that Alora thinks about it.

"Finally! What took you so long?"

Gen," Alora laughs, "it took us exactly as long as the quest said it would."

"The quest?" Gen scrunches up her face like Alora has started speaking in another language with no warning.

She just waves her hand dismissively. "Google, or Wayz, or whatever. Bria pulled up."

Her f riends laugh at her expense and then Dior is poking at her arm and waggling her eyebrows. "So, I heard someone got a girlf riend on the way up."

Aora blushes and spitters, "I did not! She's not my girlf riend!" She huf f s loudly. "Well, I didn't." Then suddenly, without her permission her tone turns cocky. "But I did get a phone number."

"Oh my gosh! Aora! Have you texted her yet? What did you say? What did she say? Let me see!" Dior demands sticking her hand out.

"Oh yeah, Aora we got so side tracked talking about my shit!" Dior spares a conf used look between the two of them at that comment. "Did you ever look to see if she responded?"

"Well, I didn't actually."

"Aora!"

Nas driving Dior crazy, jeez."

"Okay, okay, all I look now."

Aora thinks about f ighting her on it on principle but, well, she is curious. She opens her phone; sure enough there are about a dozen texts in the Best Friend Squad group chat, mostly Dior demanding a ref reshed ETA every so of ten. She also has a message f rom Myra, asking that Aora let her know when she arrives at the beach saf ely and sending her love to Eva and Dior. "Myra says hi." She of f ers, looking up f rom her phone, she mostly does it f or the reaction.

"Yeah, yeah, love back. Now get to the good stuf f ! Did she text you back or not?"

Aora looks back at her phone, "8 texts f rom Cora. "Holy shit, eight? She rushes to open them

(Really? Ork.
Ask is gif of a brown bear waving over a fence. The ork hello!
written beneath him
Scorpia is demanding to know if you liked the food.
Respond when you can.
Princesssss! Srsly she will drop it.
If I lose my mind before you ever make it home, it's your fault!
Whoops you get there safely. Text me when you get in.
If you want.

Oh, I like that face, that looks like she said something good." Bow squeaks.

"Seriously Adora, what did she say?" Adora looks up her expression caught somewhere between shock and a wide, joyous grin. "Let me see!" Glimmer demands and, without waiting, both friends press in close to look over either shoulder. The gasp once, twice, three times, in unison. "Eight messages in three hours?" Glimmer practically shouts.

"What are you gonna say?" As the press in closer Adora bats them away.

"Give me a second!" They both back off and leave her alone to catch up a little bit. Glimmer checks in about the drive and asks Bow for details about their trip to the café earlier. Adora leans against the car door and bites her lip, trying to draft a response. It takes her a couple tries but she manages.

Hey, sorry you've been getting tortured, was driving. Just got to the house. You can tell Scorpia the food was amazing, as always."
She hesitates for a moment and before she can think better of it shoots off; So... love at first sight huh? She adds a couple purple devil emojis at the last second.

*Resisting the urge to haul ass to the beach and throw her phone in the ocean she shoves it into Glimmer's hands. It cuts off her question about what they talked about on the drive up to Bow's obvious

relief . "I know you are gonna ask." While her f riends crowd around the phone Alora grabs her bag and the bag with the f ood Cora requested. Looks like Eva already grabbed his.

After she locks and closes the door , she looks up to see Cora looking at her , looking proud. "Omgosh Alora, perf ect! Okay , let us know what she says backas soon as you get it. We should go inside though, bef ore they come looking f or us."

They head inside and, to the eternal gratitude of Alora's grumbling tum , dinner is ready and waiting. Conversation is lighthearted. Mostly Costa and Angella catching up on what's going on in Bow and Alora's lif e. Alora stays quiet about Cora but she's sure the women don't miss the signif icant looks Eva and Cora shoot her when her love lif e comes up. They play a couple rounds of cards af ter dinner but af ter the drive Eva and Alora beg of f early f or bed, Cora close behind to, "help them settle in."

The next morning af ter breakf ast they hit a market in town. When they've had their f ill, they swing by the house f or lunch and spend the remainder of the day on the beach.

Alora and Cora keep up a stream of texts, they're not rapid f ire by any means but they are f airly consistent over the course of the day . After Cora's response to Alora's message the night bef ore ("idk what ur talking about.") they stick to topics that could all be categorized as chit chat. Mostly they keep each other up to date on what they're up to. Obviously Alora is pretty much glued on the beach, but as it turns out Cora is also of f f or the weekend. Scorpia's birthday is Sunday and Cora explains that it is a f ull weekend af f air . While they're lying on the beach Alora gets a message, a photo attachment with no explanation. Alora bursts out laughing and at their questioning glances turns to show the picture to Eva and Cora .

It's a picture of Scorpia, decked out in her f ull birthday glory . She has a headband with what look like crab claws poking out the top like antennae, her f ace is painted like a glittery orange butterf ly and she's

wearing a shirt, clearly hand painted, with the words Birthday Bitch' in loopy f lowery writing that Aora recognises f rom the specials board at Puteria. Must be Perf un' s writing. Bv and Ger take their turn to see and chuckle at the birthday antics.

"Tell her happy birthday f rom us!" Bv requests and Ger nods along.

Happy Birthday to Scoria f rom Bw , Ger and el Love the custom shirt!

But even a minute passes and Aora gets a response.
"Thx
Ian made it a couple years ago. She pulls it out every year now ' bw there's a surprise.

Good work, may have to commission ur skills sometime"

"Yah rite, aren't u an artist or summat?

Aora scof f s at the assessment, a couple doodles in a sketchbook hardly qualif ies her as an artist. Lol, hardly '.

"Dora, Ive seen ur shit."
"Don't see urself short, ur amazing."
"gg, heading to the park f or day drinking and capture the f lag rn."

Aora ignores the comment, at least as f ar as Extra can tell, she is def initely blushing. Hopef ully Bv and Ger write it of f as too much sun.
Sounds f un, Good Luck! She adds a f ew clover emojis f or good measure.

"Aw, thx Princess. Won't be needing it tho."
"Ian a tactical genius."
"nbd"

"Bw , sure are cocky '.

isn’t cocky if ur just that good.’
tyl Princess.’

Alora throws her phone into her beach bag and flops backonto her towel, forgetting to reapply her sunblock. It likely matters honestly, she’s probably already going to be permanently red.

After dinner Costa and Angella optto drinkwine on the porch while the twentysomethings take something a little harder down to the beach for a bonfire. Soon enough it’s roaring, stars jumping out from the flames and trailing toward the stars in the sky along tendrils of smoke. They’re laughing about nothing, pouring their second and third rumand cokes.

‘Im just saying, Ive never texted someone eight times in a row Maybe not even Bitch slurs.

‘I know, I know. Extra’s got it bad for me,’ Alora heckles back, also no longer sober.

She’s mostly joking but Ember responds enthusiastically shouting, “Yeah she does!” Bryce puts a steading hand on her shoulder, keeping her from leaning too close to the edge of the fire. “Aww, Bryce, you take good care o’ me!” She gives him a dopey smile, which he returns in kind, and pats his hand before turning back to Alora. “She does! Because you’re amazing Alora! She’d be crazy not to be gay for you!” Ember chortles at her unintentional rhyme until it turns to hiccoughing.

‘For real Drs!’ Bryce is lazy and objectively speaking you are a catch.” Ember nods so hard her whole body shakes against Bryce. He throws an arm around her shoulders and she snuggles into the crook of it. Alora raises an eyebrow but they both miss it.

‘Gay! Gay! You’re making me feel shy now’

"Aora!" Bow whines, which grabs Aora's attention. Whining is rarely Bow's style. He sings songs, "You're not listening!"

"I am so!" Her chin juts out stubbornly.

"Say then, so listen!"

"I'm listening!"

"Okay! Aora! We want you to be comfortable receiving compliments, because you know how true they are and have the confidence to admit it!"

Her gaps at him and puts a hand dramatically over her heart. "Oh my gosh Bow, you're like, so smart! That's what's exactly it!"

"Thank you Dear!" He kisses her temple, so quick Aora doesn't think he's even registered the action. She does, however, notice Glimmer set her fingers on the spot his lips touched. "Aora, and it's not for us, it's for you. You're like, so, so cool! You deserve to feel secure. I just," he sighs dreamily, "want all my friends to love each other and to love my friends! And that means all of them have to love them all. Like Glimmer loves Glimmer, and Bow loves Bow, and Aora loves Aora. You get me? That would make me so happy."

Aora is totally speechless. Luckily Glimmer interrupts, "Oh this is like that song! Bow this song is you hang on!" She fumbles with her phone and soon has an upbeat pop song blaring out of the little speaker she brought along. Conversation abandoned the friends begin to dance along, stars from the fire reaching out to twist between their bodies to the tempo of the music. In the back of her mind Aora tries to decide whether or not she hopes to remember Bow's proclamation in the morning.

Aora is blinking blearily at her phone early the next morning to check the time, but it seems she let it die overnight. The light of the

orning is still grey though. Figures, even on vacation she can't manage to sleep in. At least she's not horribly hungover thanks to Brendan ding that they all drink a bunch of water after trai ping inside last night. Even toasted he is such a dad. She's just rolled over to try and force her body to get even just a little more rest when there's a soft tap at the door .

Curious she calls out a quiet, "Come in!"

Eden opens the door and whispers "Thank goddess you're awake." Then she closes the door softly behind her , turning to throw herself face down on the bed next to Aurora. Aurora turns to her other side and props her head on her elbow to look at her new bed mate. "I'm love with Brian" Eden groans into the pillow beside Aurora.

"Okay wanna tell me where the problem is?" Aurora asks gently , carefully

Eden lets out a groan bordering on a scream and turns her head on its side to scowl at Aurora. "Please don't give me an I told you so right now. I know , okay? Everyone, anyone could have told me. Even mom and aunt could have told me. It's not like I didn't know , I just argh!"

Eden , Eden , hey I'm sorry! I didn't mean it like that. I just mean; I know it's super complicated, what specifically are you feeling frustrated about?

And then Eden starts to cry , she's not really sobbing but the tears steadily stream down her face and her voice is thick with emotion. "Sorry Aurora I just goddess! It really is just so complicated now ." Aurora nods and remains quiet while Eden thinks and gains some semblance of control over her emotions. "I just then I started to have feelings for Brad and then the ski trip , I just wasn't ready to be loved the way I know" she gets choked up for a moment, "the way I know Brian can love me. I mean even just as friends he's so stupidly perfect. I mean I know he's not like totally perfect but as close as it gets, honestly . And how am I supposed to

handle that? I mean I didn't know to take care of a love like that at eighteen! And then all sorts of something else happened a couple years later that made me wonder. Wondered if either of us knew how."

Alora shifts so she's sitting back against the headboard, allowing Gemma to flop her head into her lap where she can run her fingers through it soothingly. "Do you think you two know how to take care of a love like that now?" She asks quietly.

Gemma sobs at that, Alora never pauses her movements and they ride it out together. "I don't know, and it scares me because… because I don't know if I have a choice anymore, y'know?"

"You always have a choice Gemma; you don't have to do anything you're not ready for. I really don't think Bo is going anywhere."

"I say, well maybe I have a choice. But what if that choice is…" Her tears trip her up again. "What if it's a choice between destroying everything from the inside because I'm constantly trying so damn hard all the time to… to repress so much of what I'm feeling. I just… want him, Alora. And if I take him… it's for keeps. And that's a big commitment to make, a huge gamble to take."

"I know it is Gemma, it is. But all if you're ready to be brave is there anyone you can imagine wanting to commit to more? Is there any safer bet out there?"

Gemma doesn't answer, she just sobs into Alora's lap until she tires herself out, falling asleep for another hour. Alora just stays rooted in place, running her fingers through Gemma's hair and scratching her scalp and watching where the tears have stained the blanket with stars.

Chapter End Notes

Boy howdy, let me tell you, I did not plan the Bow/Gimmer drama when I started this. It has evolved of their own volition. Also, happy Cancer Season (to anyone who's into it), I was glad

to find a way for Cancer Queen Scorpia to have her moment in the sun!
Thanks again to anyone who has read and/or left a comment!I appreciate your time!

Blazing

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Eventually Bow comes knocking, if he finds anything strange about discovering Glimmer in Adora's bed he doesn't comment. Later that day Adora can't help but marvel at how well Glimmer seems to be able to compartmentalize; she treats Bow the same as ever. Though admittedly they are significantly less touchy feely than they have been the last week or two.

They spend the last day of their trip soaking up every last bit of sun they can get. Bow convinces them to build a sandcastle and they take about a billion pictures. Adora pouts about being photographed but they turn out so sweet she's secretly glad they've talked her into it. She sends one of the three of them making goofy faces in front of the castle to Catra without thinking twice about it. (OMFG, truly fit for a princess. U dorks.) After that they spend some more time just lying around, occasionally taking a dip in the water to cool down. Angella and Casta join them on the beach for dinner and everyone drifts off for an early bedtime. In the blink of an eye Bow and Adora are hugging Glimmer goodbye.

"Are you guys *sure* you can't beg off of work the rest of the week?" She pleads with them.

"Sorry Glim, capitalism calls." Bow shrugs.

"Okay, well then are you *sure* the apartment isn't flooding, thus necessitating my early return?"

"Glimmer!" Bow chastises.

"We're gonna see you so soon Glim, I promise!" Adora assures her.

"And I scored this Saturday off so we can hang and catch up all together! And/or go stalk Adora's new girlfriends." Bow snickers.

"She's not-whatever."

"Oh yeah, how *is* Catra doing today Adora?" Glimmer raises an eyebrow.

Adora shrugs, "I haven't heard from her yet- "

"Ha! Yet!"

Adora rolls her eyes and carries on, "I'm sure she's sleeping off her wild night."

"Oh my goddess Adora, did you get *drunktexts* from your crush last night and forget to tell your very best friends?" Glimmer demands in mock outrage.

Adora laughs, "Hardly! Nah, she told me she was stashing her phone away when they left for karaoke last night. I think she might have been a little tipsy by the time we said goodnight, but it was just a couple typos."

"Hm, you two have been talking an *awful* lot this weekend." Glimmer teases.

"Yeah, yeah." Adora waves her off. "Alright Glim, you know we hate to dash. But if we don't get on the road Bow's not gonna have time to settle back in before his shift."

"That's true, unfortunately." Bow frowns and initiates a final goodbye hug with Glimmer. She reaches out to Adora next and with promises to text over the coming week they're on their way.

Adora takes the driver's seat on the way back since Bow has to work later, and all in all it's a much more low-key ride than the way up. The mostly talk about Bow's work, him catching Adora up on the latest gossip. She only knows about half the folks in real life, but

Bow's worked at the record shop for ages, so she recognizes all the names. They get to Adora's place in record time and she sends Bow off with a hug, trudging up the stairs for a well-deserved nap.

When she wakes up, she sets to unpacking and setting herself up for the week ahead;shaking intermingled sand and stars from her clothes so she can wash them, tidying the apartment and doing a bit of meal prep. She looks around her place, she really doesnt have a ton of things, but she does need to start packing before too long. She cant believe how excited she is to move out. When she moved in nearly two years ago, she was so *proud* . It was her first place on her own, her first living in the city. It was amazing how good it felt to have a space be completely *hers*. But it had never really felt like *home* . Honestly The Castle already felt more homey that this space. She was feeling so ready to call that space hers too.

Adora's week stumbles along from there, passing relatively quickly in spurts and then dragging on in between. She messages her friends in her free time, Catra included, but for the most part she tries to just relax. Mostly that means spending an inordinate amount of time on pet finder. Friday night finds her sprawled on the couch doing just that, waiting on a pizza delivery . Glimmer is getting back late that night and Bow is closing up at work, so they've agreed to just meet at Adora' s and walk over to the café from there late the following morning.

She's making heart eyes at a senior beagle when a message pops up on her screen. "1 new message from Catra". She opens it immediately, heart thudding harder in her chest.

Wuu2?

Not much, just meeting my soulmate, hbu?

'wth?

Adora sends her the link of the dog she's currently falling in love with, already laughing at her own joke.

OMG, u think ur so funny! Dont u?

I mean I am, so…

Shut up Princess'

Like 2 see u make me'

'…
I bet u would' Adora stares wide eye at her phone, blushing like mad.
So are u getting a dog?

I wish'

'Good' Adora scof fs, a little offended.
'Cats are better anyway'
And then Adora gets a message beyond her wildest dreams. t' s a photo of Catra, sitting on a grey couch and holding a blue-grey cat with a fluffy mane on her lap. She has them held under their armpits in the crook of her arm, her head resting on theirs. They *both* look like they're smirking into the camera.

WH S TH T?
Omg'
Catra?

Omg Chillllll Adorable'
'That' s my furball, Melog'

Omg'
'omg u nerd'

?

Did udid you name your catGolembut spelled backwards?

Shut up'
No'

'They already had a name when IRESCUED them.'
U know , like a saint'
hbd'

'One does not simply walk into murder '
'Mordor '

Holy crap'
'Can u be cool?
Like ever '
'At all?

Adora laughs, she doesnt need to be cool. She' s hilarious.
'Tbh?
Not even a little bit.'

W/e, r u going to Plums 2morrow?

'Y ah, y?

Catra sends a shrug emoj then, Just asking'
'The royal guard coming?

?

U know , ur posse? Crop T op and Sparkles.'

LOL '
'Y ah, well all be there.'

'Cool.'

Adora drops her phone to her chest and smiles, feeling happy. She's even happier a minute later when she hears a knock on her door announcing the arrival of her dinner. And she's still happy when she drifts off to sleep that evening.

The morning dawns and Adora knows she likely has a few hours to kill before her friends show up. She uses the time to fold a bit of

laundry before puttering around the house and ultimately landing on the couch to work on a bit of art. She finished the portrait of Catra at the beach and started a couple different landscapes which she works on now. Caught up in the methodical scratch of pencil on paper, she's startled back to the real word when she hears relentless knocking at her door.

She opens it to reveal her two best friends. They look a little bit sleepy but overall perkier than she would have expected. "Hey guys!"

"Hey! We texted but didn't hear back. Figured you'd be awake, so we chanced heading over anyway. You ready to go or?" Bow peeks into the apartment behind Adora as if it will offer him some kind of insight.

"Sorry, yeah, I just got caught up in a project. Let me grab my stuff and we can head out."

"Cool, wanna smoke with us on the way over?"

Adora considers, it's been a while since she's indulged in that. She figures, why not, it isn't like her job ever drug tests. "Sure, I'm down for that." With everything she needs in her packets she follows them out the door and locks it up behind her, clipping her keys to her belt loop when she's through. When they reach the bottom of the steps Glimmer passes her the joint and a lighter. She gets it lit in no time and passes it back after taking her hit.

They amble down the sidewalk arm in arm, it feels like a perfect, idyllic summer day. Adora wishes she could live in the moment forever, watching the stars that pave the sidewalk below them and those that tumble along the smoke coming off the J and spilling from their mouths. "How was the trip back Glimmer?"

"Well the *trip* was good." Before Adora can ask what that means Bow jumps in, clearly keyed up as all get out.

"Glim and I got together! Last night! Like, together , together, with each other!" He s practically bursting at the seams and the stars filling the air around him are buzzing.

"Oh, my *goddess* Bow! I knew we should have smoked you out before we left the apartment. Seriously, no chill!" She rolls her eyes but reaches across Adora to take his hand, nothing but affection in her expression.

Adora stops in her tracks, pint hanging loosely from her fingertips. "Wait, *what*?"

"Uh," Bow shuffles his feet a bit, "yeah. We uh... surprise!"

"Yeah, no kidding! Oh my gosh, *you guys*! I'm so happy for you." She brings them both into a tight hug.

"Yeah?" Bow visibly relaxes.

"Of Course, Bow! Why wouldn't I be?"

"Seriously , I told you Bow!"

"Yeah, yeah I just wanna... are you still okay if you're living with a couple come August?" Bow looks unsure again.

That gives Adora momentary pause, but she answers honestly, shrugging. "I don't see any issues with that." Bow and Glimmer both grin widely and they resume their trek, Adora passing the pint to Glimmer. "So how?" She gestures between the two of them.

They look at each other for a moment and its Glimmer who answers. "I took your advice and decided to be brave and take the gamble." She gives Bow a moony smile, Adora is unsure if it's the weed or the love overtaking her expression. Probably a combo.

Bow nods in agreement, "We both know there's a lot to lose but I... like our odds."

"Alright you two are disgusting, which I love. I'm just gonna need one more hit before we head in there." She nods ahead to the café which is now just up the block. Bow passes her the J. She and Glimmer both decline a final hit so, when she's done, she rolls out the cherry and tosses the filter into the next bin they pass. Holding the door for them she says, "After you lovebirds."

She can't contain her giggles at that and that's when it hits her, she is decidedly stoned. She looks up and instantly makes eye contact with Catra. "*Hey Princess!*" She spares a glance at Glimmer and Bow and smirks, tacking on, "And company."

Where normally they would playfully protest the pair breaks down into helpless giggling. Yeah, they're also *decidedly* stoned. "*Catra!*" Adora tries for chill as she leads them up to the till, but vaguely registers that the way she's dragged the name out sounds distinctly *not* sober. Catra quirks her eyebrow at the group of fools before her. Adora, deciding any hope at chill is already lost and that, frankly, she is too stoned to care, takes on a silly affected accent. "How *are you* on this positively lovely summer's uhday?"

"What the." Adora can practically see the lightbulb go on and Catra grins, her expression bordering on sinister. "Oh my are you goons *baked*?"

"Shh!" Adora, unthinkingly presses a silencing finger to Catra's lips. It takes a moment before she realizes what she's done. When she does, she's too stoned to figure out how to solve it in any normal amount of time. If she's being honest, she kind of doesn't want to. How are Catra's lips so soft? Adora just sort of stares at her finger. And Catra's lips... mostly the latter.

Eventually she registers the awkward clearing of a throat behind her. She looks up minutely, finally registering the wide-eyed look on Catra's face. She darts her hand away and her face absolutely *blooms*.

"Lol, Adora!" Glimmer laughs openly.

Adora clears her throat and looks back and forth between her shoes and Catra's face. "That was uhthat' s my bad. Uh, sorry."She gives Catra a meek look.

"' s uhcool. Y ou fucking nerd."Adora relaxes at the familiar lilt of Catra's teasing and rolls her eyes.

"Y ou love it!"

"f you say so Princess. Now , can Iget something started for you hooligans?"Adora blinks back at her a couple times and then looks back at her friends.

Bow is staring open mouthed at the pastry case and whispers out a soft, "Oh no!"

Catra throws her head back and laughs loudly. Adora doesnt have the filter to hold back today. "I *love* when you laugh like that."She sighs. Her words register a moment later and she realizes that Catra is now blushing lightly, but she does look pretty pleased. But still"… Oh uh, wow, should Inot have said that?"She looks from Catra, to Glimmer and Bow, and back again. "Im so sorry , that was weird I probably shouldnt have- "

Catra cuts her off, looking at her with something akin to wonder. "I liked it."She admits softly . Then, clearing her throat she addresses all three of them. "Alright, seems like if Im ever gonna get you trouble makers out of my line Ishould probably just pick for you, yeah?"

Bow looks the most relieved of them all. "*Thankyou* !It all just looks so"he gulps. "W ow."

"Y ou absolute dorks, alright-no dont bother Sparkles."She stops Glimmer who has started taking out her wallet. Glimmer blinks in response but slowly slides her money away.

"Catra!"Adora protests. "Y ou gotta let us pay at some point."

Catra looks her dead in the eye, "Make me." Adora, frankly, has no rebuttal today and just blinks back. Catra laughs at her and makes a shooing motion with her hands. "Now go on, get! Get away from my register. Sit down and I'll get it to you when it's ready."

Bow and Glimmer move to find seats but when they look back at Adora she waves them off. She opts to follow Catra around the corner instead, resting her elbows on the drinks counter and plopping her head in her hands. She watches her work for a couple of minutes, losing track of what is coffee and what is liquid stars flowing around back there. Then unbidden comes, "Hey, so you're like, gay right?"

Catra fumbles for a second and turns to look at her breifly, turning back to her work almost immediately. "*Shit Dora!* Are you fu- *what?*"

Adora shrugs, surprisingly unfazed. Or maybe it's not that surprising, she's pretty sure she's more baked than when she walked in the door. Wait, what were they talking about? Oh, right. "Well I mean, Glimmer said well her *and* Bow but." She shrugs again, the movement is stilted and lazy with her head propped in her hands and her elbows still resting on the counter. "You never know."

Catra turns to consider her, sliding the first of the drinks in front of her. "Yeah I suppose not. That's for Crop Top, dont drink it." Adora arches a brow defiantly and picks up the drink to take a sip. She's pretty sure it's a cappuccino with some sort of flavoring, but she doesnt ask. She just sets the cup down and licks the foam from her top lip, holding Catra's gaze the entire time. Catra blushes, a true and proper blush this time. Adora revels in it.

"Dont tell me what to do." She sasses and sticks out her tongue.

"Ahem, noted. And to answer you question, yes, *very*." At Adora's bewildered expression she clarifies. "I'm *very gay* Princess." Now it's Adora who's blushing and Catra looks pleased to regain the upper hand.

"Oh cool. That's good, wow. Go lesbians, woo!"

Catra cocks her head to the side, sliding the last two drinks over the counter but making no indication that she's dismissed Adora. "Are… *you* gay, Adorable?"

Adora stands up and thumbs her chest proudly. "Hell yah! Certified disaster lesbian right here!" she crows, as if announcing a grand achievement. Honestly it sort of feels that way when she's rewarded with Catra's full laugh, stars bubbling out of her mouth.

"Alright Disaster Lesbian take this drink," She slides the cappuccino closer to her and then another of the drinks. "and this one to Crop Top and Sparkles respectively. Then scoot on back and I'll get y'all something to eat."

"You're a gay angel, Catra." Adora says solemnly, then picks up the drinks to make her delivery, leaving Catra shaking her head at her antics in her wake.

She drops the drinks in front of her friends, they look at them dumbly for a moment then up to Adora. "*Bless Adora!*" Whispers Bow.

"*So Adora*, how are things going over there with your Catra?" Glimmer asks slowly.

"Glimmer! She's not *my* -whatever! It's fine, great even. Totally normal."

"*Right*." Glimmer shoots back skeptically. Adora rolls her eyes and flounces back to the counter.

Still no new customers have trickled in when she reaches Catra, so she's just waiting with an amused expression, her arm propped on a low wall dividing the drink counter from the bar. "How ya doing Adorable?"

"Honestly? *So* good!"

"Oh yeah? Glad to hear it. What are you and the other goons up to the rest of the day?"

"Oh, you know , *chillin'*." Adora of fers a lazy grin. "How long are you working today?"

"Eh, not much longer . Scorp is gonna meet me here soon, she wants to go cake tasting. I told her it' s stupid, obviously she's just gonna end up making the stupid thing but," she makes a non-committal gesture, "who am I to pass up free cake, right?"

Adora just blinks back, Catra' s words not computing. "What are you?"..

"W edding cake tasting, try and keep up Princess." Catra smiles, it' s almost like a smirk but she looks significantly endeared.

"Are you?" Adora scrunches her face up in a scowl. That can't be right, right?

Catra snorts. "Oh yeah, me and Prince Charming. Y ou didn't get your invite? No, dummy! Perfuma and Scorpia are tying the knot this fall."

"Oh! *Oh!* That's so cool!"

"Y eah, pretty cool, I guess. I'm happy for them anyway ."

"A w, that's *nice*. You're so *nice* Catra, such a good friend!" She ignores Catra's blush and points down at the drink in front of her. "I t' s something iced and bright pink in a tall glass; stars are floating throughout, blinking softly within the glass. "Is this?" She points down at it.

Catra nods and she takes a grateful sip, it's tart and sweet. "Hibiscus tea lemonade." Catra tells her . Adora makes a satisfied sound and looks behind her when she sees Catra look up at the sound of the bell. Scorpia walks in the door looking cheery as ever. "Speak of the devil."

"Hey Wildcat! Ready to eat your weight in cake? Oh, hey Adora! Man, it's a good day for love, isn't it?"

Adora looks at her for a few beats too long but smiles as she gets closer and settles at the counter next to her. "*Omigosh!* Scorpia! You're getting *married*." She leans behind her to whisper yell at her friends, "Psst, guys! *Scorpia* is getting *married*!"

They call over their congratulations and are quickly reabsorbed into the bubble they've formed sitting on their own. Scorpia blushes lightly and rubs at the back of her neck. "Eh, yeah! Thanks, I'm a real lucky lady!"

"Perfuma's lucky too!" Catra insists, Adora looks over to grin at her. She really is *wonderful*.

"Well, sure." Scorpia, looking eager to slide out of the spot light, turns her attention to Adora. "So Adora, what's new with you? I hear your vacation went well!"

"Uh-huh, uh-huh, yeah sure did. I met a crab! Glimmer told it about you, she said you're a crab too. I told her that was really mean, but she said it was something about…*astrology*." Adora waves her hands around as if to encompass her confusion and wave it away. "It was your birthday."

Catra looks on, bemused, and Scorpia lets loose a booming laugh. "Well thanks, I'm sure he was a real nice little fella. Anything else going on?"

"Mm-hmm, he was, he was. Uhmoh! I have to pack!" She remembers.

"Wait, didn't you *just* get home? How much did you smoke Princess?" Catra asks.

"*No*, I mean, well yes. But not that kind of packing. I have to pack my house."

"Where are you going?" Catra asks quickly, frowning.

"The Castle!" Adora beams proudly before realizing they probably don't know what she's talking about. "I mean, Bow and Glimmer's! We're gonna live there...together. They're roommate is going to graduate school." She says 'graduate school' in her silly affected accent, an attempt at sounding fancy and collegiate. She's sure it works. "I guess we're gonna have a spare room now though. *Oh!* I could get a dog; he could have his own room."

"Woah, slow down there buddy, whose room is the dog taking?" Scorpia clarifies.

Adora shrugs. "Glimmer's or Bow's. Bow's room is bigger. Or maybe not, I guess some couples don't want to share a room. Hey," She leans behind Scorpia again to call out to her friends, missing the silent exchange she shares with Catra. "are you two sharing a bedroom now?"

"*Adora!*" Glimmer calls back, scandalized. Adora just waves her off, leaning back to her conversation.

"Whatever, dog or no dog I'm excited to move. My place is *small*." She offers.

"Ooo! When are you moving? Doesn't matter, can I help?" Scorpia asks, a pleading look on her face.

"Uhh"…

"Scorp, come on don't you think that's a little"…

"What? After all, I'm the muscle, remember?" She flashes Catra a roguish grin.

"I mean, I really don't have that much stuff. But if you *want* to help, I certainly won't say no. I was gonna get pizza and drinks after." Adora offers. "I'm moving on the first of August."

"Great! Just text Catra your address and we'll be there."

"Sorry , when did I sign up for moving crew?" Catra protests half-heartedly. Scorpia just gives her an exasperated look. "Fine, fine! I'll be there. Just text me the info Princess."

"Aw thanks! You guys are so *nice*." Adora smiles at them.

"Whatever . Alright you both gotta stop distracting me, I need to place an order before I take off. These," Catra pushes a plate with a few glittering cookies on top toward Adora, "are for you troublemakers."

"Oh yum! Chocolate chip and lavender , *very* soothing." Scorpia comments.

"Yeah well these yahoos are stoned out of their minds, so I figured." She shrugs, not bothering to finish the thought. Adora just sticks out her tongue and grabs her things.

"Thanks, bye Scorpia, good to see you."

"Bye Adora! See you soon."

And with that she walks the short distance to her friends, dropping herself into the chair across from them. "Sorry , did they just say they're helping you move?" Bow asks, his eyes wide.

"Uh, yah." Adora shoves what must be nearly half a cookie in her moth to cover any reaction. Her friends just stare back at her , mouths agape. She swallows thickly, wincing and wishing she'd put less cookie in her mouth. It was really good though, and she does feel a little calmer. "Listen I am *really* baked, and I know y'all wanna talk about this, but can it be later? Somewhere that' s you know," She makes an attempt to gesture subtly back where she came from. "not here." Though clearly both disappointed the newly minted couple nods in understanding. "Besides, what I really want to talk about is *you two* . What the heck happened last night?"

Suddenly they look shy, nervously glancing at each other with poorly disguised grins. Glimmer, always the bolder of the two, decides to fess up first. "Well so I came home, right?" Adora nods, obviously . "And I'd been thinking about it, you know since we talked, and I hadn't *really* decided what I wanted to do. But I like, basically knew and was trying to psych myself up. So, I get home and Bow is all happy to see me and it's chill- "

"You were so not chill! You know how Glimmer is when she's sitting on something Adora. I totally knew something was up."

"Oh my gosh Bow! If I'm gonna tell it, let me tell it. *So*, as I was saying, *totally chill*." Adora and Bow both laugh but Glimmer pays them exactly no attention. "And we're like catching up or whatever while I unpack- "

"Meaning I'm asking her questions and getting like, monosyllables back."

"Bow!"

"Sorry!" He doesn't sound sorry at all.

"Whatever Bow , eat a cookie. So, my bags are unpacked and I'm like, I need food immediately .' and we go down to the kitchen. Then, without me having to even ask, Bow starts making that really good green curry."

"Aw, your favorite?" Glimmer nods and Bow , eating his cookie and watching Glimmer intently, blushes softly.

"Yeah, so I'm just like, sitting there watching him and I just told him." She turns to look at him all moony eyed, but he just laughs and turns to Adora.

"Okay , no. I'm taking over narrator rights now . By I just told him' what Glimmer *means* is that out of nowhere she screams 'I love you!' at me. I was so surprised I nearly burned the shit out of my hand."

Bow laughs, clearly unfazed by his near miss with the gas range. "I figured she meant something by it, like something non-platonic, but I was so surprised I just stared for a minute. And then Glim is just ranting for like ten minutes straight."

"It wasn't ten minutes! And it *definitely* wasn't straight." Glimmer defends, all three taking a moment to laugh before Bow carries on with his side of the story.

"So, when she finally runs out of steam I just told her I feel the same way and yeah. I mean there was a lot more talking, but you pretty much know the whole gist of what was said already. There was also a lot of *not* talking." Bow's ears turn pink at his admission. "But that's um never mind. Wait, Adora are you *crying?*"

"*No!*" She's definitely misty eyed. "Fine, maybe *a little*, I'm not a monster! Of course, I'm feeling a little... I'm just so happy for you guys!" They share an awkward over the table group hug/hand holding sort of thing, all chuckling wetly. "Okay, but for real, does this mean we can get a dog? Oh, even better! A *horse* in Glimmer's old room!"

For the first time in a long time, Adora feels like she's *inside* of a star; warm and safe, and *happy*.

Chapter End Notes

> Alright, so initially I estimated this story at 10-12 chapters. That's very unlikely to happen with all I want to fit in still, I spent a little time on outline and I think it may be more like 18-20, whoops! Fun Fact: I started this thinking it might be a one shot, this is my first multi chapter story- I'm having a ball!

Paint the Stars

"Wow, you weren't kidding. This place is *small*." Adora looked around the tiny studio apartment that would only be hers for another forty-eight hours or so. It was very nearly packed. There were boxes lining the wall to the right of her front door and the living space was sparse to say the least. She was really just down to that last-minute stuff, things you need until the final days, when you resign yourself to living off take out, and all the crap you forget you even have. The remaining packing is the reason *Catra* of all people was standing in the doorway, surveying Adora's progress.

Adora had swung by the shop in desperate need of caffeine that morning before work, it was the first time she had felt the need to offer Catra any direction on her order. "Please," she had pleaded, "I really don't care what you hand me, I know it'll be good, but *please*; make sure it has like twenty shots of espresso."

Catra had scoffed and chided, "That much caffeine could give you a fucking heart attack. But I'll do what I can without risking your life, Princess."

It wasn't even that Adora didn't have the time to sleep. She wasn't kidding when she'd told Catra and Scorpia that she didn't have a lot of stuff. Moving was just a huge trigger for Adora's anxiety, hence a lot of restless nights in the last week and a half. While she didn't have much to pack, she'd still managed to collect more in the last year than she'd owned since she was a kid. When she'd moved into this place it had taken her one afternoon to pack up what she had back at Mara and Bo*pe*'s. She hadn't even needed a storage unit while she was staying at the hostel the first month after she'd moved, she just had Mara ship the few boxes (of mostly books) when she'd finally found this place. But then she'd needed bowls, and forks, pots and all the rest plus somewhere to store all those books. Then the shelves had looked so empty she collected more stuff and, and, and. So, it just *felt* like a lot.

The stress evident on her face must have been what motivated Catra to offer, but even she seemed surprised when it came out of her mouth. She'd sort of been teasing but at the same time had essentially invited herself over to help Adora finish packing. So here she was, standing in the door with a drink in either hand, just *looking* at all of Adora's neatly packed things.

"Okay I of ficially don't know what you're so worried about, what do you even have left to pack?" Catra asked, sliding into the apartment and depositing an iced drink into Adora's hand. Stars slid down along the condensation of the cup. Glass with no top Adora noted, like Catra had taken two for here cups from the café.

Adora took a sip, biding time and deflected, "Y um, this cardamom?" She'd been afraid of this reaction. She knew she was worrying over nothing, but when Catra had offered, well...she really liked the idea of seeing Catra outside of the café. Now though, she wasn't so sure it had been such a great plan under the circumstances.

Catra turned and lifted one perfectly manicured eyebrow. "Adora."

"I mean, not that much. I told you that!"

"W ell yeah, but you also said you were feeling really stressed about getting it all done in time. I mean, I haven't opened all of your cabinets but looking at how many boxes you have I'd guess you could finish this morning of if you really wanted to." Adora blushes by way of response and looks down at her shoes, poking and peeling at the plastic on one with the toe of the other. "Listen, you wanna smoke?"

Adora looks up so fast she nearly gets whiplash. "What?"

Catra shrugs, her hands on her hips now. "Perfuma leaves shit in my car all the time, I'm sure I could dig something up." She considers Adora for another moment. "Seems like you have the logistical side of things down, so that's clearly not where you need me. But I'm not

getting the impression you're gonna be able to chill without a little help."

Adora takes a moment to process that. She feels really…*seen*. She gets that from Glimmer and Bow sometimes but when it's Catra, well her stomach is doing somersaults and seems to have dropped down to her knees. "Uh…okay…" She looks hesitantly around the room. "I kinda still wanna pack though."

"That's cool." Catra turns on her heal and heads back out the door, leaving a puff of stars and a dumbstruck blonde in her wake.

Nearly an hour later they're on the couch cackling. Catra is sprawled out, leaning against one arm and Adora is perched on the other. She'd made moves to start packing about half an hour ago, had even shuffled a few things around. Talking with Catra kept drawing her back to the couch though. Eventually she had committed halfway and was sitting with her feet on the cushion, elbow propped on the backrest with her head resting on her hand. She felt *good*, she felt lazy.

"So, you wanna talk about it?"

"About what?" Adora blinked owlishly at her.

"Why you're so freaked even though you're more prepared than I've *ever* been for moving."

"Oh." Adora morphs into something significantly less joyful. She looks down and picks at a random spot on the couch. A moment ago, the threads had seemed to be lit up with stars, now though not so much. "It's, I just get anxious sometimes."

"I mean fair, same. A uh…*complicated* upbringing can do that to your nervous system. I'm asking if you want to talk about what's triggering it though."

Adora fights back tears she doesnt want to be seeing, tears she doesnt want *Catra* to see. "Uh-it' s just moving ya know?"

Catra hums, "Isnt moving supposed to be like, the third most stressful life you can go through?"

"What are one and two?"

"Uhlike divorce and, shit Idont know . Alien abduction probably." Both women cackle loudly at that. "Im just saying, it makes total sense that youre stressed but youve clearly got this. Justd hate to see you give yourself a heart attack at twentyuh however- "

"T wenty-five."Adora supplies.

"Right, too young for a heart attack."

"Iknow , Ido. Ive just never been great at managing stress. Honestly Ive used it as a motivator for so long Ihave to remind myself to not actively lean into it."

"W ow Adora, that's fucked up."She' s smirking and Adora laughs.

"Shut up."

"Hm, dont think Iwill."

"Y ou really cant think of anything better to do with your mouth." Adora freezes as soon as the words leave her mouth. *Fuck* . Catra is frozen in place too, face aflame and staring at Adora with an expression she cant decipher , doesnt know if she wants to. "Uh-didnt mean that. Y ou know, not like-Imean well, not that it wouldnt, or hasnt uhsorry ."

The spell is broken and Catra is cackling wildly at her again. Adora is *way too stoned* for how pretty Catra looks, especially after briefly visiting the places her little slip up drug her mind to. Her mind is still struggling its way out of the gutter when Catra calms enough to speak. "Gods Princess, your fucking *face*"

"Shut up, you like my face."

"Psh, keep telling yourself that Adorable."

"Fine, Iwill."

"Good then."

"Fabulous."They stare each other down for a minute and Adora couldnt say who breaks down into giggles first. Soon Adora has slipped off the arm of the couch onto the cushion, now glowing with stars once more, and her legs are bumping comfortably into Catra's.

"Alright Princess, Ithink Ineed you to feed me now ."Catra pats her stomach softly.

Adora, always good with a clear objective, nods. "Cool, well my kitchen is kind of sparse. Ive got leftover pizza, uh a jar of applesauce, and Ishould be able to throw together some pasta." Catra's eyes brighten at the mention of noodles. "Awesome, pasta it is."

Adora heads into the kitchen, Catra trailing into the tight space after her and pulling herself up to sit on the narrow counter. Adora tries to ignore the way her heart stutters every time she brushes Catra's knees reaching for something or walking past her. Blessedly Catra doesnt seem to notice, she just teases Adora mercilessly and does her best to get in the way. Despite the way Adora protests she *likes* having Catra in the kitchen with her. She avoids thinking about how domestic it all feels, about how easy it would be to set herself between Catra's knees, rest her hands on those powerful looking thighs and..She chooses instead to tease back, flicking water at Catra and laughing at her responding jump and high-pitched yelp.

Soon enough they've devoured the simple meal and are slouching on the couch, watching the cartoon Adora had flipped on. After another episode ends Catra sighs. "Alright Dora, Ishould probably get going."

Adora pouts, "Okay , yeah. Thanks for coming, Icant tell you how much this helped."

"Hm, was it my company that helped, or Mary aLane' s?" Catra' s chuckle at her own joke is cut short when Adora responds with no hint of hesitation.

"Y ours."She says simply .

Catra clears her throat a little awkwardly, a faint blush intermingling with the freckles that have continued to darken as summer wears on. Stars begin to appear between the freckles, faint like stars in a sky that is fading slowly from day to night. "Oh. Good, glad Icould help."

"Get home safe."Adora of fers her a light smile.

"No promises. Ill see you Saturday morning though, nine you said?"

"Y eah, Glimmer and Bow will probably roll in late or just wait at the new place for us. Ijust dont want to wait until they roll outta bed, Im sure Ill be up by six."Adora shrugs.

"*Six*?" Catra exclaims, Adora just nods blankly back. "Goddess Adora, maybe Ishould recruit you for the café. *Six* on your day off."

"Im an early riser!"She defends.

"Clearly ."There' s an awkward pause, like neither of them knows what their next move should be. Do they hug? Making the decision for them both Catra offers up a small, awkward wave. "See ya then Adorable."

"Bye Catra."Adora stays leaned up against the door and watches until Catra has gotten into her car and driven off with a final wave from the open driver's side window.

Adora is too preoccupied to be truly productive at work on Friday and, knowing her plans for the weekend, her supervisor lets her go early. t gives her more than enough time to set up for the following

day. When she crashes on the couch that night even her bedframe is pulled apart, mattress stood on its side by the door. Adora wakes the next morning and blinks drowsily at her phone. She does a double take when she sees the time. Eight? She feels grateful she chose to leave nothing to do this morning, rolling herself off the couch to get ready.

Promptly at nine there's a patterned knock at the door. She opens it to reveal Scorpia bouncing on her heels, Catra and Perfuma standing a step or two behind her looking significantly less animated. "Good morning Sunshine!" Scorpia crows.

"Good morning! Thank you so much for coming. Perfuma I didn't realize you'd be tagging along, I'm so happy to see you. Thanks for coming."

"Of course, it's lovely to see you as well."

Adora ushers the group inside and angles them toward the boxes. "So, there's really only one room, the kitchen and bathroom are both cleared out. So, this is all of it. Iuh, I didn't get a U-Haul, but I have a little pick up. If y'all don't mind putting a few things in your trunk I think it should all go in one load with the exception of the couch. And I'm sure Bow would come back to help me throw it in the truck."

They fit it all in one load as it turns out, couch included. Scorpia not only loves moving, she is a genius at it. After Adora had told them the projected plan Scorpia had informed her that they had actually driven two cars to get to her place. Specifically to have extra room to put Adora's things. She also outpaced everyone else by double, hauling ass up and down the stairs. The cars are loaded in record time, Adora looks at her phone as the other woman shift a couple things around in their own cars and get doors all closed up. It's not even ten, Adora always expects moving to take so long.

"Wow, thank you guys again, really! I can't believe how quickly that went." Adora praises as they walk over to her .

“W ell, we all know Scorp is the real MV P here.” Catra pipes up.

“A w, thanks for saying that Wildcat.” Scorpia blushes, scratching shyly at the back of her head. “It was a team ef fort though, really.”

“Honestly , she’s totally right Scorpia. You’re a machine.” Adora says fairly.

“A w, honey! T ake the compliment, we all know you’re wonderful.” Perfuma giggles, leaning over to kiss her partner’s cheek.

Adora sees Catra notice Scorpia’s discomfort and jump in to rescue her. “Alright, well are Crop T op and Sparkles even gonna be ready for us to come stomping in with all your shit?”

Adora bites her lip, “Uhm...”

“Y eah, I got that impression. Why don’t we hop down to the shop and get a round of coffees? W e can hassle the new kid a little bit, check in.”

“Catra, Kyle is perfectly nice and totally capable! Y ou need to have confidence in him.” Perfuma scolds her as they begin the walk, wordlessly coming to a consensus.

“I know he is Fuma, but the kid is a wreck. He’ll be fine if he can get over his nerves, but I’d be lying if I said I wasn’t a little concerned about the outlook of that.” While they bicker a little bit more about Kyle and then move on to general shop talk Scorpia and Adora fall slightly behind.

“So Scorpia, can I ask what’ s up with you and moving?” Adora ventures.

Scorpia chuckles lightly, “Oh, I just like feeling useful to my friends. Perfuma says the high priority I place on being useful stems from a deeply rooted insecurity around not being worthy or valuable to people. I’ve never been much of a Brainiac, but I’ve always been

strong. So, when opportunities come around to lend my skills to others, Itend to jump on them *pretty enthusiastically* . Plus, Ithink moving can be pretty fun, Imean the bubble wrap alone! Hours of fun to be had."

Adora laughs, though some part of her mind is still taken aback by the completely transparent answer. Truth be told she really respects that. She can barely recognize her own insecurities, let alone speak openly about them with new people.

"Anyway , that's how Imet Wildcat."

"Oh?" Adora tries, and probably fails, to not sound too interested.

"Yep, see Iknew DT from way back when and they and Catra lived together for a year. Well, that was a *disaster* let me tell ya! Two personalities that big under one roof? Yeesh. But Ihad insisted on helping them move and Catra," Scorpia chortles under her breath. "well Catra was there and she wasn't so good about accepting help back then. Tried to move her mattress in by herself, up *three flights* of stairs! That there's a stubborn one let me tell you."

Adora laughs, eyebrows raised. She chances a glance up at Catra who's absorbed in conversation with Perfuma still. "Did she let you help eventually?"

At that Scorpia's laughter is so booming the women ahead of them turn to look with eyebrows raised. "Hey! Well Catra may be stubborn," Catra sticker out her tongue at Scorpia, face flushing slightly, before turning back around. Her posture looks a little more tense now . "but I am forceful. Didn't leave her much of a choice, though she did chew me out after about respecting a perfect stranger's boundaries. She also did *not* take well to my telling her how cute she looks when she gets mad. Ijust kept showing up though, and well, now look at us!"

Adora makes a noise of acknowledgment, thinking over what she's heard. Scorpia considers her solemnly for a moment, she pauses and instinctively Adora does too.

"You know, I really can't tell you how much Catra has grown in the last five years. She actually brought that little spat up to me years after. Apologized, if you can believe it. She also told me how grateful she is for my tenacity. Well, I'm sure you can guess what a good cry I had a that. I guess what I'm saying is Catra has her faults but she's worked really hard to know herself and learn to be better for herself and for her friends. She's a keeper, and she has a lot of love to give." She gives Adora a significant look and her eyes are starry.

Adora's voice is stuck in her throat, trapped by emotion. She's saved from responding when Perfuma and Catra, now at the café, turn to see why they haven't made it up the block. Scorpia turns to catch up and Adora clears her throat, touching Scorpia's arm lightly to give her pause. She looks back at Adora. "Thank you, for telling me that I mean. I'll uh I'll keep that in mind."

Scorpia smiles kindly back. "I trust that you will Adora."

They arrive at the Castle with their full cars about half an hour later, Bow and a sleepy looking Glimmer already waiting for them on the street. "Hey Roomie!" Bow calls out the second Adora steps out of her car.

"Do I see coffee? Can I have some? Oh, goddess above!" Glimmer looks more alert at merely the idea.

"Glimmer!"

"*What* Bow?"

"Don't you want to welcome our new roommate home? You know, before demanding coffee." Bow gives her a stern look which she responds to with an eye roll. Before they can devolve into full blown bickering Catra slips around Adora, two drinks in hand.

"Alright Bert and Ernie, calm down! We got for you too." Bow looks more relieved than Glimmer and they both express their gratitude

effusively, almost missing Scorpia and Perfuma who have wandered up.

Greetings are exchanged all around but Scorpia cuts the small talk off before too long. "Alright, let's get this party started! Who wants to help me grab the couch."

"I've got you Scorpia!" Bow of fers.

"If folks are getting hungry, I can call in an order for pizza?" Adora offers and everyone confirms.

"Adora do you mind getting a veggie with no cheese for me?" Perfuma requests.

"I'm happy to if that's what you'd like. I was gonna order from the vegan place on the other end of Eternia Ave though, so there might be a few more options for you."

Perfuma's eyes brighten at this, but she insists, "Oh, you don't have to Adora. I'm really fine with whatever, y'all don't have to adapt to my restrictions!"

"It's really no problem. Besides, that place has some of the best pizza in town. Plus, I don't think dairy is that good for me anyway."

"Well if you're sure, that would be really cool! And I'm good with whatever toppings." Perfuma's smile is bright as she moves over to help the others who are already carrying Adora's things to into the apartment. Adora places the order and walks over to see what's left.

The bed of her truck is clear and Scorpia's car is closed up and looks empty. Catra is standing by her trunk, wrestling with what looks like the last few boxes. "Hey, is this it already?" She asks, approaching the other woman.

Catra shrugs, "With five sets of hands and how little shit you have, things go fast. I told the others I could handle the last of it but well I

may not be as tall as Ilike to think. Y ou mind grabbing one of these."

"Of course!Ican take a couple;Ihavent gotten anything else and it's my stuff."

Catra shakes her head. "t' s fine."

"Okay ,"Adora responds, not pushing, thinking back to what Scorpia had shared with her earlier. She does, however, pick the box she knows to be the heaviest. "Hey , thanks again for helping me out today. You really didnt have to;Iknow you kind of got roped in."

"Adorable, Iwas just teasing. Obviously Im happy to help."She hefts her two boxes up and slams the trunk closed once Adora has the third. They're about halfway to the door when she speaks up. "Icant believe how close you lived to the café for all that time."

Adora laughs, "Iknow , so much time wasted, not coming in. Im glad to have found it though, you and Perfuma really did something special there, you know?"

Catra neither accepts nor denies the compliment, instead asking, "So, that mean well still see you around now that you live in the boonies?"

Adora snorts and rolls her eyes. "Ithink Ican handle the journey ."

Catra lets a small smile slip, "Good then."

They walk in the door, finally closing it behind them, and deposit the last few boxes in the kitchen. Then they join their friends who have all settled in the living room. "Can Iget drinks for anyone?Bow you got beers, right?"

"Sure did!"Bow hops up and runs to the kitchen, returning a few moments later with enough bottles to pass around.

Catra looks down at the hard lemonade in her hand and back to Bow with an arched brow. "Thought you said you got *beers* Crop Top."

t's a malted beverage! Beer!" he defends indignantly.

Catra rolls her eyes and cracks it open, taking a swig. She's sitting cross legged on the floor in front of the television and leans back, propped up by her free hand. "It's glorified juice, but whatever, itll do. Thanks Bow." Bow smiles, mollified.

"Uh, you lovely folks dont happen to have any non-alcoholic options, do you?" Scorpia asks from her spot on the couch.

"Oh, of course! I shouldnt have assumed, we have carbonated water and *actual* juice, plus like water and milk, that sort of thing." Bow offers.

Scorpia looks relieved. "A fizzy water would be great, thanks friend!" Bow hops up to fulfill the request.

"Not a big drinker Scorpia?" Glimmer asks from the other end of the couch.

Scorpia rubs the back of her neck, a nervous tic Adora has come to assume. "Not at all actually, I'm sober."

"You're going to be accepting that five-year chip in no time babe." Perfuma interjects. She has opted not to sit, instead drifting about the room looking at the various knick-knacks and brushing her fingers against plants, which glitter with stars where she has touched them.

"Oh, well. Thanks, Fuma!" Scorpia accepts bashfully. She mutters her thanks to Bow when he hands her a can before plopping between her and Glimmer.

There's a knock at the door and Adora hops up to accept their pizza. She's just dropped it on the table when Perfuma, who had just started to propel herself back toward the rest of the group, pauses and picks up Glimmer's tarot cards. "Oh, who's deck is this? The box is stunning!" She asks the group at large, eyes wide.

"Oh, those are my cards!" Glimmer responds proudly , pausing the task of loading up her plate. "I'd be happy to read for you sometime."

"That would be lovely ." Perfuma responds with a smile, taking a seat in the open chair, joining them at last. "The cards are so powerful, but I've never been able to connect. How did you start reading?"

"My Aunt Casta gave me my first deck for high school graduation. It took me a long time to learn and really understand them, but the connection was pretty instantaneous." Glimmer explains.

"Marvelous." With that Perfuma begins stuf fing her face with the rest of them, managing to put away even more than Adora, who is known to have a voracious appetite. After the pizza is demolished and they've taken suf ficient time to digest, Glimmer sets up the dining table with some crystals and such, and invites Perfuma to sit. Bow and Scorpia follow into the little nook after them to hang and watch, but Adora and Catra linger where they're sat on the floor .

"I'm stealing a couch seat if you want to join, my butt is sore." Adora watches in a trance as Catra stands and, her back angled toward Adora, rubs her butt. "It' s a very nice butt, Adora thinks to herself before shaking head to try and dislodge the thought.

"Oh, uh sure. I'm just gonna drink. Get another drink, from the kitchen where the drinks are." Adora stutters awkwardly , feeling her face heating up.

Catra gives her a strange look. "Okay , weirdo."

Adora forces a laugh. "You want?"

"Why not, thanks."

Adora rushes into the kitchen and takes a moment to hold the cool bottles to her face and breathe deeply before returning. She hands one to Catra and takes the spot on the other end of the couch. They

sit quietly for a little bit, the silence comfortable, and both sip at their drinks.

"So, uhwhat were um, you and Scorpia talking about earlier?" Catra ventures nervously after a little while.

Adora startles, and blushes biting her lip. "Oh, uh she just told me about how y'all met. I had asked why she likes moving so much and"…

Catra gives her a dubious look. "She waxed lyrical about how proud she is of my emotional growth, didn't she?"

Adora feels embarrassed, like she's been caught reading Catra's diary. "Uh, sort of yeah. Sorry , I hope that wasn't." She' s not even totally sure what she's apologizing *for*.

To her relief Catra waves the apology away. "Don't sweat it, I'm sure she volunteered the information unprompted. Anyway, like I said, I'm lucky to have a friend like Scorpia. Perfuma too for that matter. I don't I never met someone who *cared* so much about me or anything really before she came along." Catra has begun peeling at the label on her bottle, pausing as she finishes talking to take a swig.

"I'm glad you have each other , I'm just sorry it took you so long to find someone who cares about you so much." Adora hesitates, weighing how honest to be. "Who uh, loves you like you deserve."

Catra looked up at that, right into Adora's face. "Y eah. Hey , Adora I-" Adora curses internally as their friends come back, making a ruckus along the way.

"Oh my gosh Adora! Y oull never guess!" Glimmer came skipping over and plopped between her and Catra, oblivious to the ruined mood. Bow, standing off to the side looks between the two interrupted women. Seeing that he seems to be deciding whether or not to step in Adora shakes her head subtly at him. He grimaces and

nods with a look that says something akin to, Sorry , you know Glimmer'. Adora nods in acceptance, she certainly did.

"Uh, what wont Iguess Glim?"

"W ell". She drags out the word. "Perfuma just invited me to do readings at Plumeria's anniversary in a few weeks! Im so excited, I so rarely get to read for anyone outside the friend group."

Catra turned to look over the couch at her friends with a lifted brow. "Oh, did she now? Must have gone well in there then."

Perfuma nodded, "Y es, Glimmer is *amazing*, her connection to the cards is really something. She read for Scorpia too! And dont you think that will be fun Catra? I was thinking we could set her up at that table by the door, the two top you know the one. Oh! And we can shuffle some plants around to really heighten the vibe. Glimmer, where do you get your stones, Ifeel like incorporating a few could bring a great, fresh energy to the shop!"

"All around really! There was a gem show last fall where Imade out like a bandit, but mostly Ijust get one or two at little shops around. Ooh, there is a cutie little apothecary not too far from here, Igot that selenite and a few others there. They had this *amazing* malachite but it was huge and pricy so Icouldnt quite justify it with everything else Iwas getting that day . Ibet you'd really vibe with that energy if they had something like it again though." Glimmer gushes.

"Okay , Ill have to check that out next time Im out and about. Sweetie," she turns to Scorpia, "you were planning to swing by the shop with a delivery tomorrow, werent you?"

"Sure was!"

"Excellent, if Itag along would you want to head over there with me after?"

"Sounds like a plan!" They smile warmly at each other , it radiates intimacy. "W ell, Ithink it' s about time the two of us take off. Thank you so much for everything, Ihad a blast!"

"Of course!" Adora replies. "t was the very least Icould do, you made the day such a breeze."

"Catra, what do you have going on the rest of the day?" Bow asks, then seeming horrified that his words may not have been considered hospitable he continues. "W e're just hanging out here while Adora settles in, so feel free to stay longer if you'd like."

"W ell uh." Catra looks around the room, Scorpia is nodding encouragingly and Perfuma gives a very overt wink. She looks to Adora who smiles softly back.

"I was, um, gonna paint my room this afternoon before setting up in there. Ithink Bow and Glimmer were gonna tackle the kitchen boxes to get them out of the way." Adora looks to her friends who nod in confirmation. "f you'd want to stay Iuh, wouldnt mind some company."

"Okay , yeah. Ican stay a little longer ." Her words are soft, and they feel significant.

Perfuma and Scorpia say their goodbyes and as soon as they leave the others disperse. Bow and Glimmer had set everything up for Adora, even going so far as to tape up the trim and remove socket covers for her. She'd have to remember to thank them. She and Catra get the paint set up and Adora puts Catra in charge of the music. Soon enough Adora is painting, Catra is on the floor watching her work, and stars are intermingling with the paint and dancing along to the music in the cracks of the floorboard.

"Y ou missed a spot Princess."

Adora huffs, that's not the first time she's heard this. "Catra Iswear!"

"What? I'm helping." She taunts back.

Adora snorts. "Yeah big help, thanks."

"You're welcome." She says back simply, ignoring the sarcasm of Adora's words. "So, this color."

"What about it?" Adora questions defensively.

"I mean I like it but why *this* color?" She picks up the upturned paint can lid, showing to Adora as if it's not smeared all over her wall now.

"There's no significance." She lies hastily. "I just liked it."

"Hm, it just looks kind of familiar." Catra shrugs.

It should, Adora thinks. When she had chosen it, the stars led her right to it. It was the only paint chip with any sort of sparkle, and she liked the calming rhythm of its stars. She told herself it reminded her of the one time she had seen the ocean, when Mara and Glimmer had insisted that she join them on vacation early on in their relationship. And it did a little bit, it wasn't quite the same color, but the energy was the similar. Now, looking Catra in the eyes, one green and one blue, she can't quite lie to herself anymore; that wasn't the only thing it reminded her of. The twinkling of Catra's blue eye matched the rhythm of the stars in the paint perfectly.

The air felt suddenly thick with an unfamiliar charge. Adora swallowed, "Familiar good?"

"Uh?" Catra asked, looking up from the lid in her lap where she'd been staring, as if trying to place the color. "Oh, yeah. I like it."

"Hm, enough to wear it?"

"What?" Her eyes widened as she registered Adora advancing toward her, wielding her paintbrush like a sword. "No! Adora, fuck no. Stay away from me. *Adora!*" Catra's voice turns to a whine on the name, but Adora is relentless. She chases Catra around the room

with the brush until both of them were breathless and giggling. Until Catra's back was against the wall, Adora in front of her, too close to be considered a polite distance. "Adora Iswear if you get that fucking paint on me."

"A w Catra."Adora grins evilly . "I dont have to, you just got it on yourself."Catra turns and sure enough she is backed against the wall Adora had just finished painting. She groans and turns around to complain, only to find Adora closer than before. Her breath hitches, so distracted by their closeness she doesnt notice Adora raising the paintbrush until it's dragging down her face.

By the time Catra leaves half an hour later she isnt the only one covered in paint. Adora closes the door behind her friend, grinning goofily. Glimmer turns from her spot on the couch where she and Bow had started a show a bit ago. She looks Adora up and down and smirks. "If your flirty little paint fight got paint on the hardwood it's coming out of your portion of the deposit."

Adora giggles and shrugs. "Sounds fair ."She walks away , into the bathroom to shower. Washing herself clean she cant help but grin at the blue paint and silver stars as they circle down the drain, relishing in the joyfulness of the day .

The Universe on It's Knees

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora could scarcely believe how easily she had settled into her new home. By the end of the following week she was fully moved in and she felt more at home than she had in far too long. The Castle was as welcoming and cozy as ever, but her room had really come a long way. Trinkets and books lined her shelves, and some little gem fairy had snuck into her room while she was at work on day and left behind several stones. She couldn't deny that her space had great energy though, so she couldn't find any reason to fight the small invasion. And amongst all those trinkets, gifted stones and books were stars that never left.

When she first noticed them, not quite stagnant but not really moving much either, she had assumed that they, like the others, would pass when the energy shifted. But day after day they stayed, rolling around on the shelves. After a week she grew tentatively hopeful. After two she became a much more secure, because after two weeks she started seeing them all around the house. They were intertwined with the hair Glimmer left on the shower wall, scattered throughout the pile of shoes that lived by the door, never quite making it onto the shoe rack (which Adora had bought just three days after moving in), and flew out of the lock when Adora left and came home every day, shooting out whenever she slid her key out.

Bow and Glimmer *loved* finding out the funny places the stars showed up. Bow had taken to marking each spot with glittery star stickers he had gotten from the drugstore. "So, Glim and I can be in on the fun too." he had explained, which made Adora's chest tighten with emotion. A couple times since then she had marked places without telling either of them-seeing how long it took someone to notice.

They were lounging around in the living room, laughing about one Glimmer had found just that morning. It was a magnet Glimmer had picked up when she studied abroad in Portugal, smack dab in the center of the fridge. Adora had put it there five days ago.

"Wow Glim, I saw that the next day! I can't believe it took you so long" Bow says smugly, the two of them having developed a mutual attitude of competition around finding the hidden stars first.

"Whatever, I stand by my assessment that the coloring makes it very subtle. Anyway, in all seriousness," Glimmer reaches out to hold Adora's hand, the stuttering of Adora's heart foreshadows the waterworks to come. "Adora, I just wanted to say that having you live with us," her voice grows watery and she pauses to huff once. "having you, and your stars, has really made our home a more magical place to live." Glimmer is still trying to hold back a growing pool of tears, but Bow has no such reservations. He is sitting on the floor in front of Glimmer, knees up with his forehead resting on them, crying openly. "*Bow* if you start crying, I'm gonna start."

"Well I'm definitely crying now so, might as well join us Glim." Adora gives a watery laugh.

"I *just wanted to say*, thank you, truly, for living with us and being so open with us and letting us love you. Both of us," She looks to Bow who doesn't pick up his head but nods into his knees. "I have seen how much you flourished the last few months, and we're really proud to be your friends."

"*You guys!*" Adora cries. "I love you both so much. Thank *you*, you've both honestly made my life way better. That was um really cool of you." They all chuckle readily at the welcome comic relief from the emotional moment. They sit quietly, enjoying their individual emotional landscapes. After a little bit Adora wipes her eyes and reminds them, "Hey, y'all promised me a house meeting."

Glimmer rolls her eyes. "Yes, but by house meeting we assumed you meant; let's hang out like we have nearly every other night since

Adora moved in, but she wants to talk about the spare room."

"*I want to talk about the spare room*," Adora cuts in immediately.

"Chill Adora! We can, we will. You're being such a Capricorn right now."

Adora clicks her tongue. "I still don't really get what you're insinuating when you say that. But Catra said I should take it as a compliment because it means I'm smart and driven and strong willed. So, thanks for the compliment." She punctuates that by sticking her tongue out.

Glimmer sits up properly, suddenly much more invested in the conversation. Adora kind of wishes she'd kept her dang mouth shut. "Oh, I'll just bet she did. Also, strong willed is just a nice way of saying stubborn, I stand by my sentiment. But while we're on the subject, how *are* things with you and our friendly neighborhood barista?"

"*Glimmer!*" Adora warns.

"Come on Adora." Bow pipes up. "You can't blame us for being curious. You said you wanted to get to know her before making a move. And, well, come on! You text nearly every day, see each other multiple times a week between the café and her coming over to eat all of my chips, and the girl helped you move for goddess' sake. And the chemistry is *palpable*. At this point you gotta have some idea of what you want."

Adora flounders. She feels a little panicked at being called out so openly if she's honest. Trust Bow to really get right at the heart of the thing. "What if I don't?" She asks, her voice small and too high.

"Don't what?" Glimmer looks confused. "Want to date Catra? I mean I'd be really surprised but well, then you wouldn't date her."

Adora rolls her eyes, somewhat emboldened by her frustration she asks more clearly, "What if I don't *know*? What I want, I mean."

"Adora." Bow's look is all softness and empathy. Adora hates it a little bit right now, she feels exposed. "I'm getting the impression that you're upset, and if we're pushing too hard just say and we'll drop it. But if you want to talk, we're here. And well it kind of sounds like you could use a sounding board and some outside perspective."

Feeling a little better at having been offered an out, Adora stops to consider the situation. "It's just hard. It feels like an impossible situation in a way. I mean, I really like and care about Catra. She's become really important to me, and it feels sort of scary because it's been *f ast.* Either way though, if I did anything to to drive her away or make her uncomfortable I would hate myself for it. And what if we have chemistry but aren't actually compatible and it's not what I'm looking for. Then I've put a perfectly good friendship on the line for no reason other than to satisfy my curiosity about what it would be like to kiss Catra!" Adora is ranting by the end of her spiel. After a moment of stunned silence, she adds, "That I have sometimes. Like, not that much. Just like, you know sometimes."

Out of nowhere Glimmer laughs. Bow and Adora both turn to scowl at her. "I'm so sorry Adora, it's not you, really. It's just this is essentially the exact same conversation you and I had at the beach, about Bow." Bow looks surprised at the mention of his name. Adora furrows her brow, trying to understand. "I mean, think about it," Glimmer insists, "The question is the same; is it worth risking this super important friendship because you're curious and maybe want more? And just because you *want* more, does that even mean you're ready for it? So, let me ask you; if you're ready to be brave is there anyone you can imagine wanting to commit to more? Is there any safer bet out there?"

Adora thinks about it, and when she does, she laughs. "Okay, yeah I see what you're saying Glimmer, I do. But you gotta admit, the histories are *very* different, even if there's parallels in the present. Bow already stuck around for twenty years, I've known Catra closer

to twenty *days*. And frankly you said yourself with Bow you knew it was endgame if and when you went there. That's kind of my whole dilemma, Idont know if Catra *is* endgame for me."

"Okay , okay you have a point there. But my advice is the same either way. f you set fear aside and have no hesitations, that' s probably a good time to go for it."

"And Adora, not *every* relationship you take a chance on has to inevitably feel like it's gonna be endgame. f it feels like it *could* be then it might be worth the risk to take a chance on finding out."Bow suggests.

"Okay , okay ll think about it. I *am* thinking about it, a lot actually. But Ithink d like to take a break now . Maybe bring this house meeting to order."Adora shifts her posture to something she feels is a little more put together. t makes her feel more put together at least. "Spare room, who has thoughts?"

"dont see why Icant continue to keep my shoes in there. Bow' s room is way bigger, but the closet is smaller. t makes no sense." Glimmer complains. "And anyway , Idont really know what we'd use the spare room for other than storage to be honest."

"was thinking a sort of studio space."Adora' s roommates look surprised. "Imean Bow you could keep your keyboard and music stuff in there. ve got a few arts supplies Ican keep in there so you two can use them if you ever want. Glim you could use it for readings or yoga, Iknow you're always bumping into the cof fee table out here. Alternatively, Iwould refer back to my suggestion of getting a horse."

Both of her friends roll their eyes by way of response. "On tonight' s episode of ow to Make Sure the Neighbors Get Y ou Evicted we feature Adora Grey and her Apartment orse. e stomps, he flies, he can even talk!"Glimmer snarks.

"Geez, Iwas kidding!"

Bow gives her a suspicious look, "But not *totally* kidding, right?"

Adora blushes. "Whatever , what do think about the *real* idea though?"

"Honestly that sounds dope!" Bow responds in earnest. "It would be nice to be able to practice in the mornings without waking Glim up."

"Can I still keep my shoes in the closet?"

Bow and Adora trade a look and shrug. "I don't see any reason why not." Adora says.

"Then let's make it a studio!" Glimmer exclaims.

"Yeah?" Adora asks, a little surprised at how easily that went over . Both friends nod earnestly. "Okay , cool! I saw a drafting table on that buy/sell/trade group online and the person said they'd give it to me for fifty bucks *or* a homemade pie after I suggested that option."

Bow's eyes light up. "You're making pie again?"

Adora shrugs, "Yeah, I still don't have the crust quite right, but I feel like last time was getting close. I just need to experiment a little more."

Glimmer rolls her eyes, "Adora the last crust tasted like layers of heaven and and I don't know , help me out here Bow."

"*Butter* ." Bow says the word dreamily , almost like he's no longer on their plane of existence.

When Glimmers rolls her eyes again Adora decides it must truly be impossible for them to get stuck that way. Glimmer's *definitely* would have by now if it were. "Right, cause I couldn't come up with *butter*." She deadpans. "I'm just saying, how good do you expect it to get?"

Adora shifts uncomfortably, "It's not about making it *better* Glimmer, it's about making it *right*. I don't want my grandma's generations old

recipe to be lost forever. Imade it so many times, it *must* be in there somewhere."

"Alright, you're right. Besides, now that Ithink about it, why am I complaining about more pie?"

"Seriously Glimmer!" Bow says solemnly. "Don't ruin it for everyone else."

"Whatever. Adora, did you get that personal day approved for Tuesday?" For the anniversary party."Adora nods, having stuf fed her moth full of chips from the bowl on the coffee table. "Awesome! Perfuma said they're doing drink deals for the morning rush, and I guess Scorpia made some *phenomenal* new cupcakes- "

"She let me try the frosting for them when Iswung by to have lunch with her. Iate like, four cups of frosting for lunch."Bow laughs.

"That's why you were so hyper that day! *Bow* You're unbelievable." Glimmer huffs fondly.

"Aw, thanks hon."

"*Anyway*, Perfuma said Ishould get there around nine-thirty to set up, Im so excited!And theyll have live music from three to seven. Bow was gonna head over with me, Adora what's your plan?"

Adora blushes, she rolls her eyes internally at herself. Literally, why? "Uh, yeah Italked to Catra."She doesnt admit to herself; *that's* why. "Im uh, helping her, Perfuma, and Scorpia decorate the night before. Sounds like Lonnie and Rogelio are opening the shop day of and Catra is hopping on at eight. So, Ifigured Id just head over with you two, Ithink that's when Perfuma and Scorpia are planning to roll in too. Oh, and Ifigured we could bring some kind of lunch over for the morning crew."

"Hmthe morning crew, you mean your girlfriend?" Glimmer cackles as Adora's face darkens to a deep crimson. "You're too easy

Adora, I'm just teasing! Did you just want to order pizza here and we can drive it over, save some hassle on that end with the delivery driver?"

"Uh, I actually found a recipe for vegan lasagna, I was gonna throw that in before we head out and figured I'd get like, a salad kit or whatever Monday after work. Probably bring over a pie too since I'm making some anyway."

"Smart." Bow supplies his serious expression melting into something more teasing as he continues. "I hear the ladies love a gay who can cook."

"Not you too Bow!"

"You two are just so cute! Can you blame us for rooting for you?"

Adora juts her chin out. "Yes." She says stubbornly. "You two suck, I'm going to make pie crust."

Adora huffs her way into the kitchen, Bow and Glimmer do their best to withhold their giggling until she's through the door. They fail spectacularly.

The weekend passes quickly and before she knows it Adora is parking in front of Plumeria Monday evening. Catra is waiting for her, leaning against one of the large windows in front of the shop.

As she steps out of her car Catra's teasing voice greets her. "Ah, the royal carriage has finally arrived! Welcome Princess."

"Shut up." Adora laughs.

A mock gasp escapes Catra. "Such vulgarity from her royal highness."

"Hm, funny ." Adora pretends to consider the situation. "I don't remember you getting me high yet."

Catra cackles. "Yeah, well Fuma isn't here yet. Just wait." Adora rolls her eyes and opens the back door of her car, passing a couple bags to Catra. "Hey, what did you even bring? You know we have decorations largely covered, right?"

Adora blushes. "Well, yeah that's what Perfuma said. *But* ," she drags out the word and grabs a final bag from her car, locking it up behind her. "I found this *great* eco-friendly party store this weekend. I got streamers as requested but well, did you know they make compostable *balloons*? Oh! I almost forgot." Adora hops back to her car and opens her trunk.

"Adorable, please for the love of every goddess above and below , do not tell me you bought a *helium tank* for this stupid party."

"It's not stupid!" Adora insists, red faced. "And I didn't buy it for the party."

Catra raises a brow and watches as Adora walks back to her, the tank cradled in the crook of one arm. "Of course you didn't." Adora isn't sure if she's being teased for having a helium tank on hand, or if Catra just doesn't believe her . Either way she decides to ignore it.

"So, are you gonna let me in, or what?"

"Nah."

"*Catra!* "

Catra snickers. "Fuma texted me like two minutes before you got here, they parked a few blocks up and should be here any second. She's gonna wanna smoke, so I figured we'd just wait here."

"Oh, well you coulda said."

"Didn't I just?" Adora shoves her shoulder in response. As she settles against the window, she sees Perfuma and Scorpia heading down the block. Perfuma has several canvas tote bags and Scorpia is laden down with catering trays. "Oh, fuck yes!" Catra mutters under her breath. Then, loud enough for Adora to hear, "Wait until you try these cupcakes Princess, you're gonna plotz."

Adora giggles and as the two newcomers draw closer, calls out. "Need a hand?"

Perfuma shakes her head but Scorpia calls back, "One of you want to just grab the door so I can set these inside?" Catra obliges and Perfuma and Adora follow behind to deposit their things inside the door.

Once everything is settled, they make their way back to the front of the shop where Perfuma lights up, takes a hit and passes to Catra. They make small talk about their respective days and when they're about halfway through the joint Adora accepts it from Catra and stares at the filter. How has it never occurred to her that her lips are touching right where Catra's lips *just* touched.

"You alright there Princess?"

Adora shakes herself and takes her hit before passing to Perfuma. "Uh-huh"

Catra gives her a weird look before turning back to answer whatever question Scorpia had just asked.

Perfuma claps her hand together. "Alright everyone, are we ready to get started? I ordered us a pizza on the walk from the car , it should be here in about half an hour."

They shuffle inside and pull out all their supplies, Perfuma gushing over the supplies Adora bought. "*Balloons?* Oh, I miss balloons! They really say 'Celebrate!' like no other décor . Traditional ones are

just so terrible for the environment though. Remind me to get the address of this place from you later!" She insists.

"Will do. Oh! Speaking of celebration." Adora turns to her pack, the other women in the room looking on with vague interest. A little digging around and she emerges with a bottle of champagne, damp with condensation. She holds it out vaguely toward Catra and Perfuma. The latter, being closer, takes the bottle and rests a hand over her heart.

"A w, Adora!" Perfuma starts but Adora silences her with a finger and turns back to a bag, she digs up a second bottle of sparkling cider which she offers to Scorpia.

Suddenly shy Adora addresses a random spot in the distance, her hand going to rub the back of her neck. "I just, uh, wanted to say; happy anniversary and congrats to you, Perfuma and Catra. And Scorpia you too, I know you put a lot into this space as well and, uh.. W ell, thanks to all of you, it's-it's such a special place and I'm um, really grateful to you for creating it." Adora coughs to cover the emotion in her voice. The silence lasts long enough that Adora's face begins to burn.

"W ow! Just-wow! That is some super good friend stuf f right there." Suddenly she's wrapped up in Scorpia's tight embrace. After tensing up in initial surprise Adora relaxes into it. "Just really thoughtful Adora, we're so glad we met you." She raises her head from the top of Adora's, presumably to look around at the other two. "Right ladies? Get in here and give this woman a darned hug. Bring it in. She deserves it!"

Perfuma obliges first and, after a moment, Catra follows suit. Adora feels her shoulder burn where Catra's arm touches it. She ignores it. Eventually they fall apart, Perfuma drifts of to dig up some glasses for their drinks and Scorpia plops down at a table, scratching her head trying to work out the helium tank. Catra and Adora drift over to the pile of streamers and confetti on a table by the door.

"So, you ready to be cleaning up confetti for the rest of your life?" Adora teases, she'd brought one bag and there were *six* here. Clearly someone here liked glitter. Maybe more than Bow.

"Adora," Catra says drolly. "That's the whole point of owning a business and having a staff."

Adora laughs, "Never having to clean up glitter again?"

"Yes." Catra maintains a straight face. "That, specifically that."

Adora nudges Catra's shoulder with her own. "Alright, where are we hanging these streamers Boss?"

"Ooh, Boss? I like that." Catra tells her smugly.

Adora rolls her eyes and wanders off with a handful of streamers and tape. Over her shoulder she tosses back, "Of course you do." She doesn't let herself look back to see Catra's reaction.

With four of them on the job, and only so much space to decorate, they're done in just over an hour. The place looks fit for a party and the stars trailing along streamers and dripping down from ceilings and counter tops dazzle Adora. They've set the opener up, Perfuma writing an inordinately sentimental note for them, and Catra's just locked with door behind them.

"Alright you wild kids, we are off! We'll see you in the morning." Scorpia offers with a cheery wave.

"Thanks so much for helping Adora. You really are a supportive..." The pause is almost imperceptible, but Adora doesn't miss the look Perfuma gives Catra before she finishes. "...pal. We couldn't have done it without you."

"Of course, I'm so happy to help." Adora and Perfuma exchange a final hug while Scorpia and Catra whisper next to them, likely saying their own goodbye Adora assumes. And then they're off without a

backward glance. t’ s just Adora and Catra now , neither seeming in a rush to be on their way.

“So, I- “

“Hey- “

They break into a fit of laughter, as she recovers Adora motions for Catra to proceed. “W ell Ijust wanted to say- Imean Iknow Perfuma said but well I- Thanks Dora, for helping out tonight.”

“Of course, Boss!”Adora responds, defaulting to a teasing tone. She feels unsure of how to respond to the sudden change in the atmosphere.

Catra doesnt take the bait. In fact, what she takes is one of Adora’ s hands in her own. The right. She watches it as she responds. “For real though, you didnt have to and I- “She looks up at Adora. “W ell, it means a lot. Iappreciate it. Im really glad we met Adora.”She squeezes Adora’ s hand once and drops it. Adora lets it fall limply to her side, at a loss.

She decides to meet Catra’s display of vulnerability with a little bit of her own. “Im really glad we’re friends Catra.”Catra seems to search Adora’s eyes for a moment, finally blinking without seeming to find what she was looking for.

“Y eah, me too. Ill see you tomorrow princess”?

“Y eah!”Adora smiles, jumping at the opportunity to wade out of whatever territory they’ve entered into. “Bow , Glim and Ishould be getting here just before ten. And remember , dont bring or buy lunch or whatever.”

“Y eah, you still not gonna tell me what that’s all about”?

“Nope.”Adora pops the P and smiles smugly .

Catra smiles back indulgently. "Alright Princess, Igotta get home and crash."

"Sounds good."Adora instinctively leans in for a hug, Catra tenses for a moment and then relaxes into it. When she does Adora sighs in relief. They hold each other up until the moment it begins to boarder on too long to be just friendly . Then, as she's leaning away, Adora the self-proclaimed disaster lesbian kisses her friend on the cheek. She doesnt make eye contact with Catra though the rest of their goodbye, barely even hears the words Catra stutters out. When she slides into her car, she rests her head on the steering wheel until she's sure Catra has gone.

f she had looked up, she would have seen Catra with one hand on her cheek and a dazed smile on her lips, watching every move Adora made. nstead she hides until she' s alone and, when she's sure that she is, she touches her fingers to her lips, remembering and savoring the feeling of Catra's soft cheek. When she pulls her fingers away, theyre coated in stars.

The anniversary celebration goes off without a hitch. The Best Friends Squad arrives closer to ten than nine-thirty . t comes as a surprise to no one. The meal they come bearing is met with sincere gratitude from the haggard looking baristas. Catra sends her openers off to eat and starts on drinks for the newcomers, including Perfuma and Scorpia who wander in ten minutes after everyone else.

"A w, Adora that was so nice of you to bring lunch for everyone!" Scorpia gushes while the group is sating by the bar. "Wildcat, isnt that just *so nice*?

Catra looks up, over the espresso machine. She responds to Scorpia but her eyes lock on Adora's, her smile is equal parts softness and mischievousness. "The *nicest*."

Adora is flushing with all of the attention. "It's really no big deal you guys. I just wanted to, uh I just wanted to."

"Yeah, no big deal." Glimmer says with a scoff. "Adora wasn't up late *at all* making sauce and two kinds of cheese out of cashews. It's all *very* chill and casu- Ow! Adora, I'm wearing sandals for goddess' sakes!"

"Oop, sorry Glim! Didn't see your foot there."

"You weren't even moving!" Glimmer pouts.

The Plumeria crew are all hiding their snickering poorly, so Bow jumps in to relieve the building tension. "So Catra, how was the morning rush?"

Catra rolls her eyes, "It was a madhouse when I got in. I think if I'd given Lonnie her break even ten minutes later, she would have started biting customer's heads off. But it died by like, nine-fifteen and has been quiet since then." She passes over a couple mugs to Bow and Glimmer, all smooth foam, intricate designs and stars. "I don't suspect we'll see too many folks until the music gets going. The two-dollar any size drip went over super well though Fuma, we should do it next year too."

Perfuma giggles, "Too bad we can't make it a permanent tradition." She accepts her and Scorpia's drinks with a nod of acknowledgment. "Three-dollar coffees next year will be great, but ten-dollar drip coffee? Hell No way. Anyway, thanks for these Catra. Glimmer feel free to set up at any of the tables by the door, whatever vibes. I'm gonna go look over that new contract really quick, want to come and keep me company babe?"

With a nod from Scorpia they wander to the back, Bow and Glimmer splitting off to get Glimmer all set up. She's babbling to Bow about all of her ideas and what she stuffed in her bag to create a space with.

"Alright Adorable, in the style of Starbucks, pioneer of cof fee;an iced caramel macchiato."Catra passes over her drink, she' s drawn stars on the top in caramel sauce. Adora wonders briefly if Catra is also able to see the stars that dance between the lines and run down the side of the glass, racing the drips of condensation. *Ah,probably not.*

"Oh my gosh, Catra!Are you ever going to let that go?Isaid I *don't thinkthey're that bad* , not that Ithink it' s the end all be all of coffee!"

"Y ou also said this used to be your go-to order. You know it's just- "

"An iced vanilla latte put together in the wrong order with a bunch of sugary shit poured on top?Y eah, Iseem to remember a certain coffee snob screaming that at me through text."

"Ididnt scream, and there' s a difference between snobbery and common sense!"

"Y ou wrote it in all caps!That' s screaming in a text."Adora huf fs. "And anyway , Istill think watching the espresso disperse is really pretty."

"Y oure so basic Princess."The words should sound like an insult, but Catra says them fondly.

Adora smiles smugly. "Ihave no shame in that."

A customer wonders in then and Adora gestures to where Bow has sat himself on one of the plush chairs across from the couch, not too far from Glimmer. Catra nods as she walks away backward, watching Adora until she has to turn around and greet the person waiting at the till.

Adora plops down next to Bow. "Glimmer 's space looks good."

"Y eah."He nods. "Ijust hope she doesnt set a sleeve on fire with all those candles going."

"I'm sure she'll be fine Bow."

"I know, I know. So how's Catra?"

"Why are you saying it like that?" Adora scowls at him.

"Like what?" Bow's voice is innocent, but his expression is very much not.

"All sing-songy, *how's Catra?*" She repeats back, imitating his teasing tone. He just responds by staring back at her, an eyebrow raised. "*What?* She's fine, I'm fine, everybody's fine! I don't know what you want to hear here Bow, I told you I still don't-"

Bow places a soothing hand on her knee, stopping the incoming rant before she can really get going. "It's okay if you don't know what you want. But"…

"But?"

Bow sighs, like she's really put him through the ringer or something. Then, he brightens. "Hey! We should invite the Plumeria buds to my birthday in a couple weeks."

Adora feels disoriented from the sudden change in topic. "Uh"…

"It'll be so fun. I'm so excited, first Best Friend Roommate Squad party! It's still a couple weeks out so hopefully that's enough time-"

"Enough time for what?" Comes Catra's voice from behind them. She saunters around their chairs and throws herself onto the open couch, taking time to set down a glass of water and two plates of food, one with lunch and one with a *massive* slice of pie, first.

"My birthday is on the ninth!" Bow beams. "We're gonna hang at the beach and then have a little party at our place. I was just saying we should invite you, Scorpia and Perfuma. Ooh! And Lonnie, Ro and Kyle too."

Catra's eyes cut to Adora briefly before she responds. "Sure, Crop Top, I think I could stand a night of celebrating your existence."

Bow melts, "I think that's the nicest thing you ever said to me!"

Catra shifts uncomfortably in her seat, leaning forward to grab her plate. With her mouth full of pasta, she responds. "Whatever Crop Top. Just have Adora send me the info."

Bow gives Adora a look she is not comfortable with Catra seeing. "Yeah, I'm sure Adora would be happy to."

"Yep, uh-huh. Thank you Bow." Adora grits out, then she turns to Catra she adopts an air she hopes will pass for chill and aloof. "So, pasta, am I right?" So...maybe neither chill nor aloof then.

Catra gives them both a look that borders on shock and then busts out. "Yeah, absolutely Princess." Then softer she adds, "Thanks for bringing food by the way, I uh, I appreciate it. And what the fuck is with this pie? It's lit." She flushes softly of fering the praise. Adora, warm from the compliment, doesn't mention it.

"Oh, I mean...sure, of course. Um, for the pie, well I've been trying to recreate a specific recipe."

"Well, it's gotta be close right? That crust is *crazy*."

Adora smiles sadly. "Something's still off, but it's getting closer, I think.

They stare at each other for a long moment until Catra clears her throat. "So, I know Glitter is planning to stick around indefinitely. What do you two have planned for the day?"

Bow and Adora look at each other and shrug. Catra laughs at them. "We didn't really plan past this to be honest."

"Well, hang out for however long. Oh, shit, hold that thought. One second." Catra hops back behind the counter. Before either Bow or

Adora can form a thought, she's dropping a plate of cupcakes in front of them. "You're welcome." She says smugly.

"Thank you!" Bow replies, wide eyes never moving from their plate. His hand darts out and within a moment he's making happy sounds, crumbs clinging to the corners of his mouth.

Adora reaches forward with much less hedonistic fervor. "Thanks Catra, these look amazing!" And they do, they're white cake with a pretty pink buttercream and a bright pink, dried flower on top. They glitter double for Adora, an even coating of edible glitter and stars sprinkled across the top. Adora takes a big bite and groans, *so good*. When she's finally able to swallow she looks at Catra who, Adora realizes, has been watching her. Suddenly self-conscious but also inexplicably warm and endeared to everyone around her, Adora asks, "What-uh- that's so good. Uhm, what's the deal?"

Bow quirks a brow at her, looking bemused. Catra on the other hand, flushes slightly deeper. Stars emerge between the constellations of freckles dusting her cheeks. "The deal?"

"Sorry, um, like, what's in them? I thought honey…"

"Yeah, Scorpia calls them-they're the uh," she looks at her feet. "Honey Love Cupcakes." Her eyes dart back up to Adora's, she takes a shaky breath and then manages to recover her aloof attitude. "It's supposed to be anniversary themed." She rolls her eyes with a fond smile. "So, for the cake she put in honey for sweetness, honey suckle for bonds of love, yellow rose for friendship, and yellow tulip is uh," Catra's cool veneer cracks slightly for a moment. "sunshine smile or whatever. And a hibiscus buttercream for beauty."

Bow and Adora blink blankly back. Bow cracks first, asking with a grin, "*Awh*, that woman's wedding cake is going to be *wild*!"

Catra chuckles, "Oh, you're telling me! She's been texting me about it *every day* already! Last night she asked me if I think fuchsias are too ostentatious."

"What did you say?" Bow asks seriously .

"I told her to live her best life. Scorpia can be really mild mannered, if not overly affectionate, but she *lives* for a dramatic flair." She buf fs her nails on her shirt and looks them over, adding, "I' s why I m her best friend." She looks up at them from the corner of her eye and after a moment of silence they all laugh loudly.

As their laughter dies down Glimmer's whine floats over from a few feet away. "*Hey* , what are you guys laughing at? I m bored, include me!"

Bow and Adora twist in their seats to face her better and Catra walks over and sets herself on the armrest of Adora's chair. Adora's arm burns. Catra leans closer to her and murmurs, "She' s a fire sign, right?"

Adora stutters, overwhelmed with the proximity and the feeling of Catra's breath on her cheek. "Oh, uh, she' s a um Sagittarius. That's fire, right?"

Catra laughs low under her breath. "I sure is Princess."

"Sorry , we didnt mean to leave you out Glim!" Bow assures her . "No one to read for?"

The café has been pretty quiet since they arrived an hour ago. So, it's not too shocking Glimmer is experiencing a lull also. "Noun.less one of you yahoos want to let me read for you?" She makes eye contact with Catra. "Say.one of you who has never sat for me before."

Catra throws her hands up. "Alright, I m game Sparkles. T ell me my future." She struts over and plops down across from Glimmer . Naturally Bow and Adora scramble to drag chairs over and watch.

"Not how this works." Glimmer huf fs before handing over her deck. "Shuf fle please."

"Why am I doing your job for you?" Catra asks, evidently unable to pass up an opportunity to needle someone.

"You're not- ugh. You're introducing yourself to the cards." Adora thinks it sounds hokey, but she doesn't say. She also doesn't mention the situation with the stars. As Catra shuffles they begin to appear, slowly at first and then multiplying like bunnies until the deck practically vibrates with them. The deck glows brightly in Catra's hands. "Now, if you have a query focus on that. If not, you can focus on, like, a general area of your life or just meditate for a moment."

"Alright, now what?" Catra asks after a little more shuffling. Glimmer nods, apparently satisfied, and takes back the cards.

"Now I'm gonna do just a basic three card spread. Usually I like past/present/future *or* mind/body/spirit."

"Dealer's choice I guess."

"Great, let's go for the latter then." Glimmer closes her eyes and feels her way through the cards, stars cling to her fingers. She scrunches her eyes, like she's focusing more than Adora usually sees when watching Glimmer read. After passing through a second time her face smooths over. She quickly plucks out a card from the very top, dead center, and the very bottom of her stack, laying them face down on the table.

As Glimmer blinks her eyes open Scorpia and Perfuma wonder over. "Oh fun! Catra, are you getting a reading?" Scorpia asks, leaning on the back of Catra's chair.

"No Scorpia, just making coffee, you know."

Scorpia laughs boisterously. "Oh Wildcat! That is, oh that is too good." She wipes at her eyes.

"Did you have a query Catra?" Perfuma asks kindly. Catra blushes a little bit and shrugs.

"*Okay*," Glimmer drag the words out. "Let's see what these cards have to say, shall we? So, left to right, from your perspective." She flips over the cards as she lists out their position. "Mind, body, spirit." Glimmer blinks down at the cards, her jaw drops and her gaze unblinking.

"What?" Catra asks as the silence stretches. Glimmer looks up to Catra, expression unchanged, and Adora cranes over to look; The Star. The Star. The Star. *That doesn't seem right…* Catra forces a nervous laugh. "What do they say, is it terminal or something?"

When Glimmer doesn't answer Adora fills the silence. "Um… Glimmer? Correct me if I'm wrong but isn't there *usually* just one of each card in your deck? Is that not"…

"*What?*" Catra demands.

Glimmer seems to shake herself, coughing lightly to clear her throat. She still looks at Catra with some level of wonder though. "Uh, yeah. Usually that's the deal."

There's another long moment of silence, only broken by Perfuma and Scorpia's escape with a flimsy excuse about going to their car. Bow wonders off saying something about the bathroom. Adora doesn't move, not one single inch. "What does that mean?"

Glimmer laughs, when she responds she speaks not to Adora but to Catra. "Apparently there's something the cards *really* think you need to hear."

Catra laughs, it's still a little tense but she doesn't let that stand in the way of a bit. "Yeah, well I always was the type who needed to learn a lesson more than once. What's it mean Sparkles?"

"Well The Star generally speaks to a sign of hope, something good coming from trusting in the universe. It can also be something that guides us home, or to a sense of home at least, like a guiding light. Having it in three positions, well that's unprecedented. My best

interpretation? Something good is waiting for you, something that will be good for every part of you; that you likely *want* with every part of yourself, whether you've admitted that or not. It seems to me the cards are legit *begging* you to have some faith in brighter days ahead and accept the goodness coming your way." She trails off and searches Catra's gaze. "Does that resonate?"

Catra considers Glimmer for a moment, almost sizing her up. She doesn't seem to sense any malintent and her posture relaxes. As it does, she turns to Adora. She's been watching Catra with her head propped on her hand and starts in her seat at being acknowledged. "Yeah. I think maybe it does."

Adora blushes and turns her gaze to the window to compose herself for a moment. Her eyes widen as she looks out. So many stars fall from the sky, it looks like a snowstorm of magic drifting down from the heavens.

Chapter End Notes

Bow's stickers made *me* emotional, tbh.
Excited to get going on the next chapter, Bow's birthday will be upon us *and* one of these disaster lesbians might just get ready to go out on a limb and make a move?
Also a big thank you to every person reading, commenting, bookmarking and leaving kudos! I appreciate y'all :)

A Star is Born

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Catra?" Adora answers her phone, she's on break at work. It's only Tuesday but she has the following day off, that fact seems to be making the day drag on at a snail's pace.

"Hey, what size is Crop Top?" Catra sounds distracted, some sort of shuffling in the background. Adora thinks she hears Scorpia talking nearby.

"Uhwhat?"

"Crop Top, your best friend? Tall, dark, handsome if you're into that sort of thing."

"Sorry, what sort of thing?"

"Dudes Adorable, try and keep up."

"Yeah, no way of that happening now. I'm so lost."

Catra groans from the other end of the line. "What size shirt does Bow wear?" She enunciates it slowly.

"Oh, a medium, I think. Why?" Adora blinks at the remains of her lunch.

"You do know it's your best friend's birthday tomorrow, right?"

"Yeah"…

"Alright Princess, I am genuinely concerned for you at this point." Then muffled comes, "No, Scorp she's fine. She's just being a dumbass I don't *know* Scorp medium, yeah. But I haven't

decided, oh for heaven's sake Scorp just gimme like, one second." Her voice comes back with clarity. "What is *up* with you today?"

Adora sighs. "Work."

"Ahh, gotcha. When are you leaving that shit show again?"

Adora rolls her eyes, aware that Catra can't see her. "Just as soon as drawing in my sketchbook gets me a 401k that matches five percent of my contribution." It was a conversation Catra had broached with her a couple times now. She insisted that Adora ought to pursue her art after Adora let her see a few more of her pieces at the café one day. Or, she had said, at least *something* she was even vaguely passionate about. When Adora pointed out that she had things like bills to consider Catra had said she was too pragmatic for her own good. Adora really didn't want to go there while sitting in the breakroom so she redirected. "What are you two *doing* right now?"

"Shopping obviously."

"Obviously."

"Oh my goddess Adorable, for gifts? You know, traditionally given to someone on their birthday." The sass in Catra's tone was next level.

"Aw, that's so sweet! Bow will be touched. What did you get?" Catra said nothing. "I mean I guess probably a shirt but." She was sort of asking for more specifics than that.

"Good guess Sherlock, listen I gotta go. Scorpia keeps trying to mime shit to me and if I don't get out of this mall soon, I'm gonna lose it."

Adora laughed. "Ugh, malls. Yeah, get out of there. I'll see you tomorrow then?"

"You bet." She sounded distracted and Adora knew she should let her friend go but…

"Y ou working in the morning?"

"Nah, of f all day. Swing by if you want though, Lonnie will know to hook it up."

"Catra that' s really not necessary."Catra hadnt let them pay in ages and slowly the rest of the staff was starting to not charge them too. Adora insisted that she wanted to support her friends and their business but Catra remained firm on the matter, always ready with some smart Alek remark.

"I am so not having this conversation right now . Ineed a fucking Orange ulius."

"Didnt they go under ages ago? thought someone else bought them out or something."

"ust let me live in my early 2000' s fantasy world, will ya Princess?"

"Right, right. Sorry , have a good rest of your mall. ll see you soon."

"Bye Dora."

The line goes dead, and Adora drops her head to the table. She rests there for a bit until her phone dings with a message. She looks and opens it immediately when she sees who it's from. Catra had sent a selfie, standing in what must have been the food court, pouting. Her phone chimes with another message. 'The closest thing they have to Orange ulius is orange chicken from Panda Express.' She punctuates this with the emoj of the sicky face.

Adora laughs and looks at her phone, smiling. Her eyes flit to the corner and she sees the time. Melting in her seat with a groan, her forehead finds its way back to the countertop. She stays there until the end of her break.

"Best birthday ever!" Bow exclaims. It wasn't for the first time that day, not by a long shot. They'd had breakfast at The Castle, brought snacks and drinks from Plumeria to the beach, and now were having a late lunch/early dinner around the coffee table. The plan was to finish decorating after dinner and presents, they had about two hours before their friends were set to start arriving. Adora and Glimmer had just deposited their gifts on the table. "Which should I open first?"

Glimmer laughs at Bow's wide-eyed look. "Follow your heart."

"Okay!" He tears open Adora's gift first. She'd gotten him a book of blank sheet music and had written a short letter on the inside cover. It was uncharacteristically mushy for Adora; she told him how much she loved him, how proud she was of him for picking up music and working hard to grow his skills in the last year, and about how excited to see what was in store for him in the coming year. Adora watches his ever-morphing expression until his eyes grow teary and stars begin to drift up and down the spine of the book. She busies herself with her place after that. "*Adora!* Okay, I'm gonna have to hug you now." He does, tightly.

"Love you Bow."

When the moment begins to walk the line of unbearably tender, Glimmer cuts in. "Okay, okay, mine now please!" Bow spends the rest of the meal oohing and ahhing over the fancy new quiver Glimmer had gotten him.

"Alright Bow, you can play with your new toy later." Glimmer teases. "Adora and I are gonna finish decorating, *you* go get ready. We'll be right behind you."

They shoo Bow to his room then get to spreading confetti and coordinating the hanging of crepe paper. "So excited for the party?"

"Yeah, I am! I'm excited to see Seahawk, I haven't seen him around since he and Merms were on again."

"Oh goddess." Glimmer groans. "You think he's gonna try and make impromptu karaoke happen again?"

Adora laughs loudly. "Depends on how much Captain Morgan he manages to drink before Mermista cuts him off I suppose. Hey, pass me a little more tape, will you?"

"Here. Alright, then we've gotta hide anything even remotely microphone shaped."

"Like that'll stop him." They share a look and break down simultaneously in giggles. "Alright, that looks good, right?"

Glimmer nods decisively. "It looks like a disco ball threw up in here. Perfect. Now I just gotta give myself the same treatment in... yikes, twenty minutes!" She scampers off without another word.

Adora tucks away the tape and extra decorations and follows after her to her own room. She refreshes her ponytail and swaps her loungewear for jeans and the sparkly tank Glimmer had loaned her for the occasion. It took her all of five minutes, so she throws some music on and sets to putting out drinks and snacks for the party.

Bow and Glimmer wander out of their room five minutes past the hour, both giggling and pink cheeked. They're decked out, even more glittery than Adora. In fact, she's pretty sure they're both even wearing silver and gold glitter eyeliner. Bow smiles warmly at her. "Thanks for setting everything out Adora!"

"You guys wanna do a shot?" Glimmer asks, tactful as ever. Before they even answer she walks over to the table and sets up four tequila shots.

"Uhh, someone here I'm missing Glim?" Adora frowns at the fourth glass.

Glimmer scoffs. "Two are for me. I think it's best we start you too off easy."

"Hey!" Adora protests instinctively. She doesn't even *want* another shot.

"*Please* Adora, don't even try to play like you're not a total lightweight."

Adora looks to Bow, checking to see if she has support in that corner. Bow's look tells her that she does not. She grumbles, "Whatever." Then raises her glass, stars dancing lightly around the rim. "To Bow, thank you *so much* for being born."

Glimmer clinks their glasses with a, "Here, here!" and they down their shots.

Adora hasn't even finished shaking off the taste of the alcohol, lime slice still between her teeth, where there's a round of knocking at the door. "Come in!" Bow hollers. The door opens to reveal Mermista, Seahawk and Entrapta.

"*Ugh*, are we seriously the first one's here. Seahawk, I *told* you; you were being too eager. Getting to a party first is like, not the move." Mermista groans out the moment they've made it past the door.

"Well Dearest-"

Bow interrupts, already having an idea of how this could carry on. "Hey, the first people to show get to party the longest. And *technically* the three of us got here first. Which means we party the hardest. Right Best Friends Squad?"

Glimmer's enthusiastic, "Totally!" is overlapped by Mermista, "Whatever."

"Happy Birthday Bow!" Entrapta shouts, pushing herself between Seahawk and Mermista to come pat Bow on the shoulder. She leans in, her expression growing more intense. "I hear several social groups will be overlapping here tonight."

Bow scratches the back of his head. "Uh, yeah, I guess. I'm excited to see all my friends tonight."

"I'm excited too!" She exclaims, seeming very genuine. "Ooh, are those tiny cupcakes?"

"Please, help yourself!" Glimmer cuts in. "Everyone please, help yourself to food, drinks, whatever."

Everyone settles in and before long their neighbors, Spinerella and Netossas have joined them. There's a fierce game of cards going at the coffee table and a few folks are scattered around the rest of the room, catching up. About an hour in another knock comes at the door. "It's open!" Adora hollers from her spot at the coffee table. She tears her eyes from her cards to look up and sees the Plumeria crew walk in the door; Scorpia, Perfuma, Lonnie and Catra.

Surprisingly it isn't one of the housemates who greets them. Mermista leans to the side, poking out from behind Glimmer with whom she's been catching up. "Holy Poseidon, *Perfuma*, is that you?"

"*Mermista!*" Perfuma calls out joyously. She dashes over and, perplexing everyone else in the room, the women hug tightly. "Oh, how *are* you?"

"I'm good, how are *you* though? I heard you and Scorpia are getting *married* soon."

"Oh, yes! You should come, it's going to be a really lovely party! Scorpia!" Perfuma calls turning around to gesture her partner over. When she draws closer Perfuma turns back to Mermista. "Hey, you remember Mermista right?"

"Ah yes, the old college flame!" Scorpia says good naturedly. Then she brightens with a thought. "Say, does that mean Seahawk is around?"

"Indeed, I am fair lady!" Seahawk stands dramatically , folding into a bow. The move flips over several cards, Adora groans but when she looks around it seems she's the only one still invested in the game.

"Wow! How ya been buddy? Any grand adventures since I last saw you?"

"Funny you should ask." Seahawk makes his way over to Scorpia and the foursome continue catching up. The rest of the party exchange glance all around, then the din resumes as if they had all mutually agreed to not question the reunion.

With Seahawk out of the game Spinerella and Netossa decide to fold, and when they do Entrapta sidles over to eavesdrop on the reunion. Adora can practically hear her inner monologue rejoicing over the intricacies of the dynamics within the group.

"Well, I guess that ends that." Adora pouts, she had a really good hand and was hungry for redemption after losing the last couple.

"Aw, cheer up Adora! I'd say you were probably gonna win, but it's my birthday so I get default win. But I'm *sure* you would have taken second place handily!" Adora shoves Bow's shoulder's lightly.

"Whatever I'm gonna go say hi to um." Adora stands and suddenly realizes how tipsy she's gotten. She's definitely not drunk but it takes an extra moment or two for the world to right itself when she stands. She only nursed one drink after the first shot but, well it was like Glimmer said.

"Ooo! Gonna go get your- " Bow is still waggling his eyebrows when Adora cuts him off.

"I'm gonna check on Catra *and Bonnie* ." She insists, leaving a giggling Bow behind. She notices Glimmer drifting over his way and is glad to not be leaving the birthday boy alone. Not that Bow's ever had trouble finding friends at a party.

Catra and Lonnie have only made it a little further inside. Entrapta has drifter over and ensnared them in conversation. As Adora approaches she hears her questioning the pair about how they're acquainted with everyone. Catra begins to answer when she sees Adora approach. "Well I work with Perfuma and- *Hey Adora*, nice party."

Adora's attempt to respond is cut off by Entrapta. "Ah, so you work with Perfuma, but you *know* Adora. In what sense?"

Lonnie snorts, "Oh I *like* you. You know, that's a really good question. Catra, what sense *do* you know Adora in?" She raises her eyebrows in challenge, Catra blushes a bit but Adora blushes *much* harder.

Catra preserves her sense of cool casualness when she responds. "Hmm like how do I know Adora? She's obsessed with me."

"*What?*" Adora practically shrieks.

"Fascinating, well you don't seem put off by that, care to elaborate?" Entrapta leans slightly closer to Catra.

"Adorable, you come in for coffee *once* and now, suddenly you're in practically *every day*." Catra's smirk infuriates Adora but like, in a way she's into. She shakes herself to prevent getting distracted by the expression.

"Sounds like you're saying I'm obsessed with your coffee then, huh?" Adora snarks back.

Catra is unfazed. "Same difference. Now, I think I've gotten you enough drinks. Wouldn't you say it's your chance to return the favor?"

"Oh, *very smooth* Catra." Lonnie praises sarcastically.

Catra elbows her in the gut but the words snap Adora back to hostess mode. "Right! I did come over to see if I could get y'all

anything."

"I'm good." Lonnie turns to Entrapta. "I'm actually hoping you'll share some insights on the, uh what did you call it? Dynamic interactions stemming from the overlapping of social groups which don't normally coexist and thus may not share social mores?" The other woman's eyes light up.

"Oh, I have so much information! Come with me there's a *much* better vantage point this way." Entrapta drags Lonnie toward away by the hand, before they're out of sight she turns around and winks at Catra.

After a moment of stunned silence Adora pipes up. "Speaking of people who don't normally coexist"…

"Oh, Lonnie is probably thrilled, she's always game for gossip." Catra laughs. "Now how about that drink?"

"Of course!" Adora leads her to the dining nook where all the snacks and drinks are sitting. "So, we have mixers and like all the alcohols- "

"All of them?" Catra asks teasingly .

"Well I mean, how many can there be? There's tequila, vodka, the dark one- "

"You mean rum?"

"Like I said, the dark one. No gin because Glimmer banned it from the place. And champagne and I think there was beer . I don't see beer though; I could check the fridge!" Adora smiles triumphantly and looks to Catra. "So?"

"Sorry , *how* exactly did gin of all things get banned?"

"Oh, for Glimmer's birthday party last year she did like, a bougie tea party thing. She got totally toasted on gin and tonics. As Glimmer

tells it;the botanical flavor was delightful going down but tragic coming back."

"*Gross*, why would you tell me that?"

"You literally asked!"

"Hm, that's not how Iremember it."

Adora groans and throws her hands up. "Alright, well did you want a drink, or did you just lure me over here to hassle me?"

"Aw, cant do both?"Catra fake pouts, Adora just rolls her eyes and dramatically taps her toes on the hardwood. After a minute or two Catra breaks. "Whatever, wanna do a shot?"

Adora hesitates, is doing another shot the best idea?Maybe not. Is it the worst idea?Probably not the *worst*. Does she really, *really* want to go along with Catra?Yeah, let's do it!Igotta stick to tequila though, Ill be a mess if Istart mixing."

"Sounds good Princess, wanna line 'em up?"Adora nods and pulls everything toward her. "You can pour me two if that's cool, looks like Ineed to catch up a little."

Adora schools her expression into one of mock outrage. "I am *not* drunk."

"Maybe not, but you've been swaying slightly every time you stand still for more than a second."Adora tries to focus on standing still for a moment. "You look like you're thinking too hard. You gonna do this with me or am Itaking all three?"

"Shut up."Adora sticks out her tongue and quickly downs her shot, Catra right behind her with one and then the other. "Ugh, Iforgot lime, sorry."

Catra makes a noncommittal motion. "All good."Then she wipes her mouth with the back of her hand. Adora watches the motion of her

hand intently.

"Hey party people!" Adora jumps when suddenly Bow is next to her, throwing an arm over her shoulder. "Did I see shots?" The pair nods. "I want in, pour another round! Glimmy!" He calls across the room and gestures his partner over when she looks up.

Catra pours the next round, she doesn't forget the lime. Once Glimmer has joined them, they toast and throw back the liquor. "Bleh, I need to switch to *water* for a bit, you too Bow." Adora points a stern finger at her friend and turns to pour them each a glass.

"Welcome Catra, thanks for coming!" Glimmer says from behind Adora.

"Thanks, the place looks good. Say, Adora?" Adora turns, passes a glass to Bow and urges Catra on with a gesture. "You ready to be cleaning up confetti for the rest of your life?"

Adora grins, "Aw, guess we shoulda waited to make this mess till we had employees to deal with that for us."

"Hm, sucks to suck I guess." Bow and Glimmer's eyes dart between them like they're watching a tennis match.

"*Wild!*" Bow says breathlessly. Glimmer nudges him with approximately zero subtilty.

"Oh, birthday boy." Catra says, as if suddenly remembering he's there. She rummages around in the tote bag she has slung over her arm and emerges with a neatly wrapped gift. "Happy birthday, glad you were born or whatever." She hands the package over and bow takes it, his eyes alight with wonder.

"It's *so beautiful* thank you!" He turns it over and over in his hands; inspecting the sparkly, swirling rainbow pattern of the paper and fussing with the curling ribbon on top.

"Yeah, you do get that there's a gift inside, right?" Bow huffs and begins delicately unwrapping the gift, making no tears in the paper.

"Ugh." Glimmer groans. "Bow is *always* so precious with pretty gifts. Especially after drinks. I swear I started wrapping his presents worse just so he'd open them faster."

Bow pulls out the gift and gasps, he looks up to Catra with heart eyes. "*I love it*."

"It's whatever." Catra waves him away. What it actually is, is a cropped sweater with rainbow stripes that run around the chest and shoulders, covering the top quarter of the shirt.

"*I love it*." Bow repeats pulling Catra in for a hug. "Thanks, Catra." She returns the hug, though her poster is a little rigid.

After a moment Adora giggles and when she speaks, she can hear that her words are slightly slurred. "Glimmer, hasn't your wrapping *always* looked like a car ran over it after you've finished?" Bow pulls away from Catra to laugh.

"Hey! I resent that."

"Member when you gave me that, that one gift?"

"Oh, here we go again!"

"And it was like, twenty percent wrapping paper?"

Bow laughs heartily. "More like five percent."

"Bow! Are you two seriously never gonna let me live this down?"

Adora leans in close to Catra, who has been watching the interaction bemusedly, and stage whispers. "The other nine- uh- ninety." She looks up at her friends and, in a normal voice, asks, "What's the rest of a hundred percent?"

"You mean ninety-five percent Princess?"

Adora swivels back to Catra, even closer now. "You! Are so smart. Yes, that much. It was that many percent duct tape."

Catra cackles. "Seriously Sparkles? You used *duct tape*? And a *lot* of duct tape from the sounds of it?"

Glimmer huffs indignantly. "I couldn't find any of the regular kind! And tape is tape is tape." Unconvinced everyone just laughs harder than they already were. "Whatever, I'm going to find the cool people."

She stalks off and Bow doesn't let her get far before he's following behind, protesting. "Glimmy, wait up. It's my *birthday*, that makes me automatically cool. It's the law!"

After they couple disappears Catra and Adora turn back to each other. Their faces are still close. Before Adora can filter the thought, she says, "You know, you smell like…*really good*."

She swears she can almost feel the warmth of Catra's blushing. "Uh… thanks Princess. How are those drinks settling?"

Adora draws back to flop into the closest chair. "Like, *so good*. How are you, I mean your drinks? I mean; how are you settling into your drinks?" She nods once, satisfied that her question finally makes sense.

"Great, you mind if I grab some of that champagne though?" Catra nods toward the bottle.

"Oh my gosh, *please*." Adora encourages.

Drink poured Catra cocks her hip and rests one hand on it. "So- "

"I want stars." Adora looks around the party, there are stars *everywhere*. They buzz between friends to the hum of conversation, dance lightly on the speakers, and slip along the streamers hung

from the ceiling. "Like outside stars." She clarifies, forgetting that Catra doesn't know what other stars she could be referring to.

Catra considers her for a moment. "Need a little fresh air there Princess?"

"I want it."

Catra laughs at the pouty demand. "Alright, grab your water and I'll go sit with you for a minute. You probably want a jacket too, it got chilly."

"I will meet you in the door then." Adora announces. She stomps off to get her jacket and grabs a throw from behind Mermista on the couch for good measure. When she meets Catra by the door a few minutes later she has both of their drinks in hand and a soft look on her face.

Wordlessly they slip through the door, noticed only by Entrapta and Lonnie who stay quiet, focused on observing. Well, Entrapta is. Lonnie just know better than to interrupt whatever that moment is about to turn into.

Adora and Catra settle themselves on the top step outside the apartment, and Adora drapes the blanket over their legs. She leans back on her arms to look at the sky. After a minute she closes her eyes, soothed by the break from the party nose and the fresh air. "This is nice." She whispers softly.

"Yeah, it is." The silence stretches out again, comfortable and sweet. Adora thinks of the taffy shop she saw at the seaside; machines pulling the candy, sugary sweetness stretching on for what seems like miles. Catra speaks after a little while, clearing her throat before she begins. "So, did Bow have a good day?"

Adora blinks open her eyes and turns languidly to look at Catra. "Hmm, very, I think."

"Good, that's good...and you?" Adora is too drunk to be sure at this point, but she almost feels as if she can sense nerves growing in Catra's voice.

"It's been nice, yeah. It's nice to celebrate Bow. He's so *good*, ya know? He's a *good* friend." Catra nods, Adora hesitates before she goes on. The alcohol in her system egging her on. "You're a good friend and...and I like...being here. With you."

Catra's gaze becomes impossibly sweet. "I like being here with you too, Adora." She takes one of Adora's hands in her own and looks her in the eye. "Listen, Adora- "

The front door bursts open with a wave of sound. Catra drops Adora's hand like it burned her. "What are you two dorks doing out here? It's time for cake! Oh!" Glimmer spots them and her demeanor shifts instantly from brazen to abashed. Adora curses her silently for cutting Catra off. "Uh, sorry I didn't realize you guys were...uh, carry on. No rush. We're gonna do cake soon but I still have to find, uma... lighter! Yeah, uh-huh. Could be a while, take your time." She slams the door shut before Adora can tell her there's a bowl with several lighters in the studio. She shrugs, she's pretty sure Glimmer knows that. *Must be drunk*, she thinks.

Adora turns back to Catra, she thinks about grabbing her hand again, missing the warmth of stars that had burrowed into the space between their palms. She decides the tequila didn't make her *that* brave but tries to get their conversation back on whatever track it had been on before the interruption. "Uh, you said...you were um. Words. Sorry, you were saying them, the words." She tilts her head toward the sky with a whine and then looks back at Catra to try again. "What did you say?" Close enough.

Catra seems nervous again, picking at the threads of the blanket. "Oh, uh no big deal. I was just thinking, well I wondered...maybe we should go see a movie sometime. Like, together. If you're into it."

Relief and despair war in Adora's chest. She thought maybe. but no. f she' s disappointed does that mean she wanted Catra to ask her on a date? Does it matter? Catra did seem nervous, which is odd and seems vaguely date-request like. But she probably would have said the work 'date' if it was a date, *right*? Adora' s still not sure if she wants that, anyways. he thinks. ow long has it been since Catra asked her question? Probably too long.

"like movies." She states dumbly .

Catra looks up, hopeful. "Y eah?" Adora nods eagerly . "Great! Cool, ll umtext you about it tomorrow?"

"Okay , yeah."

"Cool, awesome. Um, well maybe we should head in? Dont want to keep a bunch of drunk folks from cake, right?" She smiles gently at Adora, it does something strange to her insides.

"Y eahyeah, that' s probably best." Catra peels of f the blanket, stands and offers Adora her hand. Adora makes no immediate moves to take it, her gaze lingering on the stars. She silently begs the sky for a shooting star, just one wish. t occurs to her ironically that if she had a wishing star, she could wish for one. Then again, that's not really what she wants to waste a wish on right now.

She looks up at Catra and accepts the hand, bundling the blanket in one arm and grabbing her water glass in the other hand. Catra follows shortly behind her, resting her hand on the small of Adora's back. The spot where it rests radiates warmth.

When they get to the door Adora takes one last look at the night sky before slipping inside. They all remain calm and still. Adora makes her wish anyway.

Chapter End Notes

Is it gonna be a date? A platonic hang? Will Adora know either way? Could I project any harder onto these characters?
This was initially supposed to be half of a chapter but I realized that would likely make the next like 10,000 words. So...*voila!*

The Stars that Fade

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"It's not a date!" Adora protests, banging her head on the dining table. She's far too hungover for this conversation.

She can't see the looks Bow and Glimmer are giving her, but she's fairly certain they're condescending at best. "Adora! *You're impossible!*" Glimmer grits out.

"Alright, alright maybe it isn't- "

"Bow, you traitor!"

"Glimmer, chill. I said *maybe*. So maybe it is, maybe it isn't. But do you want it to be?" Bow asks, his voice even and calm. He and Glimmer really react like earth and fire, respectively.

"It doesn't matter." Adora tells the table, her eyes closed to block out the light that seems to be splitting her head open. "She just said she wants to see a movie or something together. She literally said it was no big deal!"

"You're hopeless!" Glimmer cries, Adora lifts her head to glare at her. "Fine," her expression grows smug. "If you're so sure it isn't a date, why not just ask her?"

"That's the worst idea you've ever had Glim." Adora deadpans, dropping her head back to the table. "Besides, it's really unfair of you two to bully me before I've had any coffee."

"Don't be so dramatic Adora, but yeah I want coffee too. We can head to Plumeria if you two want to get ready."

Adora's head snaps up, eyes wide. "Pl-Plumeria?"

Glimmer rolls her eyes. "Duh, where else would we go?"

"The kitchen?" Adora of fers weakly.

"Y eah, well the kitchen doesnt have Scorpia' s scones soclothes, now." Glimmer and Bow move to head to their room to get changed. Glimmer pauses and looks back, "For what it' s worth Lonnie mentioned Ro and Me are working this morning. t' s why they didnt make it to the party."

Adora deflates, she thinks she should feel relieved but really, she just feelsall twisted up still. "Oh, chill. t' s whatever."

"Pf ft, dont try and act all nonchalant. Y ou dont pull it of f." Adora sticks out her tongue and Glimmer laughs, following Bow to their room. Adora stews for another minute or two and goes to do the same.

Half an hour later Adora is pulling her car into the spot in front of the shop. "Seriously , *every* time? t' s not natural!" Bow calls from the back seat.

"t' s eleven on a Thursday Bow, it's not like there's much competition." Adora argues as they all climb out of the car .

The walk to the door in comfortable silence but apparently Bow still hasnt let it go. As they walk in the door , he speaks up again. "But *still.* " he gasps. "Maybe Catra' s right!"

"What am Iright about this time?" Catra' s voice calls from the counter. Adora's face jerks toward her and she' s sure she must look like a deer in the headlights. So much for it being Rogelio and *Me* on shift. While they make their way to the counter Catra turns to Rogelio, who is lingering by the espresso machine. She catches his

eye in the angled mirror above the bar and signs something. He turns to face her, smirking and signs back. She laughs loudly at whatever he says and responds back, making a poor attempt at a stern expression. He rolls his eyes, waves her off, gives a quick wave to the friends across the counter and disappears into the back.

Luckily Bow doesn't seem to notice Adora's panic and responds to Catra's question enthusiastically after waving back to Ro. Laughing, he says, "Oh, Adora got her same spot again and I'm just saying, maybe she *is* a princess! Like, some mythical, bad ass princess with magic powers."

Catra laughs and Adora feels her stomach flutters and then roll uncomfortable. She really needs a coffee. Catra's response is dripping in sarcasm. "Wow Adora, glad to see you're using your powers for good. Be a shame to let them go to waste." Her smirk shifts to something a little more self-satisfied looking. "Speaking of letting things go to waste, you remember I told you the showcase is ending soon?" She indicates the art decorating the walls around them, a showcase of a local artist's work for sale. There are also prints tucked on a shelf under the register.

Adora rolls her eyes and puts her hands on her hips. "Oh, I remember." She sasses. Glimmer and Bow's eyes cut back and forth between them, at a loss. Adora hadn't exactly shared Catra's offer with them. It was silly anyway. Catra's look tells her she suspects as much and knows *exactly* what she's doing bringing it up now.

"Yeah, so we talked to Lonnie's cousin. They're coming by to break down on the thirtieth. Just shy of three weeks. So, I'm just saying"… She gives Adora a challenging look. Adora knows exactly what she's saying.

"I wish you wouldn't."

"Ha, like that's gonna stop me. I'm *saying* if someone, ahem, was going to get ready for a showcase *of her own*, now might be a good

time to look into framing or ordering prints, you know all that good stuff."

Adora snorts. "Yeah, well I'll pass on the advice if I find anyone *it applies to*."

"Come the fuck on Adora!" Catra drops most of the playfulness from her demeanor.

"*What* Catra?"

"What are you so scared of?"

Adora scoffs, "I'm not scared."

"Sure, you're not. Okay then, so what's your deal? Why are you being such a pain in the ass about this?"

"*I'm* the pain? Catra, you hypocrite! You're the one who keeps bringing it up."

"Because I'm right, and I know you know that."

The two women are scowling at each other by this point. "Uh"… Glimmer cuts in hesitantly. "What the hell is going on here? What are we missing?"

It's Catra's turn to scoff. "Of course, you didn't even tell them."

"Yeah, because I'm not doing it!"

"You sure? Sure it isn't because you *know* they'll just tell you the same thing I've been saying this whole time?" Adora glares at her, unwilling to admit she may have a point. Like...a *teeny* one, but a point all the same

"Hello!" Glimmer raises her voice slightly, not letting them completely forget her and Bow's presence.

Catra turns to her. "You know we do this local artist's showcase thing, right?" Glimmer nods. "Well this one's about to come down. I've been telling Adora for *weeks* now that I want to display her stuff so she should get it together and she can be next. She's just being *so fucking stubborn*." She turns to Adora long enough to deliver the jab. "I mean you've seen her shit! It's fucking incredible and she should share it, right? Like, fucking back me up here guys." She looks at them imploringly until she registers their suddenly blank faces. Her expression turns to one of confusion and Adora feels her stomach drop to her knees. *Fuck.*

Bow's voice is a touch squeaky when he speaks up. "Uh, you've, you've seen Adora's art?"

Three pairs of eyes swivel to Adora and she prays for the floor to just swallow her whole. All that seems to swallow her is guilt which does nothing to save her. She's not exactly super forthcoming with her art. Super-duper shy is honestly a better description. Catra is just so… direct and also really compelling. Showing it to her had felt right. Maybe not easy, but as easy as it had felt to share something like that since her grandma's fridge had been covered in layers of drawings. Besides, Glimmer and Bow were always so respectful; they hadn't really ever asked. "Uh, so, coffee?" Adora suggests weekly.

"Dora." Catra's voice is hardly a whisper. Bow and Glimmer's eyes are still boring holes into her.

"Can we not right now, please?" Adora asks tightly.

She and Catra hold a stare for a long moment, finally Catra nods once. "Later then." Her tone leaves no room for argument. "Alright, I'm gonna get your order going, go sit." She looks away from Adora to Glimmer and Bow. "Food?"

"Please." Bow nods awkwardly. The friends hover for a moment more and Catra rolls her eyes.

"Oh, for the love of carbs, *go*! *Sit!* "She shoos them away and they find a four top in the middle of the lobby.

Adora is avoiding eye contact as they settle in, the silence is deafening. t lasts so long Adora' s head starts to spin, but finally Glimmer breaks it. "Why". There' s emotion in her voice and she huffs, attempting to clear it. t works a little, but not that well. "W e've never really seen your art. Icertainly didn't know you had enough to fill a whole *showcase* !Ijust want to know why you never"…

Adora finally looks at her friends. Glimmer looks a little wounded and Bow is surprisingly stoic. "Why Ishowed Catra but never showed you guys?" Glimmer nods shortly and Adora thinks she sees a little sparkle of tears gathering in her eyes. She sighs and shrugs. "She asked, Iguess."She doesn't say is bluntly or unkindly , decidedly abashed is more like it.

Glimmer and Bow blink in surprise. "Oh."Glimmer says simply , she turns to exchange a look with Bow;mostly it' s just more blinking. Then she turns back to Adora. "Have we really *never*". Adora shakes her head and Bows face falls instantly, Adora winces at being the cause. She waits for them to tell her that she should have taken initiative and been open with her friends, that *of course* they'd want to see her art. They love art! Hasn't Bow held those apartment recitals practically every time he learns a new song? Doesn't Glimmer offer them readings every time she feels it could benefit them? Why was Adora so hesitant to share?

t never comes. nstead Bow wails, " *We are such terrible f riends!*" He grabs Adora' s hands across the table. "Adora, Im so sorry if we made you feel like we were uninterested, or thought your art isn't important. Ithink we just thought well you seemed so shy about it". He looks to Glimmer for support, she nods and jumps in. Equally emotional but much less teary .

"*Totally!* We just didn't want to pry ."She pauses, looking over Adora's shoulder at the counter, and then back with a smirk. "But if

the new girlfriend gets to see, I say best friends should get viewing rights also." She pauses for a moment, considering. "I.. you want."

"I mean yeah, totally!" Adora of fers immediately, relieved at their response. She watches the few stars that tumble around the plants in the center of the table for a moment. "But Catra isn't- "

"Catra isn't what?" A voice challenges from behind Adora. She jumps about a foot off her chair.

"*Eek!* You scared me!"

Catra just laughs, transferring starry food and drinks from a tray onto their table. "Hm, get your heart rate going there Princess?" At Adora's gaping look she laughs again. "Now , what are you nerds saying about me?"

"Uh I was just saying you're not um.. you-you're not uh.. "…

"Not going to *believe* what Adora was just telling us!" Glimmer cuts in, much to Adora's relief and eternal gratitude.

"Oh, is that right?" She directs the question to Adora, who nods emphatically. "So what' s the deal?"

"Uh." Shoot, Adora' s mind was still totally blank.

"Adora decided to take you up on your of fer! Y ou know, the showcase thingy." Adora whips around to glare daggers at Glimmer . Eternal gratitude rescinded.

"*What?* "Catra exclaims. "How' d you manage that turnaround?"

"Y eah Glimmer, *what?* "Adora glares at her , gritting her teeth.

Glimmer pays Adora no mind and speaks only to Catra. "Oh, you know how it is with Adora."

Catra levels her with a long look. "Found a way to twist her arm?"

Glimmer laughs, "Something like that."

They share a conspiratorial smirk and Catra turns to Adora. "T ight, well you're roped in now; I have witnesses. W e can talk about it more when we hit that movie."

"Oh right, yeah. Uh, su-sure, that sounds good."

Catra smiles brightly, it attracts several stars from around the room to her, almost forming a halo. "Great! I'm looking forward to it. Alright nerds, I gotta hop to; Ro' s on lunch still. Gimme a shout on your way out."

All three of them watch her walk away, when she slips through the swinging doors to get behind the counter Glimmer pounces.

"t is *so* a date!" Naturally Adora argues but Glimmer , and Bow for that matter, will not be swayed. Adora's still too spent to put up a good fight anyway.

Adora is lying in her bed later, playing on her phone when it chimes with a text from Catra. She drops the stupid thing on her face with a curse before she's able to open it.

u free Saturday?

let me just check my v busy schedule' Adora chuckles at her own bit.
After a minute she sends, 'yah, I'm free. What' s up?

"That new animated thing is showing at Eternia Cinemark if that looks good'
'12/2:30/3:15/6/7:15'
What works for u?

Free all day , anything esp good for you?

"Thought maybe the 6?
Prob fewer little kids than a matinee'
W e could get dinner after if ur hungry?
Nvm, Ikno youll be hungry'

Shut up!
but Imean yeah, Ill b hungry .'

Sounds like a plan then!
C u soon.'

Adora sends a thumbs up emoj, with a unicorn for good measure. t' s a plan then. . .And a *plan* is not a *date*. And she *certainly* isnt pouting about that, she's just glad to know where she and Catra stand. She's not sure if she'd define her feelings as a *crush*, but even if that's what it is there's no need to analyze it. Not if Catra' s feelings are platonic, because Adora can do platonic- easy peasy.

She's lying with her phone across her forehead, continuing this impromptu pep talk when her door bursts open. Glimmer tumbles through the door and flops into Adora's desk chair. "Bow' s practicing that song again and Im *bored*. What are you doing in here? Can you pay me attention *please* "?

Adora laughs out loud and sits up on the bed, her phone tumbling into her lap. "Sure thing Glim, Im just being lazy anyway . What do you want to do"?

Glimmer hems and haws for a minute. "Scrabble"?

Adora nods, so they shuffle to the dining table and get set up. They get the game started, chit chatting (mostly about the resumes Glimmer has sent out over the last week) and listening to Bow's piano practice from the adjacent room. A few rounds in Glimmer smirks suddenly. "So Catra' s *really looking forward* to your date, huh"?

Adora scowls, putting down her letters with slightly more force than necessary. "It's not a date Glimmer!"

"Adora, come on!" She throws up her hands. "No one says *I'm looking forward to it*' like that if it's not a date."

"Well apparently Catra does, she said it's not a date." Adora crosses her arms and leans back further into her chair.

Glimmer looks shell shocked. "Wait, what do you mean she said? Did you actually *ask* her?"

Adora snorts derisively, recording Glimmer's points for the word 'star'. "I didn't have to."

"What does that mean?"

"She said, 'It's a plan'." Adora continues to frown, shuffling her tiles around without managing to make anything close to a word.

"She said 'I'm sorry', walk me back a few steps here." Glimmer demands, baffled at this point.

Adora sighs. "She texted me about seeing a movie on Saturday. So, we decided on time and like, getting food after or whatever. When we confirmed she said, 'It's a plan.' *Not* 'It's a *date*'."

Glimmer rolls her eyes. "Is that really all you've got to go one Adora? Because there's far more evidence that she's one hundred percent feeling it. That's flimsy, at best."

"Come on! 'It's a date' would be such a casual, easy way to at least imply intention. It wouldn't even necessarily mean anything; I'd say that when we make plans, it's a common expression!"

Glimmer purses her lips and narrows her eyes slightly. "Alright you have little bit of a point. *But* I still say you're overthinking this! She flirts with you *all the time*."

"Ever think she could just be a flirty person?" Adora plays the word latte' and puts down her score.

Glimmer shoots her a condescending look. "Not ever . She *only* flirts with you."

"Nuh-uh!"

"Adora! When has she flirted with anyone else that you've seen?"

Adora flounders for a minute. "Well uhuhm." When Glimmer's look turns triumphant Adora protests. "It' s not like I could give you specific examples of her flirting with me. We mostly just you know , poke around or whatever."

"More like you tease each other constantly because you like getting a reaction. Adora, she literally uses *three* nicknames for you! And they're all gross."

"They're not gross!"

Glimmer's eyes roll, again. "Alright, maybe not gross but sickly sweet for sure." Her gaze softens. "Adora, I really don't know why you're struggling like this. But if you're really that unsure, maybe it' s time to talk to Catra. You might not know exactly what you want but it seems pretty clear that you don't want to rule out romance at this point." Glimmer holds her in an intense stare for a long while, until stars are gathering densely around her pupils.

Her words are still ringing in Adora' s ears Saturday evening while she gets ready. Maybe Glimmer's right, because Adora still feels totally confused. So, she tries to think of how to broach the topic tonight with one half of her brain, while the other wishes fiercely that the answer will present itself over the course of the evening.

The question, then, is what do you wear to a maybe date? Adora tears through her closet, making a total mess of it. She doesn't even have that many clothes, but somehow they form a mountain on her bedroom floor. She ends up in jeans and white tank, throwing a red, lightweight jacket in her bag for the theatre.

She hops in her car at half five and starts toward the theatre. *Separate cars*, she thinks, *not date like*.

She pulls into the lot twenty minutes later, parks and steels herself with a few deep breaths. She then hops out, bag in hand. Walking to the front of the theatre she sees Catra already waiting for her. Adora's breath catches, and she feels silly. Catra looks *so good* though, in dark jeans and a structured red tank, a black jacket thrown over her arm.

"Hey Adora!" Catra calls when she gets closer. It sends a shiver up her spine.

Shaking it off she calls back, "Hey, hope I didn't keep you waiting long."

"Nah." Catra waves her off. She hesitates, pursing her lips for a second. "Uh, thanks for meeting me, I'm um, glad we're doing this."

Adora bites her lip, *'doing this' like dating? Like hanging out? Inconclusive.* "Yeah, me too!" She offers, her brightness only slightly forced. Awkward uncertainty aside, she *is* excited to spend more time with Catra.

Catra shoves her hands in her pockets and gestures to the ticket booth with her shoulder. "Shall we?" Adora nods and Catra silently offers her the crook of her arm. Tentatively Adora slips her own arm through, her heartbeat running wild. *This seems new*. She admits silently to herself.

They walk to the counter, where they find no line. The walk to the counter and Catra disentangles their arms to grab her wallet, Adora

starts to dig in her bag for her own. While she's digging Catra greets the cashier and asks for their tickets. As Adora's fingers brush the fabric of her wallet she hears Catra tell the cashier, "Together is good."

Adora looks up from her bag to Catra. "What? Catra, no- "

Catra waves her off with a smug smile. "I want to Adorable, chill about it."

Adora pouts back, "Fine. Thank you Catra." An idea strikes and she brightens. "I can get snacks then." *Buying my ticket, maybe date like?* Adora notes internally.

Taking her card and their tickets back from the person helping them, Catra turns to give Adora a calculating look. "Alright Princess, whatever you want." Adora notices that the stars bouncing on the counter where they had been leaning don't follow them inside.

Ignoring any implications there may be to that, Adora hops on the escalator inside the door and turns back to ask, "So what's your go to movie food?"

Catra raises an eyebrow. "The souls of the dammed."

Adora blinks once and then breaks down, snorting and laughing so hard she almost trips hopping off the escalator. "You're too fucking much Catra Estrella!"

Catra scoffs, "Whatever *Adora Geyson*." Adora sticks out her tongue and Catra just laughs at her.

"Seriously though, what do you want?"

Catra gives her that same calculating look from the ticket booth. "You sure you don't want me to get it? I mean I'm happy- "

"*Estrella!* Goddess' sakes, I'm *sure*."

Catra nods slowly then shrugs. "I usually get popcorn and either sour patch or peanut M&Ms."

Adora nods, "You want a pop?"

"Eh, I'd share some of a coke or a root beer if you want, but I'm good with water too."

Adora nods again. "Cool!" They walk up to the counter and Adora gets all of the above plus rasinettes and nachos. As they walk toward the employee taking tickets Catra looks at her with wide eyes. "Damn Princess, you sure you'll be hungry for dinner?" Adora blushes lightly and nods as Catra hands over the tickets.

"Theatre three, down and to the left."

"Thanks!" Catra nods at the person helping them and they make their way. "You're amazing. But we gotta talk about the raisins. The hell Greyson?"

"I like them!" Catra holds the door for her and she slips through.

"They're not even candy ." Catra pokes at her side, making her jump and spill a few popcorns.

"Hey! And they are too, raisins are nature' s candy! Also, they're literally coated in chocolate. Well, they're usually more chocolate than raisin." Adora looks to Catra for approval on the seats she' s landed in front of and Catra nods.

"Then why not skip the wrinkly fruit and just get some chocolate?"

Adora sets the other snacks she's holding aside, grabs he rasinettes box and opens it up. She makes eye contact with Catra as she fills her palm with candy, and then shovels them into her mouth. With her cheeks stuffed like a chipmunk she gets out a muffled, "Because they're fucking delicious."

Catra is *holding* , "Goddess Dora! That's disgusting, did you get the whole box in your mouth? Ugh." Her twinkling and wide smile eyes undermine her sentiment.

Adora shakes the box and peers in, swallowing hard to gets it all down. "Like half." She answers simply . She sets the box aside to slip into her jacket. The lights begin to dim, making the stars bouncing playfully around them more apparent until they also dim to just a soft glow. Catra and Adora settle into their seats as the ads start and distribute their snacks.

By the time the ads are done they've inhaled the nachos. When they make it half an hour into the movie, they've set what remains of their snacks aside, except the M&Ms Catra keeps close, still occasionally grabbing a few out. Suddenly Adora is hyper aware of her posture, it makes her sit all awkward and stiff. She notices Carta's eyes cut to her and she forces herself to relax a little, slouching in her seat. She's uncomfortable, but she doesn't want to be that annoying person, shifting around for the whole movie.

When the pinch in her back becomes unbearable she shifts. Now the arm rest separating her and Catra is digging into her side, she suppresses a sigh. Catra's eyes cut to her again and from her periphery Adora sees her roll them. She grabs the soda in the shared cup holder and reaches across Adora, making her heart stutter, and deposits it in the one on Adora's right. With that out of the way she lifts the arm rest between them, Adora's heart stops entirely. It remains stopped as Catra shifts so they're leaning against each other, her head on Adora's shoulder. It takes a minute but Adora finally relaxes and begins to feel her blood flowing again.

After a minute she feels Catra turn her head slightly. "Better?" She whispers under her breath.

Adora whispers back, "Yeah, thanks." It sounds strangled, she hopes Catra doesn't notice. She is genuinely much more comfortable. Her head is spinning now though. *Is this romantic? Platonic? How many times have you sat with her and/or Bow like this? But do either*

of them make your heart do… that? *Definitely not. Okay, so romantic on your side. What about Catra? What is* her *heart beating right now?*

Adora continues down that vein for the rest of the movie and is startled when the credits begin to roll, and the house lights go back up. She blinks, adjusting to the light and watches Catra uncurl and stretch out. "So?" She turns to look at Adora. "Thoughts?"

"Oh"… *Fuck, what was this movie even about?* "Yeah, um I liked it! I liked the weird frog guy."

"Nice, I was all about that dragon. What a boss bitch."

"Totally!" Adora agrees.

Catra gives her a wary look but doesn't question it. "So, food?" Adora nods. "Cool, there's a taco truck near here I like. Or if that doesn't sound good, I think there's like, a ramen place and Thai not too far."

"I'm good with the truck."

"Awesome." Catra smiles, then makes her way out of the aisle. They get to the front of the building and fish out their keys. "Why don't you just ride with me? I can drop you back at your car after, there's just not a ton of spots." Catra suggests.

"Oh, yeah that works." Adora clips her keys to her belt loop and follows Catra to her car. Adora doesn't know shit about cars, but the little metal H tells her it's a Honda, she thinks. Catra hops around to the passenger's side and gets Adora's door for her. *Interesting…* She then goes back to her own side and slides into her seat. Before they get going, she plugs her phone in and queues up an album, it's groovy Adora smiles at some of the lyrics. They listen in comfortable silence, the windows down to let in the warm summer breeze. It's peaceful and Adora is able to stop fretting for a little bit.

The truck is only ten minutes away as it turns out. Catra pulls into a gas station lot and parks. "This place is so good Princess, you're gonna plotz."

She climbs out, Adora right behind her. When they're a little bit close the woman working the window calls out, "Hola Catra!" with a wide smile. Adora turns to give her a look and Catra just smirks back.

"Hola Rosalinda, cómo está?" Catra answers as they reach the window. They begin trading Spanish back and forth, so quickly Adora doesn't catch a word. They're both smiling widely, and at one point Rosalinda waggles her eyebrows and gestures to Adora, asking a question. "Oh, this is Adora, hey don't look at me like that!" Catra answers with a blush, launching back into Spanish. After a little back and forth Catra turns to her. "You know what you want Adorable?"

"Ah so it's Adorable now, eh?" Comes from the window with a chuckle.

"Dejalo!" Catra calls back.

"Uh." Adora blinks at Catra, realizing she never looked at the menu.

"I usually get the two and the five with veggies." Catra shrugs.

"Uh, yeah that sounds good." Adora nods without even looking to see what she's committing to.

Catra smirks at her and turns to place their order, paying for both before Adora even realizes what's happening. She leads Adora to a picnic table nearby and they sit across from each other. Adora can hear frogs and crickets signing somewhere, off in the distance. "Thanks, um for dinner... So, come here often?"

Catra laughs, "Why Adora! Was that a line?"

Adora blushes and sputters for a moment. "I mean I- well- no! They uh, they just really seem to know you here."

Catra laughs again, lightly. "Yeah, they're good people here, Rosa especially. I've been coming since high school. They actually used to let me pick up shifts occasionally, paid me under the table. It's how I came up with the deposit on my first place."

"That's nice." Adora smiles warmly, she looks back to the truck and notices steam and stars billowing through the window and open back door.

"Yeah, well." Catra shrugs.

"Eh, Catra!" Rosalinda hollers from the truck window, holding their order aloft. Catra skips over to grab it and comes right back, setting a quesadilla and a plate with four tacos on each side of the table.

"Shit, this smells so good." Adora groans, closing her eyes to savor it for a moment.

"Tastes even better." Catra teases her, taking a large bite. Adora rolls her eyes and takes her own bite, moaning as it hits her tongue. Swallowing she looks up to Catra who is looking at her, though her gaze is a little distant.

"This is amazing!" Adora praises.

"You're amazing." Catra throws back, making Adora's face heat up. She wants to sass back but her brain seems to be stuck. "So, you wanna tell me what that was at the café the other day?"

"Uh what?" Adora asks, genuinely blanking. Catra gives her a look. "I seriously don't know what you're talking about Catra!"

"With the art thing." Catra explains and *oh.* "What gives Adora? Why show me when you haven't shown! I mean fuck, who else have you even shown your art too?"

Adora blushes and looks down at her plate, picking at her food. "It's not that I'm not *willing* to show people. I mean I've shown uh… Perfuma one time…and there was someone I was friends with at community college who saw a couple."

"That's it?" Catra asks, almost aghast. At Adora's nod she frowns. "Adora, why? You have to know…"

"Know what?"

"How incredible you are. Why don't you want to share that?"

"I mean, it's not that I don't. I just…it's not something I ever really took that seriously. And it's not like many people are begging to see my shit. So, I just." She shrugs, shoving an entire taco in her mouth to avoid continuing.

Catra rests a hand on Adora's free one, getting Adora to look up at her. "Sounds like you need to start taking yourself seriously then." Before Adora can think of a response her phone rings. She silences it without looking, but as she opens her mouth to say who knows what, it rings again. She huffs and gives Catra an apologetic look, she looks down. It's Mara, Adora raises a brow, surprised to see her big sister calling.

"Sorry, it's Mara. She had an appointment with Hope today. She wasn't supposed to call until tomorrow though. Do you mind if I…" Catra indicates she go ahead with a gesture, her mouth full of tacos. "Hey Mara, what's up?"

A deep sigh and then, "Hey Sparkle, now a good time?"

Her tone sets Adora immediately on edge. "A good time for what?" Catra looks up from her food, giving her a questioning look.

"For some news that's probably not gonna be super fun to deliver or hear."

"Fuck, Mara. The baby." She can't bear to form her fears into a question, barely notices Catra's hand landing on her free arm where it rests on the picnic table.

"No! No, hope and the baby are good. The appointment went well." Adora relaxes immediately. "But still... can you talk?"

"Uh," she glances at Catra, it really isn't the best time but, "I mean I don't really think I can hold out at this point Mara. You've got me on the edge of my seat here." She laughs humorlessly, Catra squeezes her arm once.

"Right, yeah. Sorry kid. It's uh... well it's Razz." Adora's heart stops, her breath caught. "She's okay! For a while at least but she... she caught pneumonia. Looks like she's gonna recover, just needs a few days. It's just..."

"Just what?" Adora demands, she flips her hand over and Catra slides her own into it, allowing Adora to squeeze it tightly.

"It's taking a lot out of her Squirt; they really don't love how her lungs are doing and her heart isn't as strong as they'd like it to be. She's not on her death bed but if she gets sick again..." Mara takes a heavy breath and Adora's heart aches. "Well, it might be time to think about coming home kid. Don't drop everything to hop on the next red eye or anything but..."

"But it could just be a matter of time?"

"I'm so sorry Squirt, but I think that's the case, yeah." Adora sobs. Catra drops her hand to come around to her side of the table. She lets Catra gather her into her arms and struggles to regain her breath. When her tears subside somewhat Mara asks, "Hey, you're not on your own right now, are you kiddo? You've got Glimmer or Bow or someone with you?"

"N-no. I mean I'm not, I'm out but w-with a friend."

"Good, okay . Im gonna let you go unless you want me to stay on the line?"

Adora shakes her head before realizing Mara cant see her . "That' s o-okay, thanks though Mar. Justis.she okay?I mean Iknow she'sbut she' s not too disoriented?The doctors are being good to her."

"She' s doing surprisingly well on that front honestly."Mara reports much to Adora's relief. "Definitely a little disoriented at times but in good spirits even when she's a little lost. Some strong moments of clarity too. She's doing as well as we could hope for her to be. Alright Squirt, keep your chin up and just let me know what you decide about coming home."

"Ill be there."

"Great, well Im sorry about the circumstances but well be thrilled to see you. Darla especially."Mara laughs and Adora lets out a watery chuckle, she does miss that old dog. "Just let me know when you have a timeline, well arrange for time of f while youre here and get you from the airport and all."

"Okay , Ill keep you posted. Bye Mara."

"Bye Squirt."

The line clicks and Adora's phone falls from her hand to the top of the table with a clatter. She turns to look at Catra, trying to find the words. When her eyes meet Catra's, the now familiar split of colors saturated in grief, all that comes is a fresh wave of tears. Catra pulls her close and rubs circles into her back, making no comment about the puddle of tears dripping onto her shoulder, waiting with Adora until the tears subside again.

Adora isnt sure when Catra starts humming. When she does finally register the sound, and the rumble in Catra's chest that accompanies it, she presses her right ear over Catra's heart. Eyes closed she lets

herself be soothed, reveling in how good it feels to just be *held*. She sniffles a little, eventually petering out after a couple more minutes. Gathering all of her will she pulls away from Catra to sit up and wipe her eyes.

"Sorry ." She mumbles, looking into her lap but sneaking a look at Catra from the corner of her eye.

Catra shakes her head. "No need to be. Hey , you wanna look at me Dora?" Adora looks up, nervous about how vulnerable she must look in this moment. It takes all she has left to not tear her eyes away and drop her head to the table, cradled in her arms. Catra sets a hand on her knee, stroking it with her thumb. It leaves a trail of halfhearted stars. "Your grandma?"

"Yeah, she's not..she' s sick." Adora chokes on the emotion lodged in her throat. "I have to go home." Suddenly Adora is stricken with fear, terrified to face whatever state Razz is in alone.

"It' s good youll get to see her again, yeah?" Catra of fers weakly.

"I dont want-wanna be aalalone." Adora cries again and is pulled back into Catra's arms, this time she's able to embrace her back. She clings tightly to her friend. "I'm so scared, Catra. I hate that I havent been there."

"I know Dora, I know ." Catra sooths, rubbing circles into her back again. "I'm sorry you're dealing with this, but I wont let you deal with it alone, okay?" Adora nods into the crook of her neck. "Okay , and not just me. You've got Mara, Bow , Glimmer, all your friends. You arent gonna be alone. No one is gonna let you be left alone." Adora cries harder at that, leave it to Catra to get right to the heart of the trauma this is bringing to the surface.

Adora settles, relatively, once more and pulls back again. She wipes roughly at her eyes and cheeks. "I just I dont know if I can go if I can face her, do this thing by on my own. I know Mara and Bo will

be there but." She bites her lip, unsure exactly what she's trying to say.

"Do you want someone to go with you, a little emotional support?" Catra asks, catching her eye.

"Would you come?" The words spill out of Adora before she can think about what she's saying. As soon as they register, she is freaking out. *That's probably not appropriate, right? You've not even known each other three months!* Catra's wide eyed stare only fuels her spiral.

"I mean if you want, I... I didn't mean to- but of course I'm happy to, whatever you need Dora. But if you'd rather I... mean Bow or , or Sparkles- not that... Whatever you want is, uh." Catra trails off, her expression somewhat pleading. It strikes Adora that she's never really seen Catra ramble before. She doesn't hate it, but she does feel bad.

"I'm so sorry! Shit, I didn't mean to put you on the spot like that. I just, you said that, and I guess you're just being so kind and I... But of course, that's a *huge* ask and if it doesn't, or you don't- totally understandable! I'm, I mean I'll be fine." Cool, cool. So now Adora is rambling too.

Catra's eyes are still wide and she blinks at Adora a few times. Suddenly she cracks, bursting into laughter. Now it's Adora's turn to stare wide eyed. "Fuck, I'm sorry! It's just- fuck we're a couple of idiots, huh?" She laughs for a minute longer , Adora relaxing and smiling, if not chuckling along a little bit. Eventually she wipes at her eyes and sighs, turning on the bench seat and looking Adora in the eye again. "Sorry , what I should have said was; I'm *happy* to go home with you if you need or want my support. Just- sleep on it tonight and let me know what you decide. Whatever you want, I'm here for you."

Adora gives her a teary smile and nods. "Okay , thanks Catra."

The rest of their night is a solemn affair, they finish their food and climb back into Catra's car. Once back at the theatre lot they sit in Catra's car for a while, listening to music. They watch the people milling around and when a few tears escape Adora's eyes, Catra reaches over to squeeze her hand.

"I should go." Adora says, finally realizing the time. Her voice is rough and worn out from all the crying, as if her vocal cords were eroded by all the salt water.

"Yeah, okay. You sure you're good to drive?" Adora nods and Catra gives her a long look before nodding back. "Alright, text me when you get home." Another nod. "Good, and Adora? I meant what I said, if you need me, I'm there."

"Thanks, Catra, I appreciate it. Everything, I'm sorry tonight wasn't well that it turned into this. I was really enjoying our hang." She smiles sadly, gathering her things and getting ready to head out.

"Yeah, me too Princess."

A final wave and Adora is on her way. She reaches home twenty minutes later, safe but unable to remember the drive. When she walks in the door Bow and Glimmer are on the couch, ready to pounce. When they see her face however, their own expressions fall, and they rush forward to wrap her in their arms. It brings on a fresh wave of tears and they lead her to the couch, soothing her until she regains her voice to explain what's happened.

"Catra, ums... she offered to go home with me." She tells them after they're caught up on everything else.

Bow and Glimmer exchange a look over her head. It's Bow who asks, "Oh? And uhh... how do you feel about the idea?"

Adora bites her lip. "It was sort of... my idea."

"Oh?" He asks again, his voice pitching a little higher.

Adora groans and rests her head in her hands, elbow on her knees. "I'm such an idiot! It just popped out. She was being so sweet and the *hugging*, ugh! And I was a total wreck so *of course* she said she would come, but that's so much and I—" Adora huffs.

"Is that what you want though?"

Her voice breaks. She remembers how it felt while Catra held her. "Maybe I think so? Is that okay?" Without lifting her head Adora turns to look at Bow. His expression is achingly soft.

"Of course it is Adora. If she said she'd go and you want her there, you should take her up on it."

Adora nods and turns to cover her face with her hands. She speaks into them, her words muffled. "I think I'm gonna take a shower and try to sleep."

She feels Glimmers hands rubbing her back, up and down. "That sounds like a good idea. Did you and Catra eat?" Adora nods into her hands. "Good, okay . . . hop in the shower, we'll be up a while so let us know if you need *anything*. And we'll make you breakfast and be there to help you figure things out in the morning."

Adora sits looking between her friends. "Thanks guys, I don't know what I'd ever do without you." With one last squeeze between them Adora wanders toward the bathroom. She scalds her skin and washes away her tears. Once she turns off the shower she stands in the shower for a while longer, just dripping and feeling spent. She brushes her teeth before going to her room. Once there she towels off and falls directly into bed and directly to sleep.

She dreams of a dark, starless night which fades into morning, which fades into another dark night in which the entire sky is lit only by the north star.

Chapter End Notes

Me: Let the lesbians go on a date
Also me: Ruin it
Adora: t was never a date, it was jµst date *lik*e .

Alright y'all!Ihave a *bunch* planned and some already written for next chapter, it should be a *doo*z . Also, this has nothing to do with much of anything but in my head Catra puts on the album Qeer Love Songs by Be Steadwell in her car .

Thanks again to everyone reading, and double to anyone whose left kudos/comments and/or bookmarked!Iappreciate it!

Galaxies Inside

Chapter Notes

Imade these silly lesbians a spotify playlist if anyone wants to tune in!
A couple songs Ive referenced, others are just songs Iimagine them pining to, and then a couple specific ones Isprinkled in for Perfuma and her plants!

https://open.spotify.com/playlist/3pT6MkLCUUyXiCN?si=WMPROaW8dCSI2skQ

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Alright Adora, you have your passport?" Adora nods. "Liquids in a clear bag?" She nods again. "Clean underwear?"

"*Bow* Oh my gosh." Adora turns beat red and turns to fuss with her duffle.

"What? I know you dont want to forget that, hanging with Catra for a week in the same underwear?" Bow gives a dramatic shiver .

She turns around again to give him a derisive look. "So *not* the point Bow."

"Yeah, yeah, but Im not wrong."

She rolls her eyes. "I'll give it to you on a technicality ."

"Thank you. Now , Iput some snacks in your carry on- "

"Youre such a *dad* Bow." Glimmer calls from her spot on the couch, not looking up from the magazine she's looking at.

"You like it." He calls back without turning around, she rolls her eyes and smiles fondly, turning the page of NatGeo. "Now, I also saw you didn't have any reading material in there. I took the liberty of putting in that book I was telling you about."

Adora's expression melts, a little bit of emotion sneaking its way into her voice. "Thanks Bow, you take such good care of me. You've got dad of the year in the bag for sure."

"Aw Adora!" He takes the few steps to close the distance between them and wraps her in a hug. After rocking them side to side for a minute or so he pulls back. "How are you feeling today, *really*?

Adora scratches her nose. "I'm fine, really."

"*Adora*." Bow's tone is warning.

"I am!"

"Adora," Glimmer finally sets her magazine to the side and turns to sit overlooking the back of the couch. "You've been saying that *all week*."

"Because I'm fine." Adora stomp her foot a little bit, she wishes they would stop asking her. She is fine, for all intents and purposes. Sure, there's a tsunami of grief waiting to overtake her the second she drops her guard, but she's nothing if not an excellent compartmentalizer. It means she hasn't slept much since the night she got Mara's call but she's *fine. She's handled plenty more stress than this. If she just keeps her head down and goes through the motions, she knows she can get through this too.*

Glimmer rolls her eyes. "*Yeah, I don't know why you keep saying that, literally no one is buying what you're selling.*"

"*Glimmer!*" *But Bow's Adora tone adopts a warning tone.*

Bw ,alays the neutralizer ,steps in bef ore they can really get into it. "Aora,we're just concerned is all.Y ou haven't really talked about what' s going on with Rz since last week"

What are you talking about? I've spent all week coordinating this trip.Y ou know , to see Rz ."Bw gives her a dubious look."What Bw

I mean,yes you've made plans and all.But your grandma is sick, you're going home f or the f irst time since asking your new mom, and you're bringing Cora which is".. trails of f ,looking a little bit like he wished he hadn't gone there.

Which is what Bw She demands,she reaches back to f uss with her hair,tugging on the ponytail."Y ou're the one who said it wasn't over the line!"She' s been stressing about that all week, terrif ied she's asking too much,putting too much pressure on such a new f riendship

It' s not!It isn't,it' s good that you're letting your f riends support you. And we're glad you won't be going alone.It' s just".. trails of f and Cora rolls her eyes,jumping in.

It' s just gonna be a little weird. What? "She adds in response to the looks Bw and Aora are giving her;Bw is incensed and Aora looks like someone just kicked her in the gut."I'm not saying it' s bad weird!But are you seriously telling me you don't have any reservations?I'm just a little concerned;you're having a hard time being vulnerable with us.How you're gonna go into this super stressf ul situation with Cora.We,need Ireind you,you still have this unresolved whatever with.Ijust want to be sure you're not doing that dumb thing you do when you get stressed."

What thing?"Aora asks def iantly .

That thing where you "contemplate"and shut down emotionally .And then,when that doesn't work, you spiral into anxiety

and stop sleeping. Don't think I haven't heard you pattering around in the middle of the night Aora Greyson, you're not sneaky."

Aora is goblsmacked at being called out so bluntly. "Way harsh Gen!"

"Yeah, all you have to leave soon so we don't really have time to pussyfoot around. Besides, if you wanted gentle guidance you should have gone to Bow."

"To be fair, I didn't come to either of you," Aora points out.

"That's the whole problem Aora!" Gen raises her voice ever so slightly.

"I'm sorry, but can you just try to not ugh!" She takes a deep breath and feels her frustration dissipate slightly. "I'm aware that this is a super weird situation, I've thought about telling Cora to cancel her flight about a billion times in the last week. And I know my coping skills could use a little work," Bo places an encouraging hand on her shoulder and squeezes lightly. "But right now I just need to get through this trip. And this," She gestures to the air between them, "isn't exactly helping."

Gen looks at her for a long while, the look in her eyes stubborn. At long last she huffs. "You're right, I'm sorry. It wasn't fair to bring this up now. Just know we're here if you need us, I don't want you to hesitate to reach out because you think it'll make things easier. Call me this week, okay? Even if it's just to say," She rolls her eyes, "that you're fine."

"Okay, thanks Gen. I'm sorry too. I know you guys are just looking out for me."

"Okay…" Bo drags the word out, then peeks down at his watch. "If you're ready Aora we should probably get going. We still need to get Cora from the cafe."

"Yeah, okay. Thanks Bow."

He nods, grabbing his keys from the hook by the door. "Cora, you still coming?"

"Yeah, sure. Let me just grab my bag." She trots off and within a few minutes they're on their way, pulling into a spot a block up from the shop twenty minutes later.

"Let me just make sure she's good to go." Aora says, pulling out her phone. She's suddenly racked with anxiety. What if Cora doesn't want to come anymore? What if she never did? What if we get there and she realizes then that it's way too much, and books the next flight home? Oh goddess, what if she hates me after this? She takes a deep breath attempting to slow her mind. She finally manages to unlock her phone and sees Cora has already texted her.

Morning Princess, ready whenever you are. No rush tho' Just text me and I can run out'

Here! Aora sends back.
No rush! She shoves her phone back under her thighs and leans her head between the front seats.

"This is okay, right? I'm not like, totally taking advantage here?" She looks for reassurance.

Cora just rolls her eyes, having grown tired of this conversation over the last week. Bow, ever the patient one, actually responds. "Aora, she offered to go, and you double checked like five times. You're good, you need to trust Cora to set her own boundaries; if she didn't want to come, she could have said at any point."

"Okay." Aora bobs her head and swallows thickly. "Okay, you're right." She leans back into her own seat.

Bwa turns back to look at her. "I just want to be sure you still want her to come, right? Because if you changed your mind-"

"I haven't," Adora answers quickly, hoping Bow won't pry further to unpack that. Luckily, he leaves it and before long there's a gentle tap on the window. Adora jumps and looks out to see a smiling Catra, suitcase and a drink tray in hand, backpack swung over her shoulder. She reaches out to push the door open and Catra shoulders it the rest of the way.

"Hey, should I put this?" Catra gestures with her suitcase, passing the drinks over to Adora.

"I'll pop the trunk for you," Bow answers, a distinct click sounding as he finishes.

Catra hops to the back and the trunk slams shortly after. She's written names, all nicknames, on all the cups so Adora passes them around and sets Catra's in her cup holder. As Catra shuts her door behind her Adora turns to ask, "Hey, I figured it out by process of elimination. But why is mine 'Princess'?"

Catra smirks, "Her Royal Highness, Princess Perfect."

Bwa and Glimmer hold in the front seat, Adora shoves her shoulder lightly. "You're a brat, thanks for getting coffee." The latter sentiment is echoed from the front seat.

"It's whatever. Thanks for driving us Bow," she says dismissively.

"Of course! Let's get going, your flight leaves in three hours, yeah?"

"Yeah," Adora calls from the backseat.

"Thanks for taking the later flight Dora, if y'all had picked me up at five I'd have been a monster."

Glimmer turns in her seat, laughing. "Aren't you a barista?

"Yeah, and the owner." Cora arches an eyebrow in question and Aora sinks back with a groan. Which means no one can fire her for being a bitch to annoying customers when she works the early shifts."

The rest of the car laughs and Aora shakes her head at her friend. They chit chat a little longer but by the time their fifteen minutes into the hourish long drive Cora's fallen asleep, her head is resting on Aora's shoulder, it reminds Aora of sitting in the theatre last week. The light snoring is new though.

Bow has an old playlist on quietly and the ride is mostly chill otherwise. "Looks like we're about five minutes out if you want to wake her." Bow says after a while, catching Aora's eyes in the rearview. Aora shifts to do so, but Bow's voice cuts her off. "Hey, Aora?"

"Yeah?" She keeps her voice low, trying to let Cora get a few more minutes of sleep.

"Remember what Cora said to you a few weeks ago, about not closing yourself off from what you want?" Aora thinks for a moment and remembers the tarot pull Cora had done for her. She nods. "I know this is a really weird time for you, but, well, I just hope it doesn't make you close yourself off to the good stuff that's happening too." He catches her eye in the mirror, giving her a significant look for as long as he can; only breaking off when he needs to look at the road to change lanes.

Aora clears her throat. "Got it. Thanks Bow."

Aora doesn't think too much about the words then; they're close to the drop off area and she wants Cora to have a second to wake up before they need to get going. She thinks about it later however; she spends an awfully long time thinking about it in fact.

At the curb they have a goodbye that lasts until Catra dryly points out that Bow has hugged each of them, including Glimmer, at least twice. They make it through security with no issues. The wait is long, but it gives Catra a little time to wake up and Adora time to chug her nearly full water bottle. Catra makes sure to give her shit for it, telling her she's gonna have to use the nasty airplane toilet so much.

By the time they make it to the gate they have about forty-five minutes to kill. Catra dozes lightly against Adora's shoulder again. She pulls out the book Bow had put in her bag to kill time before Adora knows it they're boarding and settling into their seats. When the attendant starts giving them the safety spiel, she notices Catra growing tense in her seat.

She leans into Catra's space to whisper, "Hey, you all good?"

Catra nods tightly, it's not very convincing. "Sure, yeah, great Princess."

"Catraa..."

"It's fine, really. I'll be great after takeoff." She squeezes her eyes shut.

"Fuck, you're anxious." Catra laughs humorlessly, after a minute she nods tightly again. "Hey, that's cool. But can I help you right now?"

"Adora, seriously I'm fine. It's just takeoff is when most shit goes wrong on planes. I'm not a fan of flying over water, I do not like the idea of having to survive a water landing. But it's a three hours continental flight, no big. So, we get through takeoff and we'll probably live through the flight, yeah?"

"Well that's very morbid." Adora states simply, Catra's eyes popping and her expression shifts rapidly like she doesn't know how to feel about that. "Seriously Catra, isn't there anything we can do to help

The response is far from immediate. Cora seems to wrestle internally, eventually she seems to deflate a little. She looks much more vulnerable. "I just." The seatbelt lights flick on and they start to move. "Hold my hand?" Nora doesn't hesitate. She holds Cora's left hand in both of hers and strokes her thumb across the back. They sit quietly like that until the pollers pour upon you like talk to me? Say things?"

"Uh, yeah of course um, like what?"

"Whatever, anything. How are you feeling about going home? I mean I know the family stuff's, I know. But that's where you grew up right? How long has it been since you went back?" Cora asks, clenching and unclenching her hand throughout.

Nora squeezes back. "Uh, yeah. Well essentially, my parents died when I was really tiny, so I basically always lived with Z. She wasn't in the city like Mira and Bo, more like the middle of nowhere. Our house was sort of on the cusp of the suburbs, so that's where I went to school. But the zipcode was technically in the forest."

"The forest?" Cora laughs, relaxing a tiny bit.

"Uh yeah, super woodsy. Have you seen those eco houses built into hill sides?"

"Nay, you did not live in a hobbit house!" Cora insists, relaxing a little bit more.

Nora shrugs with a wry grin. "I mean the door wasn't round."

"That's wild Geyson!"

"Yeah, it was cool as fuck"

"What happened to the house?"

Alora's eyes get a little misty at the question. "Well, I had a lot of debts and Myra helped me make sure that she didn't end up in a sketchy home, but it costs way more so I had to sell it. But, anyway," Alora continues on quickly, indicating clearly that she'd like to move on. "After that I was mostly in the suburbs, but my last foster parents were in the city. After that I moved in with Myra who was there too and went to the community college."

"And this is when you were seventeen, right?" Cora clarifies.

Nodding Alora says, "When I moved out, yeah. I had a few more months before I graduated, I got a part time job and worked through the summer to pay for classes. I got my associates and then worked in the city for a couple years."

"I don't think I've ever asked you, why did you move to Ernia? They're all through tale of for now," Cora doesn't even seem to have noticed.

Eyes flicking, "Ernia just started to feel really claustrophobic. My old foster dad bought out the company I was working for. I didn't have to see him much or anything, I mean sometimes, but he and his people made a lot of stupid changes that made the environment really toxic. And I just was trying to change some things, for myself, and my friends there were really judgmental when I stopped going along with whatever."

"With whatever?" Cora asks, an edge to her voice.

Alora shrugs, "Yeah, nothing crazy, I was hanging out with a lot of partiers, lots of heavy drinking, which I was never really into. And just kind of toxic in general, mean to each other under the guise of teasing, that sort of thing. Myra was the one who suggested taking some space, she said I should at least try it for a year. If I really hated it, I could always come home."

"Did you ever think about moving back?"

"Yeah, right around the year mark actually. I didn't make many friends before I left Brand Bar, so it was pretty lonely for a while. Plus, all I chose Fernia because of," she scratches the back of her neck, suddenly shy. "She's not actually talked about this in a long time, the only person she still talks to who knows is Mira. All I thought about going to Mistacor."

"Oh shit. That bougie art school?" Cora looks shocked. When Alora nods she asks, "Well did you apply?" Alora hesitates but nods again. "And?"

"Deferred," Alora sighs. "And I got in."

"The fuck Greyson?" Cora is loud enough that the person across the aisle turns to check out the commotion. Cora pays them no mind and Alora, with her back turned, doesn't notice.

"Yeah, all turns out bougie art schools have a bougie price tag. I thought with financial aid... but not so much." She shakes her head.

"Damn Princess, that's fucked up. The education system is elitist as shit. I'm sorry you got screwed." Cora reaches over and puts a hand on her knee, almost absentmindedly. "What are you excited to see again?"

The question stumps Alora for a minute. Then she smiles, "Definitely Darla."

Cora laughs aloud, "The dog?" She laughs even harder when Alora nods emphatically. "Okay, what else?"

"I honestly hadn't thought about it that much. I mean there's this amazing park I used to go to all the time I should take you to. And uhoh, if you wanted to go out one night there's this really cool space theme arcade. I spent so much time there for a while, I had the high score on favorite game for like, six months straight one time." She smiles smugly at Cora, who giggles back.

"You nerd, when was this?

Aora's expression only grows smugger. "Four months, first birthday to half birthday." Extra laughs, it's a deep belly laugh.

"You're too much Adorable."

Aora smiles and with a shrug says, "I know." She glances past Extra, out the window. In the bright, blue sky she sees a friendly blanket of stars.

They chat a while longer and share the veggies and crackers Bow snuck into Aora's bag. Shortly after Extra falls asleep for the remainder of the flight, walking groggily as passengers around them start to shift in their seats. She's quiet as they deboard and Aora shoots off a text to Mira, who should be waiting in the lot.

*Just got off the plane, Gate B
Met you at pickup?*

*She gets a response almost immediately; she guesses Mira's been watching the online arrivals board. Sure thing!
You checkany bags?*

Nope! Ready 2 go!

Aora lets Extra know they can make their way to the pickup and they navigate through the airport. They finally reach the sliding doors and walk out into the breezeway.

"Squirt!" They turn to their left, and there's Mira hanging out of the door of her blue jeep and waving her left arm wildly. With a chuckle Aora heads in that direction, Extra hot on her heels. As they get closer Mira gets out of the car, waiting on the sidewalk and throwing her arms open once Aora is close. They hug tightly, Mira rocking her back and forth a few times. "My kiddo, long time." Aora closes

her eyes and nods against Myra's chest, soaking in the feeling of home. When Adora pulls away she notices there are so many stars on and around Myra it looks like she's glowing.

Adora turns to Catra. "Catra this is my big sister Myra, Myra this is my, uh, friend Catra." Myra steps forward, sizing up at Catra.

"Nice to meet you Catra! Are you a hugger or nah?

Catra looks briefly surprised but grins back. "More of a handshake kind of gal."

"Alright, we'll put her there pal." They shake hands briefly. "Okay, we'll let me get the trunk for you two so we can get on the road before this attendant comes over to nag me." She laughs lightly and they get the bags and themselves loaded into the car. Myra turns the radio down from the blasting level she'd had it set to and they're on their way.

"What's been up to today?" Adora asks.

"She's home, but the baby hasn't been a fan of long car rides the past couple weeks."

"Oh no, poor bebe!"

Myra waves her hand dismissively. "Honestly I think she's enjoying the excuse to make me do all the grocery shopping and other errands."

Adora laughs, "I'm surprised she hasn't been making you do it just on the principle that she's carrying your child."

Myra points at her without taking her hand off the wheel. "Touché."

They continue catching up mostly about Bow and Glimmer, baby and the baby, and their respective workplaces. Myra makes a point to include Catra, she ends up telling her a little bit about Huntria, mentioning Perfuma and Scorpia.

They're climbing out of the car and Adora is gushing. "Oh my gosh Mira, I should really send you some of Scorpia's food by mail or something. It's unreal."

Catra shrugs her backpack over her shoulder. "I've got some stuff in my bag." She says in nonchalantly, reaching into the trunk for her suitcase.

Mira grins widely. "Oh hell yes! Alright, so Catra gets to stay the night. Adora, what's you're offering to your goddesses?"

Catra laughs loudly and she and Mira bump fists. Adora should have figured they'd be fast friends. She throws her hands on her hips sassily. "Yeah, my mere presence is offer enough, thanks. Plus, you know Perla would pitch a fit if you tried to kick me out."

"Hm, Perla can go with you. I want presents." Adora rolls her eyes and walks away, she hears the other two right behind her, still chortling to themselves. When Adora is a few steps from the house the door swings open. Perla bolts out and runs to Adora, knocking her on her ass and getting drool everywhere. She laughs, cooing at her and nuzzling their heads together.

Vaguely she hears Catra ask, "Am I are they always like this?"

She hears Mira's eyes roll. "Even when Adora still lived with us."

Adora looks up from Perla and scratches her head. She looks around the front garden, there are flowers everywhere and a large awning with shades half of the yard and the living room window. Mira and he had bought this place just six months before Adora moved. She could hardly believe how different it looked. Mira had developed a green thumb when they moved in, thrilled to have outdoor space after living in little city apartments for years. She had sent Adora pictures, but nothing was like being there herself.

She looks around, a little surprised at how few stars she's seeing. Then she hears he laugh at something Catra's said, having gone

over to introduce herself ,and she recognizes this f eeling.The inside of a star;warm, happy and saf e.She f lops onto her backin the grass,sighing,and doesn't protest when Darla takes the opportunity to slobber all over her f ace.

They're soon hustled inside so they can f reshen up while Mira and Lyle f inish making dinner .Adora leads Catra to the spare room, standing backso she can enter .If it' s cool with you I'll just leave my bag in here,so I don't clutter up the living room."

Catra tilts her head."What are you talking about?

"Well I'm gonna take the couch so I just f igured I can if you want, I can keep it out there,no problem."

"Why would you take the couch Adorable?

"Well -What?" She asks baf f led.

"I mean there' s one spare room,right?" Adora nods."Cool,well this bed is massive,and I swear I'm not a kicker or anything.Why don't we just share?" Suddenly Catra turns redder than Adora has ever seen her."If you're comfortable!Totally f air if you don't want to.I just mean,I mean if you are,there' s plenty of space.No stress either way .But I can take the couch,you've got a lot going on and you should get good rest."

"Okay ." Adora responds,her voice small.

"Okay? Okay ,cool I'll take the couch then.Do f or my stuf f ,should I-"

"No,sorry I meant;okay ,let' s share.I'm cool with it if you are.I didn't want to assume anything." Catra gives her a calculating look,she recognizes it f rom a week ago.It' s almost identical to the lookshe gave her at the ticket booth."Um,I'm thinking I'm gonna change out of my plane clothes." She grabs a change of clothes she had left packed

on top of her duf f le. "I'll be up in the bathroom. Be right back." She darts out of the room and across the hall. Once in the bathroom she leans back against the door and lets out the breath is coming. Well, she thinks, maybe it was the right call to bring Cora, if nothing else it's a good distraction…

They meet back downstairs for dinner, Cora having thrown on leggings and a t-shirt while Aora was in the bathroom. The chat over pasta, Aora catches up with Abe and Abe asks Cora a lot of the same questions Myra had in the car. Cora answers them all, no trace of impatients in her voice.

"Incredible! And the café has been open for how long now?" Abe asks her after she's told her about opening the café with Perfum

"Just a hair over two years." Cora says proudly.

"Congratulations, so have you made it out of the red yet?" She catches a sharp look from Myra. "Sorry if that was straightforward or too personal! I just know how tough those first couple of years can be on a small business."

Cora waves the concern away with a flick of the wrist. "It's all good, yeah we started really turning a profit about six months ago. Our insurance runs high though, so it's not much."

Abe's furrows her brow. "I wouldn't think a café would be too crazy to insure."

"Sorry, no our health insurance bills. We cover all of the staff, there's not a ton of them, but I mean, decent insurance is highway robbery, y'know?"

"You cover them all? A one hundred percent?"

Cora nods, swallowing a sip of wine. "Yeah, it was something really important to both Perfum and I. She worked the counter a lot at the

beginning so we could make it work. She mostly just helps with facilities and the business side of things and I cover day to day."

"I didn't know that." Alora pops up. "About everyone's insurance."

Cora just shrugs at her and offers a wry smile. "Eh, it's no big." The hold eye contact for a prolonged minute, broken apart when Myra clears her throat.

"Hey Squirt, why don't you help me clear these dishes? These two yahoos are dominating the conversation anyway." She sticks her tongue out at her and then they exchange a significant look. Alora doesn't try to interpret it. She turns to Cora and raises a brow, silently asking if she's good to hang with hope. Cora just grins and rolls her eyes. Alora smiles at the stars dusted in her hair, then follows Myra into the kitchen. Myra is already putting leftovers away, so Alora gets going on the dishes. "So, Cora's pretty rad."

Alora stills for a moment before resuming her task. "Yeah, she's a good friend."

"Friend," Alora whips around to see Myra leaning against the island from the other side. She turns off the water and faces her sister, leaning against the counter and crossing her arms.

"Something to say Myra?"

"I'm sure lots. Let's start with how did it is that you haven't asked her out yet." Myra smirks.

"Myra!"

"Alora!" Myra fakes gasps. "Seriously squirt, what gives? Are you just holding out on me? Because you two have been making heart eyes across the dinner table all night."

"I'm not, we're not, for goodness sakes! I don't even and and you just, you don't even know what-did Cora call you?

Myra cracks up. "She didn't have to, you absolute dork," she said, heart eyes. "You are into her, right?"

"I mean, maybe? I don't know. Probably." Aora shifts around in her spot against the counter.

"Aora"…

"I don't know, Myra! I mean, I think I do, or at least that I could if I opened that door but"…

"But what?"

"But I don't know, every time I think she'll then something happens, or she says something, or I stick my foot in my mouth and just feel like I've totally misread things. At first I mean I figured; get to know her, right?" Myra nods. "So, yeah. That went well. She's great, amazing really. So, then I was like, okay is this a friend thing or a romance thing? And I mean, it could be either! I just really like her, and I want her around for a long time and I don't." Aora's voice cracks a little and Myra rounds the island to lean beside her, slinging an arm around her shoulders.

"And you don't want to fuck up a good thing?"

"Maybe." Aora shakes her head. "And, well I mean if we did start dating, what then?"

Myra pulls back enough to give her a wary look. "Well, then you'd be dating Squirt." Aora's blank look. Myra sighs. "Is this a sex thing, because I already gave you the talk once and I—"

"Holy fuck, Myra! Yes, I remember, and it was bad enough the first time, thank you!"

Myra laughs, "Okay, okay, I'm sorry kid. I'm teasing. But also serious. I guess my real question is; is this an intimacy thing? Have you ever really done that?"

Myra, are you asking me if I'm sexually active?

"Absolutely not. I'm asking if part of the reason you're so intimidated by the idea of pursuing romance with Cora, is that you're intimidated by the idea of navigating an emotionally and physically intimate relationship. I mean, potentially. Just because you date, doesn't mean you have to fuck."

Adora blushes deeply, and her voice squeaks for a second when she opens her mouth. "I mean, I've kind of not bothered thinking about it, cause I figured it isn't really relevant at this point but, maybe, yeah. I mean you're right. I haven't ever really. So that would be… new. I mean, a little, like kind of casually. But not like you know, everything. But I mean eventually, with someone I trusted. I'd…" Adora groans and covers her face with her hands.

"Alright, I'm gonna ask because I love you; do we need to have the sex talk again." Adora turns her face to peek out from her hands and glare at Myra. "Hey, I just want you to be safe! But in all seriousness, I mean I avoid thinking about that as much as possible, but that doesn't shock me. You've been out, what? Like a year and half? And it's not like you were bringing any guys around while you were closeted. It's you've never really struck me as a casual dater or whatever."

Adora huffs and drops her hands. "Sometimes I worry. I mean sometimes it feels like most people expect by twenty-five that you've, you know, got more experience. And you're right, I've not always been super into it. But what if… Ugh, I don't know what I'm trying to say. Why are we talking about this again?"

"Are you really asking?"

"What's that supposed to mean?" Adora turns to face Myra more fully.

"Fine, we're talking about this because I brought up the fact that you have feelings for Cora. Seems there's a direct correlation between

those f eelings and you needing to unpackyour f ear of intimacy ,just saying.Ad as f ar as being worried about hat hapens if and hen you are ready to be physically intimate ith someone?T otally valid, Ive been there too,Ithinkmost of us have.Honestly the best advice Ican give you;ith a f oundation of trust,instinct and comunication ill usually get you here you ant to go."

Adora considers that quietly f or a inute."Y ou knowI never thought Id iss the days hen you are hassling emabout shit like taking out the recycle."Adora chuckles.

Taking the hint to drop the subject,Mara rages,"How hard can it be to remember that? "

It as under the sink,out of sight out of ind!"

Keep Ireminded you, all the time ."

If it bothered you so much,hy ouldn't you just trade chores ith me?"Adora challenges.

It as the principle of the thing!"

Pft,there's got to be some proverb about howuseless it is to argue on principle,"right?

"Oh,howare you twenty-ive and still this much of a brat?

"Howare you thirty-our and still so petty?

"Y ou little-"

"Ladies,"Hope's head pops through the door ."Hey Ireind you that e still have comany?

Adora flushes deeply ,"I'..

"Aha,ebarrassed you in f ront of you little girlf riend."

Myra, shut up!" Adora yells, diving at Myra's side, tickling her. Myra shrieks and runs, Adora hot on her heels.

"Hey! I'm about to be a mother, I'm too dignified for this shit! You little gremlin." Myra taunts from the other side of the island. Bow shakes her head and pops right back out, presumably apologizing to Catra for their antics.

"Oh yeah, then why are you running away?" Adora throws right back.

"Because you're a monster!" Adora breaks right and Myra high tails it out of the kitchen, past the dining table where Catra and Bow watch them fly by with wide eyes, and into the living room. Finally, able to catch her, Adora tackles her to the ground and pokes at her sides until she pleads for mercy, tears of mirth streaming down her face. Adora falls off of Myra, onto the floor beside her, both of them panting for breath.

"I'm sorry our girls are such heathens, Catra. I wish I could say they aren't always like this, but." They hear Bow say from the doorway.

Myra lifts her head enough to look over at them, propping up on her elbows at an awkward angle. "Please, we both know that my youthful energy is what drew you to me in the first place."

"Of course, darling, it's also why I'm so excited to have your baby. Finally, we'll get you a new playmate now that Adora's moved out."

Myra's answering smile is big, starry and joyous. "It's gonna be so much fun."

Adora finally sits up and she catches Catra's eye. Her eyes are crinkled with her smile, and she's still laughing lightly at the show they've just put on. Adora jerks her head to the stairs and Catra nods.

They say their goodnights and Myra checks in about their plans to visit Bow the next day. They head upstairs and get ready,

taking turns in the bathroom. Adora has managed to put off thinking about their sleeping arrangements until this very moment, standing by the edge of the bed, watching Catra apply lotion to her face. "Um. Is there a side of the bed you usually take?" She asks Catra, staring at the pillows.

"I'm left usually, but I'm not picky."

"That works." Adora pulls two of the three pillows off the right side of the bed and punches the third until it lies as flat as she can get it. Then she just stares at it again, placing her hands on her hips.

"What do you think?" Catra asks, her tone teasing. "Is it a knockout."

Adora shakes back, a little shyly. "Probably. But you can never be too sure."

"You dork."

"Whatever, you love it." Catra doesn't respond, and Adora looks up to see that increasingly familiar look of calculation on her face. She clears her throat, jumping on the bed, and Catra seems to snap out of it. "Anyway, um, never asked, are you planning to come with me to see Razz tomorrow?"

Catra freezes for a moment and then comes to stand by her own side of the bed. "Duh, do you want me to?"

"Well, um, I mean your call. It's—"

"Adora." Catra cuts her off, climbing onto the bed to sit on her knees and reaching across to hold her hand. "It's whatever you want. I'm here to support you. Do you want me to come?"

As much as she wants to, Adora doesn't break eye contact. She takes a deep breath. "Please." Catra nods with a small smile and climbs into bed. Adora slips under the covers herself and asks, "So um, how was hanging with Bow?"

Extra turns onto her side to face Aurora, propping her head on her arm. "This was chill." Extra's grin turns mischievous. That, combined with the fact that Extra didn't have more to say about her conversation, makes Aurora very nervous. "How was your conversation with Myra?"

Aurora blushes fiercely and prays to whoever is listening that Extra didn't hear anything incriminating. She rolls her eyes, trying to force herself to react normally. "It's whatever. She's lucky I love her because she's a pain in my ass."

Extra laughs. "You two really are like little kids together, I didn't know you had that tackle in you."

Aurora bites her lip and shrugs. "What about you?"

"What about me?"

"Do you keep up with any of your foster siblings."

"No, just Bonnie. She was just in the house so much more and most of junior year though, so we don't have much of a sibling dynamic." She laughs humorlessly. "Just trauma bonds mostly."

Aurora frowns. "I didn't know that about you and Bonnie. I'm sorry"… She isn't sure what she's apologizing for, just all of Extra's trauma in general maybe? "I'm sorry your environment wasn't better."

"Yeah well, we've done a lot of healing since then. There's a reason Bonnie's the only one I keep up with. Weaver fucked up or alienated everyone else who came through the house."

"Weaver?" Aurora asks tentatively.

Extra's expression grows stony. "My foster parent. I was in her house for about ten years. She was a real piece of work."

"I'm sorry. Do you want to talk about this?"

f” s f ine.” Ostra of f ers her a sad sile. “I can talk about it, but I mean, I don’t really love doing so, y’know? She was hella abusive and my social worker was a joke so.” She shrugs. “It took me a long time to work through it af ter I got out, you know, f iguring out it wasn’t actually on me. Learning to put an end to the cycle of abuse. All that good stuf f .”

“I’m proud of you Ostra.” She receives a questioning look. “For doing all of that work, it’s heavy emotional labor and I just think you’re amazing.”

Ostra f lushes lightly . “Well thanks Dora. I should probably get some sleep. Don’t want you to be dragging when we see your grandma tomorrow, right.”

“Y eah, okay . Sweet dreams Ostra.”

“Goodnight Adora.” They each f lick out the light on their respective side tables. Adora spends an hour watching the stars that swirl around the ceiling bef ore joining Ostra in sleep

Adora wakes the next morning to f ind that Ostra is already out of bed. She trundles downstairs to f ind her and Mara sitting at the kitchen island. Darla gets up f rom her spot under Mara’s chair to snif f at Adora in greeting and f ollows her around the kitchen, begging f or scraps and/or attention. “Morning sleepyhead.” Mara calls when she walks into the room. “She got called in last minute, but she said to tell you good morning and she’ll see us all f or dinner later .”

Adora f urrows her brow , reaching into the f ridge to grab the OJ. “I thought all the appointments she couldn’t cancel were virtual now?”

“Y eah, they are. But there were a f ew staf f meetings at the clinic, and she had some paperwork stuf f she really wanted to get caught up on. She tried to get it all done bef ore you got home, but they

changed systems and, well don't ask her about it. She won't stop ranting for hours. at a time"

"Heard a lot about this new system then, have you?" Extra asks.

Mira waves a finger in her face. "Oh just you wait, all it'll be one day your future partner is gonna come home ranting and raving about some shit. It'll be all well and good until you hit hour three of them talking in circles. that's when the tension headaches start." Adora raises the quick look Extra gives her when Mira references her future partner, Mira doesn't. Oh well I guess I should have assumed. Are you seeing anyone Extra?" She blinks innocently.

Adora tenses at the counter where she's now doctoring her oatmeal. She can't believe she just assumed! All this time fretting about whatever was happening between her and Extra and she never even bothered to check. She would know by this point, right? Like, it would have had to come up unless they're long distance like she's dating some cool travel journalist who's always on assignment. Or a supermodel constantly being called away to Milan, having to live in NYC for work to establish herself. Before she can spiral too much further than she already has in the three seconds it takes Extra to answer, she replies, "Uh, no?"

"Is that a question?" Mira teases. Adora schools her expression and walks around the island to sit on Extra's left.

"No, I just um, not seeing anyone." Mira gives her a long look.

"Someone in mind then."

Extra flushes. "I mean, not- not necessarily. Uh-"

"Alright Mira." Adora cuts in. "Can we at least wait until the sun is hot to start pestering my friend about her love life."

Myra puts exaggeratedly. "Off un." She shifts quickly to a side.
"Sorry Extra, didn't mean to press, I'm just nosy. It's where Aurora
gets it from." Extra snorts. "Right, I'm gonna go get ready and take
Darla to the dog park. You two heading out after breakfast?"

Extra turn to Aurora for confirmation. She nods at Myra, "Yeah, that's
the plan."

"Great, I drove Hope to work so you can use her car, keys are in the
usual spot. Have fun kids, and don't get in too much trouble." She
sets her dishes in the sink and leaves with a wink.

They eat relatively quickly without too much chatter, Aurora's brain is
slow to awake fully this morning. They shower, Aurora taking the liberty
of using the master bath, and get ready. Less than an hour later and
they're hopping in Hope's car, trying to figure out her GPS.
Eventually Aurora has to admit defeat and Extra take over with a
smirk, sorting it out in no time. Turns out the place is only ten
minutes away.

Beth has been released from the hospital so they're heading to her
home. The place is what could best be describes as budget bougie.
For instance, there are chandeliers in the lobby and dining area, but
the carpets look only slightly nicer than the ones in the portable
Aurora took Algebra in, in high school. A friendly middle aged woman
greets them at the front desk and gets them all signed in. Soon she's
leaving them by Beth's door, inviting them to let her know if they
need anything.

She walks away and Aurora turns to face the door, suddenly finding
herself frozen. After a minute or maybe ten she feels Extra's hand
on her arm. "What's up Dora?"

"I don't know."

"Are you excited to see her?" Extra asks gently.

Alora nods but the motion shakes a couple tears loose. "I am I just that what if she's different?"

Extra gives her a sympathetic look. "I dunno Dora, but I think there's only one way to find out." Alora nods and steels herself for a moment more before knocking on the door.

A creaky "Come in!" comes from inside and she opens the door. Ezra is sitting in her old rocking chair, an old quilt and a coffee table book that appears to be about medicinal plants resting in her lap.

"Hey Ezra," Alora greets her, unsure if she'll be recognized. "It's me, Alora. And I brought someone with me. This is Extra, Extra this is my Granny Ez."

"Nice to meet you." Extra says reaching out to take her hand and shake it. Ez gives her a wary look, it lasts long enough that Alora's stomach drops to her knees, but the it melts into a smile.

"Pleasure dear, please sit, sit." She indicates a couple armchairs that sit across a coffee table from her. They take the seats and Ez beams at them. "Alora, Darie! How are you?"

"I'm good Granny, how are you?" Her voice is choked with emotion. She can't believe how clear Ez is today. It's a prayer answered.

"I'm, you know, old." She cackles loudly and Extra snickers while Alora just rolls her eyes. "How's Myra, is she still with that girl, what was her name?"

"You mean Abe?"

"Oh, no, what was it? What was it? Ah Rachel."

"Um, they actually broke up a long time ago Granny. She's actually been married to Abe for a few years now."

*"Oh good, that girl was terrible." She practically shouts the insult. Extra snickers again and Ez's gaze cuts to her quickly before

sliding back to Aurora. She shields her mouth with her hand and stage whispers, "Who is that girl?

Aurora blanches and worries for a moment that Astra might be offended, she'd just introduced her, but she just chuckles softly. "That's Astra, remember? You just met."

"Yes, yes, obviously I know that. But who is she?

"Oh, she's my muse, she's a, uh friend." Luckily, she doesn't seem to notice the way Aurora is blushing and just shrugs the whole situation off.

"Oh, before I forget Dearie! Pass me that notebook, won't you? That's my girl." She pulls a slip of paper from the notebook Aurora grabs off the coffee table. "Now, you promised you would make a wish later, and still, no wish!" She reaches over and Aurora receives a gentle slap on the wrist. "So, you're going to need this." Aurora looks down at the paper she is handed, the writing is hard to make out. It appears to be a devolved version of Ezra's chicken scratch. But there it is, plain as day; the old wish recipe, the one lost in the mess of near strangers packing up her childhood home. The one she's been unable to replicate despite her best efforts. The one she had totally given up hope of finding. It burns so brightly with stars that it's hot in her hand, and she worries it will be lost in flames.

"And don't forget the stars!" Aurora looks up suddenly, jolted from her thoughts and totally caught off guard. She can feel Astra still next to her also.

"What?" She breaths.

"The stars dearie!" She shouts, then slightly calmer, she continues. "You put them in the wish! It tastes much better that way; don't you remember silly girl?" She looks at Aurora pointedly and then turns to look at Astra. "That girl has galaxies inside of her, don't you forget that." She gives Aurora an appraising look and turns to Astra again. "And don't you let her forget that either."

Catra nods solemnly, "I don't." Stars seem to work their way from every one of Catra's pores, vibrating with the rhythm of a soft purr.

Razz nods, satisfied she turns to Adora again. "So, how is school dearie? Is that stupid math teacher still giving you trouble? I can give him another talking to!"

The rest of the visit passes quickly, they laugh a lot. Razz is clearly all turned around about timeline, but she doesn't let it phase her one bit when Adora corrects her. She just laughs it off, calling herself old again, like she just found her glasses on top of her head or misplaced her keys. They stay until their stomachs are rumbling and an aide comes to collect Razz for lunch in the dining room. Adora kisses Razz already but is relieved to go home and recharge, emotionally spent. They'll be back again before they leave Etheria. She gratefully accepts Catra's offer to drive them home.

They settle in when they arrive, making lunch and sitting in the back garden which is even more vibrant than the front. Mara finds them out there and pulls out a few games which they play on the patio. Adora rests her feet on Perla under the table, rubbing her back. She's happy, content. She doesn't even mind when Mara and Catra team up against her just to get under her skin, and then tease her when she loses. Adora does notice that Catra doesn't seem to put her regular level of hutzpah into her teasing but shrugs it off, they've had a long day.

Mara heads out after a few games to get home and Adora starts dinner for everyone. This evening's meal a much calmer affair than the previous. They stay up late chatting after they're done and finally go upstairs when Mara can't stop yawning long enough to finish a thought.

Adora and Catra go through their same routine of preparing for bed. They're sitting around, winding down when Adora finally asks, "Catra... are you okay?" From her spot on the bed. She'd been acting sort of funny all evening. First with the games and then she'd been quieter during dinner than Adora was used to seeing her.

Hi, of course Dora, how are you holding up?

I'm holding up." She shrugs then hesitates, wondering if she should press or just drop it. She decides just a little wouldn't hurt. "Are you sure you're alright? You've been quiet since we left the house."

Extra shrugs and turns around to crouch on the floor and fuss with the contents of her bag, her back to Adora. "Just a weird day Adora, but I'm here to support you. It's not a big deal."

Adora waits a moment. When she doesn't continue Adora steels herself and moves off the bed to sit cross legged on the ground, perpendicular to Extra. She ventures a hand on her knee and waits until Extra looks up to her face. "I'm here to support you too Extra. Your uh- your feelings matter too."

Extra stares at her a moment, looking back and forth between her eyes, searching. It's that same calculating look that's haunted Adora for over a week now. The moment of blue and hazel eyes stares Adora for a moment, and she swears she can't feel her lungs. Then Extra breaks the spell by looking down into her lap. "Why did you ask me to come here Adora?"

Adora tenses, "Wh-"

"Don't get me wrong, I'm happy to be here with you!" She looks up quickly, eyes frantic and eager to reassure Adora that she isn't expressing displeasure at having come. Adora nods, biting her lip she gets the message. Extra relaxes and looks back down, playing with her fingers in her lap. "I just mean why me? I know that Glimmer and Bow would have done anything, dropped everything to come. You've known them a lot longer and we're friends and I'm happy to be here to support you but why did you ask me?"

Adora had kind of hoped she'd never have to answer this question, for Extra or for herself. She shrugs, feeling helpless, and knows

she's started blushing. "uh—I mean you just you were there, when I got Mira's call."

Cora nods, frowning. "Was that it?"

Alora hesitates, she could say yes. She could say it was a matter of timing and proximity. That if she'd been with any of her other friends, she would have wanted them by her side just as much, would have had the same instinct. But even though it doesn't totally make sense to her, she knows that isn't true. She shakes her head and a few stars slip in through the cracked window. "That's not it." She admits and the stars begin to fall in more freely, like snow flurries kicked up by the wind.

Cora's answering sigh is small, but she nods once and finally looks at Alora's face again. "So, hypothetically, Alora, this is kind of fucked up. Are you sure you want to have this conversation now? It's okay if you—if you're not in the right headspace. We can talk about it when we get home."

Alora shakes her head, she doesn't want to chicken out right now, not yet at least. "I'm fine."

Cora waits a moment, almost like she fully expects Alora to immediately change her mind. When she doesn't Cora takes a deep breath in and whooshes it out. Stars dance along the current of her breath, not a ton but Alora still thinks it makes her look like a dragon. "Alora when you—when you introduced me to Mira, and again today with your grandma, you called me your friend." Alora nods, that's true. "But you all you hesitated, right? It wasn't just… imagining that?" Alora nods again, though this time she feels her face burn. Cora nods, more to herself than anything. "Alora do you want me—I mean, like I want you."

Alora choked on air, not sure what to say in the wake of such a direct question and sly admission. "I—"

Because last ed you out, and you said yes. But then when we went got the impression you didn't think it was a date. Like maybe you didn't want it to be one." Astra looks so vulnerable and Aurora hates that she did that. Her heart stops in her chest. The stars in the room freeze. The moment of truth has finally come and it's her turn.

"I wanted it to be!" Too loud, way too loud; she practically shouts the words. Astra looks initially shell shocked, probably due to the shouting. Then her face relaxes into a self-satisfied smirk and the stars resume their movement, those closest to Astra first, and then out from there like a ripple.

"Oh yeah?" Aurora nods, suddenly shy again.

"Cool so, maybe when we get home, you let me take you on a second?" The invitation combined with that damned smirk still on her face makes Aurora's stomach drop out. Still she manages to nod enthusiastically.

"I'd like that." She squeaks.

The stars in the room break into the celebratory dance Aurora won't let herself indulge in.

Chapter End Notes

WE HAVE ADMISSION OF FEELS ALL, THIS IS NOT A DRILL!
I've had that part written since like, the third chapter and let me tell you, it felt *good* to finally catch up to it.
Next chapter should be pretty fluff heavy; there's a lot that I was gonna add at the end of this chapter, but then I got wordy and wrote the longest chapter yet without the extra. So...see ya with another update soon!

Thanks again for reading, kudosing, commenting and bookmarking!

A Guiding Light

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora wakes up the next morning and finds the other side of the bed empty again. She reaches a hand over, still a little warm, but not by a lot. She rolls onto her back and take the opportunity her solitude offers her to grin happily, kicking her feet with elation. She might let out a small scream too. She wants to bound downstairs to join her family, but it occurs to her that if she holds out on Glimmer and Bow, theyll never forgive her . She looks at the time, nine. She figures Glimmer is probably still asleep, but Bow will be up, and waking Glimmer up can be *his* problem.

She clicks the contact in her phone, it rings for a little but a finally clicks. Bow's voice is still a little groggy when he answers. "Adora?"

"Hey , sorry, did Iwake you?"

"No, no, my alarm only beat you by a couple minutes though."She hears Glimmer grumble something in the background and Bow hushing her. "What' s up?Have you gotten to see Razyet?"

"Uh, yeah Idid. t wasreally good. She remembered me and all, which was nice. Last time Isaw her she thoughtshe kept calling me by my mom's name. She actually asked me when her son and I were finally gonna give her grandbabies."Adora and Bow laugh at her past self's mortification.

"That' s gotta be weird."Then away from the phone. "Adora saw Razyesterday ...yeahIcan go into the living roomhang on."Bow is back. "Hey , Im gonna put you on speaker , kay?"

"Sounds good."

"Adora," Glimmer groans, "why are you calling in the middle of the night?"

Adora just laughs. "It's nine in the morning!"

"Same difference. What's going on?"

"I was just telling Bow I saw Razz yesterday. We had a really good visit." Her eyes fall to the lined paper sitting on her side table. "I uhm I have the recipe."

"Uh?" Bow asks, still sounding like he hasn't made it to fully awake.

"For the pies. She gave it to me." Adora feels her eyes get a little misty. "I finally have it."

"Adora that's amazing! Oh my gosh, were you close?" Glimmer asks, sounding a little more awake at the news. Adora grabs the paper and inspects it for about the billionth time since her Granny gave it to her.

"Uh, pretty yeah. Some of my quantities were off by a smidge and looks like my technique was off in one or two parts but it was the stars."

"Oh, Adora." Bow breathes. "Did Razz."

Adora hears the unasked question. "She did, yeah. She-she said I always used to that they always made it better."

"Damn." Bows voice then shifts to something a little more mischievous. "So does this mean like, some next level pies?"

Adora laughs loudly. "I guess so, yeah." Bow whoops. "I was actually thinking I might test it out today."

"Ooo! Send us pics." Glimmer demands. "So you gonna have Catra help you with that?"

"Very subtle Glim." Adora bites her lip and grins.

"Come on Adora! We've been *dying* over here. How is it going? Is she getting along with your family? Are *you two* getting along?"

"Uhm, she and Mara seem to have bonded over giving me shit. Honestly, I can't believe I didn't see sooner how similar their senses of humor are. She and Hope are getting along too, y'know Hope isn't overly emotive but I can tell she likes her. I think she's really impressed that Catra's running her own business."

When Adora doesn't expand Glimmer groans. "And *you two*? Geez Adora, it's like pulling teeth with you, I swear."

"Yeah, it's good. She's been really supportive. We uh, we talked last night." She can't stop her face from splitting into a wide grin that makes her cheeks ache.

"Sorry, just to clarify," Bow interjects, "did you two talk, or did you *talk*?"

"Well we're gonna go on a date a. *second* date." She smiles and then considering adds. "I mean, she told me she *was* asking me on a date before."

She ignores glimmer's smug, "Ah!"

"But does it count on a date if it ends with a call letting one of you know your grandma is sick?" She twists her lips, not having considered that last night.

She can practically hear Glimmer rolling her eyes. "Don't overthink it too much Adora."

"Right, right, that's probably y'you're right."

"I know."

"But seriously Adora, we're so happy for you! I'm glad you can put a lot of that uncertainty to rest, I think this is gonna be really good for you. For *both* of you."

"Thanks Bow , um, so do I Anyway , that's basically all the news I have, how are you two?"

"Oh, Glimmer has news actually!"

"Oh, yeah. Igot a job!" Glimmer shares.

"Oh my gosh Glim, congrats!What are you gonna be doing?"

"Eh, Ill basically be like a glorified intern, slash secretary . *But* it's for that *amazing* design company downtown, so hopefully it's just a foot in the door, ya know?" She sounds happy .

"Glimmer , that's amazing!Ill take you out to celebrate when we get home."

"Sounds good!There' s actually some swanky new bar on Eternia Ave, just down from the café, that Ireally wanna try . Maybe we can go get drinks?"

"Y eah, whatever you want!What about you Bow?"

"Eh, same old. W ork, oh and Sea Hawk finally leant me his lute, so Ive been messing around with that."

"Fun!Icant wait to hear your progress."

"W ell it's not much but-uh oh Glim's stomach is growling;we should probably let you go, feed the beast an all."

"*Bow* " He just snickers in response to his girlfriend' s protestation.

"Y eah, Im pretty ready for food now that you mention it. Ill talk to you guys soon!"

"Y eah, sounds good. Keep us posted on how things go with Catra and Raz" Bow requests.

"Will do, love you guys!"

They chorus back, "Love you too!" And the call ends.

Adora flops back to the bed and kicks her legs around again. After a few more moments of reveling she flips her legs over the side of the bed, throws her hair up and makes her way downstairs. When she hits the bottom steps, she can hear sounds of cooking and laughter coming for the kitchen. And something smells incredible. She smiles, making her way in that direction. She passes Hope at the dining table, clearly on a video call, and waves silently. She receives a smile in return.

When she enters the kitchen Darla plods right over, Adora couches down to scratch behind her ears and looks up. Mara is sitting on the counter next to the stove where Catra is making breakfast; looks like pancakes and eggs. Adora's stomach rumbles loudly.

"Well, well, look who finally joined the land of the living." Mara teases her. Catra turns around and acknowledges her with a warm smile, turning around again to poke at something in one of her pans immediately after.

"Yeah, yeah whatever." She sticks out her tongue. "I've been up for a while, but I called Bow
and Glimmer to catch up a little bit."

"Oh, I just bet you did." Mara taunts. Adora looks over to Catra, her shoulders are shaking with poorly suppressed laughter.

"Okay... So how are you two?" Adora asks slowly, trying to gauge what Mara knows. It's not like Adora wouldn't just tell her herself. But still…

"Oh, we're *great*." Mara smirks, nudging Catra's shoulder with her own. "The real question is; how are *you* Sparkles?"

Adora stands, patting Darla firmly on the back as she gets up. She gives Mara a look. "Alright, what the fuck?"

Mara blinks in false innocence. "Whatever to you mean Adora?"

Adora snorts, "You aren't slick Mara."

She resumes her smug expression. "Wasn't tryna be Dora."

Adora rolls her eyes. "Catra, anything to share with the class?"

Catra turns one of the burners down a touch and turns around. Her false innocent look is eerily similar to the one Mara just shot her. "Not that I can think of."

"You're a couple of brats is what you are." She points an accusing finger at both of them before throwing herself into a chair at the island, Darla coming to lay down under her. Catra and Mara just laugh at her.

"What?" Mara asks. "We were just catching up!"

"Hm, right, right. Any highlights?"

"*Well,* now that you mention it, I heard you went on a date and just *forgot* to mention it to your big sister. Just imagine *my* surprise!" She puts her hand on her heart, adopting over exaggerated scandalized expression.

Adora flushes, looking to Catra to gauge her reaction. She's just smirking at her; a little bit of tension she didn't realize she was carrying releases from Adora's shoulders. "Well, now that you mention it, yeah I did."

Mara's smile becomes a bit more genuine. "Oh?"

"Yeah, um, Catra took me to the movies the Saturday before we flew in."

"What did y'all see?" Adora can't quite figure out the look she and Catra share, but she's not sure she likes it. Especially since she can't remember the name of that stupid movie she barely watched.

"Uhm...that new animated thing?"

"Ah," there's that false innocence again. "I haven't heard of that one, what's it about?" She turns away for a moment to grab plates from the cupboard, which she passes to Catra. Catra begins loading them up and Adora's stomach rumbles again.

"Uh well...so there's this dragon."

"Uh-huh."

"Yeah and um, it's very good. You should see it!" She winces, hearing how ridiculous she sounds.

Catra spins on a dime, pointing at Adora with her spatula. "I *knew* you weren't paying attention! You're a terrible actor Princess, truly."

Mara laughs and slips off the counter. "She always has been, shoulda seen her as a kid! Good thing she was such a goody-goody, can't talk herself out of trouble to save her life."

"Hey!"

"What, am I wrong?"

"I'm just not sure I like this little… *alliance* you two seem to have going." She just gets laughed at again.

"Pfft." is all Mara says in response to that. "Alright, I'm gonna take syrup and shit to the table and clear a hole out."

"Sounds good." Catra tells her. "We'll be right behind you."

"Cool, thanks again for making breakfast Pal." She gathers toppings and one of the plates of food and slips out.

"Mara said something about coffee beans, I forgot I was gonna start another pot. You know where they might be?"

Adora cocks a hip, placing her hand there, and raises a brow. "So, you've been talking to my sister then."

For a second Catra looks uncertain but covers it quickly with a smirk. "What, you mean my friend Mara?"

Adora laughs openly and shakes her head. She nudges past Catra to dig up the coffee and get a pot going. "Yeah, her." Catra shrugs and leans against the counter by her.

"I mean, yeah. We got to talking."

"Uh-huh"…

"Is that-I hope I didn't overstep." The uncertain looks is back. "I just sort of came up and, well"…

"Catra, it's fine, really." She turns to give her a reassuring smile before tucking the beans away. "If you hadn't said anything, I probably would have told her in less time than it took you."

"Yeah?" Catra looks much more comfortable again.

Adora leans beside her on the counter. "Yeah. So, listen, I was thinking"…

"Did it hurt?" Catra snickers, Adora shuts her up with a light flick on the forehead.

"Well I wanted to test out Raz's recipe today, but later-well I know we talked about going out again when we get home." She pauses and Catra urges her on with a wide smile. "I just thought-maybe I owe you one. I could take you out tonight?" She fights the urge to look down at her bare feet.

Catra's expression and tone are both terribly soft. "Yeah, I'd really like that Dora."

"Great." Adora nods, turning to pull mugs out of the cabinet. She almost flinches at the tidal wave of stars that spills out when she opens the cabinet door.

After breakfast everyone heads upstairs to get cleaned up. They're taking a little field trip to a U-Pick orchard to get fruit for pie filling. They meet half an hour later in the entryway, Mara leading them to her car and setting them on course. It's just out of the city in the suburbs so it doesn't take too terribly long to get there. They pile out of the car and check in with the farmers before they're let loose in the orchard. Giggling, Mara leads Hope over to the small petting zoo on the property. Catra and Adora peel off to start walking through the trees.

"So," Catra begins, "Do we just start grabbing fruit?" She looks around at the trees, slowing her pace to do so. She swings the basket they'd grabbed to collect their apples in with a wide motion.

"Hm, in theory. But not these ones." At Catra's questioning look she explains. "They just don't feel right." It's basically true. She's trying to take Raz's advice; she's chasing the stars. When she was little, and they would forage for fruit, Raz always let Adora choose which ones to go for. Adora always looked for where the stars were most dense and started there. So, in an effort to honor Raz, she's trying her old strategy.

They walk another five minutes, the stars gradually starting to increase. "Seriously Princess, what are we looking for?"

Adora bites her lip. "Nothing, I mean apples." Catra stops short, Adora walks a couple more steps before she realizes then turns around. "What? Sorry, are you bored?"

Catra gives her a dubious look. "Remember what I said earlier, you're a terrible actor. I'm not bored, but you're definitely being weird."

"Rude." She reclaims her hold on her lip and stalks forward, hearing Catra catching up behind her. Then, four trees down, she finds it. The tree is radiating with stars. Nearly all of the fruits are *deep* red, and absolutely glittering. "*Oh* ."

Catra walks up next to her and looks up at the tree. "So, what makes this," She sets the basket on the ground and grabs an apple on an easily accessible branch, managing to pick the one glowing most brightly. The stars on it begin to multiply, dripping into the palm of her hand. She plucks it easily from the tree and offers it to Adora. "the *one*?

Adora takes it slowly, watching half of the stars slide from Catra's palm, into her own. Under her breath she whispers, "*holy stars* ."

She doesn't fully realize she's said it until Catra says, "Excuse me, *what* did you just say?" *Shit.*

Adora's head snaps up and she knows what her face must look like. She tries to school her expression, but it does her no good. "Oh, uh, nothing!"

"No, you did." Adora shakes her head and Catra looks—well Adora thinks she looks genuinely *annoyed*. Adora is surprised at the distinct lack of playfulness in her expression. "Adora, come on, just tell me; what did you just say?"

Adora stares at her, pleading her with her eyes to drop it. She doesn't know what she'll do if Catra brushes her off, assumes she's joking. Or worse. This is still new, still feels tenuous. Catra's expression makes her stance clear however; she is *not* dropping this. "Uh—holy stars?" *I can brush this off as a weird expression, right? Yeah, right. Maybe if you hadn't gotten all squirrelly about it. Seriously Adora, no chill!*

Catra looks like she's trying to figure her out. "Why, Adora, what aren't you saying?"

"Nothing!"

"*Adora!*"

"It's not a big deal."

"Could have fooled me." Catra scoffs.

"Why do you care so much? I just said a weird thing. It doesn't have to be a big deal."

"You're right." Adora dares to perk up. "It doesn't *have* to be, but it clearly *is.*" There it is. "Otherwise you wouldn't be so defensive right now!"

"I'm not defensive!"

"*Adora*, get real."

"Fine I just don't want to tell you!" *Fuck*. It comes out in a rush, before Adora can even think the words. She registers Catra's slightly wounded expression. "No, Catra, I didn't mean it like I… *want* to tell you."

"But?" Adora barely hears the word it's so quiet. She sighs, deflating a little.

"Can we sit?" She gestures to the tree. Catra looks at her suspiciously for half a second but nods. They sit at the base of the tree. When their backs knock against it stars rain down from the branches, settling into the grass and roots around them. Through the tension of the moment Adora notes how *stunning* they look, carpeting the ground like this, tumbling in the breeze.

"So?" Catra prompts after a minute.

"So." She sighs. "I'm not really sure where to start." Catra doesn't respond, just waits patiently and hugs her knees to her chest. "Well um, you know stars?"

Catra snorts. "Like do I know about stars? Yeah Princess, I'm familiar."

"Right, duh, sorry. So sometimes—well I can—" Adora huffs and runs a hand through her hair, mussing her ponytail. "See, it's like this; there's this weird thing that's happened, basically since I was a kid. Just minus a few years in the middle. That part isn't super important. I mean kind of, but not for the purpose of this explanation." She glances over to Catra briefly, she's resting her head on her knees and watching Adora. Her expression is relatively devoid of any emotion. "Sorry, the point. The point is I can kind of see stars."

"Okay I mean same Adora. I know I grew up in a city with hella light pollution, but I've seen them too."

"No, fuck, sorry no. I'm not explaining this right. So, sometimes if something, or someone is like, special or um, like significant somehow—well *then* I can see the stars. Not like, so not real stars. I mean maybe they're real. That's kind of a whole thing honestly, but yeah, we don't have to go there. Um, and they're just kind of this like, glowing light. Sometimes they're like pinpricks, other times it's star shapes or a mix. Usually a mix."

Catra has lifted her head and is staring at her knees with wide eyes. "So, when you said"…

"Yeah, uh, on the—on the apple. A lot actually. It's um—Razz said, so, that's what I was looking for." Adora waits for a reaction with bated breath.

Catra is quiet for a long minute. Then, at long last she lets loose a harsh, quiet, "*Fuck*." She turns to Adora, eyes still wide as saucers. "Adora, no fucking *way*. Are you telling me you can literally *see* stars? Like, all over; on stuff, on people, whatever?" Her tone is demanding. Adora, flushing deeply with dread and shame, just nods hesitantly. Then, more emphatically Catra insists, "No *fucking* way, Adora." Suddenly, seeming to notice Adora's reaction, she hastily

backpedals, her eyes popping even wider with panic. "*Shit*, no, Dora! I'm so sorry, I know, I—I believe you! I do, I'm just…"

Adora looks up, feeling her chest loosen ever so slightly. "You do?"

"*Yes*, oh my gosh, Adora, yeah of course I do!" Adora finally feels like she can breathe again. "Shit, I'm so sorry that—that wasn't cool. I um—okay, so this is really wild." Adora raises an eyebrow, how does Catra think she feels? "I know, I know. It's just, damn Dora, my- my Abuela, *she* and- oh *fuck* Adora when your granny said that- about there be-being galaxies inside of you and all that talk about the stars?" Adora nods, remembering. "Gods Dora, I thought it was some kind of *sign.* I mean, I figured it *must* be. And then last night… But I never imagined she meant *you*. I thought it was like, an expression or whatever. I never knew anyone but my Abuela… I—I'm just-" She takes a deep breath and huffs it out. "Sorry, I'm so sorry, I know I'm not making *any* sense. Okay, let me- is it okay if I start over?"

Adora, feeling totally lost, nods her head slowly. "Please do."

"So, okay, Adora it's so wild that-that you can see them be-because my Abuela, she could see them. She was always talking about the stars. When I was really little, she used to take care of me. And she used to always tell me; 'Catharina, even if you can't see the stars, *anyone* can feel them. Just follow the magic and you will follow the stars. And if you follow the stars then you will never be lost.' She said that to me, Adora she must have said that to me about a million times when I was little. And you—well now here you are!"

Both of their eyes have become wet with tears, neither one registering the moment they started crying. Catra turns to face her, she reaches over to dry her cheeks and Adora looks up at the stars in the tree while she does. The quantity has increased tenfold since they sat down. After she's finished Adora reaches over to return the favor. As she pulls her hands away to set them in her lap she says, "I had no idea. I mean no one else has ever… *wow*. Catra, this is… it's incredible! And you, you're—you're fucking unbelievable."

Catra laughs wetly. "Damn Adorable, talk about a *sign*, I mean"… Catra looks down and grabs both of her hands. Her eyes trail up Adora's arms, over her collar bones and back to her face, to her lips. "Adora can-can I-may I-" "

"*Please* ."Adora nearly begs. Almost immediately Catra' s lips are on hers and it's like nothing she's ever felt before, like nothing she's ever *seen* before. It' s not just *stars* and it isn't even just that this kiss exists inside of one. It' s as if as if the place where their lips meet is the sun, an entire *galaxy* erupting around them. More stars than they could count if they spent the rest of their lives together attempting to stretch out infinitely through the orchard. It' s breathtaking. *Oh maybe that' s just Catra,* Adora thinks somewhere in the back of her mind.

They pull apart, lips pink and tender, their eyes wide. "A-Adora!" Catra gasps. "Could you-did you *see* all of that?" Adora stares back at her, completely dazed. She manages a slow nod. "Does it-is it always like that?"

She blinks, looking at Catra in awe. "Literally never ."

"So that was just"…

"Us."Adora finishes for her . "That was just"She breaks the stare they've been holding feeling suddenly shy . She looks down at her feet. "That was the magic of us. Our energies combining, I think. Something like that."

Hardly a moment passes and Adora feels Catra' s fingers lift her chin until their gazes meet again. Mixed in with the total awe in Catra' s eyes is a hint of mischievousness. "You think if we kiss again, it'll happen a second time?"

It does, it *absolutely* does.

They stay under the tree wrapped up in each other long after, until they hear the sounds of people approaching. They pull apart, Adora's face flushing and a wide grin on her face. Catra is side eyeing her and smirking relentlessly. That's how Hope and Mara find them, having come looking for them once Hope was finally able to pull Mara away from the piglets.

"What have you too been up to then?" Mara asks with a knowing grin.

"Oh, uh, you know! Just apple picking." Adora explains, the overcompensation clear in her voice.

"Uh-huh." Mara says, looking unconvinced.

"Adora dear," Hope starts. "are you telling us that it has taken the both of you nearly an hour to pick a single apple?" Her lips quirk into the hint of a smirk.

"Uhm"…

Catra snorts. "Well it wouldn't have taken so long if Adora wasn't so stubborn." Adora hears the implied double meaning and turns to stick her tongue out at her. Catra just laughs and says with a smile, "You just gotta say what you want Princess."

Adora rolls her eyes and picks up the forgotten basket, dropping the apple Catra had picked into the bottom. She wanders a few steps away and starts picking apples without a word. The other women laugh and start lazily picking also, wandering over to drop their haul into the basket every so often. When Catra comes over she sneaks a kiss onto Adora's cheek. Adora makes no attempt to hide her massive smile.

They make it home in the early afternoon, Hope hassling Mara about letting her pregnant wife get hypoglycemia until she laughingly shoos

her into the living room to wait while she makes lunch. They eat sammies and melon on the patio, playing cards and laughing about nothing in particular. When they're done Catra and Adora leave the wives to sit in the sun, wandering inside to start their pies.

"Okay , so if you start peeling apples, Ican get everything out for the crust."Adora directs,

Catra smirks and gives a lazy salute, "Aye, aye Force Captain Adora."

Adora rolls her eyes fondly and hands her the peeler. She starts to wander away but Catra catches her wrist. When she turns around to see why Catra pulls her in for a quick peck on the lips, turning away nonchalantly to get started on her task. Adora has to shake off the haze it leaves her in before she can start her own. She pulls out ingredients and fetches the glass bowl she'd left in the freezer that morning.

She starts to measure out her flour when she remembers something. She digs in a cupboard and finds what she's looking for almost instantly. Sneaking up behind Catra she throws the goofy, frilly apron over her neck with a giggle. "The fuck *is* this thing?"Catra asks, plucking at a large frill.

She turns to face Adora who traps her between her own body and the counter, setting her hands on the ledge on either side of Catra and leaning in. She shrugs and, with a goofy smile, says, "I'm helping."

"Helping?"Catra says doubtfully .

"Uh-huh."

Catra smirks, giving Adora a once over that makes her whole body feel like it's flushing. "Sure you weren't just looking for an excuse to get up close and personal?"

"N-no." She blushes, pulling away ever so slightly . Catra grabs one of her belt loops and pulls her back in, even closer this time.

"Good." She leans forward and stands on her toes to whisper in Adora's ear. t makes her entire body shudder . "Cause you dont need an excuse Princess." She leans back and kisses Adora quickly on the tip of her nose. Then she turns back around and resumes peeling, Adora's arms still caging her in.

"Hey!" Adora pouts.

"Hm?"

"Catra!" She whines.

Catra looks over her shoulder briefly. "Can Ihelp you with something Princess?"

"I think you know the answer to that." Adora grumbles. Catra turns back around, still smirking.

"Hmnope." She pops the P . "Y oure gonna need to tell me what you need babe." They stare at each other , the kitchen clock marking the time with its soft, tictictic. "W ell?" Catra finally asks. "Did you need something, or can Iget back to my task?"

Adora rolls her eyes and, partly to shut Catra up and partly to satisfy her own desire, leans in to kiss her. Properly this timesuper properly. She groans when Catra catches her bottom lip between her teeth, Catra runs her tongue over the spot once and pulls back, smirking. "Hm, Ilike the way you think Greyson." Adora shakes her head at herherwell she supposes they havent really talked about what they are to each other yet. She shakes her head again to clear the thought. They've only been on one date. Adora can be patient, right?

"Alright, get back to work cadet, we've got a pie to make." Catra rolls her eyes but does as she's told without comment. Adora wanders

away to resume her own task. Hopefully all that heat hasn't warmed up the butter too much.

Before long the crust and the filling are both tucked into the fridge to rest. Hope and Mara are asleep on the couch, looks like they fell asleep in the middle of a movie, so Catra and Adora slip outside to sit on the porch swing. They get comfortable, Catra rests her head on Adora's shoulder. After a moment Adora rests her own head on top of Catra's. They sit there and swing quietly for a while. After a bit Catra whispers, "This is really nice."Adora hums her agreement, feeling like the luckiest woman in the world. They sit for about twenty minutes before Adora peeks at her watch.

"Hey, I'd still like to take you out if that's alright?"Catra lifts her head up and smiles, nodding. "Great! I just want to shower before we head out, I can't believe how much flour got in my hair."She laughs, running her fingers through it, effectively shaking loose a puff of flour and star dust.

"Okay, that sounds good. I might just chill here a little longer if that's cool?"

"Sure thing."Adora beams. "I'll be back soon."

She skips off and hurries through a shower, eager to get back to Catra. She hesitates when it comes to choosing clothes, she didn't exactly plan for a date. Inspiration strikes and she sneaks over to Mara's closet. Twenty minutes she ships down the stairs in her own jeans and a cute crop top of Mara's she had snagged. She has a light jacket thrown over her arm, and her damp hair is brushing across her neck and shoulders. She thinks, not for the first time, how nice an undercut would feel.

She walks past Hope on the couch, still curled up with a blanket thrown over her. Mara must be up. She walks out the back door to an interesting scene. Catra is on the swing where she had left her, but Mara is with her now, the latter looking awfully smug. Catra looks dazed and is flushing deeply. Adora's gait becomes a little less

hurried and when she gets closer her words are slow as she asks, "Hey Mara what did you do?"

Mara laughs clearly bemused about something. "Why do you think I did something?"

Adora points at Catra, "*I* cant even make Catra blush like that."

"*Oh Goddess!*" Catra turns her head to look up at the sky , as if praying to any deity that might help her.

"Oh, Ibet you can Squirt."

"What does *that* mean?" Adora asks, baf fled.

Mara smirks, "It means youre way more powerful than you know kid."

"*Mara!* For fucks sake!" Catra grumbles, snapping her head to look at Mara. "Y oure incorrigible." She clearly takes that as a compliment, at least if her preening is anything to go by.

"*Okay* well Idont know what *this* is, but Im gonna roll that pie out. And then Catra we can go after that." Mara, Ican still borrow the Jeep, right?"

"Sure, sure, just dont do anything Iwouldnt do."

"Pf ft." Catra scof fs. "Idont get the impression that guideline is very limiting."

Mara just winks in response. Adora rolls her eyes at the pair of them and walks toward the kitchen. She's rolling out the crust, Darla snuffling around to look for scraps on the floor by her feet, when Catra joins her . "Hey Princess, how' s the pie?"

Adora arches an eyebrow. "Pie is greathow are *you*?

Catra blushes but shrugs nonchalantly as she flops into a chair. "Fine, chill."

"Oh yeah? What were you and Mara talking about?"

Catra shuffles around for a moment, then stills and looks up to stare Adora dead in the eye. "You mostly."

It's Adora's turn to blush. She manages to stutter out, "O-oh." Catra smirks at her. "Cool, cool, cool. Um, wanna get the filling out?" They made a double batch and Adora has two pie dishes lined. They get the filling in and Adora lays a lattice, alternating thick and thin strips. She throws together a couple pastry roses and wipes her hand clean She looks up to Catra and pauses when she sees Catra's expression.

"You just did that *so* fast."

"Uh? Oh, yeah, lots of practice." Adora shrugs nonchalantly .

"Right." Catra answers. "Well, are we ready to boogie?"

"Yeah! Oh, I'm excited." She leads Catra out to the car , giving Mara and Hope a wave on their way out the door . "Okay , so I was thinking; there's a few places we can get takeout from and we then can take it to the park? After we eat I can take you to the arcade, kick your ass a little bit. You know, to impress you." She buckles her seatbelt and turns to smirk at Catra, who's laughing at her.

"Ooh, big talk Princess. Careful you don't underestimate your opponent. Or do, it would work in my favor now that I think about it."

"Hm, I'm not worried. Here," Adora passes Catra her phone. "You can put something on if you want." Catra choses her Drive' playlist and they settle into a comfortable silence, listening to the music.

The decide on Mediterranean food and find their way to a picnic table in the park after swing by to pick up food. They're situated by

the shore of the lake which is covered in water lilies, a weeping willow brushing the edge of the table.

"Damn Dora, this is beautiful." Catra looks around at the water and the rest of the park.

"Yeah, I used to come here a lot. I'd read or work on art, it's usually where I came for alone time. Mara's and my place was pretty cramped so it was nice to get out in the open. We got the same thing, right?"

"Sure did." Catra reaches over for her falafel and fries and they tuck right in.

Adora wolfs hers down pretty quick. When she's down to the last of her fries, she watches Catra unnoticed for a minute, gulping down water from the bottle she'd brought along. "Hey Catra?"

She looks up, grinning, and says back, "*Hey* Adora."

Adora can't begin to understand why just that makes her blush, but she feels the heat creeping up her neck nevertheless. "I just wanted to say... well I'm sorry I made it weird. When we... went out. Before."

Catra snickers. "You mean on our first date?"

Now Adora's face really burns. "I mean... yeah."

Catra leans down to catch Adora's eye. "Dora it's really okay." Adora bites her lip, not fully convinced, and Catra runs a hand down her own face. "I was definitely confused but I realized in hindsight I could have been clearer about my intentions."

Adora nods her head side to side. "Yeah that makes sense, I'm sorry I was confusing. If it helps, I was confused too. You *did* say it was a plan."

Catra furrows her brow in confusion. "What are you talking about?"

"When we were texting." She prompts, Catra still looks confused. "You know, about our plans?" Nothing. "Catra we decided on the time and stuff and you said, *it's a plan.* And a *plan* is not a *date*."

Catra's expression clears with understanding for a moment, and then she busts out laughing. "I'm sorry, *that's* why you were being so weird?"

Adora shifts awkwardly on the bench. "I mean, yeah, but not just that."

"What do you mean, what else?" Catra's tone shifts to something a little more serious.

"Well, when you said that I was already feeling uncertain."

"Why?"

"What?"

"Like, what about the way I asked you out was unclear? I mean, when I asked you if you wanted to get dinner and a movie I kind of thought the intention was implied."

"I-you said, 'we should do this thing sometime.' I don't know, it sounded casual!" She tries not to be too defensive; she isn't sure how successful she is. "And Bow and Glimmer kept saying it was but I was-I just didn't want to be *that guy* you know?"

"Uh, what guy?"

"You know, the person who like, makes it weird by assuming what they want to be true. And then it either makes things really awkward or it's like, really fucking embarrassing. I don't know, I don't like to assume."

Catra considers her for a moment. "Can I ask you something?"

"Uh, yeah?"

"Were you flirting with me?"

"Flirting, when?"

Catra makes a vague hand gesture. "All of it, I don't know, at any point I guess."

Adora is sure her face can't possibly get hotter than it is now, she could surely burst into flames at any moment. "Uh"…

"Adora, we're literally *on a date*, there's no wrong answer. This isn't a trick question."

"I think so?" Catra gives her a dubious look. "I don't know! Probably. I'm not really good at the whole, flirting thing. But I like you, and I like hanging around with you, and I like it when you tease me. Is that flirting?"

"You like it when I tease you?" Catra looks *way* too pleased with herself. Adora rolls her eyes.

It's a snap decision to be this honest, it's barely a decision at all. In fact, she doesn't even think the words to acknowledge their sincerity until they're out of her mouth. "I like when you pay me attention. And I think you're really funny." Her voice is small, almost inaudible, but Catra's expression confirms clearly that she heard it.

"Well that works out great Princess, because I like paying you attention. And I think you're really funny too. And smart, endearing, talented, a total dork, not to mention completely *adorable*." She winks and Adora's heart stops.

"Cool, cool, cool. Chill, so chill."

"Hm, chill? You think?" Catra asks, and Adora can already tell she's about to say something either sassy or provocative. "I thought it was pretty hot.

And that is how Adora Stella Grayson died.

…

Okay, so she didn't die. But she swears she *could* have died in that moment. She's so flustered she barely remembers anything other than Catra's shit eating grin from their walk back to the car. Or the drive over to the arcade for that matter. But competition? *This* she can handle; familiar territory *and* home field advantage? *Bring it on.* She holds the door for Catra and follows her in, the atmosphere feels instantly familiar. The first room is lit primarily with blacklights and lava lamps, and there are glow in the dark stars *everywhere.* Adora really loves this place. She came here a lot a just a few years back, the stars a familiar motif at a time when she thought her own were gone forever. Coming back is magical. Stars surround the stars on the wall and more stars surround those stars. She watches her stars begin to gravitate toward her and Catra.

"So, what do you think?"

"Adorable, this place is groovy as hell. I'm curious, is this place just stars on stars on stars for you?" Adora laughs, having just noticed that.

"Well." She gets a sneaky idea and peeks around the room. Seeing that no one is paying them any mind she darts in to give Catra a firm kiss. Naturally the stars explode; the stars surrounding the stars surrounding the stars burst into tiny little milky ways. It's totally new, unlike every other kiss they've shared so far and certainly beyond anything she's seen before. She pulls away and smirks at the dazed look on Catra's face. "You tell me."

Catra blinks twice, presumably to clear her head of the haze she's in. "Oh, you think you're *so smooth* Greyson."

"Am I not?"

Catra looks her up and down. "Try's still out. Why don't you buy me a drink and blow me away with your sick air hockey skills? Then we can talk."

"I mean I'm more of a pinball girl, but sure, I can beat you at air hockey too if you want."

She does *not* beat Catra at air hockey. To be fair Catra plays dirty, using her wiles to distract Adora every time she tries to take a shot. She claims it's not against the rules and thus doesn't make any of her victories less valid. Adora gives it to her, especially since she *more* than makes up for her losses when they switch to pinball.

About an hour in Catra nudges her in the side. "Hey, you know what I'm thinking about?"

Adora rolls her eyes. "Is it something dirty?"

"What? No, get your mind out of the gutter Grayson."

Adora blushes, "Fuck, right, sorry."

Catra rolls her eyes and steps dangerously close, she runs a finger down Adora's chest, making her gulp and leaving a trail of stars in its wake. "You don't have to apologize Dora, it's okay if you…*want* me."

Adora releases a shaky breath, unsure how she's survived the night. Especially now that's she's heard Catra say…*that* in her low, raspy voice. "Ri-right. Okay, um, thanks." Catra chuckles and steps back much to Adora's combined relief and displeasure. "What um, were you gonna say? Before?"

"Before you came onto me you mean?"

"I did not! If anything, *you* came onto *me*!"

"Hm, not how I remember it. But to answer your *question*, I'm thinking about that pie back at the house."

Adora's eyes grow wide with hunger. "Fuck, that sounds good. I'll text Mara and tell her to preheat the oven." She whips out her phone to do so and almost immediately gets back a long string of thumbs up emojs.

Then, Hope wants ice cream 2 plz'
Srry , she said to say THE BABY wants ice cream'
So'
Baby is in charge apparently'
OMG HRR YOME'
Im under attack'
Can u get brain damage from getting hit w/pillows?

Adora laughs shaking her head, she turns her phone to show Catra, who snickers. "Want to head out then?" Catra nods and they make their way to the door, giving polite thank you's to the employee at the bar as they walk out. Adora jogs around to hold Catra's door for her. She moves to get in but pauses, turning back toward Adora.

She stares into Adora's eyes intently for a long minute. "Hey , thanks for taking me out. I had a nice time."

Adora smiles back softly. "Yeah, me too." Catra nods and turns around again to hop in the car. Their extra stop doesn't take long at all and soon enough Adora is sliding a beautifully golden-brown pie out of the oven. They decide to eat it on the patio so Adora plates up and she and Catra each grab two, heading out back. Hope is settled in and Mara is lighting the last couple of citronella candles scattered around.

"Damn Squirt, that smells good as hell." Mara finishes her task quickly and joins them at the table.

"Truly Adora, it looks wonderful, thank you." Hope smiles warmly at her.

She feels Catra squeeze her leg under the table. "Oh, it's no big deal, please, dig in."

They all do as they're told with no hesitation, except Adora. She stares at her plate for a minute longer, not hearing the sounds of pleasure coming from the other women. Will it be like she

remembers, or has she just been building it up all this time? She takes a bite.

The swarm of stars and memories is dizzying, Adora nearly feels drunk on it. She excuses herself from the table, ignoring the expressions of concern she receives. She stumbles her way into a chair in the kitchen, laying her cheek down on the cool stone countertop. She takes deep, soothing breaths but it's not enough to stop the storm of tears and accompanying sobs that wrack her body. Before long she feels another presence in the room. Mara sidles up next to her and rubs soothing circles into her back.

Eventually Adora calms and sits up. "Sorry , sorry I know I'm being silly. It' s just pie for heaven' s sake."

Mara looks at her seriously. "It isn't though, is it?"

A few more tears escape and Adore shakes her head. "It' s I'm not even upset just overwhelmed. It was like I'm experiencing every powerful emotion I felt from ages four to ten."

Mara blinks, taken aback. "Yeah, well that sounds like a lot kid. How ya feeling now?"

Adora pauses and takes stock. "Better , I just wasn't expecting I… mean I was worried I'd just built the whole thing up in my mind but, well I guess not." She and Mara both chuckle.

"You wanna come back out or?…"

Adora nods so Mara leads her out back. Catra and Hope have started a conversation about some nature documentary they've both seen and fold Mara and Adora seamlessly into the conversation upon their return. The only acknowledgement of her disappearance is Catra's hand on her knee, her thumb rubbing soothing circles on the side of it.

Once everyone's eyes start drooping, they deposit dishes in the sink and head upstairs. Catra and Adora talk about plans for the following day while they brush their teeth. Adora wants to take the second pie to the home for Razin the afternoon. Other than that, the plan is really just to hang at the house with Hope and Mara. Soon they're climbing into bed, laying on their sides facing each other.

Catra reaches over to tuck some stray hairs behind Adora's ear. "How ya feeling Dora?"

Adora smiles. "Really good, tired though."

"Makes sense, big day."

"Yeah." Adora nods in agreement. "I thank you."

"For what? You're the one who took me out, showed me your stars." Catra leans over to kiss her softly on the cheek, Adora raises her hand to the spot after she pulls away, as if to hold the kiss there longer.

"Yeah, well thanks for wanting to go. And with the stars well gods Catra I cant even begin to express"…

"I know." Catra takes peels Adora's hand from where it still rests on her cheek to hold it in her own. Adora notices the stars that linger on her finger tips, watches the way they lace themselves between their intertwined fingers. "I get it, I do."

Adora leans forward to kiss her, falling deeper and deeper into the cosmos with Catra as their bodies shift closer and closer together. Catra's hand comes up to cradle her face and she wraps her arm around Catra's waist. They only pull apart when it becomes a matter of necessity, both of them catching their breath. "Wow." Adora breathes. Catra rolls her eyes, shaking her head fondly.

"No kidding. Alright Adorable, I gotta sleep." She pokes her shoulder. "Turn over." Adora quirks an eyebrow but does as she's told. Her

silent question is answered not a moment later when Catra snuggles forward to spoon her. Adora's legs stretch far past Catra's but the position makes her feel small;vulnerable and cared for . They fall asleep that way, stars raining down from the ceiling and pooling in the sheets around them.

Chapter End Notes

Whew this chapter felt like a marathon, so many fun parts to write!
Couple notes here:
First, Iwrote a lil companion one shot to this piece. It's several conversations with different characters from Catra's perspective. It just needs to be edited so Ishould have it up tomorrow . (Technically later today Iguess?) It will be part of the Starry Eyed series which Ijust created and added this work to. Keep an eye out if you're interested!:)
Second, so this story has started to move in a somewhat *steamier* direction than Iinitially anticipated. Ive considered bumping up the spice level, and the rating with it. Ive also considered posting another companion piece and putting the spicier bits there. Ithink the former might flow well but Idid start this as teen and up so Iwanna keep that in consideration. If anyone has thoughts/feelings Id be curious to know!

Thanks again for your time spent reading, and to everyone who's kudosed/commented/bookmarked this story. **I am feeling the love!**

Bring Me Home

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The rest of the week flies by. They bring Razher pie the following day, to her utter delight. And though she calls Adora 'Mara' the whole time, and calls Catra 'you, girl!', they have a good time. Adora decides to go by herself the last time she makes it to the home. Raz is pretty out of it that day but before Adora leaves her eyes clear.

"Oh, my Adora." She says. "I hope you remember the magic will never disappear. Not yours, not mine. It *grows* dearie, every day. Don't try so hard to hold onto it, huh? Focus on making more." Adora spends twenty minutes in the deep crying after she leaves, realizing that might be the last words her Granny ever says to her face.

Now she, Mara, Hope, and Catra are gathered around the dinner table, sharing a last meal before Adora and Catra fly out in the morning. It's somber as it is joyful. "So," Catra begins as she passes a basket of rolls to Hope. "How often do you two make it to Eternia? I mean I know this is Adora's first time back here but, it's not the first time y'all have seen each other in person since then, is it?"

"Oh *gods* no." Mara responds, horrified. "No, we went for the holidays the first year Adora was there, and I've been back a couple times since. Definitely not as much as I'd like but." She shrugs.

"I'll probably be us coming back here again next time though." Adora supplies nonchalantly, shoving a massive bite of spaghetti into her mouth.

"Us?" Catra asks, amused. Adora is absorbed in her pasta and doesn't catch the round of snickering being sent her way.

"Well, yeah. I mean, hope, you probably don't want to be flying. Then when the baby comes… Well, *I* certainly wouldn't want to be taking a baby on a flight." She shivers dramatically, finally looking up. "What? What did I say?"

"Well, you certainly have a point Adora dear but, ah," Hope sets a soothing hand on Adora's where it rests on the table.

"But what?" She looks to Catra and Mara who are doing a poor job of containing their laughter. "What did I say?"

"Oh Sparkle…"

"*But*," Catra says. "Just make sure you give me a little forewarning before you book that flight Princess. Can't just leave the Plumeria crew high and dry."

Adora frowns, not catching her meaning. Then she thinks back over what she said and blushes. "Oh, right… sorry, no. I didn't mean- I just meant." She shoves another massive bite of noodles into her mouth to avoid continuing.

"Hey." Catra calls from across the table. Adora looks up and Catra just smiles and winks at her. Adora immediately looks back down at her food, smiling wide and blushing.

The rest of dinner goes along without incident, mostly they talk about the baby. The third bedroom has been emptied for weeks now but all they have in there is a crib so far. Apparently, Mara is ready to *nest*, she pulls out a massive booklet of paint chips to show Catra and Adora the dozens of colors she's considering. They're all yellow and green and Adora can see the moment Catra's eyes glaze over, no longer to discern the differences between shades.

When Hope finally convinces her to "put the infernal toy *away*," they clear the table and try to decide how to round out their evening. They're talking about maybe playing a game, or watching a movie when Mara cuts in.

"Hey Squirt, mind if I actually steal you for a little bit of sister time?"

"Yeah, of course Mara." While Adora certainly doesn't miss the weird look Mara and Catra share as they leave the kitchen and walk out to the patio, she ignores it. They head out back and get situated on the swinging bench a little further into the garden. The spot has a beautiful view, Adora watches the flowers and stars sway in the breeze.

"You wanna smoke?" Mara asks, producing a joint from seemingly nowhere.

"Oh, sure. Thanks Mar." She gets the feeling that a little weed is going to make whatever conversation Mara is about to incite a little easier. She can't remember the last time she saw her sister so… fidgety. She lights up and they pass it back and forth for a little bit, both staring off into the garden.

"Adora, I wanted to talk to you about something, before you go." Mara's voice breaks her reverie and she looks at her carefully.

Adora glances at her, a single brow lifted. "What's up?"

"Do you do you remember when you were younger, and you used to talk about seeing stars everywhere?" Adora freezes for a moment, then nods tightly. Mara nods back. "Yeah, you loved them so much. I remember when you were like, eleven, we were at the river and you got all excited, said there was this huge shooting star. You ran straight into the river." Mara laughs. Adora thinks she knows where this is going, but she doesn't stop Mara from telling the story. "Your shoes got soaked, oh your care giver was *so mad* when I brought you home that night. But you didn't care, just chased this damn thing like your life depended on it. So, finally I catch up to you and you're staring at this *massive* dragonfly that landed on a rock.

"I remember I asked you, I thought you were chasing a star?" I kind of teasing you, which of course you didn't even notice. You nodded your head; you know that enthusiastic way kids do? And you told

me, "The stars are how you find the magic Mara." Mara's eyes have grown damp and Adora realizes hers have too. "Goddess, I'll never forget the way you said it too. Like; how did I not know that?" She forces a breath through her lips, ruffling her bangs, and looks off into the distance. "I think I fucked up Squirt."

Adora jumps in surprise and turns to look at her sister, hesitantly accepting their pin back from her. "What? Mara, no"…

"Nah, come on kid, I did. Let me try and make amends, yeah?" She looks at Adora imploringly, she nods silently back and tries to swallow the emotion lodged in her throat. "I shouldn't have taken that away from you, the magic I mean. You just, you got to your teens and you were still talking about them and, Adora I thought I was *protecting* you. But I was wrong. I lost my faith in magic, and the world told me it wasn't loss; I was gaining wisdom. I've done a lot of unpacking of my own, especially since I met Hope. I realize I see now that was harm done to me which I turned around and did to you. Hm. I'm so sorry Adora. I trusted my own disillusionment more than I trusted you and it was so much less than you deserved."

Mara wipes at her eyes and turns to face her, one leg crossed perpendicularly on the bench. "Adora, do you still see them?" The openness and vulnerability in Mara's eyes as she looks at her breaks Adora down into sobs. She didn't know, never could have prepared for this conversation. Mara scoots closer and rubs soothing circles into her back, waiting patiently until Adora wears herself out.

Adora takes a moment to compose herself, taking a few deep breaths and wiping at her face. "I do, yeah." She nods, and notices that Mara has been crying too. She sees a few dried tear tracks left on her cheeks. "I still see them. But I- well, do you remember picking me up at Bardak's? The day of my hearing."

Mara rolls her eyes. Right, of course she does. "Duh, of course I do."

Adora nods, collecting her thoughts. "That was the last time for, for a while. And then I met Glimmer, and there they were again." She

laughs, "I thought I was losing it. Then I met Bow and that was the second time. It was really sporadic for a while. I didn't believe in… The stars… herself? Um and then a few months ago they sort of… started becoming more and more common, more like when I was a kid."

Mara hums, "Around the time you met Catra? Do you think she's…?"

Adora shrugs, "Partly, yeah. The café though, gods Mara I can't wait to take you. They all love it so much; Catra, Perfuma, and Scorpia too. I mean, you tried those cookies."

Mara's expression melts. "Fuck yeah I tried those cookies. Stars."

Adora nods, "On *everything* Scorpia makes."

"Hm, well that shit was *def initely* magic." Adora laughs as Mara absentmindedly rubs her belly.

"So yeah, I think all three of them were part of it. Catra probably a little more so. And just… I don't know. I feel like meeting Catra and talking with Bow and Glimmer about some stuff, moving into the new place, it just, all of it made it easier to… feel my feelings or whatever. And like, *relax* and just be for a second."

"Uh, do you think that being present in the moment has something to do with it?"

Adora considers that. "Honestly, maybe. I haven't really thought about it like that before but it… tracks." They sit silently for a little while, looking out at the garden again, Mara slings her arm across the back of the bench behind Adora. After a little while Adora clears her throat and asks the question nagging at her brain. The one that could make or break her. "So, you… you believe me? You don't think I'm… know, whatever?"

Mara turns back to her; her face is a melting pot of emotion, it's tender. "*Yes* Adora, I believe you. From now on I commit to trusting

you Adora.”She holds her hand. “I love you so much Squirt, and you've done *everything* to deserve that trust.”They both let a few more tears escape. Mara considers her for a moment. “Can I tell you something?”

“Please.”

“I've never lost anything, not in my whole life.”

“What?”Adora laughs. “Is that true?”

Mara nods earnestly, relighting the joint they had let go out. “Not once. You know I really do think there's magic in all of us, at least a little bit. That little bit of *something* the universe gives us. I think sometimes you just have to look a bit harder for it. And I think the stars make you really good at finding it. Which is so *powerful* Adora.”

Adora digests that for a moment. She laughs at a memory. “You know you did always have an uncanny knack for finding things. You remember that stuffy I lost on that fieldtrip? The Pegasus.”

“Ugh, *Swift Wind*. Yeah, I also remember combing that damn park to find him when you lost him. Worth it though, I honestly don't think you've ever loved me more than when I brought him back to you.”

Adora laughs, “You're probably not wrong.”

“Whatever happened to him anyway?”

Adora shrugs. “He's home now, keeping my bed safe and warm.”

“Of course, he is.”Mara smiles warmly. “Hey Squirt?”

“Yeah Mar?”

“I fucking love you, you know?”

“Yeah, I love you too Mara.”She smiles back, her grin a mile wide.

They hug tightly and when they pull back after a minute Mara looks her in the eye and asks, "You can see them now, can't you?"

Adora startles, she could, they were *everywhere* in that moment, the very air made up of star dust. She's surprised Mara can tell. "I mean, yeah."

Mara nods, "Yeah, I remember that look from when you were a kid." She reaches a hand to Adora's knee and gives it a squeeze. "It's *really* good to see it again. You look *happy*."

And Adora *is* happy, incandescently happy.

By the time Mara and Adora head back inside most of the lights are flipped off and it looks like Catra and Hope have gone upstairs. They head in that direction and part ways with a goodnight, Mara double checking what time they need to leave for the airport. Adora brushes her teeth and slips quietly into the bedroom. Catra is still awake, sitting up under the covers with only her side table lamp on, flipping through her phone.

She looks up and smiles when Adora walks in. "Hey Adora."

Adora closes the door behind her and leans against it. She's happy, but she feels loops from the pot and the exhaustion; she's nearly spent emotionally. "Hi, you look *cozy*."

She lifts a brow in challenge. "Well why don't you come find out how cozy it is for yourself?"

Adora blushes lightly and Catra smirks at her. "Right, yeah. I just gotta, jammies."

"Right." Catra says looking back at her phone. "I won't look if you wanna just change in here."

She says it breezy and casual as can be. Adora can tell she has no idea how the words make her implode. She doesn't even look up until Adora squeaks out, "Oh, um, that's okay." Her hands shake a little bit and she fumbles with her bag. Popping out the door, she ignores the weird look Catra gives her. She changes in the bathroom, taking deep breaths as she does so. She knows she's overreacting, it's so not a big deal. But they kissed so eventually they'll probably do, y'know, other stuff.

The thought makes her mortified at the same times it lights her up, making her limbs tingle. She shakes her head, trying to clear the thoughts attempting to drag her mind directly into the gutter. They're about to share a bed for goodness sakes! Adora needs to chill. The thought doesn't help her any. It's not like she thinks they're gonna get busy in Mara's guest bed. But at what point will Catra expect that to be on the table? Or will she even want that with Adora? Adora isn't totally blind, she knows it's probable that Catra's mind will eventually go there, if it hasn't already. She just doesn't want to assume, doesn't want to expect anything.

Adora can go with the flow. Adora is chill. It becomes her mantra, and she marches back to the bedroom. She startles Catra, making more of a ruckus than necessary when she comes back in the room. "Nice jammies." Catra compliments with a smirk, giving her a once over. Adora swears even her *knees* must be blushing.

"Thanks." She responds, glancing down at herself. She walks slowly toward the bed and crawls in, turning on her side to face Catra.

"How was your time with Mara?" Catra asks, setting her phone to the side.

"It was." Adora takes and lets out a big breath. "Really good. Healing, I guess."

Catra raises her eyebrows. "Oh yeah?"

"Yeah, she, you didn't happen to mention the stars, did you?"

Catra tenses and looks suddenly abashed. "Uh, yeah sorry , I did. I didn't realize it was after the orchard and she asked what I was thinking about. It didn't even occur to me that she might not…"

"It's fine Catra, really." She gives her a reassuring smile and Catra relaxes. "I honestly probably owe you a thank you. I don't know if we would have talked, ever , if you hadn't said something to her ."

"So, it really was good then."

"*Yeah*, it's hard for me to admit that Mara's ever done anything wrong but she did really hurt me. I was already so alone, already felt like no matter how loud I was or how well I behaved no one was listening to me or-or believing in me." She takes a breath and Catra slides further into the bed, lying on her side and holding on of her hands. "I mean," She laughs. "I'm sure part of that was being a teenager but."

"Come on Princess, give yourself some credit. It's not like life was a walk in the park for you then."

"Well yeah. I guess, but either way it did hurt, and I'd forgiven that and let it go but… it felt weird, y know , to have them come back and feel like I couldn't tell Mara. It was beyond amazing to hear her tell me she believes me."

"I'm happy for you Dora." She looks it too, all wide smile and tender eyes.

"Thanks, me too." They lay there for a few minutes more, hands and fingers and forearms intertwined. "How are you feeling? Ready to be home?"

Catra hums. "Yeah, I think so. I definitely miss my cat."

"Oh my gosh that video Scorpia sent you yesterday! Can we watch it again?" Adora feels a light second wind perking her up.

"What?" Catra laughs. "Right now?" Adora nods eagerly and, looking pleased despite her griping, Catra pulls up the video. She looks over at Adora and considers her for a moment. "SO exactly how stoned did Mara get you?"

Adora laughs suddenly. "I mean not that much? I just feel a little… floaty."

Catra smiles back at her. "Alright Princess. Y ou ready for this?" And Adora's answering nod she plays the video. They watch Melog stalking a string stuck to Perfuma's foot, Perfuma totally unaware of the attention, or the string for that matter. Then Melog scares her half to death when they pounce. Adora laughs just as hard as she did the first time she saw it.

"So." Catra gives her a questioning glance before turning away to set her phone aside again. "Melog seems pretty cute…"

"I mean, yeah, I think so." Catra gives her a strange look. Adora huffs.

"Catra." She knows she' s whining but she doesnt care, not even a little bit.

"What Princess? I really don't know what you're getting at here."

"I wanna meet them." Adora mumbles.

Catra looks like she's straining to hear her, taking an extra couple beats to register the words. When she does, she laughs loudly. "Oh, you mean you're trying to invite yourself over to my place."

"No!" Adora cries indignantly .

"Uh-huh, sure, sure. W ell I mean, that' s where they live so…"

"What, am I not allowed in your home or something?"

"Pf ft, I never said that."

Adora rolls her eyes. "Whatever . Why dont you just give Melog my number and we can make plans ourselves."

Catra gasps, a faux scandalized expression on her face, and puts a hand over her heart. "Why *Adora* !You would hang out with my own cat without me?"

"Mm-hmm, tell them Ill be expecting their call."

"Ooh."Catra sucks a breath in between her teeth. "Yeah, one problem. Ithink Ilost your number ."

"Oh my stars, you little brat!"Adora giggles, pushing Catra's shoulder. "You did not."

"Oh, but Ithink Idid."Adora pokes Catra in the side and she lets out a little yelp. Adora starts and before she can form a single thought Catra sticks a finger in her face. "Do not. Dont even think about it. Im not ticklish. *Adora* Im warning you."

Adora is grinning evilly. "Aw, Catra, youre ticklish?That's so…*cute*." And this that she pounces, poking at any part of Catra's sides and stomach that she can reach. Catra laughs, barely able to pull in air, and does her best to defend against Adora's attacks.

"*Iamot cute!* "She finally manages to shriek. Adora freezes, leaving her hands where they are;one propping her up on the bed next to Catra's waist, so she's leaning over her slightly, and the other resting gently on Catra's stomach. She lets the second hand slide down so she's cupping Catra's waist slightly. She notices how very soft and warm the spot is and hears Catra's breath hitch.

"Are so."She was going for sassy but thinks her voice is too breathy to pull it off. Not that she'd admit that. Catra just rolls her eyes and tugs her down by the collar of her shirt. Her arm gives out from under her and she lands on Catra with an, "Oomph!"

"Ugh, *Adora!* You're crushing my fucking diaphragm." Adora scrambles to push herself up so she's no longer crushing her.

"Sorry! Wait! No, I'm not, you pulled *me* down." She laughs, sticking her tongue out at Catra.

"Huh, funny, that's not how I remember it."

It's Adora's turn to roll her eyes and she moves fully off Catra, crossing her legs and facing her sideways on the bed. "How convenient." Catra sits up also, leaning back against the headboard and shrugs. Her expression morphs into something slightly more vulnerable.

"Hey." Adora lifts her eyebrows in acknowledgment. "When we're homey, you *should* come over, meet Melog, see my place."

Adora smiles wide. "I'd like that."

"Good then." Adora nods in agreement. They sit quietly for a couple minute, neither making any moves to retire fully for the night.

Then, Adora gasps out of nowhere making Catra jump. "Oh no, Catra!"

"*What?* Goddess Adora, you about gave me a heart attack."

"Shit, Catra we're getting back on twenty-*sixth*." Adora moans.

"Uh, yeah, tomorrow. I'm aware. What is wrong with you?"

"That's only four days before the end of the month!"

"So what?" Catra grumbles, frustrated at not being looped in on the source of Adora's freak out.

"So that's not enough time! Fuck, I should have thought about this sooner. I was so distracted and- Still, it's no excuse. I don't want to leave you and Perfuma in the well it doesn't matter. Even if I

wanted to there's still not enough *time*, and I'm not sure that *I'm* ready! I mean I said I would, well *Catra* said, but I didn't- "

"Adora!" Catra snaps, putting a hand on each of Adora's shoulders and forcing eye contact. "What the *f uck* are you going on about?"

She flounders, locked in by Catra's eyes but frozen by guilt. After a few prolonged seconds of opening and closing her mouth she groans. "The showcase thing! I didn't get *anything* ready. I didn't even *think* about it after our date and Mara's call. Ugh, I'm so stupid! I'm so sorry . Is this gonna put you and Perfuma in a tough position?"

Catra just rolls her eyes and falls back against the headboard. "Really Adorable, that's what's got you in a tizzy?" Adora bites her lip and nods guiltily. "Well chill, no one expected you to get something like that together with everything you have going on."

"Re-really?" Adora ventures cautiously .

"What the fuck do you- *of course* really! Adora seriously , it's fine. Perfuma said she'd deal with it. Honestly she'll probably just have Lonnie ask her cousin if they don't mind leaving their stuff up longer." She shrugs and watches Adora visible deflate. "Adora babe, come here." She pulls Adora so she's sitting across her lap and wraps her arms around her. Her right thumb rubs circles into her shoulder .

"Sorry I- y'all have been so good to me I didn't want." She sighs.

"I appreciate that Princess, but we've got your back. And if you wanna do it when we're home, we can get your stuff together and figure out the timing."

"Oh, well I don't I mean I wasn't really even it's okay if it doesn't work out."

Catra squeezes her once. "You never told Sparkles you wanted to do the showcase, did you?"

"Uhnot exactly ."

"Uh-huh, Ifigured. Sowhat was Glitter covering up for?" Adora blushes. "Adora"…

"t' s nothing, she and Bow were just trying to rile me up. Embarrass me aboutuh, well, you. So."

Catra tips her head back and laughs. "Oh yeah? Y ou like me or something Princess?"

"Psh!" Adora wiggles her way out of Catra' s arms, smirking at the fake pout she gets in response. "I do *not* like you."

"Hm, what a shame. Guess that means you dont wanna share this big, comfy bed with me tonight." Catra flops down, splaying her limbs as far across the bed as they can reach, her left arm nearly smacking Adora in the face. "Shame. Enjoy the couch though, truly ." She closes her eyes and pretends to be drifting off. "*Hey!* "She snaps, bolting upright when Adora smacks her face with a pillow.

Before she can grab one of her own Adora climbs on top of her torso and pins her arms to the bed. "Hm, Idont think so."

"Hey , *get of f* of me!" Catra grunts out, punctuating her words by bucking her hips. Adora bites her lip and does her best to ignore the way the motion makes her insides flip. She's on a mission here.

"No." Adora answers simply .

"Y oure the worst." Catra supplies, giving up her wriggling. She doesnt exactly look miserable.

"Nah, Ithink you like me."

"I do not!"

"Y ou so do." Adora taunts.

"Gross."

"Hm, sorry but I'm actually gonna need you to admit that you like me." Catra gives her a look that just screams 'as if'. She's undeterred. "Otherwise I'm just gonna have to stay here, on top of you, all night long." She enunciates the last words, but she can tell it's about to backfire before she's even finished because Catra's expression grows sinister.

"Oh yeah babe?"

"Y e-yeah, that's right!" She juts her chin out stubbornly.

"You wanna stay on top? All night long." Her eyebrows wiggle salaciously and Adora flushes from head to toe.

"Oh. Uh"…

"Dont get shy on me now Princess. What are you planning on doing up there? You know, all night long. *Impressive* stamina by the way, I just hope I can keep up."

Adora crosses her arms over her chest, leaning back slightly, and pout exaggeratedly. "You're teasing me."

With her arms free Catra flips them in a move so smooth Adora can hardly track it. When they land Catra is on top. Adora's hands grip her shoulders and Catra is bracing herself on either side of Adora's head. "Nah, Princess." She coos, then leans down so their cheeks brush. Adora feels the tip of her nose run along the shell of her ear from bottom to top. Then her tongue flicks out in quick motion against her earlobe and Adora's breath catches. "*Now* I'm teasing you." Her breath is a warm tickle in Adora's ear, it makes the spot feel extra cold when Catra is suddenly off her, settling in on her side of the bed again. Adora lays still for a few seconds. After a few deep breaths she turns to Catra and, seeing her smug, triumphant grin, sticks her tongue out. Catra just laughs.

"Mean."

Catra shrugs. "At least it's not cute. Now come on Tiger, I think you've worn me out enough for one night." She yawns at she finishes as if to illustrate her point. Unsurprisingly her yawn is catching, and she's got Adora going in no time.

"N-Now you've got me started!" Catra smirks and shrugs without contrition. "Alright, alright gimme some of that blanket." As she shuffles down under the covers she adds, "You know you steal in the middle of the night, right?"

"I do not!"

"You so do."

Catra grumbles, "It's not like you need them, you're a fucking furnace!"

Adora shakes her head, still smiling. "You know if you let me *share the blankets*, I could share all that heat. Does you no good if you trap me out in the cold, it's like putting a heater outside in a snowstorm."

Catra gives her that calculating look. "Alright, point taken. C'mere." She opens her arms to Adora.

Adora considers her for a moment and then shuffles over, snuggling up and resting her head on Catra's chest. Catra puts one hand on her back and one slides into her hair, lightly scratching her scalp. Within a minute she's barely awake but manages to murmur, "This is nice."

"Hmm." Catra hums her agreement. "Sweet dreams Princess." When they wake up in the morning Catra's lamp is still on.

The journey home is relatively painless. Security is a breeze and, anticipating Catra's nerves, Adora gets Catra ranting before the flight

is even fully boarded. She asks her how Kyle is settling in at the shop. What starts as Catra railing against his ineptitude ends with a tirade against the inherent white supremacy within the public education system.

Suddenly, taking a breath, Catra looks out the window. She turns back to look at Adora, blinking dumbly. "We're in the air."

Adora smirks, "Well, yeah. I mean *I* noticed."

"Oh, you think you're awfully clever, don't you?"

"Just helping." Adora replies cockily. Catra rolls her eyes, but she's smiling and leans over to kiss her on the cheek.

"Thanks Princess." She whispers in her ear. Pulling back, she jumps back in with, "Oh, but get this! I totally forgot to tell you; when I stopped in before you and the wonder twins picked me up last week I one hundred percent caught Kyle checking out Ro's ass. I texted Ro about it later and he sends me back a winky face. He's *loving* it."

That devolves into chatter about the rest of their friends and anything else they can think of. Before they know it Scorpia is pulling up to Adora's place to drop her off, having offered to be their ride on this end of the journey.

"Well it's so good to see you Adora. And I'm glad you two crazy kids figured things out. That's just awesome!" Adora blushes but manages to stutter out a thanks. "Oh! Hey, you should come to game night on Saturday!"

"Scorpia." Catra groans.

"What?" Scorpia demands. "Does Adora not like games?" She gasps, as if horrified her jab at Catra might actually be accurate. "Oh my gosh! Adora, do you not like games?"

"I like games." Adora pipes up from the back seat.

"See, Catra? Adora like games."

"Y eah Catra! I like games.

"I never said she didn't, that was you Scorpia."

"Oh well then I just don't see the issue."

"There' s no- ugh, never mind." She turns in her seat to face Adora. "Y ou can come if you want, it's at my place this week."

"W ow, what an enthusiastic invite." Adora replies sarcastically . Catra pokes her tongue out. "I'll consider it."

"Ooh! Y ou should definitely come Adora. Perfuma and I are on snack duty and you haven't *lived* until you try our artichoke dip."

Catra makes a yielding expression. "That' s actually pretty true, they even grow the damn artichokes."

"Exactly how big is your garden Scorpia?"

"Pf ft, less a garden than a farm." Catra answers on Scorpia' s behalf.

"W ell, it's only one point seven five acres."..

"*Wow* , that sounds amazing."

"Oh, just our little slice of heaven, you'll have to come see it sometime." Scorpia of fers cheerily. "Ooh! Y ou two can come for dinner! Double dates, how fun. Oh! Or , bring Bow and Glimmer *triple date*. Oh, oh! I've been snapchatting with Glimmer too. *Quadru-* "

"*Scorpia!* " Catra cuts in with a laugh. "Y ou're just throwing a party at that point. Why don't you and I chat, and I'll text the princess the detail."

"Right, yes, sounds good! I'm sure you're ready to get inside Adora. I'll see you soon, it' s been lovely as always."

"Yeah, you too Scorpia, thanks again for picking us up."

"Oh, dont mention it! Did you put anything in the back?"

"No, Ive got it all back here with me." She pats her bag. "Thanks though."

Catra clears her throat. "I um, Ill walk you up."

"Oh." Adora gives her a flattered smile. "Okay." Catra takes her duffle and drops it on the doormat when they make it upstairs. "Thanks for getting that, and welluh." She blushes again. "everything. Really /Catra, I She takes Catra's hands in her own and looks down at them so grateful to you. And so happy that we all that we're doing this."

Catra squeezes her hand and waits until Adora looks up at her to speak. "Too adorable. Im glad all thanks for asking me to come with you. It humbles me that you wanted me there with you." She stands up on her toes to kiss Adora sweetly.

"Well, uh," Adora clears her throat. "When can I see you again?"

Catra laughs. "What, haven't had enough of me after the last week?"

"Not nearly."

That sobers Catra up pretty quickly. "Cool. Well uh, when I gotta checkin at the cafe tomorrow. I won't be on bar much but you're welcome to come by." Adora perks at the next suggestion before she even knows what it is. "I suppose I could swing by here after?"

"Yeah! If you want. I can make us dinner or lunch or whatever. I don't know what your timeline is."

That sounds chill. Text you in the morning to checkin?" Adora nods and Catra leans in for another kiss. This one starts to get a little

ore heated h en suddenly the f ront door bursts op en,sending thems hooting ap art.

f told Qu ar Iheard som ething out-oh.H guys."Bw s eyes dart bet ween the tw of them,a knowing sm ile growing on his lip s. Fightall,Ca tra,good to see you.Ao ra welcom hom e.I just gonna go-"

Uhuh,yep,sounds good Bw .Thanks,Ill be right-"

Bwhat is going-Ao ra!"Qu ar bustles out the door and throws herself into Ao ra' s arms.Ao ra mes apologetic eye contact with Ca tra over her head,but Ca tra just snickers and waves her of f .

Alright,well Ishould get going,Scorpia' s dow nstairs so."

Ca tra,bef ore you go,have you check ed in with Perf umabout ourkyet?

Uhy ,should Ihave?"Ca tra gives Qu ar a wary look, Qu ar shoots a suspicious one right back.Finally ,satisf ied Ca tra isn't lying,Qu ar sm iles.

Uh,no.She'll tell you soon Im sure.Y ou ay not even have to wait till you see her."She says m steriously .

Fightall Im gonna leave now ."

Bye Ca tra."

Bye Ao rable."Ca tra waves her f ingers and hops backdow n the stairs while Ao ra is ushered inside

Alright,so,yes;hi.W elcom hom e,how was your trip?W e miss ed you,yada,yada,yada."Qu ar rushes out,taking Ao ra' s bags f rom her and setting them behind the couch.

Uhey B?

"What's up?" Bev asks from his spot, leaning against the back of the couch and doing nothing to temper his whirlwind of a girlfriend.

"I don't start taking speed while Lu was gone," Bev laughs but Cher rolls her eyes and otherwise ignores the teasing.

"We have a surprise for you!"

"We agreed to let you settle in first but," Bev gestures to Cher. "I told you that was an unrealistic expectation but that I'd try."

"Oh honey," Cher says, "my heart, Adora hasn't even taken her shoes off."

"Yes, but I tried."

Bev rolls his eyes but doesn't argue further. "Well, let's do this then. Adora, do you have any immediate needs?"

"I actually really need to pee."

"Well hurry!" Cher insists. Adora does as she's told and scoots off to the bathroom.

When she comes back Bev and Cher are waiting by the closed door of the studio. "So what's up?"

"I'm here," Cher tells her, practically bouncing on the balls of her feet. She and Bev step out of the way so Adora can enter. She looks at them both suspiciously for a moment before pushing the door open. Her lungs freeze when she opens the door. A tidal wave of stars crashes out and any that remain are coating the floor of the studio and climbing up the walls. On all four sides of the room, leaned against the walls, are a dozen of Adora's pieces, expertly framed and matted. She takes another small step into the room and notices several stacks of prints on her drafting table.

She turns to look at her friends who are lingering in the doorway with shy smiles on their faces. "I..."

One more thing!" Quinn says. She digs around in a pocket and procures a business card. When she passes it over Aurora sees it has her card and, apparently, she has a website now. The card is cute. Her name and information printed in gold and stars from some of her work scattered around. Ironically there are some of her stars that linger around the stars on the card. She looks up at her friends.

"I don't know what to say." She breathes.

"Say, all before you say anything! We got this all ready and have been talking with Perfume who's been talking to Jordan, Connie's cousin, so you can start your showcase on the first. But if you're not ready Jordan said they're happy to leave their work until Peneria arranges another artist. And Bran and I figured, worst case scenario, we hang your art in the house!" Bran clears his throat. "Right, only if you want."

A few tears escape Aurora's eyes as she looks away from them and walks slowly around the room. She flushes, pausing in front of an image of Cora. Beside it is a watercolor of Bran and Quinn, Bran sitting on their couch laughing and Quinn sitting upside down beside him with a bright pink gum bubble in front of her mouth. There are stars all around them

There are a few still lives of Perfume's plants, several landscapes from the forests of Peneria and the Fernia mountains. She pauses by the one of a canyon that she and Myra and Bran went on a trip to Cannon Lakes. The stars seem to lift off the page making her relive the majesty of that place here, in her apartment. There are the portraits she did of Myra and Bran while they were there, surrounded by the deep oranges and reds of the landscape. She gets to the last and lets her tears fall freely.

She's not even sure how they found this one. It's one of the pieces she had submitted when she applied for Mystacor. When she had realized she wouldn't be able to attend she had buried all those pieces, lost in a shuffle of paper work and half-finished sketches. But here it is; an illustration of Aurin her old apron laughing with her

hand on her hip a cloud of blackcurrant and stars billowing out of the oven behind her and is splattered across the floor. It's a scene from one of Aurora's happiest memories.

"You guys." Her voice breaks as she turns to face them. There is zero hesitation as they rush forward to crush her in a hug. They continue to hold her there until her stomach rumbles, effectively ruining the moment.

Exhausted as she is from the emotional trip and all the travel, she stays up with them for hours. They laugh and catch up more in depth than they had over the phone while Aurora was gone. The trio sit in the living room until the wee hours of the morning. The stars trickle out of the studio until they fill every corner of the apartment. They still haven't faded by morning.

"You're being weird." Extra accuses the following afternoon when Aurora answers the door, making no move to let her in.

"I am not." Aurora defends. She is though, fidgeting and biting her lip. "You're weird."

Extra rolls her eyes. "Whatever. So, like, should I stay or?" She gestures back the way she came.

"Extra sinks at her. She still makes no move to clear the doorway.

"Adorable!"

"Right! Sorry, come in." She finally lets Extra in the door and closes the door behind them.

"Oh, hey Extra." Ben sinks from the couch, a teasing lilt to her voice.

"Rainbow." Extra deadpans.

“Hey! That nickname makes sense for Bow , but not Glimmer !”

“Are you not Bow?” Catra continues to keep a straight face. “I literally cannot tell the difference.”

Glimmer huffs and crosses her arms. “The difference is Bow is too nice to kick your ass.”

Catra throws her head back and laughs. “Alright Glimmer , point taken. So do you know why the princess is being weird?”

Glimmer sighs again. “Oh yeah.”

“You’re not gonna tell me, are you?” Glimmer ’s eyes cut behind Catra. She turns to see Adora freeze in the middle of talking dramatic slashing movements with her hands and arms. “Yeah, I’ll take that as a no. Adorable, what is up with you? I left you here last night relatively normal, y’know for you. Now one night with Kiran and Kyle and you’re, all whatever this is.” She gestures vaguely at Adora.

“Okay , okay I have something to show you.”

“Okay… ”

“Only , this morning I was sure I wanted to show you only , maybe that was a mistake.”

“Well I already here Princess so suck s to suck .” Catra crosses her arms. Glimmer , tired of their antics, flop s back on the couch and flip s her copy of Vogue open.

“Adora, you’re going to have to commit at some point. I told Perfuma I’d text her back sometime today . Besides, you already said you would which would mean Catra’ s gonna see it at some point.”

“But, what the fuck does Perfuma have to do with whatever this,” Catra gestures vaguely at the whole of Adora. “is?”

Right, okay right. I'm being silly, right? Right, totally. It's not like you haven't seen Lexa naked a million times before. You know what, lets just go." Without another word Aora marches to the studio door, which she had shut in anticipation of Octavia's arrival. "Well, are you coming or what?" She questions Octavia who is still standing in the same spot.

"I'm supposed to?"

"Obviously. Don't be intentionally obtuse Octavia, I'm too nervous to rif f with you right now."

Octavia shakes her head but comes closer. "So it's in here?" Aora nods but makes no move to open the door. Octavia's eyes widen and her eyebrows shoot to her hairline as a thought occurs to her. "Fucking stars Aora, did you get a dog in the twelve hours?"

Aora startles, ready to respond, but is cut of f by Octavia. "Hell no she did not, my shoes are still in there. There's no f ucking horse either." She looks up to shoot a mostly teasing glare in Aora's direction.

"Wait, the f uck? A horse? Holy shit, Aora Geyson are you a f ucking horse girl?"

Aora's emphatic, "It's" is directly overlapped by Octavia's deadpan, "Big time."

"You know that's really neither here nor there." Aora insists.

"It's def initely not here, horses don't belong in apartments." Octavia's eyes don't leave her again.

Aora shoves a f inger in Octavia's f ace. "We are not talking about this right now."

Octavia smirks. "Fine, but we are so talking about this later."

Adora rolls her eyes. "Whatever, just get in the f ucking studio, will you? Anything is better that telling Catra about her horse binder, especially in f ront of her. Catra gives her a wary look but opens the door anyhow.

It takes her a moment to process what she's looking at but then she does, she breaths out, "Damn, Adora." bef ore stepping into the room. She spins slowly in the middle of it, her eyes lingering on each piece. She starts on the opposite end Adora had so she comes to her own portrait last. She f reezes and then sinks to the f loor in f ront of it, one leg crossed, and the other knee bent up so her head can rest there. Adora lingers in place, leaned against the door f rame.

"What do you think?" Adora asks tentatively, unable to bear the silence and longer.

Catra looks up f rom the portrait slowly, as if having to drag her mind back f rom another world, and looks up at Adora with misty eyes. "Damn." The corners of Adora's lips quirk up slightly and she lops down beside Catra. They rest their arms around each other in a sort of awkward cuddle. "Adora, baby is this is...that how you see me?" She looks around the room again. "I?"

"Oh, all y eah, pretty much." Adora panics when a f ew tears roll down Catra's cheeks. She reaches up to brush them away. "Is that okay? I don't I don't have to show them if -"

"No!" Catra insists. "Adora, they're so wonderf ul, you should def initely show them. I mean, Dora I've seen your still but these portraits. I mean, like this one obviously, the subject is super hot." She snickers and Adora gives her a light punch on the shoulder. Catra turns and shif ts Adora with her. "The Rone though Adora it's really something special. It's older right?"

Adora quirks a brow, surprised she can tell. She supposes the style is a bit distinct, not terribly so but it is nearly f ive years old now. "Y eah, it is. Iactually submitted it as part of my portf olio to Mystacor." Catra squeezes her f or a moment, Adora appreciates it.

"Hood over, it's raining. I wonder you got in." Aora rests her head on Cora's shoulder and they sit for a while, just looking at the image. Dora." Cora ventures hesitantly.

"Hm?"

"Have you ever- did you ever consider really trying?"

Aora pulls back to sit up and look at Cora. "Cora"…

"I'm serious! I mean, just look at this." Aora gestures to the four walls of the studio. "I know it's a whole financial thing and you hardly need it but if… you want it, I truly believe your art is worth investing in."

"Honestly, I'm not sure I do want it anymore."

"What changed?" Cora asks gently.

"Well I think when I applied, I wanted to go because I thought it would be the best, you know? If figured if I was gonna go for it I should go all the way. But I don't know, I feel a little disillusioned, I guess. It's so expensive and so entrenched in the elitism of higher education." She shrugs. "I think if I did decide to go back to school for art, I'd sooner apply to Fernia, by half as much."

"I think that's a great idea babe."

"Well, maybe." She concedes, ready to put this conversation to rest.

"So… does this mean you're doing the showcase after all?"

Aora rests her head on Cora's shoulder again and feels her press a kiss on top. "Yeah, I think it does."

Perfume, Cora and Bvlgari have Aora eternally indebted to them. With all their planning while she was away the instillation of her

showcase goes off without a hitch. By the end of the first day several prints have already sold. Aora decides to only put up a couple of her originals for sale, most of them have too high a sentimental value for her to part with.

Aora is honestly pretty damn pleased, even if she does feel extraordinarily talking into Periwinkle and seeing her art on the walls. But what really has her excited is what she has on the agenda today. It's game night tonight and Astra has the day off, so she invites Aora to come over in the afternoon to hang out, get Mog and maybe make some pie. If we don't spend too long necking on the couch," Astra tells her with a wink. Aora gives her crap for using the term "necking" and tells her that she doubts she'll have time for that anyway. She plans to be very busy with Mog, but it doesn't fare Astra one bit. She probably can just see right through Aora.

She gets to Astra's pad at noon. It isn't an apartment like Aora had assumed, but a small bungalow just a couple blocks down from one of Aora's favorite parks in the city. Astra answers the door in a t-shirt tied at her waist and a pair of crimson leggings with leggarers over the top. Her hair is loose and voluminous, she looks relaxed, comfortable and happy.

"There she is!" Astra smiles. "Come on in." Aora looks around, she enters into the living room which is separated from the kitchen by only a large island. There's a set of beautiful French doors leading out to the backyard of a dining nook to the side of the kitchen. Aora figures the doorway to a hall behind the couch must lead to the bedroom and bathroom. The place is nice, definitely not minimalist by any means but not the cozy clutter of the castle. A few pieces of art adorn the wall and there are several floating shelves with plants and photo frames around the walls. Aora recognizes the large grey couch from pictures and Mog videos and sees there are several dark red pillows scattered across it. And everywhere there is a personal touch, stars bloom like wildflowers.

"I like it Astra, it suits you."

Thanks! I did a lot of work when I bought the place. I couldn't be happier with how it turned out."

Alora stops following Extra into the house. "Wait, what?"

Extra turns, looking confused. "I did a lot of work? Nothing crazy, but the doors to the back were new, paint in all the rooms, and there were a few plumbing things that had to be taken care of. Stuff like that."

"Oh, sorry, wait like, wait you own your home?"

"Oh, did you not know that?"

"Extra," Alora chuckles, bemused. "How on earth would I know that?"

"I guess you have a point. Well, yeah, this place is mine." She looks around the room, smiling proudly.

"You're incredible." Alora states simply. It makes Extra flush lightly, stars turning their way from her scalp and down her curls.

"Shut up. Are you hungry?"

"Not really, there's a dog?" Alora cranes her neck to look around, maybe she just missed him...

"Wow." Extra teases. "Straight to the point, not even gonna pretend like you aren't using me for my cat."

"Please, you know there's nothing straight about me." Alora answers, wandering away to peek under the couch.

"Hell yeah I do!"

"But yeah, I pet my cat here for the cat." Alora says as she pops down in the corner of Extra's L-shaped couch.

Extra shakes her head, coming to sit by Aurora, throwing her arm over the back of the couch. "Yeah well, sucks to suck, I guess. They just ran under the bed. Probably gonna creep out in twenty minutes or so once they're sure you're not here to like, murder us or steal their bunny or whatever."

"Bunny? I'm sorry, does your pet have a pet?" Aurora's mostly kidding, but if there's a bunny here she definitely wants to pet it.

"Yes." Extra answers with a straight face. "I dunno, it's just a cat nip toy. They carry it around like it's a baby though."

"That's so cute!" Aurora squeals, Extra looks pleased.

"Yeah, yeah, whatever. So, are we baking this pie or what?"

"Yes, right, let's get started. You got everything?"

"Sure did. Oh, but you didn't really need flour, right? Because I did forget the flour." Aurora giggles and shoves her shoulder, then rolls up her sleeves and gets started.

Aurora is just wrapping the dough to rest when she freezes. In an urgent whisper she demands, "Oh my stars! Holy stars! Extra, treats, I need treats! Extra, leave it be! The filling can wait, I need treats. Will you stop laughing at me?"

Extra does not stop laughing at Aurora. "You're an idiot."

"For fuck's-you know what, just tell me where you keep them."

"Babe, chill." She rolls open a drawer and grabs a little plastic pouch. Mog, who's just emerged from the bedroom, looks over with sharp eyes. "Hear something Mog?" She asks the cat, who slowly starts to slink over. "Why don't you meet us by the couch bud?"

Aurora follows Extra over and Mog meets them there in two bounds and a leap. Aurora sits close to Extra, leaning around and over her

slightly to keep her eyes firmly trained on the cat. "Are you sure they're gonna like me? Sometimes cats don't like me."

"Yeah, probably because you're way too excitable. You gotta calm down, Princess, let them come to you." She shakes a treat out of the bag and Mog goes for it instantly, purring the moment it's out of the bag, a few faint stars rumble along his fur to the rhythm. He sits primly, sniffing the air for more snacks.

"Dogs like my energy," Aora utters bitterly. "Can at least?" She gestures a delicate hand toward Mog.

"By all means." She leans back to make it easier for Aora to reach Mog.

She offers her fingers to sniff. "Uh, hey, hi buddy. Uh, Mog. I'm Aora, and we can be friends if you want." Extra laughs so quiet it's practically a whisper. Mog regards Aora curiously for a moment, their purring growing significantly quieter. Then, they apparently decide she's alright because they sniff her fingers before rubbing their face along her hand. It leaves a trail of vibrant stars in its wake. She gives Extra an excited look and receives an encouraging smile in return. She turns quickly back to the cat, who is now headbutting her hand, demanding pets.

She scratches their head, focusing behind their ears when they lean into her hand. The effect is incredible. Stars begin to emanate from the spot where Mog initially rubbed against her until they surround them like an aura. Still vibrating along with Mog the stars begin to span outward, filling the room with Mog's magic. Aora blinks rapidly, trying to take it all in and continue her pets simultaneously.

"Omg Extra, kiss me."

Extra laughs, "Wow so bossy all of the sudden. What, do you-"

"Extra!" Extra rolls her eyes, smiling wide but with a hint of confusion lingering in her expression. She leans forward and kisses Aora, as

ordered. Adora makes no secret about the fact that the kiss isn't where her focus lay, but a few stars still sparkle from their lips. Without pulling away she whispers against Catra's lips. "Alright, now open your eyes, and look at your fucking cat."

"Uh." Her face scrunches up and her eyes flutter open. Then she's pulling away with a gasp, looking at Melog with wide eyes. "Damn dude, I knew you knew how to command the energy of the room, but this is extra." She looks around the room, taking in the stars that now reach so high they crowd the ceiling, still vibrating to Melog's rhythm

"So." Adora ventures, breaking Catra out of her reverie. "Does this mean we're friends now?

"Don't ruin it Princess."

They snuggle and play with Melog until he's decided he's had enough and scampers over to a cat tree in the corner. Adora puts but it's probably for the best, they never ate lunch and still have two pies to bake before the rest of their friends join them. Folks start showing up around a quarter to seven, unsurprisingly Scorpia and Perfuma are the first to walk in the door.

"Oh, it smells heavenly in here." Perfuma praises, slipping of her burlies. Melog eyes her from the top of his tree and scampers back to the bedroom

"Yeah, Dora's just pulling pies out." She calls over. "Adorable, how long did you say I have to wait?

Adora rolls her eyes fondly. "Just until the filling isn't molten Catra. Hey guys, it's good to see you." They exchange greetings all around, coming to stand around the island. Catra and Perfuma launch into shoptalk pretty quickly. While they're chatting Catra peeks at the pies between the lattice every so often, wincing every time she finds

the f illing to still be hot. Finally , af ter the f if th time in ten minutes Adora huf f s. "Of or the love of the stars, just cut into it already!"

Catra brightens, "Really?"

Adora shakes her head and smiles at her but passes her a knif e f rom the drawer in f ront of her all the same. "Just cut a slice f or everyone else please. And it' s gonna be really messy ."

"Y eah, yeah." Catra grumbles good naturedly . She gets to cutting and passing around pie, resuming her conversation with Perf uma. They're really just gossiping at this point. They chat about Kyle and Angelio' s potentially budding romance but Scorpia and Adora dig right in. They blow on the steaming dessert, Adora watching stars dance and curl along the hot air, and take their bites when they're conf ident it won't burn them. Immediately Scorpia' s f orkclatters to her plate. The sound startles the rest of the group, they look over at her and she's looking intently at Adora. Tears laced with stars have sprung into her eyes.

"Wow , Adora. This is your grandma' s recipe, right?"

Adora shif ts under all the attention suddenly on her . "Uh, yeah, yeah. Granny Ax."

Scorpia nods and gives her a watery smile. "Wow , that is just so sweet. So much love. It' s older than that though, right?"

"Huh, what?" Adora asks, f eeling lost.

"I mean this crust, it' s gotta go back, what? At least two or three generations f urther than Madame Ax, right?"

Adora f lounders and Catra swoops in to save her f rom answering. "What? Scorpia, how would you even?. ."

Scorpia raises her eyebrows. "I mean, of course I don't know f or sure. But it does tastes like it, right? There' s a lot of f amily history ,

generations of magic, in there. A trust like that doesn't just happen."
She looks to Erfumf or validation, she smiles and rests a hand over her partner's.

"I'm sorry, I feel like I'm being really slow on the uptake here, but what are you saying exactly?" Adora asks after a shaky exhale.

"Well I'm no expert"…

"Sure you are honey."

"Thanks, Em, but really, like I said I have no way to know. I just… get the sense that though this recipe came to you from your grandmit connects you with more of your family tree than just her. Is that not?"…

Adora shakes her head. "I don't really know. I just thought as the only family I ever had, the only family I knew about. What you're saying though, it makes sense I suppose."

Scorpia nods and smiles, the expression is tinged with the weight of emotion hanging in the air. Adora looks down at her plate, the stars that were dancing along it are now a little more sober but still bright. Maybe brighter even. Her family tree, what does that even look like? Adora still struggles with the concept of family sometimes. She feels like it's only in the last couple years she's started to figure it out. She knows there must have been generations of Greyson's before her but Mara is her family, Bow and Glimmer are her family. It feels strange to think about connecting to the family she was born into in this way, now that she's learned to build one from scratch.

Once conversation has resumed around her Adora leans slightly toward Scorpia. "Hey Scorpia?" She ventures softly. The woman turns to her and lifts her eyebrows in question. "If you want, I mean totally chill if not, but I can give you that recipe?"

Scorpia looks pleasantly shocked. "Adora, oh what's really so sweet of you. You don't have to though; I mean, I know it's a family

thing. I wouldn't want to impose."

Adora shrugs. "Hey, I mean, how do you even begin to define that? I'd like you to have it if you want it Scorpia, I have no doubt you'll honor its history."

Scorpia looks emotional and dabs at the corner of her eyes. "I would, Adora, I'd really like that." They share a significant look that makes it clear; neither of them is talking purely about the recipe.

When they both go back to eating Catra shoots Adora a questioning look. Adora just gives her a small smile and shakes her head. Catra's eyes cut to Scorpia briefly and then she looks back to Adora she mirrors her expression and offers a small nod in return. She looks pleased when she turns back to Perfuma.

Around a quarter past there's an energetic knocking from the door. "Hey, that's definitely Seahawk Scorpia that's on you, I don't have the energy for that shit."

Scorpia laughs and bounds to the door. Sure enough, Seahawk is on the other side of the door, a bored looking Mirsta by his side. "Beautiful Scorpia!" he announces with his usual bravado. "And three more lovely maidens! Catra, thank you for welcoming us into your home this evening. I am so looking forward to besting you all at a variety of games this evening."

Everyone drifts toward the couch now that more of their friends have arrived. "Fucking stars ah, you ever tone it down?" Catra grumbles.

"Yeah no." Mirsta drawls.

"Well." Seahawk begins. "I brought wine!" He offers Catra a bottle of red that had been tucked under his arm. She considers him for a moment before taking it with a reluctant grin.

"I still don't think you're charming." She insists with a finger waved in his direction.

"Fine, I'm like, sort of helping with that." Krista supplies. "And I have another bottle in my bag or whatever."

"Hey Krista! Are you saying you think that I, Sebastian Shaw, am charming?"

"Oh… please. Tolerable is more like it." Elsie likes like she just professed her undying love and devotion.

It's just the six of them this evening and soon enough they're all settled in with snacks and drinks. They get promptly set up and it becomes clear very early on; Perfume, Scorpia, Akuma and Krista are all just there to have a good time. Adora and Catra, on the other hand, are there to win. Their friends watch in with varying degrees of amusement and concern.

"Pay up Catra!" Adora demands when Catra lands on one of her hotels.

"What? I fucking own Princess! We had a deal."

"Yeah, we did. You got to land on three of my properties without paying, plus cash, in exchange for Baltic!"

"I'll," Catra responds smugly. "I get to land on three of your hotels without paying, those other two didn't have hotels, now did they?"

"What? No! That was so not the deal you little cheater."

"Was so!"

"Then why didn't you pay me when you landed on the last two, huh?" She demands, sure she's got her there.

Catra just shrugs, smirk never slipping. "Not my fault if you forget to collect rent Adorable, screw landlords."

Adora groans in frustration. "How many times are you gonna try and fuck me, Catra?" Her voice is raised now, and it makes the silence that follows her words even more striking. Their friends are snickering and Catra just stares her with an eyebrow raised.

"Well that depends, Adora, how many times do you want me to?

Adora blushes and stutters, Catra's laughter only fueling her. Finally, she manages, "Shut the fuck up and give me my money, will you?

It's a move that infuriates both Catra and Adora, but Catra beats them both a little while later. The game takes so long that everyone starts taking off shortly after ten. Adora hangs back to help clean up. She's rinsing dishes and loading the dishwasher when Catra comes up behind her and wraps her arms around her waist.

"So, did you really stay just to clean or?" Adora turns off the faucet and flicks excess water off her hands before turning around in Catra's embrace.

"Why, whatever else would I have stayed for?" She asks, her voice a mix of faux innocence and mirth. Catra gives her a droll look and Adora just laughs. "What?

"Whatever, do you wanna make out with me on the couch or not?

"I mean I guess," Adora teases.

"Great." Catra drags her by the arm to the couch and has her lips on Adora's the moment her butt hits the cushion.

Adora does go home that night, but it's very, very late. When she falls asleep in her own bed her body is still buzzing with stars.

Chapter End Notes

Hi! Hi again!
So after writing a section and reading some folks' input (thanks to everyone who shared their opinion!) I decided this story will

be getting spicier!Almost definitely starting next chapter . t's been established that Adora has a fear of intimacy and Ithink exploring her physical relationship with Catra will be really significant to unpacking that.

Thanks again to everyone who reads/comments/leaves judos/bookmarks this story!Iget so excited, you dont even know. This story was gonna be a one, maybe two shot, then I was thinking ten chapters and...here Iam now with over 90,000 words written for this beast and Im having a gay ol'time over here!Im so happy to share it with folx.

Also Ijust got twitter!Im l@logoblens and am in it primarily for cartoon content (she ra-obvs-, dragon prince and atla mostly), so if thats your vibe plzcome find me so Ican find more of that good animated ish.

Scorpio Season

Chapter Notes

> CW: We have reached the spice! It comes up a couple times in this chapter and there's a fair amount of discussion about Adora's feelings about physical intimacy.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It's been a couple weeks since Catra and Adora returned home and things are going pretty great. Work is, as usual, pretty whatever for Adora, but everything else... The castle has reached peak symbiosis, both the dynamics between friends and use of the space. It occurs to Adora that it's pretty convenient her the person she's dating, has a place of her own. They end up spending a lot more time at Catra's. Adora discovers that as much as she loves her best friends there is something to be said for a roommate free space. Namely the ability to make out on the couch all they want. And she *knows* that Bow and Glimmer are enjoying having the place to themselves on a semiregular basis.

As far as her relationship or whatever it is, things have been going well between them, great even. In fact, things mostly haven't changed; they see each other a lot, banter and tease. The main difference is that now when Adora gets flustered by Catra's flirting, Catra leans in and kisses her. So that's pretty rad. There have also been a couple more dates. The first time they go out again in Eternia Catra insists on taking Adora back to see the same movie from their first date since she hadn't watched any of it. Of course, once they're there Catra drags Adora to the back row and distracts her through nearly the whole thing again. She promises to rent it for them when it comes out but Adora doesn't see how that's likely to turn out any different. She says this to Catra and gets a smirk in response. Then Catra says innocently, "And would that be so bad?" They make out in

the car for twenty minutes before going to get food and Adora admits, no, that wouldn't be so bad at all.

Of course, just as she knew they eventually would, things between them start to escalate. And just as she suspected, Adora has no fucking idea what to do. After game night they had kissed like, *a lot*, but that was really it. But a week later Catra has Adora over for dinner, and she makes an absolute feast. They chat and joke around over dinner and settle on the couch with their wine after the table is cleared.

"So," Adora begins. "When were you gonna tell me that your birthday is in less than three weeks?" She questions with a teasing lilt to her voice.

"Uh… who told you that?"

"Catra."

"Never mind, I know who it was. Scorpia's too meddlesome for her own good, I swear."

"So not the point."

"Uh, I think it's very much the point actually." Catra insists.

Adora laughs, "Stars, of course you're one of those people who's all weird about their birthday. What I don't understand is, don't you love attention? I would think you'd be all about your birthday!"

"Shut up! I do *not* love attention," you brat." She puts air quotes around Adora's words.

"*Oh* I get it." Adora smirks at her.

"What?" Catra demands with a defiant look.

"Nothing, nothing."

"You're not cute you know."

"Hm, it's just so clear to me now. You totally love your birthday, you're just too stubborn to admit it."

"Fuck of f, that's not even- you're wrong."

"I'm not though, am I?"

"*Adora…*"

Adora just laughs at Catra's warning tone. "Okay, so like, I shouldn't get you a gift then?"

Catra looks totally caught off guard. "What the fuck?"

"I mean if you hate your birthday so much I just wanna respect your wishes. Is it okay if I wish you a happy birthday at least? I can wait until the day after if that's better." Adora wants to laugh so bad, but she fights for a serious expression.

"I- wait, so you're not getting me a present?" Catra looks dumbfounded.

"Well, I wouldn't want to bring any excess attention to you. It's *your* birthday after all, if you want to celebrate by pretending it's not I… suppose I'll just have to make that sacrifice." She adds a little dramatic flair at the end. She's fighting a losing battle trying to keep her cool anyway.

"You little shit!"

Adora pretends to be aghast. "What, me? What did *I* do?"

"You-you're, ugh! Why are you like this?"

"Wildly charming?"

"Wildly infuriating is more like it."

"So, are you just gonna work on the twenty-eighth then?"

"Will you knock it *off*? Seriously." Catra crosses her arms and scowls at her.

"Me seriously? What about *you* seriously?"

Catra shoots her a baffled expression. "That literally means nothing. Will you just- ugh!"

"Will I just what?"

"Will you just stop being such an idiot about this and get me a birthday gift?"

Adora smiles, pleased. "Okay."

"Okay?" Catra's tone is hesitant.

"Sure, okay."

"Okay, cool."

"So for real though, why *didn't* you tell me?"

"Well I mean you know I'm a Scorpio! You had to know it was coming up." Catra defends.

"Okay, I think you know perfectly well that information means nothing to me." Catra rolls her eyes. Adora doesn't *mean* for emotion to surface in her voice when she continues, it just *happens*. "Hey, listen. I don't if you have something planned it's not I can give you a gift whenever."

"What? What are you talking about?" Catra's face is all scrunched up.

"I just mean, like if there's a *reason* you didn't tell me, I'm not gonna give you a hard time for having plans already." She shrugs a little

pathetically. Adora means what she says but she'll lie to Catra, but she won't lie to herself; her feelings will be a little hurt if Catra doesn't want to see her on her birthday.

"What, you mean like if I have plans that don't include you?" Adora purses her lips and makes a noncommittal gesture. "*Adora,* you dummy!" She's quiet for a minute, maybe waiting to see if Adora will respond. She doesn't. "Hey, babe, listen I didn't mean to- to hurt your feelings by not telling you. I *def initely* want to see you that day I just... You're right, I do like my birthday but I kind of hate the lead in, you know?"

"What does that mean, the lead in?"

"I don't know. I didn't really like my birthday as a kid, no one ever really made a big deal about it. And I mean, *now* I do but I still don't like making a thing of it leading up to it. And I sort of hate planning shit for it." She shrugs.

"Wait, so what are you doing this year?"

"Uh well."

"Catra! It's less than three weeks away." Adora points out indignantly.

"I *know* when my own birthday is, thanks Princess. I think Scorp, Fuma and I were gonna get a fancy dinner that night. And um… *you* hopefully. During the day, I don't know, I guess I'll just hang out."

"Hang out?" Adora questions dubiously.

"Sure. Are you it's a Wednesday, you have to work, right?" Adora convinces herself Catra sounds a little sullen when she asks.

"Well"…

"What?"

"Why do you ask?"

"I dunno." Catra's voice lowers to a mumble. "I kind of thought it could be cool if we hung out but like, no stress."

"Great!" Adora answers cheerily. "I'm sure I can make that happen." She decides not to mention that she already asked her boss and got approval as soon as she found out, just in case. She can tell Catra it's set in stone later.

"I mean, if you want. Like I said, it's not a big deal."

"Catra." Adora waits until she looks her in the eye to continue. "I want."

Catra sniffs and nods once. "Okay."

"So is there anything you want?" A salacious look is thrown her way and Adora rolls her eyes. "Like for your birthday Catra."

"Yeah, I want you to make out with me right now for my birthday."

"Hm, I thought you didn't like to make a thing of your birthday leading up to it."

It's Catra's turn to roll her eyes. "Just shut up and kiss me."

Adora's responding laughter is cut off by Catra's kiss. It's not gentle; it's all passion and promise and *please*. It pulls sounds out of Adora she never imagined herself making, they spill forth from Catra's lips too and Adora has never been so worked up in all her life. Stars, a veritable waterfall of stars, rush from the area above her heart. Catra clambers onto her and stars begin to pool in their shared lap. They rush forth like water but are hot like lava simmering in the space between them. Catra's hands have been resting on her neck, her jawline. When she slides a hand down to her chest Adora is sure the two of them are going to light this couch on fire.

Adora's passion freezes when Catra begins to tug her shirt from the waist of her pants. The molten stars between them instantly solidify

into rock and the flow of stars halts to a stop. It only takes Catra a moment to notice that Adora isn't responding. "Sorry, sorry, are you okay?" She pants as she pulls away, her hands moving to rest where Adora's neck meets her shoulders.

"Mm-hmm." Adora nods, lips pressed tightly together. "Great, um we can keep..." She gestures between them.

Catra gives her a wary look. "Babe you just froze solid, are you sure that wasn't too much?"

"No, no it's fine." Adora insists. Catra just sighs in response.

"Adora." There's a tone of finality to her voice. "Come on, I need you to be honest with me here."

"O-okay. Really, it-it's fine. I just- maybe want to keep um, my shirt on for now?" She slides her hands from where they've been resting on Catra's thighs to fuss with the loose hem of her top. Her eyes watch the movement of her fingers.

"Hey." Catra's head ducks down to catch Adora's eyes with her own. One hand moves to cup her cheek and Adora sees a few stars glitter beneath her palm from the corner of her eye. "That's totally fine. I'm sorry for getting caught up and not checking in. That wasn't cool."

"No, it's really fine!" Adora insists.

"Adora." Catra admonishes. "It's *not* fine. What you want, your consent, it *matters*." Adora feels her muscles loosen and the stars between them melt ever so slightly.

"O-okay. Um, thanks, I guess." Adora relaxes even further when Catra's hand starts combing through her hair. The stars between them gradually melt until they float between them, lukewarm like the end of a bath.

"Baby , of course. Im here to make you feel good, just keep me in the loop about how Ican do that. There doesnt need to be any pressure."

Adora nods and nuzzles into the palm of Catra' s hand. "uh,"She begins, mumbling. "wanna make *you* fee-feel good to, yknow? I dontwill you...tell me how ."

Catra considers her for a minute then her face gradually warms to a smile. She leans forward to kiss Adora on the cheek. "Y ou already do Dora."She just sits there, on Adora' s lap, smiling at her for a minute more. The stars continue to heat up until they are fuzzy and warm. Adora smiles back. "So Princess, what do you wanna do?"

"Oh, uh we can- "

"Adora Ididnt ask what we *can* do. Im asking you what you *want* ."

Adora and the stars heat up a few notches. "W elll like to kiss you again. ifthat' s okay."

Catra leans forward and brushes their lips together, just a whisper of a kiss. Adora yanks her closer by the shirt and kisses her firmly, sighs into her mouth. Catra hums and the stars are bubbling. She tears her lips apart and leans her forehead against Adora's, her eyes are closed. "What ifyour shirt stays of f, but mine."Her eyes flutter open to gauge Adora's reaction. She cant even imagine how red she is.

"if-if you want that um, that would beneat?"She registers her words with a groans and tips her head back to rest against the couch. Catra giggles at her and Adora feels her shift around a bit.

"*Hey Adora* ."Adora looks up, slowly , to find Catra shirtless. She's in a grey sports bra, Adora's eyes follow the outline of it then trail down to her belly button. She's staring and Catra is watching her do it. The stars boil, spilling over their lap and flooding the carpet, they seem to

regenerate, and endless sea of them bubbling up from the pool between them. The spot in their lap remains *warm*, hot even.

Adora reaches a tentative hand forward then hesitates, looking up into Catra's eyes. "Can-may I?"

Catra nods with a small smile. "Anything you want Dora."

Adora nods, barely noticing the stars that trail up Catra's stomach until they meet her fingers where they brush against Catra's collar bone. She sees as much as she hears the sigh that escapes Catra's chest at the contact. She brushes her fingers along the bone, then her other hand comes up to mirror the contact on the other side. Her hands trail up and over Catra's shoulders, a swath of smoldering stars lingering in their wake. She runs them down her back and brushes the tips of her middle and index fingers up along her spine. Catra shivers as the contact and Adora bites her lip to keep from letting on just how much that turns her on.

She looks up to Catra's face again and she's still watching Adora's face intently, her breaths shallow. Stars shine along her forehead like a sheen of sweat. "Can you," Adora whispers. "Can you see them?"

She shakes her head and whispers back. "I think I think I know where they are though. I think I can feel them." Adora nods and returns her attention to her hands where they've been lingering at the base of Catra's neck. She slides her fingers up until they slide into her hair and scratches her scalp lightly. Catra's eyes flutter shut and she sighs with a small smile. Still whispering as if not to break the spell and spook Adora she says, "Feels nice. When you touch me I..." Another soft, dreamy sigh.

Adora slides her fingers down her neck again until she reaches the top of Catra's bra. She slides her fingers along the edge, fingers just barely sneaking under. They the slide down her chest and Catra gasps as Adora brushes her nipples through the fabric. Adora freezes for a moment but the stars never still and soon she's

resumed movement. She cups her hands where they rest and brushes her thumbs over the sensitive area. Oncetwice, three times until Catra's breath is stuttering. She slides her thumbs over the spot in a vertical motion once and then her hands move again. One goes to hold Catra's waist and the other her neck, fingers sliding just barely into her hair .

She looks Catra over, at the path the stars leave, all the places her hands have been now. She leans in and rests her forehead against Catra's again. Voice soft and pleading, begging Catra to hear just how much she means it, she whispers, "*Thankyou* ."Catra gulps and nods shakily before closing the gap between their lips.

Adora's not sure how long they stay there. But she knows the stars pulse and glow until they've combined forces and enveloped the women inside of a star. And she knows that ever single minute of it, every new and now familiar spot explored, feels *good*.

The next day Adora drags Glimmer to the mall while Bow is at work. They've been to three shops with nothing to show for it and Adora can feel her anxiety rising.

"Adora, what are you even *looking* for?"

"I already told you, a gift for Catra!"She snips, marching into the next closest shop. Seeing that she's wandered into an athletic store she turns right back around and almost bowls Glimmer over. "They probably dont have that here."

"Goddess Adora!Alright, that' s it. Food. f you try and make me go into one more store without some pizza or a soft pretzel, you're gonna regret it."Glimmer demands, already walking in the direction of the food court. They part ways once they get there and reconvene at a table a few minutes later with trays. Glimmer got *both* items on her wish list and Adora went to the Americanized Mexican place for a plate of disappointing looking enchiladas.

Glimmer immediately starts inhaling pizza but Adora just pokes at her food. "*Ugh!* I've no idea what I'm doing."

"Like for a gift?" Glimmer asks around a mouthful of cheese.

"Maybe, I mean yeah that but also." She pouts and drops her fork, slouching in her plastic chair.

Glimmer swallows thickly. "But also"…

"I don't know!" Adora huffs and crosses her arms over her chest, the gesture is rather protective. "With Catra I guess."

Glimmer scowls at her. "What do you mean? I thought things were going well."

"Well, they *are* mostly. I mean *she's* great, it's me. I'm just a fucking mess. I've just never done this before, and I don't know how to navigate whatever we are! Fucking stars, I don't even know *what* we are." More quietly she adds, "I'm just afraid I'm gonna ruin it."

"Oh, Adora." Glimmer sighs sympathetically. "I'm honestly not even sure where to start so I'm just gonna jump right in. You said you don't know what you are, so I take it you haven't had the DTR talk yet?"

"Uh what?"

"Defining the relationship Adora."

"Oh no."

"Do you think you should?" Glimmer asks simply, as if that isn't a whole can of worms in and of itself.

"Isn't it like, too soon? We've only been on a few dates."

"I mean, there's no rule book. You don't have to follow some time line. Just look at Bow and me. It took us *years* to truly figure out what

we wanted to be. But we did talk about it a couple times along the way. Sounds like that's exactly what you and Catra need to do, *talk*."

"Well what would I even *say* in that situation."

"That depends; what do you want?"

Adora huffs. "This whole answering a question with a question thing is very annoying."

Glimmer just laughs at her. "Yeah, well having to drag information out of you is no walk in the park either my friend. Do you want to date anyone besides Catra? Play the field before you commit as it were."

"Glimmer." Adora gives her a droll look and then gestures to herself. "Please, try to imagine *me* playing the field' it would be a disaster. No, I don't want that!"

"Excellent point. Okay then, so do you want to commit to Catra, be exclusive?"

"Well I mean if she does that's-that'd be cool. But it's whatever, I don't want to rush her or anything. I can be chill!" Adora could not be any less chill in this moment.

"Yeah, no you can't. And just because you want something doesn't mean it will work out. If Catra doesn't want to be exclusive, then I'm sure she'll tell you that. But if that's what you want then you need to ask for that. She can't read your mind Adora, and there's nothing wrong with asking for what you want." She lets that sink in for a moment and then jumps right back in. "Do you want to be Catra's girlfriend?"

"Uh." Adora knows she's blushing, she doesn't even care that much anymore. She's resigned to being a tomato.

"Okay, how would you feel if you found out Catra went on a date with someone else?"

"Uhm, bad? I guess." Truthfully the thought makes Adora glad she didn't eat any of the so-called enchiladas. Picturing Catra on a date makes her feel ill.

"So"…

"So, I guess, yeah. It would be cool if we were only dating each other."

"See, now was that so hard?"

"Pfft, yes. And now I'm supposed to tell *her* that?"

"Goddess above. *Yes* Adora. This," She gestures at nothing in particular. "It's kind of the whole thing. Communication, trust, emotional intimacy; all things a healthy relationship needs."

"Ugh!" Adora groans dramatically. "I'm not even emotionally intimate with *myself*!"

"Yeah, you might wanna work on that." Glimmer picks her pizza up again. "So, is that the only thing bothering you?"

Adora sinks further into her seat and so quiet it's almost inaudible mutters, "No."

"Okay, out with it." Glimmer shoves her entire crust into her mouth.

"We haven't had sex." Adora admits, just as quietly. Glimmer nearly chokes on the wad of dough in her mouth. A lot of spluttering and coughing follows. Adora sinks further into her seat in embarrassment.

Finally, Glimmer manages to swallow her food. She takes a large drink of water and then turns her attention back to Adora. "Wow, sorry, okay where were? Right, right! So do you want to be having sex with Catra?"

"I don't know... I think so? Maybe it's just, every time she tries to go any further than we have before I just freak out. Which like, she's been really sweet and supportive about." Adora sits up a little more as her rant gets going. "She promised we won't do anything I'm not ready for and she's been like, super good about asking consent. Which is great, don't get me wrong! It's just I don't know how to ask for more when I don't even know what to ask *for*. Plus, then there's *her* side of things and like, I want her to be satisfied with what we do or whatever. I just feel so clumsy and awkward and I'm already so flustered around her! I don't know what to do and I'm afraid." Adora takes a gasping breath but doesn't finish.

"What?" Glimmer prompts.

"I'm afraid I'm gonna fuck it up either way! Like, I could go for it, but I might freak out and ruin it. And even if I don't freak out, I'm so clueless I'll probably make a complete fool of myself. Or we just stay stuck in this holding pattern and eventually she'll get sick of the fact that I act like a bashful *twelve-year old* who still hasn't gotten the sex talk when it comes to this stuff!"

"Wow... okay. You know, for someone who sucks so bad at feelings you sure have a lot of them."

"*Ugh* tell me about it." Adora shoves her tray aside and rests her head on her arms on top of the table.

"Adora... there's nothing wrong with being nervous about this stuff. I've had plenty of sex and I still get nervous when I do something new or am with some*one* new. It's a really vulnerable position to be in. Really, I know it's not what you want to hear, but you should talk to Catra. This stuff can be scary but good communication is important to getting through it. And getting to the good stuff. As far as actually *doing* stuff, that's mostly instinct."

Adora looks up long enough to snort and tell Glimmer, "That's almost exactly what Mara said."

Glimmer looks smug. "She' s a smart lady."Adora rolls her eyes and drops her head back down.

"W ell it's not actually that helpful. Also, Istill dont know what to get her for her birthday."

"Im sorry , were you talking to me or the table? Because Icant hear a word you say when you cover your face like that."

Adora picks her head up with a grunt. "*Isaid* ;Istill dont know what to get her for her birthday."

"W ell, let me eat my pretzel and we can go look some more."She eyes Adora's plate dubiously. "Y ou might want to get something else for lunch, that looks awful."

Adora does get something else, she returns to the table five minutes later with pizza for herself and another slice for Glimmer . She didnt ask but Adora knows if she doesnt Glimmer will just pout until she shares. Then Glimmer is dragging her through stores. In the end their trip isnt totally wasted. Actually , inspiration strikes in the middle of the third store. Catra doesnt like the lead up to her birthday? Adora will take that challenge.

The next weekend finds Catra and Adora back on the couch. Catra is straddling Adora's waist, her top haphazardly discarded on the spot Melog was previously occupying. The air is charges with buzing stars. Adora digs her fingers into the velvet of the couch, then into Catra's thighs. It spurs her on and she reaches for the hem of Adora's t-shirt. "Can I?"She breathes against her lips. Adora doesnt want to, she tries *really* hard not to, but she tenses, and her lips pause on Catra's. When her brain manages to reboot, she tries to resume their frenetic pace but Catra is already pulling away. "Adora"…

"*Fck* , Im sorry , Im sorry! Ididnt meanit .doesnt matter , let's just." She makes a vague gesture with her hands.

Catra forces a harsh breath through tight lips. Adora tries to ignore the way the action makes her chest lift for a moment. So much lace and .t does though Adora, it matters. So no, we cant just." She imitates Adora's gesture, sliding so she sits perpendicular to Adora with her feet on one side of her lap and the rest of her body on the other. She throws an arm on the back of the couch, behind Adora.

Im so *sorry* Catr- "

"Oh my fucking stars! Adora! W ould you knock it off?" Catra huf fs.

"Right, yeah, sorry ." Catra gives her a look.

"Adorait'. s fine, really. Idont wanna do anything you're uncomfortable with. But I *really* dont like the fact that you wont talk to me about whatever's going on with you." Adora chances a glance at Catra's face and darts her eyes back to her lap when she registers the tender expression. t' s not the first time Adora's seen that look over the last week.

"m-ugh." She groans, cutting of f her apology before she can be scolded for it, and buries her hands in her face.

"Adora, what is going on with you? W e keep ending up here. We *really* dont have toy.ou know , if that's not something you want. I Im worried that you keep saying it is because you think it' s what *I* want to hear or something."

Adora looks up at herwell Adora *still* hasnt brought up that particular subject. Which Adora feels weird about. She knows she should just *talk* to Catra butshe' s nervous, she feels totally out of her depth. Especially on top of her complete inability to round the bases without freaking out. "t' s not that."

"Okay , so what is it? Because I gotta tell you Dora, this," She gestures between the two of them. "I really isn't working for me anymore."

"*Fuck*," Adora's voice breaks, "I'm *sorry* Catra."

"Adora, please stop apologizing to me. I just want us to have like, an open conversation about this." They're quiet for a minute, Catra giving Adora a searching look. "Adora, have you." Adora shakes her head quickly , tightly. "Got it. So, what *have* you?"...

Adora lets out a shaky breath and blushes deeply. "Well are we really talking about this?"

"I think we should."

Adora stares at her a minute then nods. "Right well I've not had sex."

"Okay , I figured. What about what *we've* done so far, was any of that new?"

"I mean, other than the stars?" Adora shakes her head.

"Okay , and more?"

"Um less clothes. I made someone," Her voice goes high and pinched. She can't believe she's talking about this, and with *Catra* . Catra, who still isn't wearing a shirt. "I like, *finish* once? But um I mean there were never uh, *no* clothes. Like I didn't directly… whatever." She waves her hands and drops *that* like a hot potato. "And I mean *I've* never"...

Catra gives her a sharp look. "Never?" Adora shakes her head shyly . "Adora are you telling me you've never had an orgasm?" Adora shakes her head again. "By yourself?"

Adora blushes deeper and tilts her head side to side. "I mean I think I've gotten close? B-by myself but it's not like I *try* super often."

"Do you want to"?

"Masturbate more"? Adora is so taken of f guard by the direction they're going she doesn't think to be embarrassed at asking that so frankly.

Catra rolls her eyes. "I mean sure, but no Princess. I'm asking if you want to come. Like are you interested in having sex to begin with"?

Adora flounders, sputtering. "What, you mean like right now"?

"What"? Catra looks surprised at the question. "No, Adora, not right... Adora, baby do you think you might be ace"?

"Um, that's actually something Bow, and I have talked about a lot… and I mean, I think so? Like somewhere on the spectrum at least. I… it's definitely never been like, a priority for me and my interest level kind of ebbs and flows. But I mean, I am curious, and I've always thought when the right"... She blinks back tears. "I thought I'd just know, you know"?

"Adora... can I ask; how did you feel about your previous physical relationships? Like, during a fter , whatever."

"Um I... mean there were parts I liked, that felt good. I guess I always just felt pretty timid? And like, definitely awkward. I guess when I've done like, *oral* or whatever, well no one else I've... No one else has *stopped* , if I freeze up. I mean I said it was okay! Or well, just kept going so... But *you're* the only one who"... She trails of f, watching Catra's morphing expressions.

"Oh, *Adora* , babe come here." She pulls Adora toward her body , cradling her to her chest, one hand combing through her hair. "Dora we won't do anything without your consent, okay? *Y* ou're full, enthusiastic consent. I don't want I... mean I want *you*, oh my stars, baby I want you so bad. But not at the expense of your comfort." Warm tears drip from Adora's eyes and she watches them drip down her nose and onto Catra's chest, sliding between her cleavage.

"Okay ." The sit there for another minute, Catra just combing her fingers through Adora's hair, rocking slightly. "Catra I want you too. I *do*." Catra kisses the top of her head and Adora thinks she can feel her smiling. "I don't want you to think I'm just nervous, I think."

"Thanks for telling me that Dora." She pulls back and Adora reluctantly disentangles herself, wiping at her eyes and cheeks. "So, what do you want?"

"What do I want?"

"Yeah Adorable." Catra laughs. "Come on, clearly just feeling it out isn't working for us, so what do you want?"

"I feel shy ."

Catra smiles patiently. "Okay what if I ask you as we go?"

"That sounds good." Adora nods, a slight tremor in her voice and hands. When Catra resumes her position on top of Adora she shakes even harder with arousal.

Catra takes Adora's hands in her own and kisses her finger tips. "Is this okay?" Adora nods quickly . Catra leans in close, her lips a breath away from Adora's. "Adora, can I kiss you?" Adora closes the distance herself. Catra smiles against her lips. This kiss is nothing like what they were doing before, that was all fireworks and pop rocks, stars bursting and shooting across the room. Now their movements are slow, tender, and achingly sweet. The stars left rolling around the couch pulse, soft and steady. It's driving Adora *crazy* .

Catra drags her lips to the corner of Adora's jaw . She kisses behind Adora's ear. When she whispers the breath tickles and it sends a shiver all the way through Adora's body. "Do you like it when I kiss you here?"

"Mmm m-hmm." Adora moans softly .

She moves down another inch. "What about here baby?"

"*Catra*."Adora whines.

"Tell me what you want Adora."Catra teases, never taking her lips off her neck.

"There."Adora breaths. Catra kisses her , sucking lightly and then dragging her teeth across the spot. Adora barely recognizes the sounds she's making as coming from her. Catra gives the spot one last peck. Pulling back, she slides her fingers to the bottom of Adora's shirt.

"And this? Can Itake your shirt Dora?"Adora nods, slower this time, and raises her arms. They only break eye contact when Adora's face is covered by her shirt. She's vaguely aware of the arching trail of stars the shirt leaves in the air as it flies off to the tide. The stars slowly fall to the ground like a melting, shimmering rainbow. Adora is left in her jeans and a cotton bralette. Catra stares at her , mouth slightly agape. "Fuck, Adora. Y oure so sexy."Adora shifts awkwardly.

When she does, she notices Catra bites her lip tightly. She raises an eyebrow and gives another experimental wiggle. Catra lets loose a high-pitched gasp. A flash of stars stretches out of her mouth like a visible echo. "*Catra*."Adora breathes. "I want."She doesnt even really know *what* she wants, what she's asking for. She just wants more of Catra doing *that*. She darts her eyes between Catra's lap and her bitten lip.

Catra watches her for a moment, then shifts so that she's straddling just one of Adora' s legs. "Like that?"

"I dontis.that good? For you Imean."She watches her face.

Catra blinks at her a couple times then grinds down onto Adora's thigh, eyes closing, and lip caught. "Mm- *hm*."

Adora has to fight to keep her own eyes open, she doesn't want to miss a moment of this. But when Catra shifts her knee grinds into Adora and the seam of her jeans digs in *just so*. "More, *please*." Catra's eyes flutter open and she watches Adora as she braces her hands on her shoulders and begins to find a rhythm. Adora digs her fingers into Catra's hips, throwing her head onto the back of the couch with closed eyes.

"Adora, baby, I want to take off my pants. Is that, mm *please*, I wanna be closer to you." Adora flips her head up and nods eagerly. She watches Catra scurry off her lap and slip her pants off. She moves to come back but Adora stills her by grabbing onto her hips.

She looks up to Catra's face, her expression is dopey and so, so sexy. "Can I just." She darts her eyes back down to Catra's exposed skin. The lace of her panties the same as her bra but dark red instead of black. "Is this okay?"

"Anything you want Adora, just… *please*." Adora nods and turns her attention back to what's directly in front of her face. Not taking her hands off Catra's hips, she runs her thumbs beneath the edge of Catra's underwear. She follows the V shape of Catra's inner thighs to the place where they meet, feeling the untamed hair that peeks out. Catra lets out a shuddering breath, bracing herself with her hands on Adora's shoulders. "*Fuck*, Adora."

Adora can scarcely *believe* how turned on she is. She looks up to Catra's face and finds her looking down, watching her with heavily lidded eyes. She looks back down, leans forward and gives a gentle kiss on Catra's underwear, right above where she assumes her clit to be. Catra gasps, her eyes flying open wide. "Ca-Catra?" Adora ventures. "Do you do you *want* your underwear on?"

Catra blinks at her, her expression a mix of disbelief and tentative hope. "Fuck *no* I don't want them on."

Adora nods. "Cool." She hooks her fingers into the waistline of Catra's underwear and pauses before finally, *finally*, tugging them

down. Adora's visions floods with so many stars she can't see Catra at first.

"*Oh*, baby your stars. *Fuck*, I can see *it*. I can see." She groans and her head lolls to the side for a moment. "Please Adora, just… *please*."

Adora nods but doesn't move otherwise. She's just *staring* at Catra's cunt. Her pussy. It's… "Stunning Catra, you're stunning." She leans forward, giving Catra another soft kiss. She hears Catra sigh above her and feels her squeeze her shoulders tightly. On instinct she gives an experimental flick of her tongue and Catra's grip becomes like a vice.

"*Oh, holy stars!* Adora… that's oh, it's so good." Spurred on Adora licks her again, eventually finding a rhythm that has Catra going wild above her. She sort of slides down and still has to crane her neck funny to make it work. It's well worth whatever crick in the neck she's sure to face later if it means seeing Catra like *this*. "Faster… please, just a little." A gasp. "*Faster*." Adora does as she's told, switching *from a back and forth movement to rubbing circles with her tongue. In practically no time at all Catra's thighs are quaking. Dragging her nails across Adora's skin one hand moves from her shoulder to grab a handful of her hair. She grips it tightly, pressing them closer together. It turns Adora on even more and her tongue moves even faster. Catra starts positively yowling, muttering gibberish, occasionally the word 'stars' or Adora's name slips out. Stars explode around Catra's head, then each of those stars explode into more stars, the cycle continuing exponentially. As Catra comes they freeze in the air. All too soon she collapses in a heap, half bent over Adora. The stars relax and begin drifting slowly back to earth.*

Adora rubs soothing circles into her hips with her thumbs. When Catra's breathing begins to slow she murmurs, "Catra that was so… fuck, that was the hottest thing that's ever."

Catra slides down until she's on her knees in front of Adora. She takes both of her hands in her own, lifting one pair she looks at

Adora' s chin ith a sirk, her eyes are still all aw and stars and wonder . "Y eah, baby . Me too."

Adora f urrows her brow . "But you' ver ight?"

Catra' s she sof tens. "Y eah but never Adora you literally ade y m head explode ith stars. Ive never." She shakes her head. "Not like that." Adora she s, leased ith herself . Catra giggles at the expression. "D you ant e to?" She strokes Adora' s thigh f irly , asking her intention clear .

"I'…

"I ant to, ow or he never . Whatever you ant."

Adora nods slowly . "I think not. Not right now . But I really liked that, hat e just did." She she s tentatively .

Catra giggles, "Y eah, babe, e too." She reaches up, letting Adora' s lef t hand go, and cups her cheek, stroking across it ith her thumb. "Thankyou. " She hispers. Adora just nods shyly .

"I ant"…

"Anything, lease tell e"

"I think I just ant to hold you, if that' s okay." Catra she s arily and nods. She stands on shaky legs and reclaims Adora' s hand so she's holding both again. She alks backards, leading Adora to her bedroom. She tells her to ait and slips into the bathroom. When she comes back, she guides them so that Adora is sponing her . They f all asleep like that in the idst of a sof t ocean of stars.

Of course, Adora is still in jeans and Catra never bothered to turn lights out so they ake up a couple hours later , in the iddle of the night. Both groggy ith sleep, they exchange f ew ords, not even bothering to discuss hether or not Adora ill spend the night. With sleepy , dopey she s they brush their teeth, turn lights out and get

Adora into something more comfortable for sleeping. Adora falls asleep now being spooned by Catra, Melog hops on the bed and curls up against her. She falls asleep to the lingering stars blinking softly to the sound of their purring.

Catra wakes the following morning and Adora wakes up to a kiss on her forehead as Catra sets a note on the bedside table. She manages to drag her back to bed for a quick snuggle. After five minutes Catra drags herself away, giggling at Adora's sleepy pout. She hadn't slept much longer after Catra left but waking up alone in the house was surprisingly cozy. It was like waking up to Catra's presence even in her physical absence. Hazy stars drifted in the air around her.

In the days since they'd really only seen each other in passing at Perfuria. It made Adora hate going to work more than ever. They wouldn't be seeing each other at all tomorrow. Adora had an early meeting and Catra had plans in the evening. Plus, she was in for an early night so she could open the café the following morning. But tomorrow marked one week until Catra's birthday and Adora would not allow her plans to fall apart before they even began. She was calling in reinforcements, all she was sending Bow to Perfuria in the morning but same difference.

"Ad don't forget the card!" She reminded him from the doorway to the living room

"Adora, chill! I won't forget." Bow assured her, not for the first time

today, okay, you're right. I know you've got this. It just might not make sense without the card."

Glimmer scoffed, pausing her video game to look at her. "Adora, it's bubble bath. I'm sure she'll get it with or without the card."

"It's not just-ugh! Mind your business Gen." Alora huffs. "It wasn't just bubble bath, it was fancy solid bubble bath and a fizzy thing that was apparently not the same as bubble bath. Alora was more of a ten-minute shower kind of person but the sales person had assured her they were both very relaxing. She'd have to take their word for it. "Thankyou, Bev. I know I'm being…"

"Super uptight about this?" Gen supplies.

"A little overzealous, I just want her to like it. You don't think it's too much right? She said she doesn't like the lead up but I thought it could be nice. But maybe it's too much. I don't know, what do you guys think?" She bites her lip and shifts around awkwardly.

"Alora, we told you; it's not too much, it's sweet." Bev assures her.

"Yeah, your girlfriend is gonna love being wooed, stop stressing so much."

"I'm not wooing - it's her birthday. Besides she isn't my girlfriend!"

"Oh, so stupid. Why not? I thought you were gonna talk to her."

"I did talk to her Gen!"

"No, no. From the sounds of it you fooled around with her."

"Gen!" Surprisingly it's Bev who admonishes her. "Don't slut shame Alora, she can fool around with whoever she wants, in a relationship or not."

"Thankyou Bev"

"But she's definitely in a relationship now, so the point is kinda moot, I guess.

"You two are unbelievable!"

"Aw, thankyou."

but a comment BW

"You know, you probably should talk to Cora about the fact that you're in a relationship. It's always good to BE

I'm sorry, is that like, a thing? I've never heard that before, BD I just like, somehow miss the boat on that one?

"Adora."

Dyn.. stars, you're a couple of busybodies. I'll talk to her, okay? I'm just waiting for a moment."

"What moment?" Glimmer demands.

"I dunno." She admits, shifting under her friend's gaze. "Just when it feels right, I guess."

"Adora," Bow says softly before Glimmer can snark back. "I get it, and definitely wait until you feel good about having that conversation. But if what you're waiting for is a moment when suddenly it doesn't feel so intimidating to be vulnerable and up front with your feelings? Well, it's probably never going to come."

Adora considers the both of them for a minute. "I'm going to bed." She announces and turns on her heal. She ignores her friends' protestations, calling over her shoulder, "Goodnight! Thanks for doing that of f for me tomorrow BW"

Adora walks out of her meeting the next morning feeling extra resentful. That definitely could have been in an email. It's half nine by the time she makes it to her desk but when she checks there's still no notification from Bow. She slams her phone on her desk face down. The sound is loud enough that her supervisor shoots a disapproving look her way. She sinks sheepishly back and pulls up her email. This job is so dumb, she's basically an assistant to an

assistant. She barely even understands what this company does. Maybe Cora is right, maybe she should leave.

She groans as she types out an email, reiterating the same thing she already told this person on Friday. She needs coffee, she checks her phone again. Still nothing. Grabbing she gets up to go to the breakroom. When she looks at the sputtering pot of burned coffee, she thinks better of it and just gets hot water for the green tea she keeps at her desk. Back at her desk she finally gets into her groove but at eleven she realizes she's been on hold with Kytis office for over half an hour. She picks up her phone again. 6 Messages.

She unlocks it and reads what Bow sent first.
Happy day 1 of Cora's bday week!
Just dropped it off.'
She said I should tell you ur an idiot'
But I liked it tho. Ur a lil weird'

Aurora grins like a fool, like an idiot. The hold music changes and she flips to her conversation with Cora.

U an idiot'
Cute tho'

'Aw, u like me'

The response is almost instantaneous. Don't get ahead of urself Princess.'

*Uuuu

‘Ad a sap
Pr sure that card gave me a cavity’
Ill be sending u a bill f rom my dentist’

Bl

Im not saying it’

‘y tho’

Bc I don’t like u’

Do too’ She sends a puty f ace f or good measure.

Ctra doesn’t immediately respond so Aora f lips back to her conversation with Bo to thank him f or running that errand. She drops her phone again, snaping it back up when it chimes a couple minutes later .

Whatever .’
Maybe a little.’

Aora sends back a string of hearts in rainbow order ,f inally connecting to the Kytis of f ice as she hits send.

The nek day she has to wait even longer bef ore she hears f rom Ctra. Her phone chimes around two in the af ternoon. She managed to sneak in an extra breakby of f ering to grab some decent cof f ee f or her boss too. She pauses, steping of f to the side out of the f low of f oot traf f ic and pulls out her phone. Her heart leaps when she sees it’s a message f rom Ctra.

So. I just got a v ebarrassing delivery .’

Aora grins and sends back the little purple devil f ace. As soon as it sends, she decides, f uck it, and dials Ctra’ s number . She answers pretty quickly but there’ s some shuf f ling and talking in the

background bef ore Adora hears her voice greeting her . Adora can hear the sound of a grinder whirring in the background being cut of f by the clickof a door.She must have slipped into the of f ice.

"Hey Princess."

"How do they look?" Adora asks eagerly , without preamble.

Catra sighs,it' s somehow both impatient and tender . "You're ridiculous."

That' s been established. How do they look?

She can practically hear the eyeroll she gets in response but Catra' s words are colored with sweetness. "They're beautif ul Dora,you really didn't have to."

"Well,sure. But I wanted to."

"You know there' s still six days till my birthday , right?

"Aware,yes."

There' s a beat of silence and then,"Holy f ucking stars."

"What?" Adora asks,blinking in genuine surprise.

"You didn't."

"Uh.

Is this some kind of f ucking countdown or something?

Birthday week!" Adora' s excitement bleeds into her words.

"Adora ." Something in Catra' s tone tempers her excitement.

"Oh,uh too much?" She f eels emotion jackat her eyes and anxiety threatening to build in her chest. Like darkclouds rolling in bef ore a

thunderstorm

Cora sighs again. "Not exactly. It's really not necessary though."

"Well, I mean necessity wasn't really the point." Aora defends, but her tone is more apologetic than defensive.

The silence stretches long and Aora absently wonders how long she has to get back before her boss gives her shit. She'll be coming with coffee though, so that should help. "You're really sweet, you know that?"

"Well I, uh." So, not too much then? Aora's a little lost, unsure if she should be anxious or proud. "You said you didn't like the lead up so I just thought I'd- I'm sorry if it if I was-" Aora sighs

"Hey listen." Cora trails off, as if she didn't know what she wanted Aora to listen to in the first place. When she speaks again her voice is quiet. "I don't wanna wait till tomorrow to see you."

Something like hope sparks in Aora's chest, warm like stars. "Me neither."

"Hey. Good. Can you come over after work? I can make us dinner." *Aora smiles, already ready for the end of the day.*

"Yeah, that works."

"Great."

"Listen, I should get going but"…

"Mm"

"I'll see you later, okay?"

"Sounds good Princess, I'll see you soon."

"Yeah, soon. Bye."

She disconnects the call and takes a moment to gather herself before continuing toward the coffee shop. The line moves slowly, and she gets back to the office red faced and out of breath. Her boss doesn't say anything about it, or about how long it took. It makes her wish she hadn't run down the street like a total goof, but whatever. By the time she's settled at her desk again she has less than two hours to go. They pass surprisingly quickly and before long she's parking in front of Astra's place.

Affled "Come in!" comes from inside the house when she knocks, and the door opens easily. She notices a blog scamper into the bedroom as she walks in, a star shooting right behind him. Something smells phenomenal and she follows her nose and a trail of stars to the kitchen where Astra is stirring a saucepan diligently. "Hey babe, you mind grabbing that wine for me?"

Amora looks around her and drops her bag. She spots the bottle on the island and walks over to Astra. "Hey."

Astra glances behind her and reaches for the bottle. "Thanks."

Amora pulls it out of reach. "Uh, what'll you give me for it."

Astra rolls her eyes with a smile. "Eh, all I was planning to give you dinner."

"Yeah, that was in exchange for the pleasure of your company. Here I am and I've got something else you want, so." She shakes the bottle tauntingly.

"Alright all I can't stop stirring this. So, what do you want?"

Amora pretends to think carefully. "Think you could stir and kiss at the same time?"

"Guess we'll just have to try it and find out." Amora smiles and leans in. As her eyes close and stars begin to crowd at the corners of her

vision, she feels the bottle snatched out of her hand. Her eyes pop open to see a smirking Catra pouring wine into the pan.

"Hey!"

"Sorry Princess, I'm cooking here. Very serious business. I can't allow any distractions."

"Oh, you owe me, I've promised payment for that wine!"

Catra snorts. "What, like love you for all Marvin Gardens?"

"Exactly like Marvin Gardens, and thank you for finally admitting that you totally screwed me during that game."

"By stars above Adora, let it go."

"You're the one who brought it up."

"Really? But how I remember it."

"You're impossible."

"If you pull a glass out, I'll pour you some wine." Adora grumbles but goes to the cabinet. Catra owes her twelve-hundred or-so dollars and Adora will get her due. One of these days. It doesn't take much longer to finish the risotto. Soon enough they're settled on the couch eating, an aloof Mog perched as far away from them as possible.

"Catra, this is amazing!" Adora says around a mouth full of rice. "So garlicky."

"You're disgusting. And yeah, it ought to be. I put like eighty cloves in there."

Adora swallows thickly. "Hey." Catra turns to her. "Thanks for having me over tonight. I know you have an early morning."

Astra's expression softens. "Yeah, I'm glad it worked out. Thanks. For the flowers. I didn't intend. I hope I didn't sound ungrateful."

Aora smiles shyly and shakes her head. "No good. I'm glad you like them."

"You're an idiot." Aora shrugs, she unwavering. "Caring, but still."

"Aw, you think I'm caring."

"Pft, like a golden retriever."

"Now that is a good dog." Mog adjusts just then with a harrumph and Aora wonders if he can understand her. She reaches over and scratches his chin. "You're a good dog too Mog." Astra makes a sound of indignation but Mog just purrs loudly and leans into her hand. Stars crowd around the spots she scratches for him

"So does this mean I'm getting a present tomorrow too then?"

Aora looks up, trying to gauge Astra's tone. She looks… mischievous. What's new. I mean that's sort of the whole concept of birthday week."

"Right, right." She trails off, setting her plate on the coffee table. Then she delicately takes Aora's and sets it there too, while Aora watches suspiciously. Astra leans back, her hand slowing to a stop much to Mog's obvious displeasure. Then suddenly Astra pounces on her, nearly knocking her over and scaring Mog of completely. "What did you get me?"

Aora cackles. "I'm not telling you that!"

Astra, now straddling her lap puts dramatically. "Why not?"

"It's a surprise, that's the whole point."

"That's dumb."

is not."

Cora's expression grows mischievous again. "But I could convince you."

Aora blushes, looking Cora up and down. She takes note of the stars that drift around her and she's honest when she says, "Yeah, I bet you could too. But I would be really bummed out if I ruined the surprise." She sticks her bottom lip out to punctuate the sentiment.

Cora eyes her warily for a moment, then gets off with a huff. She grabs her plate, passing Aora's back also, and settles back in her seat. "Aw, you're no fun."

"Eh, what are you talking about? I'm like, so super fun."

"Well you just ruined my fun."

"Nah, I delayed it, thereby increasing your ultimate level of enjoyment."

"Stars, you're a dork. Eat your rice Aora." She does as she's told with a happy hum. She really is glad she got to see Cora tonight, it's nice. Even if Cora's early wake up means she's walking out the door at eight thirty. Cora had told her she was getting banished at eight actually but neither of them had exactly been watching the clock after dinner.

"We didn't expect you home tonight." Dar teases from the couch when Aora walks in the door.

"What are you talking about?" She asks with a laugh. "I told you guys I was just going to Cora's for dinner."

Her turns to give her a look over the back of the couch. "Well, plans change."

"How was your night? I take it the f lowers went over well?" Bri is sitting on the f loor in f ront of her . Amber af ter her asks he's pausing his video game to turn and look at Alora. She walks over to f lop in the chair .

"Y eah, it was great! I'm pretty sure it went over well. In the end at least." Alora purses her lips and Amber sits up properly .

"What does that mean?

"Nothing, she said she liked them."

"Uhuh, what else did she say?

Alora grunts noncommittally . "It's really not a big deal, it was just like a little weird when I talked to her right af ter she got there. She realized what I was doing this weekend I don't really remember what she said. Just like, that it wasn't necessary but it's sweet and then she asked me to come over ."

"A ha!" Bri bursts out. "Alora's going out!

"Shut up, I am not!"

"Y ou are so though." Amber taunts. "Have you established that you're def initely girlf riends yet?

"I am because we aren't girlf riends!"

"Y ou're a f ool Alora Greyson."

"Alora," Bri interjects, much calmer than his partner . "don't you want to be girlf riends?

"W ell, I mean sure. But it's f ine, I just like spending time with her ."

"Y eah, but do you want to be exclusive?

Okay, don't you two talk about like, everything? I assumed Cora already told you about our conversation at the all honestly." Aurora's friends' sheepish looks she rolls her eyes. "It's fine, if I tell one of you, I don't care if the other knows."

Okay, well Cora might have mentioned that you expressed some desire to be exclusive. Aurora do you do you think that the same thing that's keeping you from broaching the subject with Cora is the same thing that's, uh," Bow's ears turn red.

"What?"

"That's keeping you from, well," he makes a vague gesture that Aurora doesn't understand. When he doesn't elaborate, she looks to Cora who rolls her eyes.

"Oh heavens, he's asking if it's the same reason you can't fuck your girlfriend."

"Cora!"

"What? Am I wrong?"

"Well no," he admits. "But I wasn't gonna phrase it quite so"...

"Directly?"

He gives her a disapproving look. Sassily," looking back to Aurora he adds, "But yeah, do you think it stems from the same insecurity."

"I mean, maybe? We've talked a little bit about the physical stuff. And like, done more since you and I talked. Um"

"Right, you mentioned. Do you still shut down when she tries to reciprocate though?"

"Uh." Aurora flushes deeply.

"Aora," it's Ben addressing her again. "I know you've all you've always been good at loving us, but you've come a long way since we met you when it comes to expressing that love and also, letting us love you."

Okay." She's not sure where he's going with this.

"Are you ready to let Extra love you?"

"Ben, Extra doesn't love me. We've only been dating a few weeks."

"So that's a yes then." Ben says with a roll of her eyes. "Don't you love her already?"

Aora blanches, she thinks she hears Ben say something else but can't hear him over the ringing in her ears. "What?"

"I said, I think maybe it would be good to sit with your feelings. We're here if you want to talk and process but Aora," Ben waits until she looks him in the eyes to finish. "be radically honest with yourself, okay? It's scary but worth it, I promise."

"Okay, okay. I'll try I guess."

Her friends let the subject drop after that, shifting the conversation to Meg who Ben is dying to meet. Aora is distracted though; Ben's words ring in her ears the rest of the night and into the morning. She's not sure what he expects her to come up with. Do her friends do they think she's already in love with Extra? Is that even possible?

Aora is quiet the next night at dinner. She's taken Extra to her favorite Italian place, not far from the shop and her old place. Extra can definitely tell something is up. Aora's efforts to compensate for her distraction only serve to make it more obvious. She can't seem to fight off the memory of Ben and Ben's advice, what they

asked her. She keeps looking at Catra and wondering. Is this feeling love? She supposes she does love Catra in some capacity, but is that different than being in love? Is the distinction just the underlying romance of their connection, or is it something else? And as far as Catra loving her she's not willing to hope for that. Not yet at least.

Catra reaches across the table to take hold of Adora's hand, startling her out of her thought. "Hey, are you alright? You seem super in your head tonight."

"I'm fine!" She assures with forced cheeriness.

Far from fooled Catra looks pointedly at Adora's nearly full plate and back to her face. "Oh, really?"

Adora sighs and more genuinely answers, "I am, really. I just saw and Glimmer got on my case last night."

Catra's face shifts to a small scowl. "Oh, do you wanna talk about it?"

With a shake of her head Adora tells her, "I'll maybe later. It just gave me a lot to think about." She knows she's ignoring a perfect opportunity to talk, but she bypasses it anyway. "I'm sorry I'm not super present tonight."

"Totally fine. But I'm here, if you decide you wanna talk."

Adora smiles and she can feel it reach her eyes for the first time since last night. "Thanks. I think I think I will. Eventually. I just…" She rolls her eyes, "Gods I should be radically honest with myself. Like what does that even mean?"

Catra appraises her. "I dunno babe, is there shit you're repressing?"

She's surprised at the direct question. "I don't know, maybe?"

"Well I think that's your answer, sounds like he's just encouraging you to dig that shit up." She gives Adora a weird look. "It's not bad

advice."

Alora nods slowly. "Right. Right." There is quiet for a long time, then Extra jumps and grabs her wallet out.

"Shit, I almost forgot! Someone left something at the cafe for you?"

"What?" Alora asks bewildered. "Who?"

Extra shrugs. "I think she said her name is." She looks down at the slip of paper she pulled from her wallet. "Belle, yeah. She liked your art and wanted to talk to you about some sort of opportunity."

Alora takes the paper and looks at it. It's a name, phone number and email address. "What?"

"Yeah, it was kind of busy, so we didn't get into it too much. She just said she's working on a book or something and is looking for an illustrator."

"Pft, okay, all I'm not an illustrator." She folds the paper backup and looks up to see Extra looking at her like she just said something wildly stupid. "What?"

"Come on Princess."

"What?" She repeats.

Extra lets out a long-suffering sigh. "Nothing, never mind."

"No, what are you gonna say?"

"Alora, I know this is something you could do. All of our friends know this is something you could do. I just." She sighs again and glares at her food for a moment before looking back up. "I really looking forward to the day you figure it out too."

"Ok." Alora answers, sobered.

"Just think about it, okay?"

"Yeah, okay. I'll think about it."

The rest of their meal is still relatively quiet, but far more companionable. Adora drives Catra home and follows her inside to give her today's gift. They set upon the couch and Adora hands it over."

"Oh! It's big." She shakes it around and squeezes it. "Squishy too, what the fuck did you get me?"

"You'll find out if you ever open it." Adora tells her with a laugh.

"Yeah, yeah." Catra is not the least bit delicate opening the immaculately wrapped gift. She tears the paper to shreds and gasps at what's inside. "So soft!" She rubs her face against the fleecy blanket.

"I'm glad you like it. I still think it's freakish that you managed to go nearly twenty-six years without a single throw."

"You know historically I would have fought you on that. This is just…so soft though." She has the blanket half unfolded in her lap and is practically kneading the damn thing. Stars grow from the spots her hands touch like rising bread. "Right, I want to be snuggled under this thing the rest of the night, if not the rest of my damn life. Wanna watch a movie or something?"

Adora does absolutely want that, so they both change into some of Catra's sweats and snuggle on the couch. As Adora drifts off half way through the movie, stars lingering in the corners of her vision, she can't help but think, she may not understand exactly how she feels about Catra, but she definitely loves this.

Chapter End Notes

Woot! And they're off! This chapter was supposed to include Catra's actual birthday too but then the chapter got really long so...next time!

Basically all I do anymore is listen to the playlist I made for this story that I linked in a previous chapter and write this story . It's a gooood time. I've now hit over **[illegible]** words written for this story which is a *huge* personal milestone. So, so cool! Thanks so much to everyone reading and double thanks to those who have left comments/kudos and/or bookmarked this story!

Solar Return

Chapter Notes

cw: Things get spicy at toward the end of the chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra's birthday is tomorrow. Catra's birthday is tomorrow and Adora is questioning basically everything in her life that has led her to this moment. *What was she thinking?* It's too late to go to anywhere to get a new gift so this is all she has. She's a fool. Honestly, she hadn't thought *that* much of it when she picked it out. She'd mostly allowed herself to forget about it until Bow had asked what the last gift was. So, she had told him, and he'd just been so… *Bow* about it. His eyes went glassy and his expression was so tender it was hard to look at. So yes, she's definitely thinking this through *now*.

It was too much.
Now, actually thinking about giving it to Catra it made her feel exposed in ways she hadn't even looked at herself yet. Apparently that whole 'radical honesty' thing wasn't working out so well for her. She flipped open the book and read the inscription on the inside cover. It was written in Spanish, but she knew the translation by heart.
"My heart,
When I am far from you hold these words close. When I am near to you hold me even closer.
Your love, A
May 15th, 1992"

She traces her finger over the grooves the words left in the paper. It had felt so right when she found it. She was going to write an inscription of her own by the existing one, of course she had no idea what she would say. She had figured she'd just wing it. She rubs her hands up and down her face with a groan, standing abruptly from her

desk. No one is in the living room when she walks out but she hears music coming from the studio. She pokes her head in the door and finds Bow at the piano, squinting at a sheet of music.

"Hey , what're you working on?"

Bow looks up, seeming unsurprised to see Adora standing in the doorway. "Maple Leaf." Adora looks at him blankly . "Scott Joplin?" Adora raises an eyebrow. "It's a ragtime song."

"Oh fun!" Adora responds, tracking finally . "Can I hear?"

"Uh, yeah. There's a couple parts that are still a little rough." He warns, she doesn't respond and just joins him on the piano bench. The song is fun and upbeat, Bow hardly stumbles at all. Stars dance on top of the piano and along the keys to the rhythm of the music, cartwheeling off Bow's fingers. Adora claps as he finishes, and the stars almost seem to clap alongside her.

"Yay! Bow , that sounds so good!"

"Thanks! I've been working hard on this one."

"You really have, and it's paying off. I'm really proud of you."

"Aw, Adora! You know, it feels really good to learn something new. It's been really soothing to have a new form of expression. What time is it though? I thought you were heading to bed a while ago." Adora groans. "Uh-oh, you wanna talk about it?"

"It's just this book."

Bow nods, shuffles his sheet music and starts to play something slower. Adora recognizes it from when he started learning it a few weeks ago. She thinks she remembers him saying it was Bach. "What's the issue?"

"I just I'm not even sure it's about the book honestly. I just feel so uncertain all the time. *Especially these days* , with everything going

on with Catra." Bow doesn't say anything, just keeps playing, leaving room for Adora to process. "I feel like, lost, I guess? I'm confused and I'm not sure I know what I want or how to ask for it even if I did."

"Adora, just try to let yourself be selfish for a minute, no judgement, doesn't have to leave this room. What does your life look like if you could change what isn't working for you?"

Adora huffs, a big breath that ruffles the stray hairs that have fallen from her ponytail. "I'd love to quit my job. I'm not even sure what I'd want to do instead. I just *hate* being in that office all day." She shrugs in lieu of contemplating that further. "I want to be exclusive with Catra and I wish I wish the intimacy stuff could come a little easier. I dunno, my life is so good now, and it feels like it took so long to feel settled. How do I ask for more when I already have more than I ever imagined having?"

Bow doesn't answer for a long time, the only sound in the room is his continued playing. "It's okay to want things Adora."

"Then why do I feel so *guilty* for wanting them?" Bow's music halts and he gathers Adora into his arms. The gesture makes her cry like a baby, and soon she can feel a damp spot on her shoulder where Bow's head rests.

They stay like that for a while, Bow rubbing a hand up and down across Adora's shoulder. With a tight squeeze Bow pulls away, one hand wipes at his eyes and the other holds tight to her shoulder. "I can't totally answer that for you Adora, but if I had to guess? The world wasn't always kind to you, and you learned to accept so much less than you deserve. But Adora, you *deserve* to be loved and you *deserve* to feel fulfilled. That isn't too much to ask for."

"Thanks Bow."

"Anytime. And for what it's worth? That book is an amazing gift."

"You think?" She asks hopefully.

"Come on Adora, it's super romantic."

"It's not…*too* romantic though, is it?"

"Maybe just don't overthink this so much buddy." He pats her on the knee gently with a pitying smile. Adora purses her lips but nods.

"Right, I'll try. Anyway, I really should get to bed. You need anything while I'm up?"

He shakes his head. "All good, sweet dreams Adora."

"Yeah, goodnight Bow."

Of course, Adora doesn't go right to bed like she knows she ought to. She sits at her desk, pen in hand, reading and rereading the inscription in Catra's book. Finally, at midnight, she decides to throw caution to the wind and just write what comes. So far, she has, Catra, I so it's going pretty well. She huffs and forces herself to stop thinking and just writes something. She slams the book shut without reading what she's written and practically throws herself into bed.

She wakes up at eight the next morning, which gives her just enough time to wrap the book, get ready and still be able to stop by a shop for flowers on her way to Catra. She rolls up to Catra's at nine-thirty on the dot. She leaves the book in her car but grabs the flowers. Then she's knocking on Catra's door, ready to start this birthday.

They have plans to meet Scorpia and Perfuma for dinner that evening. So, Catra had requested that the rest of the day be pretty unstructured. They were starting with breakfast and going from there. The door swings open, a cloud of stars wafting out to reveal Catra in her birthday best. She has on dark jeans and a crimson, floral button up Adora hasn't seen before, with a black bomber jacket thrown over the top. Her hair is up in a bushy ponytail and she's

smirking at Adora. "W ow, here I was thinking we'd match, and you show up with your hair down."

Adora reaches up to run her fingers through her hair self-consciously. "Oh, well I…

"I like it."

"Y eah?"

Catra rolls her eyes, the corners of her smile glow with stardust. "Dont fish Princess."

"I'm not! Whatever , happy birthday!" She thrusts out the hand holding the flowers.

"Y eah, yeah. Thanks, Adorable, these are beautiful." She accepts the offering and leans her face into the bouquet and closes her eyes as she smells the flowers. Her breath seems to pull stars from between the petals.

Adora shakes her head to clear it. "Y ou ready to go?"

Catra narrows her eyes, expression mischievous. "Hm, you know I feel like I'm forgetting something."

"Okay well no rush."

"Or maybe is it *you* forgetting something? I mean, it is my birthday ."

Adora laughs. "What are you talking about?"

Catra rolls her eyes. "Y ou can be so oblivious, are you gonna kiss me or what?"

"Oh! Right, yeah c'mere." They linger in the doorway for a few minutes until Catra's gurgling belly interrupts them. They pull away, both snickering. "Alright, for real though, you have what you need?"

"Almost, just gotta grab my wallet, put these in water ."

"I mean, you're not gonna need it, but if you want."

"Adora"…

"Nuh-uh, no way . I'm setting the precedent now and I don't want to hear a word about it the rest of the day. You don't pay on your birthday." Catra shakes her head and stands on tiptoes to kiss Adora's cheek.

"You're sweet."

"This is true. Now go get your stuff and let's get out of here."

Catra disappears back into the house and emerges just a minute later, following Adora to her car. She slides in and immediately spots the gift sitting on the back seat. She gasps, like an excited little kid on Christmas morning. "Is that for me?"

Adora eyes it in the rearview mirror as she starts the car. "That? Oh, no it's for the *other* beautiful woman I'm taking out for her birthday today."

"Uh huh, so what I'm hearing is; you think I'm beautiful."

In mock seriousness Adora replies, "Catra if I have made a secret of that fact please, feel free to just kick me to the curb right now ."

Catra laughs and shakes her head. "Alright, Princess. So can I open it?"

A laugh bubbles out of Adora's mouth. "Like right this second?"

"Can I?"

"Catra!"

She crosses her arms and grumbles. "Fine, fine I can be patient." It's quiet for a moment, Adora flips on the stereo and lets Catra plug her phone in. Seemingly unable to contain herself any longer she says, "I'm just so curious how you're gonna top the massive fucking houseplant you snuck into my house yesterday."

Adora blushes and bites her lip. She thinks of the book sitting on the back seat, what is written inside. She pushes it down and forces bravado into her voice. "Psh, well don't get your hopes up. I made sure to leave the worst for last. You know, make it extra anticlimactic."

Catra snorts. "Yeah, you're way too type A to break pattern like that."

"I'm not type A!"

"Hey Princess, you won't find me complaining. The world needs type As, y'all get shit done. You know how hard it is to run a business with two type Bs? Thank god for Scorpia."

"You think Scorpia's type A?"

"Eh, in certain ways. When it comes to problem solving very much so."

"Interesting." Catra shrugs "Am I taking a left here?"

"Nah, next block at the light."

"Got it, thanks." Adora gets through one intersection and turns on her blinker. "So, any thoughts about what you wanna do today?"

"Mm, there's a bookstore close to the diner I wanna hit up. Then I was thinking there's a couple museums I might wanna check out. And I'll honestly probably want to go back to mine for a little bit before dinner, take a nap."

Adora smiles wide. "Sounds like a nice day. Alright, this the place?"

"Fuck yeah, it is! Babe, it's so good, you're gonna plotz." Adora parks and they climb out. Catra snatches her present from the back seat before closing her door. Adora just smirks at her. They're seated quickly in a booth with sparkly vinyl seats. The whole place is a surprisingly successful overlap of an 80s color pallet with 50's mom-n-pop diner vibes. Stars twine around the walls like ivy, which Adora takes as a good sign. The hostess leaves them with menus and water. The both of them start flickering through eagerly. "Should we get fries for the table?"

"Can we even get fries at ten a.m.?"

"Adorable, it's a diner. I can't imagine it'll be a problem. Plus, it's my birthday wish, so." She finishes like that settles the matter.

"*That's* what you're gonna spend your birthday wish on?"

Catra looks up, challenging Adora with a defiant look. "Who said I have to limit myself to *one* birthday wish?"

Adora laughs at her moxy. "You know, I really like you."

Catra's defiant look falters and her returning smile is tentative and genuine. "Well I should hope so."

They just stare at each other for a couple minutes, smiling. Adora's vaguely aware that they must look like a pair of moony-eyed fools, but she can't find it within herself to care. They're eventually interrupted by the waitress coming to take their order. The moment she walks away Catra is eyeing her gift. After a few beats of silence, she reaches over to drag it toward her slowly asking, "So, can I…"

Adora worries her bottom lip. "Yeah, yeah might as well."

Catra wastes no time in shredding off the paper. When she finishes it's upside down, she flips it over and Adora watches as the title comes into focus and her expression turns. It's tender, nostalgic and achingly sweet. Stars crawl lackadaisically across the cover from

where Catra holds the bottom of the book. She looks up at Adora, opening her mouth to say something. Adora cuts her off with the shake of her head. Clearing her throat, she tells her, "Open it."

Catra's brows furrow but she does as she's told. When she looks inside her mouth drops open and her eyes flit to Adora once more before she starts reading. Adora can tell she's reading the original inscription, her smile soft. The aura of stars above the book grows denser and denser as she reads. Then she turns to the opposite side and flips up the dustcover, flicking a spray of stars into the air. A moment into reading her eyes flit to Adora's again and her bottom lip trembles slightly. Adora may not have reread what she wrote last night, but she read it about fifty times this morning. She knows what it says.
"Catra,
Im so glad to be spending your birthday with you this year . Icare for you so deeply and feel so lucky to have met you. Thank you for spending this day with me.
Yours, Adora
October 28th, 2020"

A starry tear rolls down Catra's cheek and she flips through a few pages of the book, not landing on anything longer than a moment. Before long she folds the book closed gently, a few stars pressing out as she does so, leaving one hand resting on the cover. She wipes her face with the back of the other;two more tears slide down to replace what she's dried, but she ignores them. Instead she reaches up and across the table to pull Adora's lip from between her teeth, stroking her thumb over the pink skin gently. "Adora Grey , you fucking asshole."The words are harsh, but her tone is tender .

A small gasp escapes Adora. "Wha- I "

"Ijustcant believe you made me cry on my birthday ."A watery chuckle follows her words and she pulls her hand back to wipe her face again. "Oh, my stars, youre too much."

"Like in a good way?

"Like in the *best* way." Catra gets up and pushes Adora further into her seat so she can slide in after her and snuggle up. "Why are you so nice to me anyway? You like me or something?"

"Pff ft, or something." It doesn't escape Adora that could mean one of two things; something less or something more.

"Noted." Apparently, it doesn't escape Catra either. She rests her head on Adora's should and starts humming a tune Adora doesn't recognize. Adora turns her head to kiss the top of Catra's. It's a nice moment, the kind that feels nostalgic, even as it's playing out. When they see the waitress approaching with their food Catra sits up, clearing her throat. She slips back to her side of the table just as the waitress arrives.

Conversation over breakfast is light and fun. Catra teases Adora and rebukes her when she teases back, reminding her, "It's my *birthday* Adorable, rules say you have to be nice to me." Adora is pleasantly surprised when she doesn't put up a fuss about her taking care of their bill before leading her out of the diner.

"So, bookstore?"

"Yeah, it's close by so we can walk over." Catra leads the way, absently grabbing hold of Adora's hand to guide her. Adora likes it, the casual touch as intimate as it is innocent. The walk is nice too, the streets are lined with large trees and flower baskets hand from lampposts. A light breeze and soft stars tickle at the leaves.

As they come up on the shop Adora asks, "Anything in particular you're looking for in here?"

Catra shakes her head. "Nah, I just like this place." Adora pulls the door open for her and when she follows her in, she freezes immediately and gasps.

She looks at Catra with wide eyes. "*Who is this?*"

"This is Rupert, he's part owner."

Adora laughs. "Excuse me?"

"It's true!"

Adora looks down at the old golden retriever who's ambles over to check them out, a halo of stars around his head like a literal angel, then back to Catra with a misbelieving look. She crouches down to offer her hand to Rupert and scratches behind his ears when she gets the green light. "Well, hello then Rupert. I very much like what you've done with the place. Have you owned the business long?"

"Oh, about fifteen years now." A voice behind Adora makes her jump. "Rupert's the idea man, just keeps me around for the opposable thumbs and all the math." Adora turns to see a woman whose muscles put the gains from her own workout routine to shame. She's also at least a head taller than Adora, who isn't exactly short. Adora's mouth goes dry, she isn't sure if what she's feeling is intimidation, attraction or respect. All she knows is she wants to arm wrestle this person. Well, that and that it would be really weird to do so right now.

She chuckles weakly at the joke. "Gotcha." She winces at her own response.

"Name's Huntara." She offers Adora her hand to shake and Adora takes it. She thinks she sees something like respect in Huntara's eyes when she grips her hand firmly. It bolsters her confidence enough to finally peek at Catra from the corner of her eye. She's just standing with her arms crossed, smirking at Adora.

She clears her throat. "Ah, Adora. Good to meet you."

"Back atcha Blondie." Huntara looks over to Catra. "Good ta see ya again Kitty."

Catra scowls. "Tara, the fuck did I tell you about calling me that?"

Untara just laughs at her. "Nothing I took to heart. Now what are you doing in my shop?"

"Ooh," Catra winces theatrically and sucks her teeth. "Yeah, you're about to feel really bad for being such an ass. It's actually my *birthday*."

"Nah, doesn't make me feel bad. Happy birthday though kid, really. From the bottom of my heart."

Catra throws her arms up in exasperation. "Seriously? Why do I continue to support this business?"

"For Rupert's sake I assume."

Catra eyes the dog. "You know I'm a cat person Tara." Her goofy grin when Rupert wags his tail as their eyes meet gives her away. Adora reaches down and scratches his ears again when Catra turns back to Untara. She watches the women's exchange with possibly a bit more intensity than it warrants.

"And here I thought you were a friend to *all* living creatures."

"You're thinking of *Perfuma*, I think."

"Say, how is she doing?"

"Good, good. She and Scorpia are getting hitched on the eleventh. You're coming right?"

"I'll be there, still gotta nail down a plus one though." She eyes Adora. "I assume you're taking Blondie over here."

Catra shrugs, just oh so casual, and says, "Yeah."

Adora jumps, this is news to her. "What?"

Catra turns to look at her, eyes narrowed like she's being exceptionally obtuse. "Duh, who were you planning to go with?"

"Uh I wasn't aware I was invited."

Catra rolls her eyes and looks back to Huntara. "Looks like I have my own nailing down to do." Huntara laughs and shakes her head at the pair of them.

She eyes Adora and then Catra. "Yeah, seems like something you might wanna figure out pretty quick kitty." She gives Catra a look that Adora can't even begin to interpret. Then, more lighthearted, she adds, "Wedding's coming up quick."

"Seriously, even on my birthday you're not gonna cut me a break?" Huntara just eyes her. "Right, of course not. We're going to look at books now." She pulls Adora up and drags her away without another word. Huntara's laughter fades as she disappears back into her office.

"She seems nice." Adora offers as they slow so Catra can look at a display on one of the end caps.

Catra side eyes her and smirks. "Hm, you think?" Adora flushes ever so slightly at the implication in Catra's tone and she nods. "Eh, she's nice enough. Pain in my ass though." She picks up a book to read the back and that seems to be the end of that.

Adora follows Catra around for a while after that, not really picking anything up. Mostly she just reads over Catra's shoulder. Finally, after about ten books Catra laughs and shoos her away. "Stars Princess, you have got to stop *lurking* like that."

"Right, sorry." She sort of just stands there and Catra shakes her head fondly.

"Hey, what's your favorite book?"

"Uh"…

"Come on, you show me yours I'll show you mine." She clearly knows the challenge in her tone will be enough to get Adora to go along with this.

"Fine, I'll find you. Bring your book." She stalks off, thinking hard about what to grab. Why is it so hard to pick a favorite book? She finally figures something out. Once she tracks it down by following the trail of stars that rolls out before her after the idea hits, she wonders around until she finds Catra. The minute she sees what Adora is carrying she busts out laughing.

"I'm not sure that counts Adorable."

"Shoulda laid down ground rules before we started, too late now."

"Adora, it's *cook*book!"

"Yes, a cook*book*, totally counts." She smiles smugly and hands the book off to Catra who is still shaking with giggles. "A cake cookbook to be precise. I can literally not think of a single thing I like more than cake, so."

"Alright fair enough."

"What about you?"

"Uh? Oh, right, here ya go." She passes Adora a copy of Fahrenheit 451.

"Good book." Catra shrugs and Adora watches her, something's not adding up. She's not sure if it's intuition, or the glaring lack of stars that dust the cover, but she's not convinced. "This is your favorite?"

"Uh, yeah." Catra continues to read the back of the book she was holding when Adora walked up.

"Of all time? Desert island, you're gonna read Fahrenheit 451 over and over?"

Now Catra looks up, smirking. "I mean if we're going by desert island rules, what the fuck are you gonna do with a *cookbook*?"

Adora shrugs, "If there's a kitchen I'm set and if not, at least I'd have pictures of cake to remember her by."

"Unbelievable"…

"Seriously though, why are you lying?"

"Excuse me? It is my birthday, how dare you?"

"Catra." The birthday girl looks her up and down then scrutinizes her face.

"I mean it is my favorite *adult* book."

"But not your favorite of all time." It's not a question.

Catra huffs. "Fine, you know what?" She scoops up the couple books she'd picked out to buy and grabs Adora's hand. Adora's surprised when she's dragged back to the children's section. She's pushed onto a very tiny stool and Catra gives her a look. "You're very pushy, you know that?"

"You like it."

"Hmm…maybe." Catra wanders off, running her fingers over the spines of the books, a trail of stars following along. She crouches down and seems to find what she's looking for. The trail of stars finishes their path and gather on the cover when Catra pulls the book out. She looks hesitant when she walks back, but she holds the book out to Adora anyway. When Adora takes it, she sits on the ground in front of her.

"The Kissing Hand?" She looks at the cover, two Racoons sit in front of the moon. The larger looks like it's kissing the little one's hand. There are starts twinkling around the moon and along the spine of

the book, soft and cozy looking. It looks sweet, she looks to Catra and every star in the vicinity seems to be migrating toward her.

"Mm hmm." She looks up at Adora and bites her lip. "Read it to me?" Its demand and request in equal measure, and Adora is thrilled to oblige.

She opens the cover, "Chester Racoon stood at the edge of the forest." Catra's eyes don't leave the pages of the book the entire time Adora reads to her. She looks up at Adora with misty eyes when she closes the book.

She clears her throat. "Thanks, I haven't it's been a long time since I actually read it." Adora responds by leaning down to drop a kiss on her forehead. She sniffs and rubs at her eyes, but no tears fall. After a minute she unfolds herself from the ground and pulls Adora up after her, clearing her throat of emotion. While she gathers her things Adora walks back to the place Catra grabbed the book and slides a second copy off the shelf. "What are you doing?"

"Oh, I want a copy too." Adora smiles at her, gesturing with the books.

"What? Adora, no."

Adora frowns, "Oh, you don't already have a copy, do you? You said you hadn't read it in a while so I figured"…

"No, I don't, but- "

"Great!" Adora's smile resumes, and she pries the other books from and open mouthed Catra's weak grasp. "Did you wanna look at anything else?" Brow furrowed Catra shakes her head.

Following Adora to the till, she questions, "Just what do you think you're doing there, Princess?"

"Checking out? You said you're done, right?"

"Adora, no. You already got breakfast, give me those." She stops in her tracks reaching out an expectant hand.

Adora stops and swivels back but holds the books protectively to her chest. "Not the deal, I told you; your money's no good today."

"Well then I'll come back for them another day. Seriously, put them back."

Adora sighs and sets the books on a display next to her. She grabs Catra by the shoulders and cranes her heard to make eye contact with Catra. "Catra, birthday queen, will you please stop being such a brat and let me buy these books for you?"

Catra opens and closes her mouth a few times before anything actually comes out. "You really don't need to." She offers weakly.

Adora beams, "That's what makes it fun." This elicits a small smile and a fond shake of the head from Catra. She takes this as permission to scoop up their books and proceeds to the till. Huntara doesn't make much small talk as she rings them up. Mostly she just darts her eyes between the two of them and smirks like she knows something they don't.

Adora's relieved to walk out the door to say the least. A block or two away from the car Catra clears her throat. After a minute she says, "Thanks, um, for that... I know I'm not always great at accepting, y'know, whatever. And you *really* didn't need to do that, but, well… thanks Dora."

Adora stops by the trunk of her car and uses the hand she's already holding to pull Catra closer to her. "You're welcome. And I get it, no stress." She pulls Catra just a little bit closer and leans in to kiss her on the forehead. Catra closes her eyes and hums. "Besides, you'll get to see what a big hypocrite I am on *your* birthday."

Catra pulls back and arches an eyebrow. "That's in January, right?"

"The nineteenth!"

"Interesting"…

Adora's expression drops just a touch. "Is this an astrology thing?"

Catra laughs at her. "No, no, nothing like that."

Adora eyes her for another minute but eventually nods and lets her hand drop. Somehow, it's already midafternoon and Catra decides she wants to skip the museum and head right home for that nap. As they pull in Adora hedges, "So did you just want me to pick you up for dinner or?"…

Door on the handle Catra turns to give her a weird look. "What? No, get out of the car Princess."Adora beams and doesnt hesitate to follow Catra inside. She swears she can hear Catra mutter, "Come pick me up, honestly."under her breath. Catra sets her new books carefully on the coffee table but keeps hold of the book Adora had given her at the diner. Then she holds her hand out to Adora and pulls her to the bedroom. "You want sweats or something?"

Adora's brows raise. "You have something that's gonna fit me?"

"I'm sure I can dig something up."She manages to find a pair of sweats that she claims she swims in, but which fit Adora just this side of snug. They crawl into the bed and Catra snuggles up on her chest, drawing lazy patterns against her collar bone. Ambient stars drift around the room. After a while Catra drowsily mutters, "Thanks."

"Hm, what for?"

She shrugs against Adora's chest. "Being here. Making today feel special."

Adora smiles softly to herself and cranes her neck to kiss the top of Catra's head. Her eyes close at the touch and she starts humming quietly . Adora watches the stars floating through the air sway to the

dreamy tune. She feels content, safe. It's a feeling she wants to hold onto. It takes her about twenty minutes to wrestle with her thoughts, Catra's breathing has grown steady. Adora's not even sure she's awake but if she doesn't say it now, she's not sure if she ever will. She mutters, "Hey, I think I think we should date."

Catra cranes her head to look up at Adora. Her expression is stuck somewhere between amusement and concern. The stars in the room seem to crackle slightly. "Uh"…

Adora hastens to explain, "Like I know we've been *on* dates."

"Uh huh"…

"I'm trying to say like, we *should* date, y'know?"

Catra leans further away and props herself up on her elbow. "Uhm, no Princess. I'm gonna need you to explain the distinction to me."

She can feel her nerve slipping. "Well like, we're dating, right?"

"Right"…

"And I'm not sure why this is so hard." Catra's expression melts into something patient and soft. Something like understanding seems to dawn on her. She doesn't offer Adora an out though.

"Take your time." Adora shoots her a grateful if not distressed look.

"You're not like seeing anyone else, are you?" She bites her lip, terrified of the answer.

Catra's expression doesn't waver and she shakes her head, flipping her hair over her shoulder. "No Dora, there's no one else."

"Good that's um, good."

"Are you?" It seems like she knows the answer but Adora nevertheless, her voice shy and tentative.

"No and I don't want to." It's silent for a minute and then, so quiet she's not even sure Catra will hear her, she adds, "I...don't want you to either if that's okay?"

Catra beams back at her, stars exploding behind her like fireworks. "Yeah, that's okay."

"So"…

"So, Adora, are you asking me to go steady?" She teases. Adora goes bright red and fights the urge to cover her face.

Gathering every bit of wit and will left inside of her she forces herself to make eye contact and keep her voice steady. "I am, yeah."

"Cool, I'm into that."

Adora feels herself brighten. "Yeah?"

"Yeah, you big dummy. C'mere." She yanks Adora closer by the collar of her shirt and kisses her firmly. After a minute of the relatively chaste embrace she nips at Adora's bottom in and maneuvers her onto her back. They stay there for a while, stars continuing to pop off around them as if they're celebrating too. Hands and lips wander but before they get very far into that Catra's phone chimes with the alarm she had set before they laid down. She flops off Adora and onto her back so she can reach over and shut it off. Throwing her arms over her head she groans. "Ugh, do you think it's too late to cancel?"

Adora snickers at her. "You really think Scorpia's gonna let that fly?"

"It's *my* birthday." She grumbles. Adora rolls her eyes and climbs out of the bed. Catra reaches for her but she dances out of her grasp, laughing. "Hey! Just exactly where do you think you're going?"

"Hmm, I mean I *thought* I was going to my girlfriend's birthday dinner."

Catra grins at her. "Oh, you like saying that, don't you?" Adora sticks her tongue out in response and pulls her sweats off. Catra bites her lip. "Okay , now I *really* want you to get back in this bed with me."

Adora laughs, "You're nothing but trouble Catra." In the blink of an eye Catra's face darkens and the stars disappear from the room, as if Adora's words are a black hole.

"Don't fucking say that to me." Catra snaps harshly , then immediately her face freezes and falls. She takes a choppy breath and much gentler she says, "I don't like that. Please don't say that to me."

"Wha- Catra I- "

Registering Catra's lip wobbling Adora rushes around to the other side of the bed. She reaches out for Catra who throws herself willingly into Adora's arms. Clutching her tightly, Catra sits on the edge of the bed with her torso leaned fully against her. "I'm sorry , I'm sorry . I'm so sorry . This-I shouldn't- it' s so stupid. I'm so *sorry* Adora."

Adora pulls back without releasing her grip, just enough to look Catra in the eye. "Hey , it's not stupid. *I'm* sorry, you're no trouble at all Catra, you're-you're fucking perfect."

Catra shakes her head, there's no threat of tears but her breathing is too shallow, and her brow is furrowed. "I'm not though. I'm not."

Adora shrugs. "You are to me. Do you-you don't have to but do you wanna tell me what this is about?"

Catra meets her gaze for the first time since Adora' s slip. She seems to trust what she sees there because she answers, "I've just heard that a lot in my life. It really shouldn't bother me I think-something about how relaxed I felt or something. It just-it caught me off guard."

Adora reaches a hand up to cup Catra's face and brush her thumb over her cheek. "I don't want you to be on guard with me." Catra's eyes flutter closed and she reaches up to rest her hand against the one Adora has pressed to her cheek. She takes a deep, shuddering breath.

"I'm not." She turns her face to kiss Adora's palm, holding her hand in place afterward. Fluttering her eyes open she adds, "I think that's what caught me off guard. Hearing that from *you* I wasn't prepared."

Adora feels her heart break. "Oh Catra, I'm so sorry." She gathers Catra into her arms again and holds her tightly to her chest. She continues to whisper, her cheek resting atop Catra's head. "I'm so sorry, you're not trouble, you're no trouble at all. You're so good, completely perfect to me. I'm so lucky, you're so, so good." Slowly the stars start to flicker back into the room. Catra eventually pulls back and rubs at her face. Adora gives her a minute then asks softly, "Do you are there any other triggers you'd like me to be aware of?"

Catra offers a weak but genuine smile. "Not that I can think of, I really haven't had something like that happen in a long time."

"Okay, well it's alright if it does. Just keep me posted."

"I will, thanks Dora. You're sweet." She leans forward and presses a chaste peck to Adora's lips. "We should get ready." Adora nods and moves to put of her pants. That's all she really needs to do so she hunts down Melog and ends up pulling out a toy while she waits for Catra to get ready. Twenty minutes later Catra emerges and… Adora's mouth goes dry. She laughs once in disbelief and Melog takes her distraction as an opportunity to drag the feather toy under the couch. She doesn't notice.

"*Catra*, you look wow."

"You think?" She's cocky, there's no question that she looks good. She's traded her jeans and button up for a burgundy, sleeveless

jumpsuit and she's let her hair down again. "Hm, maybe I'll have to show you how good it looks on my floor later." She cackles when Adora chokes on nothing. "Come on Princess, we gotta get going."

Adora nods dumbly, grabs her jacket and follows her out to the car. She snaps out of it when Catra teases her about her ability to drive, scoffing at her girlfriend. Girlfriend. It takes them a little bit to get to the restaurant. Catra fills the time by going through Adora's playlists and offering a running commentary. She mostly just follows Bow's playlists so there's not a ton of material for her, but she makes it work.

She teases her as they get out of the car next to the restaurant. "Seriously Princess, what was that last song?"

"A bop." Adora retorts, sticking her tongue out.

"If you say so."

"I do, yes. Thank you for recognizing my authority on the matter." Catra just rolls her eyes. Scorpia's voice carries across the lot before she can say anything.

"Ooh! Wildcat! Over here! Wildcat, oh my gosh *happy birthday*! Wow, okay, you know what I'm just gonna come to you." Impatient, Scorpia rushes over to scoop Catra up into a bear hug faster than Adora can drop her hand. Her arm ends up caught awkwardly and she has to wiggle it out.

Perfuma giggles as she watches the show. "Happy birthday Catra." She says, patting her shoulder delicately as Scorpia releases her hold.

"Ahem, yeah. Thanks guys. Why don't we head in." Seeming to recover from the discombobulation of Scorpia's embrace, Catra grabs Adora's hand again and leads them to the door. Adora catches the look Scorpia and Perfuma share and she smirks.

They're seated quickly when they walk in, Adora getting them there just in time for their reservation. Their drink orders are taken right away, and they're left to catch up and go over the menu. "So, what did you crazy kids get up today?" Scorpia asks the moment the hostess walks away.

"Brunch, went and saw Huntara, took a nap, and that's basically it." Catra sums up.

"Say, how is she doing?" Perfuma asks.

Catra and Adora chuckle. "You know she said the exact same thing when you came up." Perfuma flushes lightly. "She's good, pain in the ass as always. Said she'll be there for the wedding, which shit, isn't that two weeks away now?"

"Sure is Wildcat! Hope you've got your suit pressed and- Oh thank you so much, you're too kind." Scorpia cuts herself off as the server sets down their drinks."

"My pleasure." They tell her. "My name is Jeremiah, and I'm gonna be helping you out this evening. Any food we can get started?"

"Ooh, you know what I think we need a minute on entrees Jeremiah. But if we could get some bread and a couple orders of your incredible French onion dip, that would be just fabulous. Birthday girl, anything else you want?"

"Oh, we have a birthday here tonight?"

"Fuck you're not gonna like...sing, right?" Catra makes a face.

Jeremiah laughs. "Nah, not really our style." He gestures to the rather bougie surroundings. "But the house'll cover your first round of drinks tonight. And happy birthday."

"Sick." Catra grins. "Thanks! And uh, I think we're set with just that for now."

"Excellent, I'll go put that in and be back to check on you in a bit."

Jeremiah disappears around a corner and Scorpia jumps right back in. "So, what were we talking about? Oh! Right, Huntara. She's doing good then? Aw, and how about Rupee? Adora that means you got to meet Huntara, isn't she the greatest?"

Catra just blinks in the wake of the rapid-fire questions so Adora answers. "Yeah, she was cool. Rupert's super sweet."

Catra snickers next to her. "Yeah, I think the Princess over here was considering taking Huntara to the wedding instead of me for a minute."

"*What?*" Adora can feel herself blush all the way down to her chest. "I was not!"

"Psh," Catra rolls her eyes, unrelenting in her teasing. "Please, don't try and tell me you didn't have a little crush."

"No, I- hey!"

"Whew, and who could blame you?" Perfuma pipes up, Adora turns to her in surprise. "You know she literally bench pressed me one time."

"Wait, so how do you guys know this person?" Adora asks, confused by the collective dynamic.

"Oh, she and I dated briefly. Mm hmm, the summer after I graduated, we had a little fling. Such a sweet heart, we never lost touch. She actually gave Catra and I *a lot* of advice when we opened up Plumeria."

"Yeah, that lady knows how to run her shit, I'll give her that." Catra concedes.

"Did she say who she's brining to the wedding?"

Catra scoffs. "He hasn't decided yet. Bet you twenty bucks she asks someone from the gym."

"Oh, I'll take that bet." Scorpia wagers. "There's no way she'd risk dating someone from the Crimson Waste, she loves that gym. It's practically her home!"

"Eh, I still wouldn't put it past her. Now, enough about Tara. Stop distracting me until I read this menu." They all start flipping through their options. Aside from a little bit of chat about what looks good, conversation doesn't resume until Jeremiah's dropped off their first round of food and taken their orders.

Scorpia and Perfuma give Catra their presents while they wait for the food. She rips the wrapping off just as enthusiastically as every other time Adora's watched her open a gift. She thanks them enthusiastically for the stack of records and the fancy windchime, respectively. She even gets up from the table to offer Scorpia a hug of her own volition. Scorpia definitely cries.

Dinner is a fun and relaxed affair. Catra has a few cocktails and after the second she gets extra touchy feely. She sidles closer and closer to Adora in their booth until they're pressed right up against each other. When she's slowed down on eating, she throws an arm over Adora's shoulders and starts playing with her hair. It's all very casual and comfortable, Catra staying tuned into the conversation all the while.

Eventually Jeremiah comes to clear their plates and lets them know he'll be right back. Suddenly Scorpia is buzzing with excitement. Catra eyes her. "Scorpia, you're a good friend."

Scorpia calms minutely and her face softens, melting. "Aw, thanks buddy."

"Mm hmm, mm hmm. So, what the fuck is wrong with you?"

The accusation doesnt even phase Scorpia. "Y oull see in just one… ah here we go."

Catra and Adora flip around to see Jeremiah approaching them with a small cake, already lit with sparkler candles. Catra turns to her best friend. "What did you *do?* "

"Psh, me? Nothing really ."

"Y eah, absolutely nothing babe." Perfuma teases. "Just spent a week wrecking the kitchen." She and Catra share a conspiratorial look as the cake is set down in front of them. t' s beautiful, with rustic looking buttercream and pile of beautiful sugared violets on top. Stars dance between the flowers, carefree and light.

They all know instinctually not too sing but when Catra makes her wish and blows the candles out they clap. She cuts the cake with the cutlery provided by their server and passes the slices around. "So, what am I looking at here? Besides these violets, honestly Scorp I feel so seen." She pops one into her mouth and her expression goes contented and dopey.

"That is every color of rose that my garden grows with sweet basil and lemon buttercream!" Catra just groans indulgently and digs in. Everyone else follows suits and theirs a general hum of pleasure around the table.

"So Wildcat, what' s the next stop?"

"Uhm.. my bed." Scorpia gives her a disapproving look. "What?"

"I was thinking karaoke."

Catra laughs. "What? It' s like nine p.m."

"That is literally when it starts."

"It' s also when I start to expire Scorp."

"On your birthday?" Scorpia shoots her and doubtful look, Perfuma and Adora look across to each other and share a laugh.

"W ell"…

"aH Y ou know as soon as you waver, Ive won! Adora if you want to drop your car at Catra's after this Ican pick you up, so we dont both have to DD. The place we usually go isnt too far from her place anyway."

"Oh, sure, thanks Scorpia."

"Sure thing!"

"Uh, hello? Birthday girl here. Never said Iwas doing this."

"A w come on, Ibet Adora would love to see you crush some Bonnie Raitt. Wouldnt you Adora?"

She laughs at the look Catra shoots Scorpia. "Y eah, sounds hot."

Catra's mouth drops open a little bit and Perfuma giggles at them. "Alright then Princess, *if* Iagree to this, what are you gonna sing?"

She laughs again. "Oh no, karaoke is more of a spectator sport for me."

Catra grins evilly. "Nope, no way . Ill only agree to go if you promise to sing something."

"I promise you;no one wants that."

"Um, Iwant that. And it' s my birthday so." She says like that finishes the argument.

"Y eah, Adora." Scorpia needles. "t' s her *birthday*."

Adora sputters, "W ellwell then, what are you two gonna sing?"

"W ell Iusually go with something from Mama Morton or Adele."

"Iusually wait to be inspired by the book."Perfuma of fers.

Adora looks around the table at the expectant faces, lingering on Catra's poor excuse for a pout. Ever the people pleaser, she sighs and grumbles, "Fine, fine."There' s a collective whoop from the table and they hurry to finish and get on their way. They part ways in the lot with plans to meet back at Catra's so Adora can drop her car off. Scorpia is picking them up in no time and as it turns out the bar is almost close enough to walk to from Catra's. Of course, it's the end of October so Adora is glad to have the ride, it wouldn't exactly be a *short* walk.

They walk in and a small crowd has gathered already. Nothing crazy , it's a Wednesday night after all, but a few of the tables have small groups crowded around them. Scorpia and Perfuma offer to find a spot, putting their drink requests in with Catra and Adora.

"Perfuma, you doing shots?"

Perfuma considers for a moment and offers, "Hm, I'll do one with you."

"Sick, and that drink was a tall, yeah?"

"Ooh, yes please."

They walk up to the bar and Catra turns to Adora with a smirk. "Alright Princess, how many shots are you doing? Y ou've got some catching up to do."

"Y eah, you know I'm a lightweight, right?"

"So, what, like two?"

Adora laughs openly. "Sure, but you're scraping my ass of f the floor tonight if it comes to that."

"I can work with that." Catra steps forward to order their drinks and doesn't fight Adora when she nudges her way in to pay. Instead she just offers a fond shake of the head and a kiss on the cheek.

Back at the table Perfuma lifts her shot glass. "To Catra, whom we honor on the day of her solar return!"

Adora eyes Catra but she just smirks and shakes her head minutely before tipping back the shot. "Here, here!" Adora clinks her glass with Perfuma and they follow suit. Adora very nearly shoves her whole lime slice in her mouth trying to cut the burn and flavor of tequila.

"It's you and me again Princess." Catra hold the second glass out to her and she takes it with a grimace. She knocks it back immediately, ready to move on to her cider. "Bottoms up I guess." She laughs and takes two shots in succession.

"Wildcat, you know what you're gonna sing?"

Catra shrugs, "Probably Bonnie." Adora notices her words are already starting to slur.

"Great, wanna come up with me to put it in?"

"Let's go." They walk up to wait by the DJ and Perfuma turns to Adora.

"So, do you have any idea what you want to sing?"

"Um, I have a few songs I rotate when Bow and Glimmer drag me out."

Perfuma's smile turns into something a little more mischievous when she asks, "Hm, any songs you'd want to dedicate to Catra this evening?"

Adora blushes deeply, "Uh, I don't know that I'm one to serenade anybody. But, uh, maybe."

Perfuma giggles but Catra saunters up before she can say anything else, Scorpia just a step or two behind her. "Damn, Fuma. We were gone like two minutes, what'd you do to get my girlfriend all hot and bothered? Pretty sure that's my job."

Time stands still; Catra smirks, clearly knowing what she's done, and Adora's heart is flipping in her chest. Perfuma's expression is eerily similar to Catra's and Scorpia's jaw seems to drop in slow motion. Suddenly time seems to catch up in an instant, stars pop into existence, forming a sort of dome around their table. Scorpia nearly shoves Catra into her chair, her movements are already languid from liquor so she sort of tumbles into Adora. She throws an arm around Catra to steady her and also because she wants to. Scorpia darts into her own seat and leans nearly all the way over the table. Adora's not sure if she ever realized just how *tall* this woman is.

"First of all, I want you to know; I'm not mad. I'm just disappointed." Adora starts at that, surprised. Perfuma shoots her a conspiratorial smile and shakes her head minutely. "I also want you to know that, as it is your birthday, I will spare you the very hard time I would normally give you for not telling me immediately."

"You're still gonna barrage me with questions though, aren't you?" Catra asks in a bored tone.

"*Of course* I am. First, how long has this been going on? Oh, and who asked who? Does Bow know? Because we promised to text if one of us found out before the other, and it just doesn't *seem* like Bow to forget that kind of thing."

Adora goes into something like shock, dazed at the very least. Luckily Catra seems prepared to carry this conversation. "Wow, okay. You have got to be at least a little more chill about this. We only talked about it today after brunch, Adora asked me and it was very cute- "

"Pfft, you're cute." Adora scoffs.

Catra turns to wag a finger in her face, "I absolutely am not." Back to Scorpia she continues, "You're the first person we've told, yknow since it's been likeless than six hours."

"Aww, babe! You remembered out six-hour anniversary!" Adora teases, realizing as the words slide out of her mouth that she is officially tipsy. She takes a swig of her cider and Catra shoves her lightly with an eye roll. A few stars begin to fall like snow from the dome above them.

Scorpia is teary eyed by now. "Wow, you told me first? Wildcat, really, I am honored. Floored, really! So how does it feel?"

Catra shrugs. "Chill."

"You're lying." Scorpia accuses, and Catra narrows her eyes back.

"I'm not about to get mushy right now , alright Scorp?"

Scorpia lets out a dejected sigh. "Fine, but we are having some Super Pal Duo time soon."

"What?" Adora asks bluntly .

"What?" Scorpia repeats, clearly confused.

"Super Pal Duo?"

"Oh! That's us." Scorpia gestures between herself and Catra.

"That's just so… *cute*!"

Scorpia blushes and rubs the back of her neck but Catra scowls at her and insists, "I am *not* cute, Princess."

Adora leans in real close, closer perhaps, than she would in front of their friends were she not inebriated. In a fierce whisper , with a smile far too goofy to be intimidating, she tells her, "Are too! And d'you wanna know how I know?"

Clearly amused, Catra bites. "Now?"

With a grin so smug it's like she's already won Adora says, "Cause I seen you." Their friends devolve into hopeless laughter and Catra is looking at her with something akin to wonder, maybe?

"Well, guess I can't fight you there Adorable." Deflecting, she adds, "So, are you two squares over here gonna put songs in or what?" Adora eyes her, considering her options. She's buzzed enough to be brave, she decides. She nods once and gets up without another word to put her song in. Behind her she vaguely registers Catra laughing, "Guess that answers that then."

It doesn't take long for Scorpia to get called up, she's bashful about it right up until the music starts. Big booming stars roll off of her and she is suddenly absolutely *crushing* the song. Adora's never heard When You're Good to Mama' sound so good. She looks at Catra, mouth agape, and she just grins back and nods her head enthusiastically.

Naturally Catra is up next, Scorpia whoops and hollers for her as they pass in the aisle. Adora waits on the edge of her seat as the music gets going. Nothing, nothing could have prepared Adora for what comes next. Catra's raspy voice croons the words to Something to Talk About', turning Adora's legs to jelly. She clearly knows what she's doing too; singing right to Adora the entire time, making eye contact and walking up to her midway through the song. Perfuma and Scorpia keep shooting amused looks her way, hooting and hollering. It is really not helping the state of her blush. She chugs the last half of her drink and steals a few sips of Catra's fancy margarita for good measure. She's way too gay for this shit.

Catra saunters back to the table when she's through. It takes Adora a minute to break through her haze of lust and remember to join in on the applause. "So?" Catra asks with a smirk when she gets close.

The words are out of Adora's mouth before she has a chance to so much as think them. "Wanna get some air?"

Catra's smirk intensifies and a rush of heat rolls through Adora. "Yeah, I could use some air."

Adora follows her out into the night, shoving her arms into her jacket, and the cold air feels sharp against her cheeks. It's a relief to her system. After taking a second to adjust to the change in atmosphere, she grabs Catra's hand. She leads her past the bouncer and the few lingering smokers and around the corner. Convinced they're alone she pulls Catra to her roughly by the arm, and finally kisses her. Catra's gasp melts into a moan inside Adora's mouth. She meets Adora with equal fervor, not slowing her pace when Adora backs her into the wall of the bar. Adora presses closer, her knee sliding between Catra's legs. Her lips slide down to kiss the spot behind Catra's ear then down further to linger on her neck. The little sighs and moans this elicit egg her on.

Adora couldn't say if they'd been kissing five minutes or five hours, lost as she is in Catra, when the she taps out. Quite literally tapping Adora's shoulder she gasps, "Oh, fuck. Dora, baby, hey. Mm"… Adora pulls away almost immediately, though regretfully.

The world around them spins and she braces herself, her arms planted on either side of Catra's head. She leans in so their foreheads touch. "Good?" She whispers.

Catra hums and cradles her face. "The best. I just"… She huffs, a wide smile in place.

Adora nods. "No, yeah. Breathing's super good."

"Hm and getting carried away in an alley probably isn't." Adora snorts which makes Catra giggle.

Adora's gaze softens as she watches Catra catch her breath. A galaxy has erupted around them and it spins dizzyingly. "Hey," She whispers. "I'm glad you're my girlfriend and stuff." Catra beams and kisses her cheek.

"Oh yeah? Funny , me too."

Adora smiles back just a wide. "I cant even believe; I dont believe it took me so long."

"What do you mean?" Catra asks, eyeing her in a way she thinks she's too drunk to understand.

"Pf ft!" Adora scof fs. "*Please* , I've been tryna ask you like, this entire, the whole week. Probably longer. Long time now."

"Oh yeah?"

"W ell," Adora considers the question fairly . "No. But only because I'm kind of scared of you."

"*Excuse me?* " Catra asks, tilting her head up to see her more clearly.

"Mm, mm-hmm, could you not tell that? That' s good, actually never mind, I'm so chill. Forget I said that." She reaches down and pokes Catra on the forehead. "*Bop* , deleted it."

"Adora!" Catra laughs, a few stars shoot from within the galaxy that surrounds her and streak off into the night. "Baby , what do you mean you're scared of me?" Amusement and concern wage war in her expression.

"W ell not *you*. Maybe that's not true either, I dont know . I just like you a whole lot. So being like… *open* or-or veritable, no that's not right, hang on fuck, um..."

"V ulnerable?" Catra supplies softly .

Adora snaps her fingers and points at Catra. "That' s the one! Terrifying."

Catra giggles and wraps her hands around Adora's arms near her face, rubbing soothing circles with her thumbs. She stares at the

motion of her fingers even as she speaks, but Adora is watching her carefully. "Dora I get scared too."

"Psh, that's stupid, I'm not scary." Catra looks up at her and her smile contains the ghost of a smirk.

"Yeah well, maybe not. But sometimes the way I feel about you… feels a little scary."

Adora sobers up slightly at that and nods. "Yeah." She looks at her for a minute. "Is it like super mean if I say it makes me less scared to know you're scared too?"

"Nah, can't be mean. I feel the same way and I'm the *nicest*." Adora lets her arms collapse partway and nuzzles her face into Catra's neck with a hum. Catra's hands move into her hair and they linger there for a while. Eventually Perfuma seeks them out, Adora's turn is coming up.

"I think we have enough time for a hit or two if you're interested though." She produces a joint from her pocket which Catra readily accepts. Nerves building now that her performance is imminent Adora joins them for a couple hits.

"You end up putting anything in Fuma?" Catra asks.

"You know, I didn't."

"Hey! That wasn't the deal!" Adora protests.

The other women just laugh at her. "How much longer are you going to stick around?"

Catra eyes Adora for a minute. "We might leave after Adora's song if that's chill."

"We might?" Adora asks, unaware of this plan.

"That' s cool!Nothing was really speaking to me and Ican tell Scorpia is starting to crash after all that soda."Perfuma takes a final hit and puts out the joint. "W e should head back in though."

They file inside and within seconds of getting in the door Adora is summoned to the front. The nerves are still buried somewhere in her stomach, but the weed has made her feel much more floaty and calm. The lyrics start and for the most part she's staring at the screen trying to keep up. When she gets to the chorus of "T ake a Chance on Me'she' s finally able to look up at the table. The look on Catra's flame sets her ablaze, she doesnt look back again until the song is over.

She walks back slowly, picking her way through the other tables in her path. When she gets there Catra is standing and waiting to pull her into a firm kiss. There's more hooting and hollering from Scorpia and Perfuma which makes Adora flush darker. Catra pulls away just barely to whisper, "That was fucking hot baby . You ready to go home?"

Adora clears her throat asking, "My home or your home?"

Catra smirks at her. "What do you think?"

Adora gulps, "Y eah, Im ready ."

Catra turns away from her. "All ready to bounce?"

Scorpia and Perfuma also seem eager to get home. Though sleepy as Scorpia looks the motivation seems to be something a little different. They offer sleepy goodbyes and final birthday wishes before pulling out of Catra's driveway just a little while later .

Adora follows Catra inside, feeling suddenly shy. They peel off outer layers and kick of their shoes by the door. Catra heads to the kitchen and fills two glasses of water. She makes Adora drink to the bottom and refills both immediately.

"You take such good care of me." Adora praises as Catra hands her glass back.

A raised eyebrow and then, "I'd like to take care of you." Adora chokes on her water. "Aw, baby, did I get you wet?" She cackles at the look her teasing garners. "Let's go to bed, yeah?"

Adora nods gently and allows herself to be guided into the bedroom. Catra sits her on the edge of the bed and she looks up at her in wonder. "You're like really beautiful."

"Aw, you think so Princess?"

Despite the teasing her answer is earnest. "I really do." She starts with her hands on her hips and runs them up and down Catra's sides for a minute.

"You wanna get undressed?" Adora bites her lip and nods, letting Catra strip her down to boxers and a sports bra. Then, without breaking eye contact, she peels off her jumpsuit, leaving her in just her underwear. "Skootch back on the bed for me?"

Adora does as she's asked, maneuvering so that she's resting back against the pillows. Catra moves so she's settled half on Adora, half beside her. She trails her fingers over Adora's exposed skin, playing with the edges of her bra. Both of their breathing is shallow. "What do you want?" It's Adora who asks.

Catra looks up in surprise. "I mean, what do yo- "

Adora shakes her head. "Nuh-uh, I'm asking what you want birthday girl."

"I mean, I *want* to fuck you when you're ready. But I think we're both still too cross faded for that to decide that tonight." Adora blushes but urges her on with a nod. Catra bites her lip, squirming a little on top of her. "Will you just touch me?"

Adora smiles and flips them so that she's on top. She smiles down at Catra, their shared look soft and sweet. Adora vaguely registers a hillside of stars forming around them as she leans in to kiss her. She starts soft, growing in fervor as Catra becomes pliant below her. She moves down to her neck, lingering long enough to nip at the skin there, then down further. She looks up when she reaches Catra's chest, she has her eyes closed, face flushed and scrunched like she's concentrating.

When Adora flicks her tongue against her nipple Catra's eyes fly open. "Fuck, Dora." She watches intently while Adora takes the whole think in her mouth, pulling gently, and trails her fingers over the other nipple. Her eyes close again tightly when Adora drags her fingers down further to graze against Catra over her underwear. "Mmm"…

Keeping her fingers where they are, Adora trails her mouth up toward Catra's ear. "Do you want me to touch you with my fingers… or my mouth?"

Catra's eyes squeeze impossibly tighter. "*Fuck*, Adora."

She doesn't say anything else so Adora runs her tongue lightly over the shell of her ear. "Catra"…

"Shit um, both? Is both okay?" Adora just hums and moves to settle between Catra's legs. She pulls off her underwear and Catra gasps at the rush of cool air. Adora watches her, all of her, and reaches down to gently stroke along Catra's pussy. It elicits several more little gasps that have Adora's jaw clenched slightly with lust. The stars around them grow to mountains. Adora leans in with no hesitation and her tongue is on Catra's clit. "*Fuck!*"

She stays like that for a few seconds until Catra is muttering a string of curses under hear breath. She slides two fingers in, and the string of curses turns into primarily hums and whines as Adora moves her tongue and fingers in tandem. Catra's worked into a frenzy in no time, the peaks of starry mountains beside them are dancing to the

rhythm of Adora's movements and the melody of Catra's sounds of pleasure. All at once they freeze, then begin to vibrate in place, finally collapsing to the ground in a lake of stars on Catra's bedroom floor. Adora slides out gently with a final peck to Catra's clit which makes her thighs clench.

"Holy fucking stars Adora." Catra breathes out with a huff. Adora moves up to the head of the bed, using one arm to wipe her mouth and the other to prop her up on her elbow.

"Yeah? Happy birthday."

Catra snorts. "You dork." Her wide grin and flushed cheeks undermine the jab.

Adora shrugs. "How ya doing?"

"Hmm worn out, but happy."

"I'm glad."

"Mm, thanks for today. Do you have to work in the morning?"

"Yeah but my boss said I can come in late as long as I'm there for the meeting at ten."

"Okay, well then I need to pee, and we should brush our teeth and probably call it a night. I mean unless you." She levels Adora with a look that makes her blush.

"I think I'm ready for bed." Adora's heart clenches, momentarily concerned about Catra's reaction. It's never been an issue before, but she wonders if now that they've made things official…

But Catra just smiles sweetly and kisses her cheek. "Okay baby."

It doesn't take long for them to get back to bed and cozy under the covers. Catra wiggles back into the spoon of Adora's body and sighs contentedly. The lake of stars around them dims, its shores drifting in

and out to the rhythm of their slowing breaths. The two of them are asleep in no time at all.

Chapter End Notes

Hey!!Hello!t me!
Thanks so much for reading this story!
This chapter felt like a little bit of a grind to get out for whatever reason. Choosing their favorite books took me a full calendar year p much. But!Ihave some *plans* for next chapter. Should be a good time :)

Catra's (actual) Favorite Book: https://www .youtube.com/watch?v=X1ANWka4A

Lavender Roses, Red Tulips and Fuchsia

Chapter Notes

> CW: Things get spicy (toward the end of the chapter) in this one y'all!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Okay , but Idont even know what to say . And it's probably been too long anyway."Adora pouts, watching the cursor blink in the blank email she has pulled up on her screen.

Glimmer rolls her eyes. "Look, Adora, you're never gonna know if you dont ask. But we,"She gestures between Bow and herself. "cant do this for you. Y ou have to decide whether to take the leap or not."

Adora clenches her jaw . Glimmer is right. She doesnt say anything, choosing to type out a draft instead. "Okayljust said Hello Noelle, Ireceived your contact information from Catra, the owner of Plumeria. Iwas told you had an opportunity you'd like to discuss. I would love to hear more details. Look forward to hearing from you, Adora Grey.' Does that soundIdunno, right?"

"V ery professional."Bow assures her .

"Okayokay Im gonna send it."

"Do it!Do it!Do it!"Glimmer chants. Adora does it before she can second guess herselfagain. T riple guess herself?Y ay!Congrats Adora, you did the thing."

Adora just pulls her hands down her face and looks at her . t garners a laugh from both of her friends.

"Are you gonna tell Catra?"Bow asks.

"Um." Adora bites her lip. "Maybe I'll just wait to see what she says?"

Bow shrugs. "Your call, I'm sure she'll be thrilled to hear you took the initiative either way."

"Maybe…what do you think it even is?"

"Who knows? But whatever it is has got to be better than working in Mom's stupid office all day." Glimmer assures.

Adora huffs, dropping her chin int her hand. "That's true. Did I tell you Octavia wants me to apply for a promotion?"

"So, what?" Glimmer asks. "You'd actually be an assistant instead of like, and assistant to the assistant?"

"Pf ft, no, not even. I'd be like…supervising my peers basically…I'd be like, an assistant's assistant plus." When Bow and Glimmer look at her blankly, she explains, "So, it would be my job to make sure everyone gets reports done in time, coordinating maintenance, stuff like that."

"That's so stupid, isn't that Octavia's job?" Adora shrugs. "Are you gonna do it?"

"I mean, it sounds annoying but it's an extra dollar an hour…I mean, why not I guess?"

"Uh, because you hate it there and want to leave, not get intrenched further." Bow nods sagely along with Glimmer's words.

"Well yeah but I…mean, a dollar an hour…. That's like, a five percent raise. That's an extra hundred and sixty dollars a month which is nearly two grand a *year*. Plus, I could put it on my resume, which can only help. That's leadership experience!" Adora can feel herself getting worked up but is powerless to stop it.

Finally Bow cuts in with an, "Okay…how ya feeling buddy?"

I'm thinking if I get this job it also puts me in a position to take Octavia's job if she ever leaves or moves up. She makes like, half again as much as I do! I should definitely apply; I mean my 401k contribu- "

"Adora!" Bow's voice is nearly a shout, he clears his throat awkwardly when she cuts off. "Uh, sorry . . . just... maybe a deep breath is a good idea. I want to know how you're *feeling* not what you're thinking."

"Right, sorry . Ugh, I don't even want this stupid job. I don't want to constantly have to be reminding Brad that reports are always due on Wednesdays. Every week. Since he started. Which was before me." She groans and drops her head into her hands. "Maybe I shouldn't apply."

"Y a think?" Glimmer scoffs.

"Whatever , I don't want to talk about it anymore. How's work for you Glim? They still have you playing gopher?"

"Eh, for the most part. But I'm more efficient now so I get to sit in on the end of meetings sometimes when I drop off coffee." She laughs. "Honestly, I'm kind of learning a lot just from that. The head designer is a master, truly."

"That's great Glim!"

Glimmer shrugs with a smug smile. "It's whatever."

Bow laughs, "Yeah, like you didn't come home freaking out the first day they remembered your name."

"Shut *up* Bow! Goddess above"…

"Oh! Speaking of work, Mermista put in her notice at the shop."

"*What?*" Adora and Glimmer ask simultaneously . Glimmer adds, "She's worked there forever. Since high school, right?"

"Yeah, she just got some great internship apparently. She says it'll make her a shoe in when she applies to grad school."

"Oh, that's great! Do you know what she's doing?"

"Uhm...not exactly. Something to do with dolphin communication?"

Adora laughs, "Wait, so Mermista is going to school to learn to speak dolphin? I thought she was a marine biologist, not a linguist." Adora snorts at her own joke.

Glimmer rolls her eyes at her antics but Bow laughs and raises a hand for a high five. "Nice one."

"Thanks Bow!" She sticks her tongue out at Glimmer who scoffs at her. "I can't believe she's gonna be in *grad* school soon. And Scorpia and Perfuma are getting married next week. Everyone is so grown up!"

"Speaking of which, we're still on for dress shopping tomorrow, right?"

Adora makes a face, she is not looking forward to this particular outing. "Yeah, I guess."

"Is Catra coming with?"

"Nah, she said thanks for the invite though. Apparently, she has to shadow Hordak's shift tomorrow."

Bow sucks a breath through his teeth. "Still not going well then?"

Adora grimaces. "I think it was getting a little better, but he did something to the espresso machine last week. They had to replace a part, and I guess it wasn't cheap."

"Yikes, I'm surprised Catra didn't fire him."

"Honestly I think he's grown on her more than she lets on. He's got a nickname now."

"Aw, that's nice then." Bow softens.

"Does Catra even *know* anyone's real name?" Glimmer asks sarcastically.

"No Glimmer, not even mine." Adora answers deadpan.

"You joke, but when's the last time she called you 'Adora'?" Adora smirks at her. "Ew! Gross, Adora! Aren't you supposed to be all shy? Blech, I did not need that visual."

"What? I didn't say anything."

"No, but you thought it *really*, really loud."

"I'm not even gonna touch that one." Adora scoffs.

"Uh, duh, cause you can't tell me I'm wrong."

"I mean I *can*."

"Yeah, but you wouldn't. You have become something of a perv but you're still not a liar. Not a good one at least."

"I'm not that bad of a liar!"

"*Please*, Adora I love you, but you can't act to save your life."

Seeing Adora gearing up to argue back Bow interjects. "I mean I… wouldn't take you to Vegas. Just saying."

"Et tu Bow?" Adora throws a dramatic hand over her heart.

"Uhh…"

"Oh, leave Bow alone."

"Whatever , you guys are mean. What time is it anyway?"

It's" Glimmer pulls out her phone. "damn, almost midnight. W e should head to bed if you still want to get an early start."

Adora laughs. "I'd hardly call ten an early start Glim."

It's a Saturday." Glimmer explains like that ought to be the end of it. Adora just laughs again and drops it. No one hurries to get up but within half an hour Adora is drifting off to sleep.

"Adora, come *on*, let us see."

"Ugh, but I hate it. "

"*Adora…* "

"*Glimmer…* "

"You're impossible!"

"I just don't think anyone needs to see me in this many ruf fles. I look silly." Adora sways side to side, considering herself in the mirror . Yeah, no. No one is seeing her in this. Or she throws up a peace sign and takes a quick mirror selfie and shoots it of f to Catra. Be honest. You've never seen me look hotter , right?

She hears her phone ding as she pulls off her dress. Glimmer shouts through the door. "W ell are you at least gonna let us see *something* ? Bow is bored."

"I'm fine, you're the one who' s getting antsy."

"Not helping Bow!"

"Glimmer , chill! Just give me a minute, I'll show you the next one."

She eyes the last couple of dresses Glimmer picked out for her and procrastinates by pulling up Catra's text. Sorry , are u in that pic? Cant see past all the ruf fles.' She snorts and eyes the stack of dresses again. She grabs the sleeveless red one. t probably not right for the season, but it looks the best of all the options.

Before walking out, she smiles dopily at her phone and types back, Shut up.'

"Oh, Ilike this one!" Glimmer exclaims as she walks out of the dressing room.

"Y eah? Ithink Ido too but Im not sure about the sleeveless thing."

"I mean, Iwas gonna wear a shawl or something. Im sure we can figure it out if you like it." Adora considers herself in the larger mirror , shifting her weigh side to side.

"t makes your arms look *aaazing* ." Bow compliments. "But you dont look sold."

"Im not sure Iam honestly ." She turns back to her friends. "Why is this so hard?"

"W ell, maybe were looking in the wrong place. Do you even want to wear a dress?"

"Uh arent Isupposed to? I mean it' s a wedding"…

"Y eah, but Imean, Ibet we could find you a suit."

"A suit?"

"Just give me like, ten minutes." Bow pops out of the dressing room leaving Adora and Glimmer looking bewildered at each other.

"Okay did you want to try on the last two?"

"Honestly, not really. I think the sequins are too hard a sell for me on that purple one. And I don't think you're supposed to wear white to a wedding."

"Oh! I forgot about that one. You have to try it on! Not for this obviously, but I saw it and it just *screamed Adora!*."

"Uhh"…

"What else do you wanna do while we wait for Bow to do whatever it is he's doing"?

"Fine, fine. This one is getting kind of itchy anyway." Adora files back into the fitting room and strips off the red dress. She pulls out her phone, no new messages. She'd probably caught Catra on the end of a break. She pulls on the white dress and honestly, it fits perfectly. It's silky and the way it drapes her body, it's like it was made for her. It's a wide scoop neck in the front with a low back and a bold golden trim and sash. She turns around, she doesn't think her butt normally looks this good.

She walks out and Glimmer gasps. "Oh my gosh, did we just find your wedding dress"?

"*What?* No! Glimmer, what are you- no!"

"Oh my gosh, obviously I'm kidding Adora. Unless"…

"Unless, what? Catra and I made plans to go down to city hall and I forgot to mention it"? She scoffs.

"I mean, you are obsessed with each other." Glimmer teases right back.

"We are *not*. We just like each other."

"Adora's in *love*." Glimmer sing songs, making Adora flush.

"No!"

"Oh, come on, are you really trying to tell me you don't love your girlfriend?"

"No! That's not what I even- and you! You're just- pfft. We haven't even said- haven't said...that. So, you're way off base!"

"Adora." Glimmer sighs. "It's fine, chill."

"I mean *maybe*, but I'm not- I'm not there yet. It's too soon."

Glimmer considers her for a moment. Her stare makes Adora sit in the chair next to her, fatigued from being so thoroughly seen. "Do you trust her?"

"Catra? Yeah, of course I do."

"Do you care about her?"

"What? Glimmer, obviously."

"Just take your time and don't say anything you don't mean. But at the same time- don't overcomplicate this by thinking too hard. Okay?"

Sobered, Adora nods. "Okay."

Adora's not sure how long they sit with their own thoughts before Bow rejoins them. She's startled out of her reverie by him gasping in the doorway. "*Adora!* Oh my gosh, that dress looks like it was *made* for you. You have to get it."

She laughs. "What on earth for? I can't wear this to the wedding."

"Adora, when a piece of clothing fits you that well you don't question it. You buy it and wear it when the time presents itself." She just laughs again.

"I really don't think I need to walk out of here with *two* formal outfits today Bow."

"Uh, I really think you do. Here, try this on." He hands her a small stack of clothes and she disappears back into her room. She looks at herself in the mirror and thinks about taking a picture, maybe sending it to Catra. She does look *really* good after all... Something stops her. She really shouldn't buy it, but if she does... she'd definitely want it to be a surprise. She strips down and looks at what Bow brought her.

It's nothing she would have ever picked out for herself but... she's into it. It's a charcoal grey suit with dark crimson turtleneck. She gets herself into it and checks herself out. *Huh. Nice suit.* Feeling like she can very possibly vibe with this she steps out to show her friends.

Bow claps his hands together and Glimmer just gapes at her. "So?" She asks after a prolonged silence.

"Adora, you look incredible!" Bow gushes.

Glimmer nods emphatically. "Super hot! Catra is gonna *die*."

"Yeah?" She turns to look at herself in the mirror. She nods once. "I think I'm gonna do it."

"Great! Go get changed, I need *snacks*." Adora chuckles at the drama in Glimmer's tone but does as she's told. At the exit of the fitting room she drops the stack of dresses she had tried, hand hesitating over the one she had liked. As she stands there berating herself for even considering getting it Bow whisks past and reaches over to snatch it away.

"Happy early birthday!" He tells her as he hustles toward the front.

He ignores her harsh whispers to, "*Get back here with that right now, Bow*." She sighs and resigns herself to her fate, traipsing after him with her wedding outfit in hand.

"Hey baby , you find a dress?" Catra' s voice filters through her phone as Adora flops back onto her bed.

"Uh, Ifound something, yeah." She makes the decision in the moment to not correct her.

"Nice, Icant wait to see it."

"Hm, are you with Scorpia already?" Adora asks, deflecting.

"Nah, she and Fuma are doing dinner together . She should be here around eight though. Ithink Entrapta' s gonna get here a little early though."

"Fun, excited for your pre wedding sleepover?"

Catra scoffs, it's a lighthearted, playful sound. "I mean Ifeel like I'm thirteen again, but yeah it should be a good night."

"What are you three gonna do?"

"Eh, typical slumber party shit, Iguess. There' s some new Netflix rom com Scorp wants to watch and Igot a bunch of snacks. T rapta will probably bring a project to fuck with, so hopefully she doesnt blow my house up before the night is through."

"Y ikes, should Icome get Melog, keep 'em out of harm' s way?"

Catra laughs sharply. "Not a terrible idea Princess, but Ithink well make it out okay."

"Alright, well the of fer stands. What's the plan for tomorrow?"

"Right, Scorp' s moms' and Iare gonna help her get ready here and then head to the property. You're riding over in your truck so you can come over after, right? And Crop T op and Sparkles have themselves covered?"

"Mhmm, that's the plan." She nods, knowing but not caring that Catra can't see her. "Or, well I think I might drive them there and Mermista said she and Sea Hawk can bring them home."

"Great, I might still be doing photos when y'all get here but we're *supsed* to be done before guests start arrives. So, I might be mingling while the brides have a moment. Otherwise I'll see you at the ceremony. I'll be the one up front, looking *super hot* in a suit."

"Hmm, I have no doubt."

Catra is *not* mingling when the best friend squad arrives. Apparently wedding photos are still ongoing, so they mingle with the other guests. They spot Mermista and Sea Hawk shortly after arriving and spend some time catching up. Mermista tells them all about her new internship. By the end of it Adora is a little bit jealous and also kind of wants a dolphin companion.

The property looks beautiful. Scorpia and Perfuma had decided to get married on their own land. They're using the flower garden for the reception space and a small open field for the ceremony. There are flowers *everywhere*, stars dancing merrily amongst them. They've chose lavender roses and red tulips and Adora idly wonders what they mean. There are baskets of fuchsia flowers tucked around also, brimming over with blossoms and trailing stars. Adora knows from Catra that Perfuma has been using one of several greenhouses to grow the out of season flowers for the occasion herself.

Before long they're guided to the seats that have been set up around an elaborately carved arch. They're set up in the center of the field where the ceremony is to be held. Catra and Scorpia walk out first and it's obvious the latter is already in tears. Catra hands her a handkerchief from her pocket at they settle to the left of the arch. Red rimmed eyes notwithstanding, Scorpia looks incredible. Her dress is bright white, sleek and sexy with one shoulder bared and a large slit up one leg.

CatraCatra takes Adora' s breath away. She's in a burgundy suit with a dark pink button down underneath, and a lavender tie and rose boutonniere in her lapel. Her hair is down and wild, curls unrestrained and ruffling slightly in the breeze. As folks settle, waiting for Perfuma's arrival, Catra scans the audience. Her eyes flit over Adora and then she freezes, darting her eyes back. She looks surprised and, if Adora recognizes the look in her eyes like she thinks she does, turned on.

She mouths something to Adora, who isn't the best lip reader . She's pretty sure it's something along the lines of;What the fuck? or maybe Let' s fuck.' Probably the former...maybe. Adora just smirks back, feeling confident after the makeover Glimmer had insisted on that morning. There wasn't much to it, but Adora is wearing eyeliner for what must be the fourth or fifth time in her adult life and she has her hair down for once, soft and wavy around her shoulders.

The music starts making the ambient stars drifting through the air float along to the melody. That, combined with and Glimmer's elbow in her side, breaks the heated stare Adora shares with Catra. Perfuma floats down the aisle, ethereal and elegant. She's wearing a flowing, blush colored dress, very fitting of her style. She looks at Scorpia the entire time she walks toward her, her beaming face contrasting her almost-wife's tear stained cheeks.

The ceremony is...emotional to say the very least. The couple chooses to recite their own vows and neither one holds back. Adora watches a star come to life between them, buzzing with possibility , love and growth. Not an eye in the audience is dry by the time the music begins for the recessional. Perfuma and Scorpia dance down the aisle, the new star shooting after them. Catra and Perfuma's witness, Rosie, follow after them. Then suddenly, it's time for the reception.

There's a dance floor set up in the middle of the garden with tables scattered all around the edge. On one end is a table set for two with slightly more elaborate décor and a banner strung across the front that reads, Just Married! Candles and fairy lights provide a warm

glow and the overall vibe is incredibly cozy. There's a self-serve bar with sparkling cider and champagne so the friends grab a drink and make their way to a table where they spot Sea Hawk and Mermista.

Bow, still teary from the ceremony, greets them as they sit down. "Hey guys! Was that not the most beautiful display of romantic love you've ever seen?"

"Uhh, sure." Mermista drawls, knocking back the remainder of a glass of cider.

"Aye! Terribly beautiful Bow! Why, I don't think my heart will ever recover from the tender words spoken today. My heart is alight with the flames of passionate and true love!" Mermista groans at Sea Hawks enthusiasm, his only acknowledgement of the noise is a loud peck on her cheek. She blushes, rolling her eyes in a poor attempt to cover her obvious pleasure at the gesture.

Glimmer just chuckles at the boys, sipping her champagne. "That ceremony was the sappiest thing I have ever seen."

There's a general hum of agreement around the table and Adora goes to take a sip of her own glass. Out of nowhere she hears, "*Hey Adora*." from over her shoulder. She chokes a little on her drink and turns around to see Catra smirking down at her.

She stands and spins to greet her. "Hey! You look amazing." She leans in for a kiss but Catra grabs her by the shoulders, holding her in place.

"Me? What happened to I bought a dress today?" Catra eyes her up and down and she smirks back.

"I never said that, pretty sure I just said I found something."

Catra's words ooze and drip with sarcasm. "Wow, okay Princess."

"And anyway, who said I didn't buy a dress?"

Catra raises an eyebrow at her. "Right, you gonna explain that one? Or are you just being a fucking tease right now?"

It makes Adora bark out a laugh. "Yeah, that. The second thing."

"Whatever, are you gonna let me tell you how hot you look or...?"

"Right, my apologies. Please." She waves her arm down her body as if presenting the ensemble to Catra.

"Stars." Catra grumbles under her breath, grabbing Adora by the lapels of her jacket and pulling her in for a deep kiss. At some point Bow and Sea Hawk begin to whoop loudly, Mermista groaning in the background. Catra starts laughing too hard to continue the kiss and pulls back from a dazed Adora. "You look way hot babe."

"Right, umm... you too."

Catra looks altogether too smug. "I need a drink, anyone else need anything?"

"I'll come with you I guess." Mermista replies, standing from her seat.

"Would you get me another champagne please?" Adora requests, giving Catra a final peck on her cheek at her nod and resuming her seat.

The remaining friends chat a little more about the ceremony and cheer along with everyone else when Scorpia and Perfuma come to the ceremony space and take their seats. Mermista and Catra return shortly after, laughing heartily together. Catra drops to her seat, slinging an arm over the back of Adora's chair.

Mermista addresses her as she reclaims her own seat. "Yeah, so Catra is my new girlfriend. Sorry Adora."

"Oh dear." Sea Hawk interjects. "Is this some sort of triad thing we're trying or does this mean- "

"Gross dude, no." Catra tells him. "I'm way too fucking gay for you."

"I'm sorry , what's happening?" Adora looks between the two of them.

"Uh, yeah. W ell I just fell madly in love with Catra so." Adora feels her face heat. *Wow does Mista say that so casually when I can't even…* "sucks to suck Grey , but you're out."

Adora puts on an exaggerated pout and turns to Catra. "But I look so good in my suit." She plucks at the bottom of her jacket.

Catra's laugh bursts out of her and she turns to Mermista with a shrug. "She' s got a point. Sorry Misty, I don't think it' s gonna work out."

Mermista's face hardens in and instant and she shoves a finger in Sea Hawk' s face. "Don't you fucking dare. That' s just for Catra." He opens his mouth to argue but at Mermista's glare just offers a sad little nod instead. Satisfied she turns her finger on the rest of the table. "That goes for everyone. And you!" She turns to Catra now . "I'm out of love with you, we're breaking up."

"W ow, how will I ever recover?"

"Probably won't, I recommend ice cream as a coping mechanism."

"Ooh, ice cream. I'm fucking hungry , when's food?"

As if Catra's words are magic the caterer announces the opening of the buffet just then. The food is, of course, nothing short of magical. All very simple but expertly and intentionally prepared. Adora's fairly certain she eats more vegetables that night than she has in the last week.

The end of the meal leads into the start of dancing and these women know how to party. They kick things off with a first dance to something soft and romantic, but the energy picks up immediately after. The dance floor is hopping, each new song that plays is

Adora's absolute *f avorite* song. They dance in a group and switch up partners when they break off, but she feels like she could dance with Catra all night. They flirt and make eyes and tease, at one point Catra drops her into a dip that has her pulse racing. She's basically just a swooning mess by the time the music is dialed back for the cake to be brought out.

The cake is it'. s a thing of true beauty and pure magic. The buttercream is an ombre of vibrant pinks and purples, and all down the sides fuchsia flowers cascade with a waterfall of stars flowing alongside them. The cake cutting is adorable, Adora's heart melts at the tender look Perfuma gives Scorpia as she's fed her first bite.

The music picks back up and some folks opt to hold off on cake in favor of more time on the dance floor. Their friends opt for the latter but Adora isn't about to wait for cake so she and Catra head in that direction. They get their cake and refills on their drinks fairly quickly and make their way to the table. Catra wastes no time in kicking her shoes off under the table and throwing her feet up on Adora's lap.

She digs in without another word and Adora takes a moment to smile fondly at her before picking up her own fork. She finds herself reveling in the familiarity and comfort of their position. Adora takes a bite and suddenly her heart is flooded with emotion. All the love and care that has been simmering under the surface reaches a boiling point in an instant.

She looks up at Catra;her eyes are eyes closed and cake crumbs and tiny stars cling to the corners of her smile. She blinks her eyes open and Adora breaths the words she's been summoning the courage to say for so long now. "I'm in love with you, Catra."

Catra blinks twice and then her face warms into a smile. A star encapsulates them where they sit, and Catra's smile is the origin point of it all. "I love you too, Dora."

Adora laughs once, watery and joyful. "Y eah?

"Yeah you dummy, come here." She smiles wide and pulls her feet off Adora's lap so she can lean in all the way. She cups the back of Adora neck with one hand and smiles through their kiss, which is barely a kiss at all. More just their two smiles brushing against one another.

They pull apart just enough to lean their foreheads together and lock eyes. "I love you!" Adora gleefully tells her again.

"That's gay." Catra beams back.

Adora giggles, her heart lighter than air. "You love me back."

"That I do Princess, that I do."

"Wow."

"Alright." Catra stokes the back of Adora's neck with her thumb a couple times and pulls back. "Hit me with more of that cake lover."

They sit together for a while after that; making heart eyes at each other, eating their cake and doing a poor job suppressing their elated giggling. Eventually they're interrupts when Perfuma and Scorpia come over to sit and join them for a moment.

"Hey! You two look happy." Scorpia praises.

"Yeah well," Catra tears her eyes from Adora's and gives Scorpia a significant look. "I suppose love will do that to ya."

Scorpia's eyes water instantly. "*Aww!* You guys! Wow, and on our wedding day. It's the best wedding gift you could have given me!" She rushes around the table to crush them in a group hug which has Adora blushing brightly.

Perfuma smiles on indulgently. When Scorpia finally releases them to circle the table once more she asks, "So who told who?"

Catra shrugs. "Adora started it."

The aforementioned laughs. "Started it? You make it sound like I picked a fight."

She's distracted by Perfuma's triumphant, "I told you babe."

Catra raises a brow at them. "Excuse me?"

Without a hint of shame Perfuma explains, "Scorpia said that your big top energy meant you'd confess first. I assured her while in a different dynamic that might be true, since you've been with Adora you've been much more inclined to let her come to you. Besides, Adora has a tendency to blurt things out."

Adora chokes on her drink and Catra has to thump her on the back to calm her coughing. "Well that's fucking invasive." Catra complains while Adora attempts to gather herself.

Perfuma shrugs, unfazed. "I it makes you feel better Scorpia wouldn't let me bet on it."

"It does not, in fact, make me feel better."

"Hm, well I tried." Perfuma looks completely unbothered by the line of conversation.

"Don't be mad!" Scorpia turns to her wife. "Can I play the bride card for this kind of thing?"

"I have to assume so." Perfuma giggles back, laughing harder at Catra's groan.

"Wow, whatever. We're *not* talking about this anymore. How's your wedding?"

"Absolutely fabulous! Thank you so much for all your hard work Wildcat, we couldn't have done it without you."

"Sure, sure." Catra waves off the praise.

"Scorpia, the cake was to die for ."Adora praises. "Can Iask what was in there?"

Scorpia's eyes light up, thrilled at being asked. "Y ou betcha!It' s my Let' s Fall in Love Blend'. So that' s vanilla cake with lavender roses for love at first sight and red tulip for passion and declarations of love. Then the filling is with lavender lemon curd for calmness and devotion, and then buttercream has apple blossom for heady love, peace and sensuality. Oh!And the fuchsias are for confiding love, one of my faves."

Adora blinks at her a few times and then starts laughing, much to the bewilderment of the new brides, until tears are streaming down her face. t' s justit'. s too much. A flurry of stars dances around them, seeming to be joining in on Adora' s joy and mirth.

"Uhis.she okay?"Scorpia asks after a moment.

Catra snickers and wipes at the corner of her own eyes. "T otally fine. Iuhlthink your cake may have played wing woman tonight Scorp."

"Hh?"Something seems to dawn on her . "*O* . Oh!A w, *really*? That's so nice!"

"W ow Scorpia, you areyou're truly something special."

"Isn't she just?"Perfuma agrees readily with Adora' s assessment. "Alright, well congratulations to you both. Babe, we should keep making the rounds."

"Right!W ell, have fun you two. See you on the dance floor later?"

"Sounds good Scorp."They exchange a few final smiles and Catra turns her attention back to Adora. "Sw about it Princess, wanna dance?"

"Mm,"Adora starts shoving one last, massive bite of cake in her mouth. "Mm hmm!"She stands and holds her hand out to her

laughing girlfriend, leading her to the floor.

They dance until late in the night, taking off after a sparkler send off for the brides. Adora knows she should feel exhausted, but she's still just giddy. Love, they're in love! Adora is so full of it she could burst.

She eyes Catra where she sits in the driver's seat of Adora's pick up, cutting her eyes away each time she's caught staring. Catra just snickers at her when she catches her looking. Finally, she grabs Adora's hand and rests in on her thigh. Adora's heart jumps.

"What are you thinking about over there?" Adora wavers, unsure of how honest to be; she's thinking about one thing in particular. It leaves no spare room in her mind. She can feel her pulse thrumming in her neck, her stomach flipping and dropping. She knows what she wants, she's certain of it. Now the question is; can she ask for it?
"Adora?"

"I think we should have sex. Tonight."

Catra nearly veers off the road.

"Catra! Stars a-fucking-bove!"

"What the hell Dora?" She pulls onto the shoulder and flips on the flashers, turning in her seat to face Adora. "You can't just *say* things like that!"

"Oh." Adora bites her lip. "Because it's too forward or because you nearly ran us off the road?"

"Yeah, *definitely* the second thing there babe. That's just… *very* distracting. Holy fuck." She sets a hand over her heart, seeming to be making an effort to calm its racing. After a minute she asks, "Um did you mean it?"

Adora smiles, shy but brave. "Yeah I meant it. Is that do you want that? I know it's been a long day, I just- "

"Fuck *yes* I want that." Neither of them does or says anything after that for a long minute.

"Uh are you good to drive? Cause I was definitely thinking we'd do it in your bed."

Catra scoffs. "I'm sure I'll manage Princess." She starts the car but before pulling back onto the road she gives Adora one last look. "You're sure?"

Adora leans over and kisses her, not deep but plenty firm. She pulls her lips away leans her forehead on Catra's. "I'm *sure*. I want you Catra."

"*Fuck*, okay." Without another word she pulls away and maneuvers the car back onto the road. The drive back feels endless, Adora's practically shivering in anticipation of what's to come. Catra eyeing her every chance she gets certainly isn't helping. Not when she has that smoldering look in her eyes.

They waste no time piling inside the house when they arrive. Adora grabs the vase of flowers one of Scorpia's moms had forced on them, but Catra's extra bags lay forgotten in the trunk. Once inside Adora sets the vase on the kitchen island. And then... they just stare at each other. The air between them is thick with tension and heat.

It's Catra who finally break the silence. "I swear to all that is holy Adora, if you aren't out of that suit in the next three minutes"...

Adora laughs, equal parts nerves and elation. "Guess you better get started then."

Catra's expression remains serious and haughty as she demands, "Bedroom. Now."

She chases Adora in that direction, eliciting peals of laughter from her as she races into the room and jumps backward onto the bed.

Adora leans back on her elbows, looking up at Catra who stands between her knees where her legs hang over the side of the bed.

"So a suit huh?"

Adora makes a noncommittal gesture. "Bow's idea."

"Hmm and this mystery dress you mentioned, why not that? Not that I'm complaining mind you." She yanks Adora up by her lapels, running her fingers up and down the fabric and watching the moment.

Adora bites her lip, debating how much to reveal. "Honestly I wasn't even gonna get it, but Bow insisted."

"Uh huh, why's that?"

"Uh." She smirks. "Well it makes my butt look *really* good."

Catra looks up sharply. After a pause she says, "Huh, guess I can't wait to see it then. Now this," She pushes at Adora's jacket. "needs to go."

She doesn't stop at the jacket, removing clothes until Adora is down to briefs and a sports bra. She moves in for a kiss, but Adora holds her at arm's length. At her disgruntled look Adora insists, "You too."

Catra smirks and pulls back, her movements tantalizingly slow as she undresses, never breaking the stare she's caught Adora in. By the time her jacket and tie are off and she's starting on her shirt buttons Adora's patience is gone. With a huff she smacks Catra's hands out of the way, much to her girlfriend's amusement, and does a much hastier job of undressing her down to her sports bra and a lacy thong.

Now both down to their underwear they both hesitate, the energy in the room charged. "So." Adora beings, catching her lip between her teeth in lieu of continuing.

"So." Catra cups her cheek and strokes it with her thumb. The gesture is so tender and caring, Adora closes her eyes to stave off the overwhelming sensations it stirs in her. "How we feeling Adorable?"

Adora blinks her eyes open and smiles shyly up at her. "Good." She breaths. Then, deciding to be completely honest (because if not now, when?), she adds, "A little nervous."

Catra nods, smiling patiently. "Yeah, me too."

"Yeah?"

"I want this to be everything you're hoping for Adora. I don't want." She looks down, breaking eye contact.

Adora reaches up to place her own hand over Catra's where it lingers on her cheek. She waits until Catra looks up at her again to speak. "You won't, you can't. I just want I just wanna be with you. That's all that matters."

Something like determination sets in Catra's eyes. "Right." And then her lips are on Adora's, overpowering every one of her senses. She maneuvers Adora onto the bed, following after her without breaking the kiss. Once she's situated against the pillows Catra pulls back to take in the sight of her. The heat of her gaze makes Adora flush from head to toe and Catra smirks deviously at the sight. It briefly occurs to Adora that she is *gay* too gay for this. "Fuck Adora, I love you so much."

Catra dives back in, her lips on Adora's neck this time, pulling and nipping at the skin there. She can't contain the gasping and groaning the feeling pulls from her. That plus the anticipation of where they're headed has Adora incredibly turned on in no time, more wet than she's likely ever been in her life. "*Please*." She whines as Catra drags her lips over Adora's collar bones.

Catra pulls back, nearly panting, her face flushed, and pupils dilated. "*Fuck*. How are you so hot?"

"*Catra.*" She's not really sure if she's begging her or warning her. All Adora knows is that if Catra doesn't touch her soon she's going to spontaneously combust.

"Shit, okay. Can I take the rest of your clothes off?" Adora doesn't even give her half a chance. Sitting up so fast it forces Catra to lean back, she whips her own bra off and starts on her briefs. Catra just smirks down at her, not moving off her thighs and thus remaining an obstacle to Adora's goal. "Wow, eager much?"

Adora gives up and falls back onto the pillows with a discontented sound. "Yes, can you move?" Catra just laughs at her and moves to finish the job. Her laughter dies on her lips the moment Adora is fully exposed.

"Stars, you're so damn beautiful, you know that?" A shiver runs through Adora as Catra reaches out to run delicate fingers over her stomach, down her thighs, over her chest and up until she's cradling Adora's head once more. She leans in close enough to kiss her and whispers, "Ready?"

Adora bites her lip and nods emphatically, holding Catra's steady look. She feels every muscle in her body clench and unclench in anticipation, closing her eyes gently when Catra bridges the distance to kiss her lips one last time. She continues to press soft, feather light kisses in a path down Adora's body. Adora adjusts her position slightly so as to not lose sight of Catra and the trail of burning stars she leaves in her wake.

And then she's there, like *there* there, and Adora feels her whole body burning with white hot fire. Fuck, is *she* the star now? The question fades from her mind as quickly as is comes. Catra is just… staring at her, her mouth drooping open slightly.

"Babe?" Catra's eyes snap up to Adora's.

I *love* you Adora Grey."Adora is choked by her own emotion, burning twice as hot. Unable to speak she does nothing to wipe the vulnerability from her expression. She just holds Catra's eyes and nods earnestly, hoping the point gets across.

In an instant Catra snaps her eyes down and drops her face down. The instant her mouth is on her Adora can do nothing to contain her shout. "*Fuck*!"Catra's tongue begins to move;hot and wet and smooth fire against her. No longer able to fight to keep her eyes open Adora clenches them shut and throws her head back. Her noises quiet to a serious of uninhibited whines. She can barely breath, let alone muster up the capacity to maintain her screaming. Though she can feel the pressure of words unsaid building in her chest.

Ever muscle from her navel to her knees seizes, seeming to coil more and more tightly together centered around her clit which Catra fucks relentlessly with her mouth. Adora's incessant whining culminates until it becomes just one long, low keening sound. Feeling herself reaching some sort of tipping she reaches her eyes open. The sight of Catra moaning against her is almost too much. And when her harsh whisper of "*Shit*, Catra!"causes her lover to look up and into her eyes it's *def initely*too much. She groans. "*Ilove you*."And turning it into a mantra she continues to chant, "Ilove you, Ilove you, Ilove you"while she comes.

And then suddenly, it hits her all at once. It's like being in the dessert in the middle of the night;skies clear and stars bright all around them. She can nearly feel the burn of them on her skin, hot and growing hotter. They vibrate with pure energy. And with one final flick of Catra's tongue…

Dawn breaks;silver stars lit up against a wash of hazy pink and purple. Darkness only exists to give way to light which grows soft and steady. Adora feels herself floating between them. And then she gasps, and the stars begin to beat with her heart, time resumes.

Catra pulls back, sitting up on her knees, and wipes at her mouth. She looks at Adora in wonder. "That was the single hottest experience of my entire life. You amaze me."

Adora blushes and smiles lazily at her. She raises her arms in silent invitation and sighs happily when Catra crawls over her to snuggle. She runs her fingers through Adora's hair, laying with her as she comes down and humming softly in her ear. After a while Adora whispers, "Catra that waswow."

Catra props her head up so her can look down at her with a smirk. "Yeah? And just think," She says with a salacious wink. "I havent even been inside of you yet."

Adora doesnt even have time to blush before Catra's lips are on hers, riling her up again. Turning her back on. She manages to come several times with Catra inside of her before the pair succumb to exhaustion, their limbs an indistinguishable tangle.

Adora wakes the next morning to soft light filtering in through the curtains. There are hazy silver stars left over from last night floating on the breeze coming through the cracked window. She's alone but can hear Catra bustling around in the kitchen. A glance at her phone tells her it's after ten, which makes sense as they were up past three.

She lets out a little hum and stretches, reveling in the newfound ache in some of her muscles. She's still mustering up the gumption to get out of the cozy bed when Catra sticks her head around the door with a grin. "Hey sleepy head."

Adora smiles back, feeling so, so happy. "H"

Catra comes in the rest of the way and crosses the room to sit on the edge of the bed. She drops a peck to her lips and leans back to smile down at her. "How you feeling this morning?"

"Hmm, I *love* you." She professes, giving exactly zero care about how breathless she sounds.

Catra giggles at her. "Love you too Princess. Hungry?"

"Mm, mm hmm."

"Great, do you want to come out or should I bring food in here?"

Adora grins devilishly. "Naked breakfast?"

Catra laughs loudly at this. "Are you asking me to bring food in here or are you asking if you can eat naked on my couch? I'm fine with either."

Adora pouts, which works terribly as she's still grinning. "The bed is pretty comfy"…

"Alright Pillow Princess- "

"Hey! Inaccurate."

"wait here, I'll be back." Adora sticks out her tongue and Catra flicks it so fast Adora doesn't have time to bat her hand away .

"Hey , you be careful with that!" Adora insists. "Unless you don't want me to be able to use it later." Catra rolls her eyes and slips back out without a word. She comes back moments later balancing a tray laden with waffles, coffee and juice. "Wow, have I mentioned today that I love you?"

"You know I think you have." Catra snickers. "That first one really opened the floodgates, huh?" Adora pouts back. "I love you too Adorable, now eat your food."

Adora smiles again and happily complies. The gobble up breakfast and linger in bed for another hour before Adora gets restless. "Is anything happening today?" She asks Catra as she pulls her

underwear back on. Then she stands in the middle of the room, pondering her clothing options. "Uh, I might need to go home."

"What, you don't want to put that suit back on for me? I promise to take it off again." She waggles her eyebrows to emphasize her point.

Adora rolls her eyes and pulls her suit pants back on, inviting herself to dig through Catra's t-shirts looking for something that might fit. "Babe, plans?"

"You're no fun."

"Not what it seemed like last night."

"Fine, you're no fun *today*."

"Catra!" She scolds with a laugh, truly unbothered but still trying to get her question answered.

"Eh, I should go grocery shopping but other than that, no."

"Okay, wanna swing by The Castle first? I'm not trying to go to Kroger's in my morning after clothes."

"Hmm, morning after what?" Catra teases.

Adora shoots her a droll look. "After getting thoroughly fucked by my amazing lover. Is that what you were hoping to hear?"

"*Adora!*" Catra scandalized look seems to be at least a little bit genuine and Adora enjoys the light flush that breaks out over her cheekbones. "Shit, a couple of orgasms and suddenly you're little miss wild thing."

Adora shrugs, looking down at the shirt stretching tightly over her shoulders and plucking casually at the fabric. "They were really good orgasms."

Catra looks pleased with herself. "Yeah?"

"Oh, like you had any doubt."

"Still nice to hear ."

"W ell in that case."Adora comes to stand in front of her , tipping her face up and cradling it in her hands. "I had no idea it was possible to cum so hard. *Thankyou* for fucking me so good last night."

"Y -You're welcome."Catra coughs to clear her throat and Adora leans in to press a soft kiss to either of her cheeks.

"Do you need to get ready?"

Still a little dazed, Catra' s gaze is unfocused as she looks at her . "Uh, are you really trying to go grocery shopping with me?"

"Unless you want to go alone. Idont really care;Ijust want to hang out with you today."

Eyes clearing Catra smirks, ready to get back to teasing. "W ow, needy."

"Y eah."Adora answers plainly .

"Stars, Ifucking love you."She stands to pull Adora into a tight hug, nuzzling her head under her chin.

"I love you too Catra."Adora murmurs back, holding her just as tight.

Glimmer is home, and on the couch, when they finally make their way to The Castle. She pauses her show to turn and smirk at them. "Hey , nice outfit Adora."

She looks down at herself as if she's forgotten what she's wearing and blushes. "Uhthanks. Iborrowed the shirt from Catra."She explains unnecessarily. The shirt's owner snorts beside her then circles the couch to make herself comfortable in the armchair.

"Y ou two totally fucked, didn't you?"

"*Ugh!* *Gah!* "Adora admonishes. Catra doesn't give a shit, just snickers from her spot in the chair.

"*What?* I can practically smell it on you."

"A w, what's the matter Sparkles? Didn't get any last night?"

Glimmer goes beet red. "Shut up Catra! That' s not the point."

"The *point* Glimmer, is shut up." Adora tells her .

"W ow, very mature."

"Not really what I was going for , but sure. I'm going to put on normal clothes. Glimmer, be chill." She flounces her way down the hall and hastily throws on a more suitable outfit. She returns to the living room, still rolling up the sleeve of her flannel in her haste. There she finds Catra cracking up. Glimmer looks flustered but is laughing right along with her.

"Uhh, ready babe?"

"Sure thing, Princess. Catch ya later Glitter ."

"Glim you need anything from the- oh shit." Adora' s looked at her phone to check the time and now stares at the notification on the screen in surprise.

"Adora, what?"

"Babe, you okay over there?"

She looks up at them and blinks a few times before her brain starts to catch up. "Y eah, yeah I'm uh." She opens the email from Noelle and reads what she has to say, mouth dropping open slightly as she reads. "Oh."

She turns back up to look at the other women and shakes her head to clear it. "Adora?" Catra tries again.

"uh, Iemailed that woman, Noelle?"

"Y ou did, when?" Catra looks genuinely surprised, but unof fended at not having been told sooner.

"Like, a few days ago Iguess."

"What did she *say* Adora?" Glimmer questions.

"She wants me to illustrate a book. Or well, a book proposal and then hopefully a book."

"That' s so cool."

"Y eahI..mean yes, it is. But do Ieven know how to do that?"

"mean babe, she' s seen your art, clearly she thinks so. What's the book?"

"Right, right, that' sright. t' s likesome kind of warrior princess story it looks like. A graphic novel, Ithink. She sent along an excerpt from the draft and stuff. t' s called uhShe Ra?" She reads the email again.

"That' s so cool!" Glimmer squeals.

"t really is babe. Are you gonna go for it?"

"yeah, Ithink Iam." When she looks down at her phone again the screen bursts into hundreds of tiny stars. She has a good feeling about this.

Chapter End Notes

Whew! This one felt like such a grind to get out, Iprocrastinated by writing a whole *other* story! But feeling pleased with how it

turned out. Slated for just a couple more chapters and Ithink I should be able to tie up everything Iwant in that time, they grow up so fast!
Thanks to everyone reading and for all the kind words that have been left and all the kudos given!

Baby, You're a Star

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

December passes in a single moment. Between the huge bash Glimmer had organized to celebrate her birthday, the holidays and working on She Ra Adora felt like she barely had time to think about the year ahead. So, when New Year's Eve hits it feels like it comes out of nowhere.

Luckily Adora doesn't really have to think about the holiday or plan for it; Mermista's parents are off visiting her Nani so she and Glimmer are hosting a party at their big, fancy house. Adora is excited, but she's also had a weird feeling in her gut all day. The stars lingering around The Castle seem to be muted somehow. It puts her on edge going into the prefunk Glimmer had insisted on.

She gives herself a final once over in the mirror. Mermista had insisted on a "classy event for classy people" and Glimmer and Bow had instantly insisted it was her opportunity to wear the dress. She still thinks it's maybe just a bit too formal but has to admit it looks just as good as she remembers. She runs a hand through her hair, which she's left loose and natural for once, and smiles at the glitter that sparkles on her cheeks as she moves. Bow had insisted it would complete the look. He wasn't wrong.

Satisfied she nods once at her reflection and walk into the dining room where Bow and Glimmer are mixing cocktails. "Damn Adora, you look bangin!" Glimmer compliments, looking up from her task.

"Yeah? Thanks, you two look awesome. Leave any glittery fabric for the rest of the New Year's Eve crowd?" She teases.

"Of course!" Bow tells her solemnly. "Hoarding resources does no one any good."

"T ruewhat are you making?"

"French 75' s!"She looks back at him blankly . "Like champagne and lemon juice and uh, gin?" is gin, right Glimmer?"

"t is, here you can take this one Adora."

She accepts the glass with a nod of thanks and sips tentatively, taking a proper drink once she's decided she does indeed like it. Before she can polish it off Bow demands a toast, "T o the Best Friend Squad' s best year yet!"

As Adora takes another swig of her drink a knock at the door grabs her attention. "Oh!That' s probably Catra."

She bustles to the door and opens it wide. The minute she opens it her eyes go wide, and her mouth is suddenly dry as the Sahara. Catra looks good. Fabulous even. She's wearing a black suit Adora's never seen before with a sheer silver button up and some sort of lacy black bralette visible underneath. "A w, we're night and day ."

Adora startles out of her lusting and looks down at herself and back to Catra. "Uh, what?"

Catra rolls her eyes, pushing past Adora to get into the warm apartment and turning around to face her again. "Y ou're white and gold, m silver and black;night and day ."

"Oh."She considers this for a moment. "That' s gay."She decides.

"Come here dummy ."Catra laughs, planting a deep, sloppy kiss on her mouth. Pulling back, she checks Adora out again. "Y ou look"… She lets loose a long, low whistle that makes Adora's stomach flip.

"Y eah?"Catra wordlessly pulls away and holds her arm up to lead Adora into a spin.

"*Oh yeah* . Totally unrelated;how sure are we that we want to go to this party tonight?"

Adora smacks her shoulder lightly with the back of her hand. "You're incorrigible."

"I've heard that before, yeah. Doesn't answer my question."

"I know you're not serious."

"Wanna bet?" She pulls Adora by the hips until they bump into her own and shoots her a smoldering look.

"Ahem, what would you say to fashionably late?" Adora asks with a quirk of her brow .

"Oh, I *like* the way you think. What do you think our odds are of making it past Simon and Garfunkel in there?"

"Shit." Adora pouts, glancing back in the direction she'd come from. "You have a point. Raincheck?"

"Eh, guess we'll just have to see what the new year brings." Catra teases with a wink.

Before Adora can open her mouth to respond, Glimmer and Bow start hollering from the dining room; getting on their case for "making out in the hallway all night." With minimal grumbling they head to the dining room to join their friends, ready to get this party started.

By the time they show up to the house Adora has managed to mostly shake off her sense of foreboding. The several cocktails she had before they left seem to help with that. Mermista's party makes for an idyllic New Year's. All of their friends are dressed to the nines and most of them get toasted on champagne, laughing and filling the house to the brim with starlight. Seahawk even manages to convince Mermista to let him shoot off fireworks at midnight. Adora rings in the new year kissing Catra beneath a sea of stars and crackling glitter.

Having not been able to arrive fashionably late they make their farewells early. A cab drops them off at Catra's just before one and

they fall in the door attached at the lips, giggling at Catra's fumbling with her keys. Melog takes one look at the tipsy pair and bolts for the bedroom.

Catra pulls away to tease him. "Hey little dude, you know that's where we're heading too, right?" She turns to wink at Adora who rolls her eyes but blushes anyway. "Alright, I need to pee and then I'll get us some water. Meet me in the room?"

"Uh huh, sounds good. I'm just gonna steal some night clothes, I'm ready to be out of this dress."

"Aw," Catra stick her bottom lip out. "Shame to see it go, but I have been wondering what it'll look like on my bedroom floor all night."

"You hopeless flirt!" Adora reaches over and pokes her forehead. "Get outta here, go pee."

Catra obliges with a cackle and Adora smiles fondly at her back, heading to the room to change. She peels off her dress, laying it over Catra's desk chair, Catra's fantasies be dammed. She is not putting the fanciest thing she owns on the floor, thank you very much. She pulls on a t-shirt, overlarge on Catra and just a little loose for her and digs out a pair of her boxers that's come to live here.

When her phone rings she's surprised. When she sees it's Mara calling... something like shock and terror twist her gut. She had texted Adora earlier in the day. She joked about hope making them watch the east coast telecast of the ball dropping and being in bed by ten; Bc hope apparently skipped mom and went right to grandma lol!

Suddenly the uneasy feeling she'd been battling all night returns to her gut with a vengeance. All the stars floating around her freeze, their tension matching that which has settled in her shoulders. "Mara? What's going on?"

"Woah, chill Squirt!"

"Mara, why are you calling me in the middle of the night?" Catra walks in with two glasses of water and gives Adora a questioning look. She frowns and shakes her head.

"The middle of the night? Damn kid, you're more of an old woman than Hope! It's New Year's Eve." At Adora's distressed noise Catra comes up behind her and guides her to the bed. She sits behind her and rubs circles into her back.

"*Mara!*"

Mara sighs deeply. "It's really *fine* Adora. I just figured you'd be up and would wanna know; Hope is having contractions."

Adora feels like she's been waiting all night for this news. She just isn't sure why it doesn't feel like good news. "She- is that okay? I mean that's early, right?"

"She's fine right now. And it's a little early, yeah, but that's not what the doctor is worried about."

"But they are worried." "It's not a question.

"It's the baby isn't in an ideal position or something. They're talking about a C section."

"Oh, what is-what does that mean?"

"Adora, Hope and the baby I'm nervous but all the doctors are saying that we shouldn't be worried at this point. I think we just gotta trust them for now K."

"Okay, okay. Keep me updated if you can. How are you holding up?"

"I'm keeping my cool. For now. I should probably go though, check on Hope."

"Right, yeah of course. Give her a hug from me."

"Will do, send Catra our love." A few stars in the air relax ever so slightly at her words.

"Yeah, okay. Love you Mara."

"Love you too Squirt."

It takes Adora *hours* to get to sleep that night, but eventually Catra's hand in her hair soothes her into a light doze. She's a nervous wreck the next morning. Catra is gentle with her, coaxing her to eat breakfast with reminders that a hunger strike isn't going to help anyone. Finally, *finally*, while Adora is still unenthusiastically picking at her bagel her phone chimes.

"It's Mara." She announces after practically pouncing on her phone. Catra reaches over and grips her free arm, watching her reaction intently. She feels herself deflate with relief at the message, tension melting from every part of her body. "They're fine, false alarm!"

She can practically feel Catra's tension melt off of her. "Fuck, thank the stars."

"Yeah, no kidding. The baby is still breech, that's like...sideways or something, right?" She looks up from her phone to see Catra still watching her.

"Uh, or like feet down I think."

"Right, yeah. Sounds like they have an eye on it but might still end up doing a C-section if they don't turn on their own."

"Do they think they will? Move on their own I mean." Adora shrugs, she has no idea, but she'll probably do a ton of research later.

"Hopefully."

That's all they hear as far as baby updates for a while. After a couple weeks Mara calls with the good news that the baby has in fact begun to shift. Adora's research had told her that *wasn't* super likely, so

she's thrilled to hear it. After that things are quiet but lingering in the back of Adora's mind is the knowledge that as her birthday draws close so does Hope's due date.

The eve of her birthday, and Hope's due date, finds Adora at Catra's again. Catra makes her a fancy dinner and plies her with wine all night. Staying the night at the house usually means an early bedtime, and after two bottles of red wine split between them Adora is glad for it. They're cuddled up by half nine, and within half an hour they've nearly drifted off to sleep.

Then out of nowhere Adora's phone rings. She silences it blindly, mumbling an apology to Catra who's grumbling sleepily at her. She settles back in and just as her breaths begin to even out again her phone rings a second time. She looks at the screen;Mara.

She scrambles to sit up which gets Catra's attention. She turns to watch Adora as she sits, blinking sleepily. She then reaches over to flick on Adora's bedside lamp. The both of them wince at the bright light. "Mara?Why are you calling so late?"

"Adora, darling."It's Hope. "I am just calling because- "her voice becomes strained. "Sorry , one moment."

And then Adora's eyes stretch wide and she's fully awake. She's fairly certain she's *never* heard Hope curse. But sure enough she can hear her gritting out a string of especially vulgar expletives. She can hear Mara's voice in the background, muffled but easy enough to understand. "Hope?Baby?I told you I'd call her at the hospital!"

"I am alright Mara, please keep your focus on the road."Then she's back on the line. "My apologies Adora, just a small contraction."

"Contraction?"I heard Mara say something about the hospital. "Hope, are you going into labor?"She tenses, waiting for an answer . Her question seems to wake Catra fully also as she sits up too. She flips on a light and her arm wraps around Adora to rub her back.

"Yes dear, nothing to worry over. My contractions are still quite far apart but my water broke seventeen minutes ago." A frenzy of stars begins circling around Adora's head like rings around Saturn.

"Oh my stars, Hope! How are you feeling? Can-can I do anything?"

"Adora, you are just as bad as your sister; I can hear your tension growing from here. We are absolutely fine and right on schedule. I will have Mara update you after the birth."

"Okay, okay. I'll start looking into flights and stuff." Catra leans her head down to nuzzle her head into Adora's shoulder and the pressure is somewhat grounding.

"Flights?" Hope questions, sounding bewildered.

"Yeah, it shouldn't be too hard to get out there. I just gotta call work, Catra?" Catra nods against her shoulder. "Don't let me forget to call Octavia." Catra nods again.

"Adora, that's really not necessary. They won't be going anywhere anytime soon. There's no rush."

"I mean." She starts to second guess herself. "I don't wanna overwhelm you guys but I'd like to meet them. Soon."

"Adora, you are always welcome at home. That being said; this baby will be here whenever you arrive, so feel no need to rush. Now, we're getting close to the hospital so I should let you go. Just let us know what you decide, Mara will call you."

"Right, yes, go. Have a baby. *Stars* Hope, you're about to have a baby!"

Hope chuckles lightly into the phone. "Yes dear, I believe I am. Oh, and Adora?"

"Yeah Hope?"

“Happy Birthday.”

The line clicks and Adora stares at her phone blankly for a minute in shock. “So, baby?” Catra prompts after some length of time.

“Yeah, baby. I guess Mara is stuck with another Capricorn after all.” Catra’s laughter shakes Adora’s shoulder, and soon she’s joining in. It feels good to laugh after the shock of big news.

Before they’ve even fully settled from their laughter Adora is on her phone, looking up flights. After searching for ten minutes she tugs at her hair and groans. “How are there no flights to Etheria?”

Catra peels herself off Adora’s shoulder and snuggles back into bed. “No flights at all?” Catra asks, her voice colored with exhaustion and doubt.

Adora bites her lip. “Fine, no flights as soon as I want there to be. The next one with available seats doesn’t leave until five in the morning on the twentieth.”

“Well,” Catra begins. “It might not be the worst thing in the world to let them get a night of rest before we show up. Plus, like I know you aren’t worried about it, but you can still celebrate your birthday at home that way. Besides, labor can last long, babe. There’s no knowing exactly when this kid is gonna show up.”

Adora continues to gnaw at her lip, but one point of Catra’s sticks out to her. “We?” The stars still circling her head bounce a little at the repetition of the word.

Catra just rolls her eyes and flops onto her back. “Adora, my love, would you just book the tickets so I can go to sleep?”

Adora’s heart flutters in her chest. She looks around the room for the first time; the stars have shifted to form constellations in the air around them. She recognizes the one burning most brightly from

different cards and gifts Glimmer and Bow have given her: Capricorn.

She pays for two tickets on the next flight to Eternia, turns out her light, and snuggles up to her girlfriend. She falls asleep much faster than she expects to.

She wakes up the next morning to feather light kisses moving across her cheeks. A grin stretches wide across her face. Catra pecks her way across one cheek to Adora's ear. "Happy birthday Adorable." Adora turns her head quickly to catch Catra in a kiss and soon they're both melting into it.

Then suddenly Adora remembers the night before and pulls away with a gasp. Before Catra can ask what the hell just happened Adora is scrambling for her phone. Sure enough there's a text from Mara from around four that morning. Little Starla finally showed up! 2:13 this morning. Ur an aunt now Squirt." Adora, choked by her own emotion, chuckles at the text and opens the attached image.

An exhausted Hope cradles a little, squishy , pink bundle in her arms. Adora drags Catra over to coo at the picture too. "Damn, that thing is tiny."

"Catra! Stars above"…

"What?" She asks, just the littlest bit defensive.

"That thing." Adora quotes with the shake of her head.

"Yeah? I stand by it. Babies are weird little aliens."

Adora looks back at her phone screen with a big smile. She agrees, "Yeah, super weird."

Eventually Catra manages to drag Adora away from the picture to feed her the breakfast already laid out on the table. She hadn't

realized just how ravenous she was until she's three pancakes in and showing no signs of slowing down. "So," Catra begins, a few pancakes later when Adora finally pushes her plate away with a groan. "what's the plan?"

"Hmm nap." is all Adora can come up with, patting her belly contentedly.

"Adora."

"*What?* All those carbs made me sleepy." She pouts. "It's my birthday and I wanna snuggle." Catra just gives her a derisive look and she huffs. "*Fine*, we still need to go get snacks and drinks and stuff. Then we're meeting Bow and Glimmer for lunch around one, and they're gonna come back here to." She gestures around the room vaguely. "y'know, decorate or whatever. Just fair warning on that; Bow did say something about confetti. Everyone else is coming over at three, I moved the time up since we're leaving so early tomorrow."

"Thank the stars. So, when do you wanna go to the store?"

"Eh, probably sooner versus later so we can drop stuff off back here with plenty of time." With a nod from Catra they get up from the table to start making moves toward the store. Catra shoos Adora out of the kitchen when she tries to help clean up. She ignores her when she says to go get dressed though. Instead she loiters around the island distracting Catra from her task until she's ready to get dressed too.

Their errand doesn't take too terribly long and unloading goes even more quickly. They have enough time to spend a half hour playing with Melog before they need to head out to meet Bow and Glimmer. Around half noon Catra starts urging Adora toward the car and she says an overly dramatic goodbye to the cat. Catra has to admit they seem to revel in the attention.

They make it in time to meet their friends promptly at one at the restaurant, not too far from Plumeria. "Birthday!" Bow shouts as soon as he spots Adora from where he and Glimmer are waiting outside the restaurant.

"Hey Bow!" Adora call back with a chuckle. As soon as she's within reaching distance Bow pulls her into a hug, which Glimmer promptly joins.

"Catra, I know you wanna get in here." Bow tells her, looking up to find her watching them with crossed arms. She smirks over at them, eyes soft and tender, and scoffs lightly as she relents. With one last squeeze they break apart.

"Should we go inside?" Adora asks her friends.

"Let's do it!" Glimmer leads the charge, holding the door open for the others. Being a random Tuesday, they're seated pretty quickly. They barely even have time to make small talk before someone is over to take their order.

That out of the way, Glimmer is ready to get down to business. "Presents!" She demands.

"Aw guys, you really didn't have- "

"Goddess above Adora, I am not doing this with you *again*."

Adora gives Glimmer a bashful look. "I'm just saying- "

"Uh huh, sure you are. Don't though. We just had this conversation *last* year."

"Fine. Thank you for getting me presents."

Satisfied Glimmer smiles serenely back, Bow and Catra just watch their girlfriends' exchange in bemusement. "You're welcome. Now, me first."

She plops a sparkling gift bag with big tufts of silvery tissue paper onto the table. Adora, much to *everyone's* combined impatience and amusement, takes time to neatly fold each piece of tissue paper as she digs through the bag. The first thing she pulls out if a thin box, inside of which she finds one very fancy fountain pen. "Ooh! Bougie, I love it. Thanks Glim."

"Keep going!"

Adora digs a little further and finds a book—not a book, a planner. It's pretty much the most beautiful planner Adora has ever seen; a cloth cover, thick pages and laid out the *exact* way Adora would do it herself. "Glimmer, it's *perfect*. Where did you—?"

"Custom." Adora's mouth drops open. She didn't even know that was an option. "You've described your perfect planner about one point five billion times, and that kind of thing just doesn't exist. Well… didn't, until now."

"This is so cool! *Thankyou* Glimmer!" Adora gets up and crosses over to wrap Glimmer in a tight hug. She crosses back to her seat and find Catra giving her a weird look. "What?"

"Uh? Oh, sorry. I just I knew I was dating a big nerd; I just didn't realize just how *big* of a nerd."

Adora just smirks, she can own that. "You like it."

"Stars save me, I do." Adora makes a goofy face and is distracted by a box landing on the table in front of her.

"My turn." Bow practically squeaks.

"Thanks Bow!" Adora moves to unwrap the box, just as methodically as she unpacked the bag. She opens the box to find several tubes of paint, some brushes and one or two other things rolling around. "Is this—?"

Bow nods eagerly. "Oil paints, yeah! There's also like, paint thinner and this other stuff the guy at the art store recommended."

"Linseed stand oil." Glimmer provides.

"Right, anyway, I know you've been wanting to try them out so ta da! Oh, and I got you a few canvases too. I just left them at home since they're kind of big."

"Bow, I'm so excited!" She stands again for another hug. When she sits back down Catra is waiting with an envelope.

"Happy birthday Princess."

Adora grins and accepts the gift. She slices it open with her butter knife and pulls out some sort of pamphlet, a card and certificate of some sort. She reads the card first and feels her eyes pop open. Ignoring everyone else's snickering, she shuffles the stack of papers to look at the pamphlet. Heart thumping fast she looks up to her girlfriend. "No way."

"Yes way." Catra grins wide at her excitement.

"*No way!*"

"Just to be clear I'm coming with you to take pictures and tease you about being a twenty-six-year-old horse girl, but *you* will be the only one getting on a horse. I will be staying *safely* on the other side of the fence."

"That's fine, oh my gosh, I really get to ride a horse?"

Catra snickers at her. "Sure do babe. And if the first ten lessons aren't enough for ya I'll reup you for valentine's day or something."

Adora can't hold back the squeal in her throat and, paying no mind to Bow and Glimmer's laughter, she throws her arms around Catra's neck and hugs her tightly. She's a little embarrassed to feel a couple

of tears escape but like, come on. This is a childhood *dream* coming true right now.

She laughs off her emotional display and is saved from any potential teasing by the arrival of their food. Lunch goes by quickly; Glimmer entertains them with updates on the latest family drama and it turns out to be a whole saga. It usually does to be fair .

Back at Catra's house Adora is set up on the couch with a mimosa and strict instructions not to help. The rule is soon broken when they realize Adora is the tallest among them, and they need to use her height. She is assured that is the only amendment to the rule when she tries to sneak in the kitchen to prep the snacks after streamers are hung.

A little while later, tipsy from the champagne, Adora giggles when Bow and Catra get into a heated debate over confetti. Bow *insists* that it's completely, 100% necessary for any good party . Eventually Catra allows a *little, tiny bit* to be spread out. She does, however, offer a warning: "If she' s still vacuuming it up in six months, she will not hesitate to lock Bow's first born in an isolated tower somewhere, or some other fairytale witch crap, maybe I'll invest in a spinning wheel."

Distressed, Bow turns to Glimmer for back up. Unfortunately for him she just shrugs and offers, "Sounds inevitable but yeah, that' s fair enough."

Even with Bow's continued protests over the severity of Catra's proposed consequences, soon the house is decorated to everyone' s satisfaction. Stars fill the space like bunting and even the snacks are ready when Mermista and Sea Hawk roll in at 2:45. When Glimmer opens the door Mermista is in the middle of scolding her boyfriend. "See I *told you* we were gonna be early. This is so not punk rock Sea Hawk." She points a warning finger at him. "Do *not* tell me that rhymes, I *know* that it rhymes and I do *not* care."

"Uh, hey guys, welcome." Mermista pushes past Glimmer with a groan. Sea Hawk is much more enthusiastic and greets her with a hug tight enough to leave her gasping for air. Soon they're joined by Scorpia and Perfuma, Entrapta, and Lonnie.

After they've greeted Entrapta and Lonnie, who arrive together, Catra tells Adora conspiratorially that, "The two of them have been hanging out an *awful* lot after Lonnie's Plumeria shifts." At Adora's questioning look she clarifies, "No dates at this point, but I mean look at them." Adora looks over to see Entrapta explaining something animatedly to Bow and Scorpia, while Lonnie laughs more often and much harder than their other friends.

Once everyone is set up with drinks and snack and gets settled in, they get set up with a game. They play poker with skittles in place of chips for a while. Adora insists on being the dealer every round so she can shuffle showily. The process gets increasingly lazier as Bow and Glimmer continue to keep her drink topped off. After a few hands Mermista and Sea Hawk begin to bicker in hushed whispers.

"Uh, you two good?" Catra interrupts.

"Totally." Mermista answers with an eye roll. "*Someone* just ate all his candy and is trying to get me to share mine. Like, I'm winning right now? So- "

"Hey!" Adora cuts her off, the word broken up by a body rocking hiccup. "Clearly *I* am winning." She gestures vaguely to her admittedly massive piles of skittles.

Glimmer furrows her brow. "Wait, when did that happen?"

Adora smirks and shrugs. "Players gonna play, amirite?"

Catra can't hold back a snort at that. "Yeah, okay Princess. Don't think I haven't noticed you sneaking candy from Bow and me. You're not slick."

Bow, sitting on the other side of Adora, looks alarmed at this. "What? I knew I wasn't losing *that* bad!" Then he curls an arm around his candies and starts counting them out.

Adora adopts a scandalized look that she is completely unable to pull off in her inebriated state. "Excuse me! It is my *birthday* and I would *never*!"

"Wait so who's actually winning?" Perfuma asks tentatively.

There's a brief silence until Adora makes her appeal. "I mean it *is* my birthday, so"…

"Whatever, besides Adora who is a cheater but I'm like, not supposed to say because it's her birthday apparently, it's definitely me." Mermista tells everyone in a tone that leaves little to no room for argument.

"Uh guys?" Adora turns from side to side to look at Bow, Glimmer and Catra. "Are there prizes?"

Catra just looks up as if sending a prayer out into the ether but Bow responds. "Eh bragging rights."

"Okay." Adora nods. "Mermista and I can share bragging rights." And with that she shoves a handful of her winnings into her mouth.

They play a couple more games after poker but Adora's attention is already straying to their trip to Etheria in the morning. Mara has been sending her a steady stream of pictures and video clips and Adora will show off the baby to anyone willing to look. Her phone pulses with starlight and it's impossible for her to leave it alone.

At seven she and Catra finally manage to usher most of their friends out the door. Bow and Glimmer stay behind to tidy up and take Adora home so she can pack a bag. It doesn't take them too long to clean up and too soon it's time for Adora to go. She lingers in the doorway with Catra once her friends have hopped in the car.

"I miss you." She pouts, playing with Catra's hair, mesmerized by the stars twining through the strands.

Catra smiles, clearly pleased, but puts up a fight anyway. "We're only gonna be apart for like, seven and a half hours."

"Yeah, that's stupid."

That gets her a loud bark of laughter. "Wow, you big sap. You and Bow gonna be here to pick me up in the morning?"

"Mmhm, at three."

"Alright, not so bad, see?" Catra leans in and kisses her. "Now, go home so you can get your shit ready and come back to me sooner."

"Pretty sure that's not how it works, but fine." With a final kiss Adora flounces to the car, watching Catra waving from the doorframe as they drive away.

Adora is so fidgety on the flight the next morning that her sleepy girlfriend finally breaks and snaps at her. She's better after that but never does manage to settle. Once Catra's gotten another hour of rest in she's much more understanding and is able to find humor in Adora's restlessness.

She teases her as they deboard, "You gonna run off and leave me in the dust as soon as we're off this plane?"

"Not if you can keep up." Adora volleys back.

Catra raises her eyebrows. "Oh, I think you know perfectly well just how good I can keep up."

Adora blushes at the insinuation and sticks out her tongue in the absence of a better comeback. She texts Mara when they land and brushes off her offers to come get them. She insists they take a cab,

so Mara doesnt have to leave Hope and the baby behind. Mara is only too happy to agree.

Adora's restlessness only grows as they near the hospital, and Catra's hand on her knee does nothing to settle it's shaking. She practically sprints through the hospital and lets Catra handle talking to the nurses while she cranes her neck around. It' s not like she thinks she's going to find her family that way butwhat if, right?

Finally, Catra pulls her to the door the nurse has directed them to. She pauses in front of it, taking a deep breath. "Ready Adorable?"

She glances at Catra then turns back the door, stars inch around it's seems like an invitation. She turns back to her partner with a wide smile. "So ready ."And with that they knock and enter .

Adora and Catra walk into the light of the star that envelopes the room and Mara stands instantly from her spot by the bed. Hope turns to face them, the baby cradled in her arms. "Just in time guys!Starla just ate and she' s mellow as fuck."

"Mara dear , you do realize you are going to need to clean up your language, yes?Hello you two, it is so lovely to see you."

"Hi!It' s so good to see you, how are you?"Adora rushes out, reaching over to wrap Mara in a tight hug. Keping one arm wrapped around her neck she turns to face Hope and Starla. "So, this is?.."

"That' s them!"Mara smiles proudly at her wife and child, ambient stars flicker to life and float around the room. "You wanna hold them?"

Adora's eyes pop open wide and she nods eagerly. Mara smirks back knowingly and moves to take Starla from Hope. "You can take the chair if you want."Adora moves to sit and watches with eyes as big as saucers as Mara and Starla approach her.

Adora holds the tiny bundle in her arms. They feel heavier than Adora expects them to, still fragile and small, but a firm weight in Adora's arms. She vaguely registers as Catra sit on the arm of the chair and slip and arm around her, squeezing her shoulder tightly. Adora's eyes roam the tiny face; their little button nose, teeny tiny ears, and the littlest cupid's bow mouth that is already so like Hope's. They gaze unfocused at the air around them, settling on Adora's face occasionally and looking away just as quickly.

"Hey little one, I'm Adora. It's so nice to meet you. I'm, um, I'm gonna be your aunt, I guess. I'll try and be a cool one, but maybe Aunt Catra can help with that. I was always kind of a nerd." Catra squeezes her shoulder again and she looks up to smile at her. Catra's mouth hangs open and something in her eyes looks smug as she stares back. Adora almost asks about it but a small gurgle from Starla draws her attention back to the baby in her arms.

"They're beautiful." Adora vaguely hears Catra praising to Hope and Mara.

"Yeah," Mara answers, voice wavering just a bit. "We definitely think so."

"How are you feeling Hope?"

Adora barely hears the answer to her girlfriend's question, wrapped up in Starla as she is. She just watches them in awe. It's in that moment she watches tiny eyes focus on a star drifting in front of her face. And in the next she gasps, watching a tiny hand reach out and clutch loosely to the star. Starla seems to forget about the star just as quickly as they catch it, their gaze shifting to Adora's face. Adora continues to watch it though, tracking it as it floats across the room to hang in the air between Hope and Mara.

She looks down again. "Oh Starla," She whispers. "You're *magic*."

Chapter End Notes

Wow, so ending stories is like, so hard? I still can't believe the sheer volume of words I've written for this story , this is a huge accomplishment for me and I appreciate everyone who's reading and leaving comments and kudos and such!
Pretty much everything I brainstormed wanting to happen for this story has happened. So, the next chapter, the epilogue, is gonna be the final bit! Which is so wild! I've already written a fair amount of it so hopefully I'll have this story wrapped up soon.

Thanks again to everyone reading, I appreciate you!

Prologue: White Dwarf-Protostar

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Today is a very important day. Mama is coming over for dinner and Adora *is in charge of dessert. For the first time, she's been promoted from baking assistant to full on baker, with granny as* her *assistant for the day. Just thinking about it makes her stand a little taller. The pie tin is lined and the berries she and Granny collected that morning are piled inside. Mountains of raspberries, blackberries and stars draw Adora's eyes as she gathers the second half of her crust from the fridge.*

Adora sneaks a look at Granny Razz who is bent over the oven mumbling to herself. Figuring she has time enough; she grabs several berries from the uncooked pie. She takes care to choose the brightest stars and the berries taste extra sweet. Granny turns around right as Adora swallows her last stolen berry. Adora doesn't exactly think Granny would care, but a stolen berry just tastes that much sweeter, it's just a fact.

"Ah, now you see Adora? Look at the stars in this pie! Magic dearie." *She crosses the kitchen and hands Adora the old wooden rolling pin.*

"Granny, Frosta said magic isn't real. She said that's baby stuff." *Adora puts and starts slamming the ball of dough with the rolling pin, just like granny taught her. Puffs of stars billow with each loud* Smack!

"Eh! That happens to many people who cannot see the stars dearie. They think to see is to believe. Sometimes it can be. But you can feel *the magic too, no?" She looks to Adora who pauses her project to nod seriously. When Granny nods back, she begins to roll out the crust for their lattice. "You see Adora, many people they will think magic is a* performance. *But we do not* perform *magic, it is not*

a show. Magic, it is in the way the plant grows the berries to share its life force with the birds and the rodents and with us. There is magic in the way we craft our food, like our pies. There is magic in the way that I love you. Don't forget this Alora dearie, don't lose sight of just how easy it is to find magic." Alora considers this and focuses extra hard on rolling out her pie crust nice and thin, just like Granny Rz

ay. "She finally decides. Fosta is kind of grumpy anyway, and Granny Rz is the smartest person Alora knows. So that means magic is *real. Granny starts cleaning dishes and humming some old jazz tune while Alora finishes assembling their pie. Once it's in the oven they go sit in the living room so Granny can crochet and Alora can work on her times tables.*

After a little while something strange and altogether unpleasant hits Alora's nose. She places the harsh, bitter smell with a gasp Granny, the pie!"

"O stars!" Granny launces from her chair and scurries into the kitchen, Alora hot on her heals. The kitchen is filled with smoke. It sets the smoke alarm into a frenzy and Granny wrenches the oven open, releasing clouds of black smoke into the kitchen. The hectic scene before her is just about all little Alora can take.

She feels hot, wet tears slide down her cheeks. How could she be so stupid *and not set a timer? She should never be allowed to bake again! Rz sees the state her granddaughter is in from the corner of her eye and frowns, abandoning the pie in the open oven. She turns the oven off at least, but really it's the least of her concerns. She drops to her knees and places her hands on Alora's shoulders.*

"Alora, what are you crying for?" She says it in the brash way she always does when something doesn't make sense to her. Sometimes it makes Alora feel like she's in trouble, but she never really is. Granny gestures to the oven. "This old thing. Eh! Good new. You know what is so magical about ovens Alora? Just like your bottomless tum, there is always room for more pies." She pokes Alora's belly. Suddenly Alora finds it much harder to stay

upset, fighting off a giggle. "Sometimes we learn a lesson the hard way dearie, nothing wrong with that. We just make sure we're safe."

Adora's lip wobbles again but she feels her tears slow. When she turns to look at the oven, she sees clouds of stars billowing out alongside the smoke. She smiles tentatively at Granny. "Can we steal peaches from the Robinsons yard for the next one?"

"Steal peaches from the… of course we can! *Go get your boots on dearie." Adora hurries into the hall to get ready. The pie is still sitting in their sink, already forgotten, when they venture out into the fog to collect their loot.*

The rain is relentless, not especially forceful but it's been coming down steadily for days now. It feels like too much of a cliché, the misty morning skies as somber as the energy in the house. Adora sits on the edge of Hope and Mara's guest bed with her head in her hands. She's focusing on breathing when the door clicks open.

"Hey baby, how you holding up?" Catra sits next to her, her hand goes to Adora's back and begins rubbing familiar circles into the stiff fabric of her dress. It's uncomfortable and the sounds Catra's hand makes against the fabric is grating, but Adora already knows she'll never be able to wear it again anyway. She turns to look at her girlfriend, a sad ghost of a smile on her lips.

"As well as can be expected I suppose."

Catra hums softly. "The baby sitter is here so all of us are ready to go as soon as you are. No rush though, take whatever time you need."

Adora shakes her head and stands on weak legs. "No, no let's get this over with."

"Oh Dora." Catra sighs, wrapping her in a big hug and squeezing tight. Adora fights back the tears that threaten to fall. She knows it's just a matter of time but figures there's no reason not to delay the inevitable. Besides, she's cried enough the last couple weeks. She's been nearly inconsolable ever since Mara called with the news. The fact that they'd seen this coming a mile off did nothing to soften the blow.

She clears her throat and steps out of the embrace, squeezing Catra's hand once in gratitude. "Are Bow and Glimmer meeting us there?"

"Yeah, I told them I'd text them when we leave; they're just waiting at the hotel now. Mara scrounged up a few umbrellas and Hope already got the pie. All you have to do is show up and…"

"And say goodbye." Adora finishes for her.

"And say goodbye." Catra confirms softly.

"Alright, let's do this. Hold my hand?"

"To the end of the world." They hold tightly to each other and Adora leads Catra downstairs where Hope and Mara are waiting in the hall.

"Did Starla already go down?" Adora asks, accepting the tight hug Mara greets her with.

"She did, sorry Squirt. Jewel is up there with her now."

"No, that's fine. I'm not sure I have it in me to be a very fun aunt right now anyway." Mara just gives her a sad smile and squeezes her shoulder in response.

They pile into the jeep and before Adora is truly ready to face the music they pull up to the edge of the forest. Later that day there would be a small memorial in the dining hall at the home where Raz had spent her final years. Adora's still not sure if she wants to go,

she thinks all she may have in her is spreading the ashes and saying her goodbyes here.

Bow and Glimmer are waiting for them when they park at the tree line and take turns giving Adora tight hugs before greeting the other women. She steps away to open the trunk and takes a stabilizing breath when her eyes fall on the small clay urn. She grazes her fingers over the top before picking it up and turning to find everyone watching her.

"Ready squirt?" Mara leans into the trunk beside her to grab the pie tin and Adora nods at her. "Alright, lead the way."

Adora knows exactly where she wants to go. It's a patch of blackberry brambles just a fifteen-minute walk from the old house, a few meters into the forest. It's a path she's followed a hundred times in her life, and her feet carry her there without much conscious thought. She stops when she gets to the spot, and her family follows suit. The stars she remembers filling the place are still there, but they're muted and hum with mournful energy. "This is it."

Mara shoots Adora a soft look and asks, "Do you want to say a few words or would you like a moment?"

Adora's lip wobbles and Catra grabs for her hand. "Can-can you maybe start us off Mar?"

"Of course, Squirt. Alright, well Raz was special, to say the least. And Raz will *always* be special. She is magic personified, and eccentric almost to a fault, and was hardly ever aware enough to care what anyone else thought." Adora chuckles and Bow reaches over with a handkerchief when it causes her tears to finally spill over. She smiles gratefully at him. "I met Raz as a teenager and even then, I knew." Mara chokes on her tears and Bow steps closer to put a hand on her shoulder. "I knew she was going to change the person I would become. She loved more openly than anyone I had ever met and lived with more abandon then I have seen since. I'll always be grateful to Raz, for the example she set." She pauses

to sob, looking over at Adora. "and for raising the coolest fucking sister Icould have ever asked for . We love you Raz, you will be missed."

Mara and Adora clutch each other tightly, their partners stepping back to give them a moment. "Thank you, Mara. Ilove you so much." Adora whispers into the spot in Mara's neck where her face is nuzzled.

"Love you too kid."They hold tight for another couple minutes before Mara rubs a few circles into her shoulder and releases.

"Ahem. Um, thanks for being here with me."Adora starts, looking shyly at her loved ones. "I was thinking Id just like to share a memory of Raz that Ive been thinking about a lot."Adora looks up to the crowns of the trees around them, heaving a great sigh. She closes her eyes shutting out the softly swaying pines which stir the dim stars around them. She feels Catra squeeze her hand once and looks down again.

"A few months before, um, before Raz had to move, we were baking. She told me, she said she thought Iwas ready to take the reins and she was just my assistant for the day ."She chuckles wetly and wipes at her face with her sleeve, forgetting all about the handkerchief clutched in her hand. "It was a disaster;it took us *hours* to clean up all the flour later. Raz just rolled with it, did everything exactly like Itold her to. It was the first time Igot to lay the lattice. It looked so clumsy, but Iwas so *proud* of it."She trails of f, and her family chuckles at the mental image of young Adora. She takes a moment to remember the stars that had intermingled with the excess of sugar she had directed Raz to sprinkle on top after she had finished.

"Anyway , we put it in the oven and moved into the living room so I could work on homework. Of course, Iwas nine and by that time Raz had already gotten forgetful, so we didnt set a timer . The next thing Iknow the fire alarm is going of f in the kitchen. We walked in and even before Raz pulled the oven door open, Ive never

seen so much smoke. I was beside myself; I'd been put in charge and absolutely *ruined* it. Razz got down on her knees in front of me instead of getting the pie or the alarm or anything and held me by the shoulders.

"She said-" Adora laughs remembering her kook of a grandmother. "She said that there's nothing wrong with learning a lesson the hard way. And she said- she told me the magical thing about an oven is that there's always more room for pie." She chuckles wetly at the memory, remembering how Granny Razz had poked her tummy and said something like, 'Just like someone else I know.'" She was always like that, goofy and understanding and so, so patient. I just I... don't really have anything profound to say. I'm just really gonna m-miss her."

That's the last Adora is able to get out before her tears overtake her. Catra is there to hold her, lending support when Adora's knees feel weak. It takes her a moment to work through them but eventually she centers herself again. She pulls away from Catra and takes the lid of the urn in her arms. In one graceless move she turns it upside down into the blackberry patch.

Bow looks on with wide eyes and Hope clears her throat a little awkwardly. Glimmer and Catra make some attempt to hide their snickering but Mara just laughs openly; big belly laughs that fill the forest and sets the stars buzzing. "Just like Granny would do it, eh?"

Adora smiles, bordering on a smirk, and shrugs. "Why not, right?" Mara snickers and hands Adora the pie. "Oh right. Um, Granny, this- Mara and I made this for you. One last pie for the road." She sets the pan gently on top of the pile of ashes, and she says goodbye.

They end up skipping the memorial and head back to the house for some quiet time. They play some cards and Hope puts a cartoon on for Starla when she wakes up from her nap. It's nice but after an hour or two Adora slips out into the yard. Catra finds her after a little while out on the swinging bench. It's just all a little too much, the

looks her family keep giving her are just a little too tender. And anyway, the cold air feels good on her face.

"How ya doing babe?" Catra plops down to sit next to her. She studies the garden around them, so much less vibrant than the last time they were here.

"I mean, relatively speaking? Fine." She shrugs and starts picking at a hangnail.

Catra hums thoughtfully. "And how are you actually doing?"

Adora's lip wobbles despite herself and when she sucks in a breath, the sound is harsh. She still manages to answer without totally losing it. "I'm just sad." She leans into Catra and her girlfriend takes the hint, wrapping an arm around her shoulder. She leans down to press a firm kiss on top of her head.

She doesn't say anything for a while, just sitting with Adora in the midst of her sadness. It's exactly what Adora needed but didn't know to ask for. "Adora?" Catra asks after a while, her voice tentative. "Do you ever wonder... do you think Razz could see the stars?"

"Hmm." Adora thinks about it, not for the first time. The truth is she'll never know but... "Maybe. I definitely think sometimes she could at least." She turns to look at Catra. "Kind of like with you and me. Like when we're connecting, I mean. Sometimes when we would bake together it felt like there was so much magic in the air, how could she not, you know?"

Catra smiles and it's just a little watery. "Yeah, that makes sense. Your passion is powerful Princess."

Something about Catra's words combined with her soft tone and tender look has Adora curling into her side, riding out a fresh wave of grief.

Raz's timing was both tragic and morbidly convenient; Catra and Adora had already been planning to come out this week for Starla's first birthday. Bow and Glimmer had invited themselves when they found out, insisting they were never the type to miss a party. Adora knew it was just because they'd fallen in love with Starla when they finally got to meet them. So, when Mara's call came it was easy enough to plan their tribute to Raz within the time of their trip.

Adora and Starla's birthday celebration a few days later is a modest affair. Bow and Glimmer come over to the house and the seven of them have dinner together. It's exactly what Adora needed this year, something low key with her family. After everyone has stuffed themselves full of pasta Hope brings out a pie with two candles stuck in the top. Adora pulls Starla into her lap and smiles indulgently at her family as they gather around the table in front of them.

Starla giggles and claps when they start singing, getting distracted from the stars that float up from the candle flames that previously held her attention. Adora leans in to whisper in her ear as the song finishes. "What do you think Star, enough stars in there for a couple birthday wishes?"

She looks up and catches Catra's eye, receiving a wink in return. Mara smirks at the two birthday girls and teases, "Alright get those wishes made and blow those candles out, mama wants pie!" She smiles at her giggling child and adds, "Dont worry about helping her out there Squirt, she's definitely got the lung capacity for a measly birthday candle."

The joke gets a round of laughter and Adora smiles, shaking her head before leaning in. "Alright Starla, on three okay?"

Starla smiles back and cheers, "Star!"

Adora's eyes widen and she looks up to her sister. "Did she just?.."

Mara's eyes are just as wide, Hope's too for that matter. "I think she did."

"Of course Mara's kid would say her own name as her first word." Catra jeers and it breaks Mara out of her reverie. She leans around Glimmer to shove Catra lightly.

"Shut up Estrella!" Catra just snickers back.

"Hey Mar." Adora ventures hesitantly, her eyes on Starla who is reaching for a star floating in front of them. She grabs her little arms to keep her from catching her sleeve on the flames. "I dont think"…

"Think what Adora?" It's Glimmer who asks.

"Their name. I dont think it's their name." She looks up again and Mara is giving her a sharp look.

"Uh, think I know my own kid's name there, Squirt. What are you saying?"

Adora glances down at Starla again who is now watching her moms, still happy as a clam. "The stars Mara, I think Starla can see the stars."

Mara looks a little shell shocked and after a moment Bow cuts in hesitantly. "Uh guys? I know this is like, a huge milestone. But uh, wax is *kinda* getting everywhere so you might wanna…" He points at the birthday candles which are in fact rapidly melting all over the pie.

"Oh! Right. You ready to do this Starla. On three, yeah?" Starla just watches Adora as she leans in. "One two three!" She blows the two candles out quickly and she and Starla clap along with the rest of the family.

"So…" Mara says into the silence that fills the room. "That's pretty fuckin' rad."

Adora laughs loudly and Starla's eyes dance over the stars that pour forth with the sound.

Catra lingers downstairs, helping Mara clean up from dinner. They insist that Adora get upstairs and relax so she heads to the guestroom alone. She changes into sweats and gets cozy in the bed, checking in for their flight out in the morning on her phone. Catra wonders in a little bit later, smiling at her own phone.

"Hey Princess, you see Tinker and Tanker's post?"

"Bow and Glimmer? Nu-uh."

"Check it out, we look cute as hell." She tosses Adora her phone while she moves to get changed. Glimmer's posted four photos from that evening. The first is the group shot they had set up, wrestling with her phone's timer for a good fifteen minutes to get it to work. Then there's one of the best friend squad, a cute posed picture of Mara and Adora with Starla sitting half on each of their laps, and the last is a candid of Catra, Adora and Starla all laughing.

"Damn, we are cute." Adora agrees. Catra smirks back, hopping over her to get to her side of the bed.

"Damn straight."

"Ooh, awkward. I'm not straight though."

Catra snorts indelicately. "Yeah, I'm *very* aware." She assures with waggling brows. "Now lay down, I wanna spoon the birthday girl."

"So bossy." Adora grumbles good naturedly, getting into position despite her protestations.

Once they're settled Catra sighs contentedly in her ear. "So, good birthday?"

Adora smiles. "Yeah, it was nice. Fun to have a buddy now. Convenient she's so cute too; now I know no one is watching me during the happy birthday song."

"Oh, I wouldn't be so sure about that Princess." Adora squirms when Catra's teasing is accompanied by a little pinch to her side. "What do you think a baby wishes for anyway?"

Adora snorts. "I'm not sure one-year-old's really get that whole concept."

"Meh, I bet she wished for a unicorn pegasus."

"Ooh, that's a good wish! Think it's too late to change mine?"

"Depends; what did you wish for?"

Adora laughs and nudges Catra blindly with her elbow. "I can't tell you that dummy! It won't work."

"Hmm, guess you can't wish for the pegasus then. Probably for the best, Glimmer would probably kick you out if you tried to bring up an apartment horse again."

"Psh, whatever. I barely live there at this point anyway. I'd just keep him in your yard." When her teasing doesn't get a response, she turns to look at Catra, twisting awkwardly in her arms. She's looking at her, a serious set to her jaw.

Just when Adora opens her mouth to question the shift in energy Catra speaks. "That's true Princess." She just keeps looking at Adora for another minute. Adora stares back, not exactly patient, but willing to wait. "Maybe you should have you thought about making that official?"

"What, barely living at my apartment?"

Catra rolls her eyes, looking thoroughly unamused. "Yeah, I was thinking just like, half a step further. You know, like not living there at all." At Adora's blank look she huffs impatiently. "Baby come on, work with me here. I'm trying to ask if you want to move in."

"Oh. Oh!" Adora breaks away from their cuddle fully to turn and face Catra. "Are you sure? I mean I'd be in your house like, all the time."

"Yeah, well as you've just pointed out Princess; you already are. Plus, that's like, the whole point of moving in so. And since you practically live there already, we'd really just be removing the safety net."

Adora feels a grin creep across her face. "You're that confident?"

Catra smirks cockily back. "Oh, I think I can handle it."

"Yeah, me too."

"Cool."

"Cool." Adora grins goofily at her girlfriend/soon to be roommate. Together they lean in for an elated kiss. "Cool." Adora repeats as they pull apart.

Catra rolls her eyes again, this time the gesture is much more fond. "Yeah, whatever. We can talk it out in the morning or whatever, right now I need to get some sleep since *someone* decided seven a.m. was a reasonable time for a flight."

"What? I wanted a day to settle in when we get back! But yeah, good call; we should get some sleep." The exchange one last quick kiss before settling in and turning out the lights.

Adora lays there, wrapped up in Catra's arms and staring into the dark, watching stars tumble through the air around them. She can feel her heart swell to three times it's size. She feels like the grinch but instead of starting with a tiny heart, hers grows from an already extra-large size until it fills the room.

"Hey Catra?" She whispers into the dark. She gets a low, questioning moan in response. "I wished for this."

"Hm?" Catra mumbles sleepily.

Adora squeezes Catra's arms tighter around her for a moment. "I just- everything in my life- in *our* life feels so solid right now. I wished for longevity, for more of all the good things I have. More days like these. I wished for *this*."

Catra hums and the sound is warm and honey sweet. A few stars drift over from behind Adora and she feels Catra press a kiss into her shoulder. "Mm, Adorable, that sounds magic."

And it is, it really is.

Chapter End Notes

Wowowowowowow, I can't believe I finished it? I can't believe this was gonna be a one shot and then *maybe* ten chapters or so? And then it turned into this 22 chapter long **beast**!
I've had the epilogue mostly done for a week or two now and kept going back and making minor edits because I was having such a hard time letting go! But here it is.
Thank you so, so much to everyone who has read and left love for this story. I'm a cancer sun (for those of you who vibe with the astrological element to this story) so your validation gives me life tbh. Also, an aside for anyone who cares to know; I absolutely looked up Starla's birth chart: Cap sun, Aries moon, Scorpio rising. (So like, good luck Hope and Mara. Should be a wild time, I personally love the Aries moon in my life. :})

Anyway, that's all on this for now. I may be tempted to add more to the Catra pov spinoff or do another side piece with these characters, but no concrete plans!)

Thank you again for reading!

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!